# Spread Love & Acceptance

*Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with*



**The whole book** · Short version

All three parts: yourself, between us, and understanding people.

*by Christian*

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THE WHOLE BOOK · SHORT VERSION

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Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

*Spread Love & Acceptance*: The whole book, the short version.
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**Not therapy.** This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

**If you are not safe.** If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

**The examples are made up.** The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

# If you need help now

**If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number:** 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

| WHERE YOU ARE | CALL OR TEXT |
|---|---|
| **United States** | Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line). |
| **United Kingdom** | Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line). |
| **Ireland** | Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. |
| **Canada** | Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French. |
| **Australia** | Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14. |
| **New Zealand** | Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?). |
| **Anywhere else** | **findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat. |

## For children and young people

| | |
|---|---|
| **UK** | Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19) |
| **Ireland** | Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18) |
| **Canada** | Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868 |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Australia** | Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25) |
| **New Zealand** | Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234 |
| **US** | 988 is for every age. |

## If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12, page **305** says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16, page **371** about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

# How to use this book

*This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 26 chapters in three parts, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.*

### THE PARTS

**Part One: Self-discovery.** Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.

**Part Two: Between us.** One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

**Part Three: Understanding people.** How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

### TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

### READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

### IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

### THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the workpapers (pages you fill in) and tools (helpers you use) that the chapters mention; the next page explains both. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

### GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

# Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **Workpapers: pages you fill in**

A workpaper is a page you fill in, on your own or together: a one-week log, a list of who owns which job, a short check. Each one has a number, like **WP-03**, and it is always called a workpaper, for example “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. The blank workpapers are also at the back of this book, one page each, to copy.

TOOL **Tools: helpers you use on the site**

A tool is an interactive helper on the website: a quiz, a calm-down timer, a card maker, or the Chat analyzer that reads a message with you. You use it and it gives you something back. It is always called a tool, for example “Tool: Chat analyzer”.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

## Three friends who give hints



**Professor Puddles**, the site’s cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints: a thought to take with you, and the workpaper or tool that fits.



**Tidbit**, the quick, curious pup with the big smile and the collar, bounds in now and then with a playful tip.



**Sugarfoot**, the steady, gentle pup with the long soft ears and the best hugs, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

# Find it fast

*Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.*

SHARING THE LOAD

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **We keep arguing about chores.** | Part Two · Chapter II · One owner per job | **88** | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |
| **I do the remembering and planning, and nobody sees it (the mental load).** | Preface to Part Two · The mental load | **71** | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what |
| **We each think we do more than our share.** | Preface to Part Two · Why the other person doesn't see it | **62** | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what |
| **The same job keeps slipping, week after week.** | Part Two · Chapter V · A repeat usually has no real owner | **136** | WORKPAPER WP-04 What keeps coming back? |
| **Is the way we share things fair? Can it last?** | Part Two · Chapter II · The setup score | **88** | TOOL Is the setup working for everyone? |
| **We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.** | Part Two · Chapter II · Small children and a new baby | **99** | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **We're about to move in together.** | Part Two · Chapter V · Starting out: before you move in | **147** | TOOL The "Who does what?" page |
| **Money between us feels unfair.** | Part Two · Chapter IV · Money between you | **133** | TOOL Who does what? The Money tab |
| **We co-parent across two homes.** | Part Two · Chapter III · Two homes | **117** | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |
| **We share a house with a housemate, or more than two of us share a home.** | Part Two · Chapter IV · A couple and a housemate | **133** | TOOL The "Who does what?" page |

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I'm raising my grandchild (kinship care).** | Part Two · Chapter V · Raising a grandchild | 148 | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |
| **Faith matters to us, or family elders expect a say.** | Part Two · Chapter I · Faith, culture and family voices | 85 | WORKPAPER WP-13 The 90-second daily check-in |
| **I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.** | Part Three · Chapter 12 · Your limits make your help last | 305 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **I'm the only one who wants to try this.** | Part Two · Chapter II · When only one of you is on board | 102 | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what (your side only) |
| **Someone handed me this book, and I'm not sure why.** | If someone handed you this book | 13 | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |

## TALKING IT THROUGH

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Small things turn into big rows.** | Part Two · Chapter I · How stress changes your frequency | 75 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **One of us goes quiet and the other pushes for an answer.** | Part Three · Chapter 5 · Feeling safe with someone | 210 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit: our pause plan |
| **Texts and messages keep landing wrong.** | Part Three · Chapter 4 · Messages lose their tone | 195 | TOOL Chat analyzer |
| **We move and talk at different speeds.** | Part Two · Chapter I · What sets the frequency | 75 | WORKPAPER WP-12 Same moment, different speeds |
| **A comment stings and I snap back.** | Part Two · Chapter IV · Let a comment land before you react | 127 | WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands |
| **We need to say sorry and mend things.** | Part Three · Chapter 11 · A real apology | 292 | WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands |
| **Conflict at work, with a colleague or in a team.** | Part Three · Chapter 4 · Saying hard things kindly | 206 | WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands |
| **Is it us, or is it everything else going on?** | Part Two · Chapter III · Leftover stress | 105 | WORKPAPER WP-14 Is it us, or is it everything else? |

## KNOWING YOURSELF

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I can't tell what I'm feeling.** | Part One · Now · When feelings are hard to name | 40 | TOOL My weather today |
| **I'm wiped out and everything feels like too much.** | Part One · Now · Check your weather; one state, many words | 38 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **ADHD: I'm overwhelmed and keep forgetting things.** | Part Three · Chapter 9 · ADHD, time and motivation | 261 | TOOL "How to talk to me" card |
| **I'm autistic, and people keep misreading me (or I misread them).** | Part One · Now · A mix-up runs both ways | 44 | TOOL "How to talk to me" card |
| **Old rules from childhood still run my reactions.** | Part One · Then · Write down the rulebook from home | 28 | The self path: where your lens came from |
| **My inner critic is loud.** | Part Three · Chapter 7 · The critic and the soothing system | 236 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **I want to change a habit, but it keeps slipping.** | Part One · Next · Tiny, repeatable steps | 53 | The self path, step by step |

## HARD SEASONS

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Someone I love has died.** | Part Three · Chapter 8 · Grief comes in waves | 256 | When you've lost someone |
| **I feel lonely, or I live on my own.** | Part Three · Chapter 5 · Building connection from where you are | 219 | Living on your own, living well |
| **A teenager's anger, or I'm a teenager and I'm angry.** | Part Three · Chapter 13 · The hot minutes | 329 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **Left out of a group, a friend group or a group chat.** | Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups online, and their pull | 381 | TOOL Chat analyzer |
| **Worry keeps me awake, or my mood is low.** | Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry time; low mood | 363 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **I'm thinking about ending my life, or I'm worried someone is.** | If you need help now | 5 | The page itself |

Each thing to try is marked as a workpaper (a page you fill in) or a tool (a helper you use on the site). All are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a

code you can scan for them. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

# If someone handed you this book

*Maybe it was left on your side of the bed with a page turned down. Maybe someone said, "Could you just read this bit?" Either way, you didn't choose it. Fair enough. Here is the short version, written for you.*

## This isn't a case against you

The book starts from something researchers have found again and again: when two people each estimate their share of the housework, the two answers usually add up to more than 100%. Nobody is lying. You see every minute of your own effort and only some of theirs, and so do they (Chapter II, page **88**). So the book never asks who the bad guy is. Its numbers score the setup, never a person.

## What's in it for you

- Fewer repeat arguments about the same jobs.
- Jobs that are clearly yours, so nobody needs to remind you about them.
- Credit for what you already do. Your jobs go on the list too: the car, the bins, the late-night lifts, the things you fix.
- A say in what "fair" means in your house. It isn't always 50/50 (Chapter IV, page **120**).

It doesn't ask for therapy talk, and you never fill anything in about the other person. You can say no.

## A first week: three small things

1. **Log your own week.** Rough minutes on "Who did what", including the thinking part: booking, remembering, planning. Ten minutes in all. Only yours, never theirs.
2. **Ask one question, and just listen.** "What's the one job you'd most like to stop thinking about?" Don't defend or count. Write the answer down.
3. **Take over that job, the whole of it,** including the noticing (below).

### Words to open the talk

> "I read the bit you gave me. I don't agree with all of it, but I get the point about the stuff nobody sees."
> "I'd rather own a couple of things properly than 'help' with everything. Which one would you most like off your mind?"
> "Give me a week to see what I actually do. Then let's look together."

**Best left out, for now:** "Just tell me what to do" (it hands the thinking straight back), "You should have asked" and, in the first five minutes, "I do loads too." That may be true. Save it for when you both have your logs.

### Taking over a whole job, noticing included

Every job has a part you can see (doing it) and parts you can't: noticing it needs doing, remembering, planning and checking it got done (the Preface, page **62**). Taking a job over means all of it.

1. **Pick one job that repeats:** the children's clothes and shoes, the bins, the car, school forms, the dentist.
2. **Get the handover once.** What it involves, when it's due, where things are, who to call. Ask your questions now, not every week.
3. **Move the remembering out of their head.** A phone reminder, the calendar, a list on the fridge: anywhere but the other person.
4. **Do it start to finish for a month** without being reminded. If you need reminding, fix your reminder, not the relationship.
5. **Do it your way.** If the result is fine, the method is yours. Their part is to let it be done differently.
6. **Ask for a backstop if you like:** someone who notices a slip and says so once, kindly. A backstop isn't a supervisor (Chapter II, page **88**).

**A made-up example.** Hester has always looked after the children's clothes: spotting toes at the end of shoes, school sizes, swimming kit, passing on what's outgrown. Wilf takes it over. Hester writes the handover note: sizes, the shop, which drawer holds the next size up. Wilf sets a reminder for the first Sunday of each month: "Shoes, uniform, kit." In week two he misses the PE kit for a school trip. Hester says once, "The trip kit is Thursday," and he adds "school letters" to his Sunday check. A month in, Hester says the biggest change is that she no longer thinks about shoes at eleven at night.

## If you think it's already fair

Log your week anyway. If it comes out even, that is useful to know, and the book will say so: a fair score doesn't silence anyone, and a low one doesn't blame anyone. And if this book feels like the wrong place to start, Find it fast, page 9 lists other ways in.

# The book in two pictures

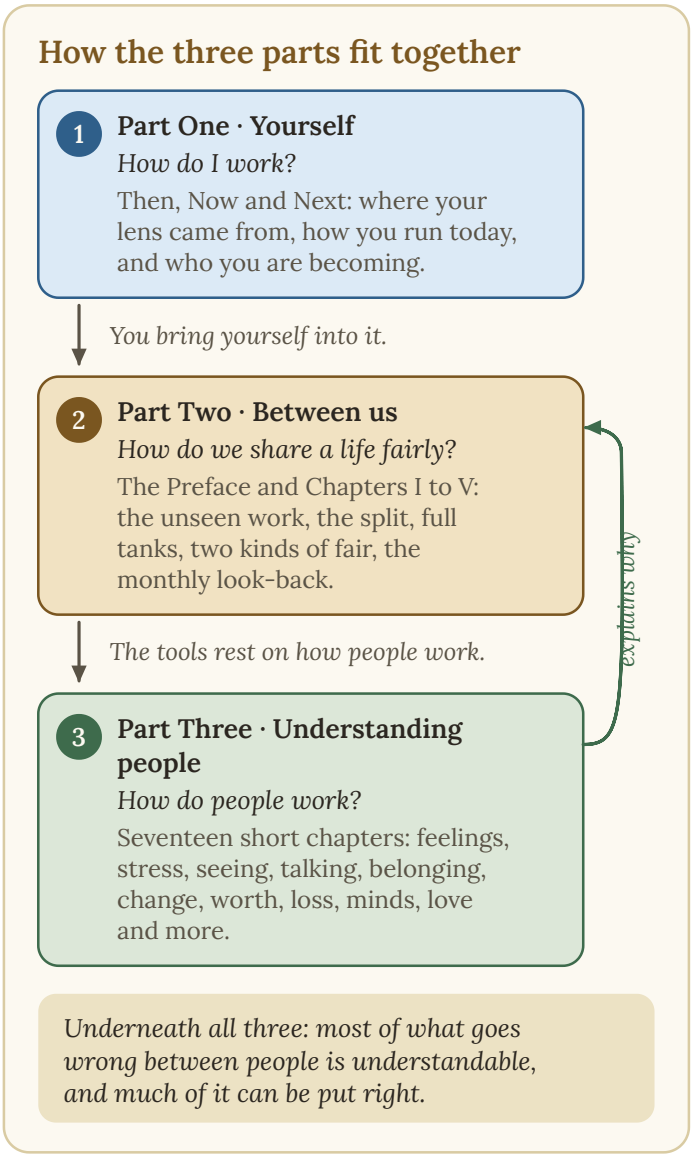



FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

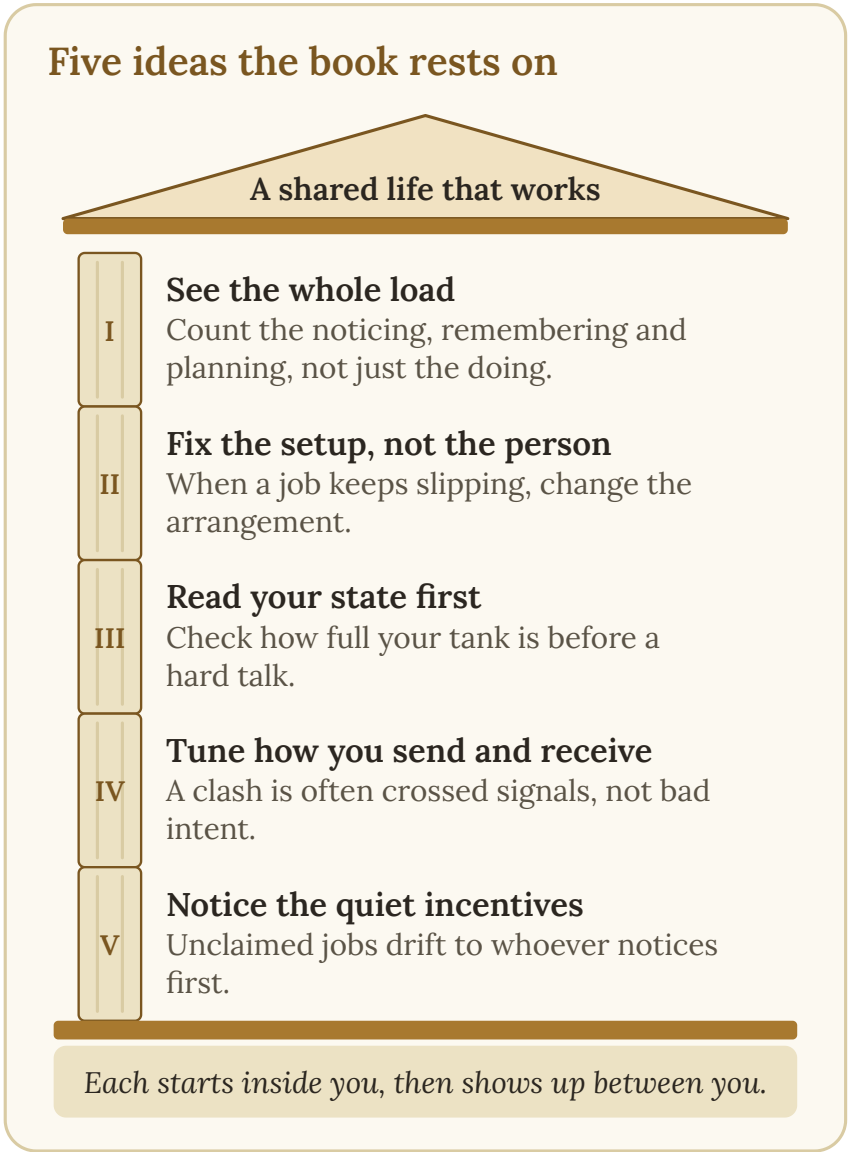



FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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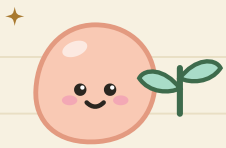
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PART ONE

# Self-discovery

*Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.*

IN THIS PART


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Then | Where your lens came from | 22 |
| Now | Your wiring, weather and words | 35 |
| Next | Who you are becoming | 50 |




SUGARFOOT

Go slowly in this part. It's all about you, and you're worth the time. A one-minute check on how you are today is an easy way in.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

# Then

PART ONE · THEN

## Know yourself: then, where your lens came from

*Why you expect what you expect, and how the rules you picked up growing up still make small decisions for you today.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. You're not one thing
2. Your lens came from somewhere
3. Each stage of growing up asks its own question
4. When something happened matters
5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts
6. An old rule can read other people for you
7. Write down the rulebook from home
8. You get to choose which rules to keep
9. What you carry forward is yours
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups


**This is where the book begins.** Part One (Then, Now and Next) is about you. Part Two (a Preface and Chapters I to V) is about the people you share a life with. Part Three (Chapters 1 to 17) is about how people work. Some printed copies hold only one or two of the parts; every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, and the book at a glance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-start-here) there gives a one-minute tour of the whole thing.

SUNDAY, 10:15AM

*Your partner is still in bed. The kitchen looks like a small storm went through it: last night's pan soaking on the hob, a tin of tomatoes open by the kettle, three mugs. Before you have had a single thought, you feel it. Of course it's always you. Nobody said that. But in the house you grew up in, whoever noticed the mess cleaned it, and that old rule has just made a decision on your behalf.*

*Across town, Ray's house has been quiet since his wife died, and nobody is going to see his dishes. He still can't sit down until every one of them is washed and dried and back in the cupboard, because a rule from the home he grew up in is still keeping watch.*

01

## You're not one thing.

A strong reaction usually comes from three places at once, and it helps to know which one is doing most of the talking. Part of it is how you're built, your wiring, which stays much the same through life. Part of it is what life taught you, the patterns that can soften with time. And part of it is just the kind of day you're having. This chapter is about the middle layer; Now (page 35) takes the other two.

Dot, who is seventy-one, snaps at her son when he turns up forty minutes late for lunch with the roast already drying out. Some of that is wiring, because she has liked things on time since she was a girl. Some of it is an old rule, picked up from her own father, that being late means you don't care. And some of it is that she was awake at four listening to the wind. She could say, "Some of this is me being tired and some of it's an old thing. Give me a minute," and the lunch would probably recover.

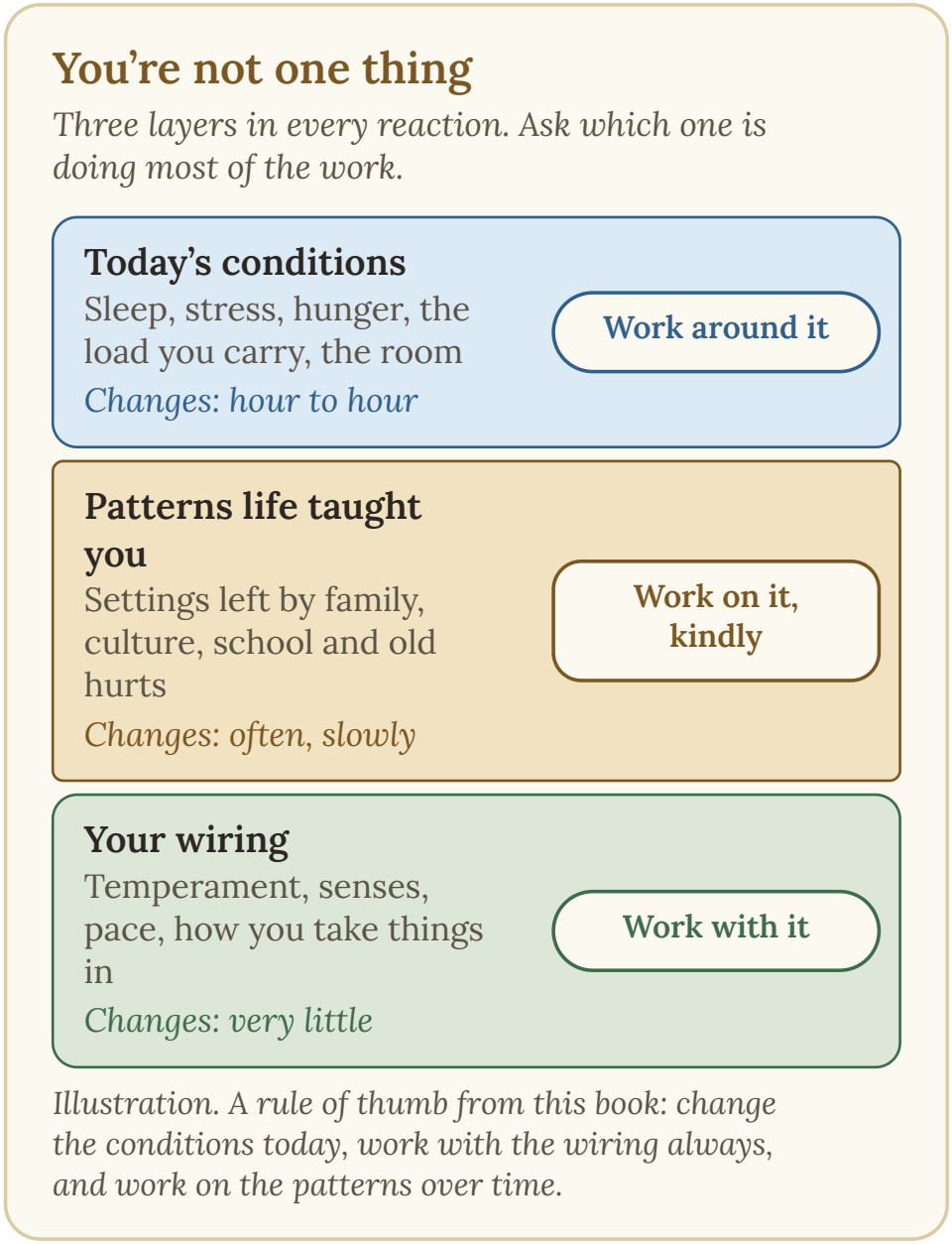



FIGURE 3 Three layers in every reaction. Each one changes at a different speed and needs a different move.

02

## Your lens came from somewhere.

Family taught you what to expect of yourself and other people, and so did school, friends, culture, how much money there was at home and whatever was on the telly. By the time you're an adult the lens no longer feels like a lens. It feels like seeing.

Birthdays are a good test. One friend grew up with a party every year and cousins down from Glasgow; the other got a card on the breakfast table and a slightly better tea. A quiet dinner for two lands as a slight on one side of the table and as perfect on the other, and "In my family this was a big deal. What was it like in yours?" clears the air faster than any argument about what birthdays are for. Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) walks through the idea slowly, and you can read one section and stop.



TIDBIT

The rules from home aren't good or bad. They're just yours, and worth a proper look. How you like to talk is a good first one to look at.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

03

## Each stage of growing up asks its own question.

A small child is working out whether the world is safe and whether they can do things for themselves. Later the questions change to whether they're capable, where they belong, and whether they can be close to someone without losing themselves. Later still, adults start asking what they're building and whether any of it has meant something. The ages are rough, but the answer you landed on at each stop can become something you go on using for decades without noticing.

Someone who moved schools four times as a teenager may still walk into every new job feeling like the new kid with the wrong shoes, and only later realise that part of them never stopped asking whether they belong. Which of those questions still feels loud for you?

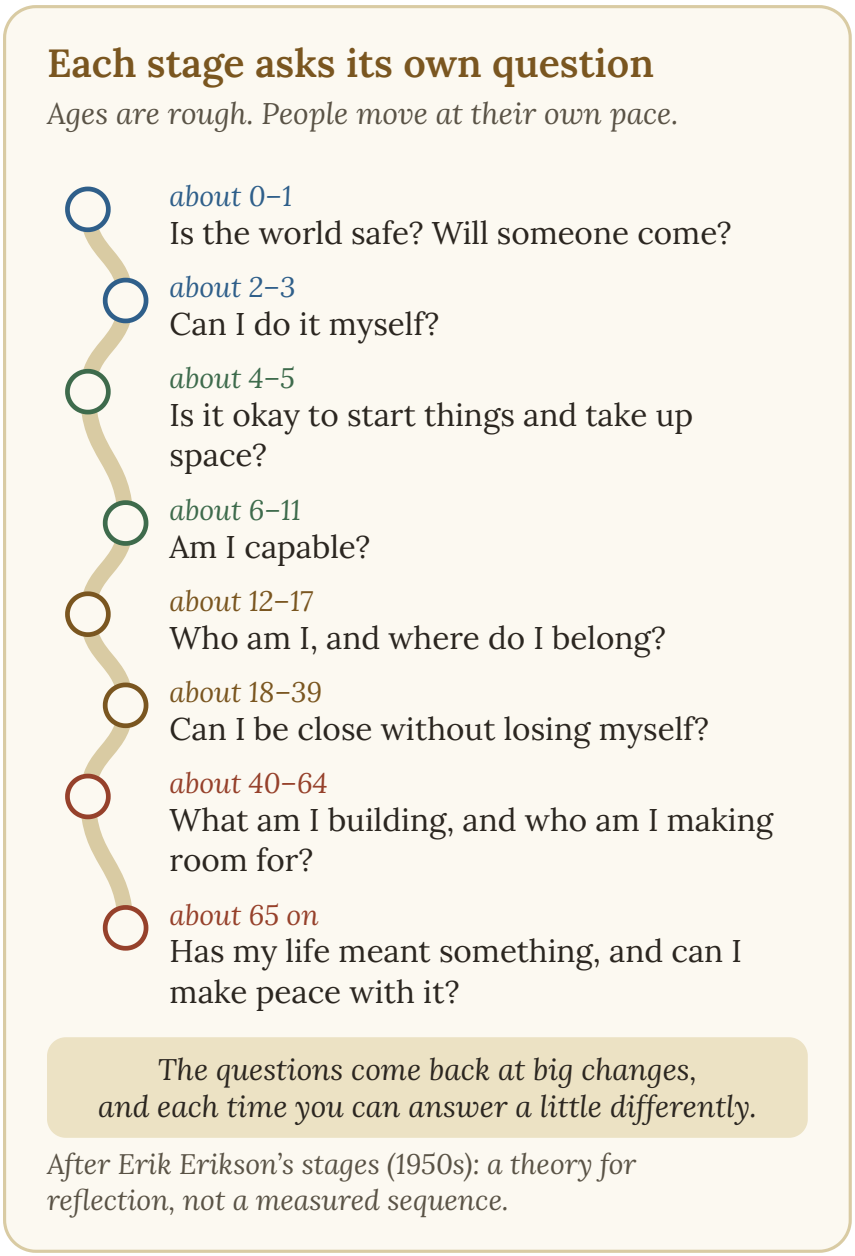



FIGURE 4 Each stage of life asks its own question. The ages are rough, and the questions come back at big changes (after Erik Erikson).

04

## When something happened matters.

An experience tends to go deeper when it touches the question you were answering at the time. A house move at four is mostly about a new bedroom. A move at fourteen, right in the middle of working out where you belong, can leave a much longer feeling of being on the outside.

Two adult siblings remember their parents' divorce in ways that hardly overlap. The younger one was six and remembers a new bedroom with glow-in-the-dark stars on the ceiling and a different bus route. The older one was fifteen and remembers feeling torn in half every other Friday. Both memories are true, which goes a long way to explaining why they still argue about that year (see Family rifts, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). Deeper doesn't mean permanent, though; people keep learning all their lives.

05

## Some old answers were learned without all the facts.

Plenty of adults carry a sentence about themselves that they picked up before they could check it: "I'm only okay when I'm useful." "My needs are a burden." "Mistakes mean I'm bad." A child can't see what is going on for the grown-ups and only knows how it felt in the room. As an adult you're allowed to look again with the full picture, which doesn't mean deciding it was all fine.

Sheila has fostered children for eleven years and is very good at it. She learned as a girl that her needs were a nuisance, and so she finds it almost impossible to ask for respite, a planned weekend when someone else cares for the children, even in the week she put the cereal in the fridge. The old voice says don't ask; the adult in her knows the service exists for exactly this. Write down one old belief about yourself, and underneath it write what you'd say to a friend who believed the same thing about themselves.

06

## An old rule can read other people for you.

If silence at home meant someone was angry, a partner's quiet evening can feel like weather coming in. And an expectation nobody ever said out loud can't be agreed to, so the other person can only fail it, whether it's "if you

loved me, you'd just know" or "whoever notices, does it". Every one of those is somebody's family rule.

A housemate heads out at ten past seven without saying goodbye, and someone raised in a quiet, angry house spends the morning wondering what they did, while the housemate is on the 7.14 to a shift she nearly overslept for. This week, when you catch yourself guessing what someone's silence means, try asking instead: "When you went quiet earlier I wasn't sure what it meant. Everything okay?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When an old rule jumps in before you've had a chance to think, you don't have to argue with it. Write it down, and look at it again on a calm day.

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

07

## Write down the rulebook from home.

This is the exercise I'd do first if you only do one in this book. Finish these six lines the way your childhood home would have finished them. "In my family, love looked like…" "When someone was upset, we…" "The jobs were split like this…" "Resting was okay when…" "Asking for help meant…" "The unforgivable thing was…"

The rulebook page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up#home) has room to write them, and nothing is saved anywhere except on your own device. Two partners from different faiths did this one December and both wrote that holidays belonged to their own family, which finally explained why every Christmas and every Eid had felt like a tug of war (see Two faiths, one family, spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths). One line today is plenty. If you share it with someone, you might say, "Here's a rule I grew up with. I'm not saying it's right. I just want you to know it's there."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

**The rulebook from home**

*Nadia, on her own*

## Your rulebook from home

Write a few words on each line, the way the home you grew up in would have finished it. Skip any line you like. Then, for each one, ask: do I still want this rule?

1. In my family, love looked like…

*Doing things. Dad fixed your bike; nobody said it.*

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

2. When someone was upset, we…

*Went quiet and waited for it to pass.*

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

3. The jobs were split like this…

*Mum noticed, planned and remembered. Dad did the big jobs.*

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

4. Resting was okay when…

*Everything else was done.*

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

5. Asking for help meant…

*You hadn't planned well enough.*

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

6. The unforgivable thing was…

*Breaking a promise.*

Do I still want this rule?

*Keep* Soften Drop

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: The rulebook from home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)

08

## You get to choose which rules to keep.

Go back to your rulebook and ask of each line whether you still want it. When a reaction feels bigger than the moment, try a one-minute lens check once you've settled. Where did I learn this? How old does it feel? Is it true here, with this person, today? A team leader at a building society notices that her old rule about mistakes makes her hide problems from her manager until they're too big to hide. She writes a new one on a yellow sticky note above her monitor ("Mistakes are information, and the team fixes them together") and leaves it there long after she stops needing it. Pick one rule from your list and write the version you'd like to live by: "I used to think ___. Now I'm choosing ___." Later, if you like, swap rulebooks with someone you trust and choose some shared rules on purpose.

09

## What you carry forward is yours.

You couldn't control the home you grew up in, or what other people did, or what you learned before you had all the facts. What's in your hands now is smaller and a good deal stronger: which old rules you keep, how you treat yourself about them, and where you spend your energy today, and that includes people. Give your time and care where they're met with care. Where the effort is all one way, let it shrink back to what feels fair, so you still have something left over.

For nine years, someone who lives alone has organised every meet-up with an old school friend who never once asks back. They stop chasing, send one warm message ("I'd love to see you. Let me know when works for you") and find over the next few months that they see more of the friends who reply (see Always the one reaching out? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)). Is there a relationship where you give far more than comes back? You could

give a little less there this month. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)




FIGURE 5 Where your lens came from, how you run today and who you are becoming, in one picture. You choose what you carry forward.

TUESDAY MORNING

*Two people get the same text from the same friend: "Can we talk tonight?" One is pleased, because she likes knowing what's coming. The other feels his stomach drop. In the house he grew up in, "we need to talk" meant trouble, and he spends the afternoon rehearsing answers in the car park and the queue at Greggs, for a conversation about splitting a cottage in Wales in August.*

## You, in all your relationships

Your old rules go wherever you go, starting with how you talk to yourself: the voice you use after a mistake is often an old one. At home they decide who notices, who plans and what quiet means, and two housemates can discover they've been living by different rulebooks about mess and who's allowed round after ten. In families, old roles like the helper or the peacemaker switch back on before you've got your coat off. At work, someone who was praised mainly for being useful may say yes to everything and then quietly resent it, until seeing the old rule lets them pause before the next yes. After a breakup old rules can get louder, which makes it a good time to look at them kindly (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists pages for many more situations.

## Common mix-ups

The biggest worry people bring to this chapter is that looking back means blaming their family. It's about understanding, and many of the adults who raised us were working with lenses of their own; if that doesn't fit your story, you don't have to make it fit. The second is that if something started in childhood you're stuck with it. Many old patterns soften once you can see them and feel safe enough to practise something new, and some leave a lasting sensitivity that you learn to carry and explain. People also assume every big reaction is an old wound, when quite often it's just a full tank (Chapter III, page 105, helps you tell leftover stress from this-moment stress).

And some decide there's no point looking at their own rules if the other person won't look at theirs. I'd disagree. Knowing your own rules changes how you react, even if nobody else ever reads a word of this.

> **A note on care:** This part looks back at growing up. It is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy, and it can't tell you what anyone has. Not every home felt calm or kind, so take only what is useful. If looking back feels heavy, you can stop and come back another day, or explore it with a qualified professional, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared.

If you want to go on, think of one "always" or "never" you felt this week and ask whose voice it sounds like, and how old you felt when you heard it. Then write one sentence that the adult you would rather be could live by and stick it on the fridge. Where your lens came from, Roots & Wings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up#roots) and Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself) go further.

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WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ You're not one thing.
- ✓ Each stage of growing up asks its own question.
- ✓ Some old answers were learned without all the facts.
- ✓ Write down the rulebook from home.
- ✓ What you carry forward is yours.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other**
*How a lens shapes what you notice in other people* page 182

**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*How early trust and attachment carry into adult life* page 210

**Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change**
*Which parts are temperament, and which can change* page 334

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Making peace with what happened, and when to get help* page 292

PUT IT TO USE

**The self path: see where your lens came from**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

# Now

PART ONE · NOW

## Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words

*Why the same words can land differently on different days and in different people, and how to understand today's you well enough to say what helps.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Today is made of two layers you can work with
2. Know how you like to be spoken to
3. Check your weather before you speak
4. Ask where this feeling is coming from
5. Plan what settles you on a calm day
6. Your needs and limits are information, not demands
7. Being wired differently is not being wrong
8. Explain yourself without over-sharing
9. Do your part, and only your part
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups


SUNDAY, 7:50PM

*"You okay? You've been quiet all day." Your friend has paused the film to ask. You say you're fine. The honest answer is that you can't tell whether you're fine, tired or quietly bothered by something someone said on Thursday, and you couldn't explain it to yourself, let alone to her, so you press play.*

01

### Today is made of two layers you can work with.

Your wiring is the lasting part: your temperament, your pace, your senses, how you take in words. You work *with* it, by building a setup that suits you. Today's conditions are the passing part, things like sleep and hunger and the

time of day, and you work *around* them by eating first or sleeping on it. A lot of frustration comes from mixing the two up. (Then, page 22, covers the third layer, the patterns life taught you.)

A dad who works nights finds the school-run chatter unbearable at ten past eight in the morning, and for a few months he quietly wonders whether he's cut out for parenting at all. Then he swaps with his partner and does the half-three pick-up instead, and the same chatter about who sat next to whom at lunch is funny again (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). The children hadn't changed. The hour had. Write down one thing that always bothers you, which is probably wiring, and one that only bothers you when you're tired.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "It's the hour, honestly. Can we talk after I've slept?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your wiring stays the same from day to day. Your weather doesn't. A one-minute check in the morning helps you tell the two apart.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

02

## Know how you like to be spoken to.

Pace, tone, how much you need spelled out, what a silence means to you: they all change how words land. How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) helps you find words for how you take things in and give them out, and it gives you a four-letter Wave Code, which is meant to be light-hearted, so please don't put it on your CV. The "How to talk to me" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) puts how you take in words on one page you can hand over before a hard talk.

Agnes, who is seventy-two, loves a phone call. Her grandson Jago loves a text. For about a year each of them privately decided the other had gone a bit distant, until a cousin pointed out the obvious over a Christmas trifle, and now there's a Sunday call at six with texts in between. If you want somewhere to start, finish the sentence "I take things in best when…" and keep it for your card.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

**“How to talk to me” card**

*Ife, made on her own to give to a friend*

## Your card

Pick what is usually true for you. Add a few words where the buttons are not enough. Leave a line blank if it does not apply.

Who it’s for

A partner  Family  (A *friend*)  Work (a manager or coworker)

Name on the card, optional

*Ife*

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

**How I receive things best**
In writing. One thing at a time.

**I take words**
Literally when it matters, tone when it is light.

**Give me time to answer**
A few minutes.

**If I go quiet, it means**
I’m thinking.

**Please avoid**
Long texts or many topics at once.

**A request lands best as**
The ask in the first sentence.

Applies more strictly when I am running low. Not a contract, and not a label. Change it when it stops being true.

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: “How to talk to me” card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

03

## Check your weather before you speak.

Every conversation runs through your own state before it reaches anyone else. Part Two, Chapter III (page 105) looks closely at the stress tank in a shared home, so all this chapter adds is the self side: a one-minute reading on your own before you decide what a hard moment means. My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is the quick check, and How much are you carrying? is a fuller one on a short worksheet.

A long-distance couple notice that every difficult call falls at the end of one partner's late shift, around midnight her time, so they move serious talks to Saturday mornings with coffee (see Long distance, spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm running on empty tonight. Can we pick this up tomorrow morning?"

ONE STATE, MANY WORDS. The chapters and tools use a few everyday pictures for one thing, how much room you have today.

- **The three states** (Chapter 2, page 166, calls them the ladder) are calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty.
- **My weather today** uses sky words for the same three. *Clear* is calm and connected, *gusty* is revved up, and *fogged in* is running on empty. Its *pressure* is how much you were already carrying.
- **The stress tank** is the score from How much are you carrying?, from 0 to 1, where higher means fuller.
- **The battery** is the other side of the tank, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery.

"Gusty", "revved up", "a fairly full tank" and "a low battery" can all describe the same Tuesday afternoon. I'd pick one set and stick with it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

**My weather today**

*Joel, on his own, after a short night*

## Check today's weather

### The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

### Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · Someone I care for · Friends · *Mostly on my own*

### The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

### Ground conditions

*Haven't eaten in a while* · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · Running on caffeine · Screens since I woke up

### Last night's sleep

Barely slept · *Short night* · About enough · Properly rested

### People load

Barely any · A normal amount · *A lot* · Nonstop, no gaps

### What's blowing in

*Work* · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

### What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · *Food or water* · Rest · *To move* · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

**Gusty today**
Revved up · Some room today

**Pace**
go gently, settle first

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for big decisions.

You said what would help is food or water and to move. Arrange that before anything else.

Overall: some room today. There is less room than usual, so spend it carefully.

If you want to send someone a line: "I'm a bit wound up today, so I'll keep replies short. It isn't about you."

Fill in your own: My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

## Ask where this feeling is coming from.

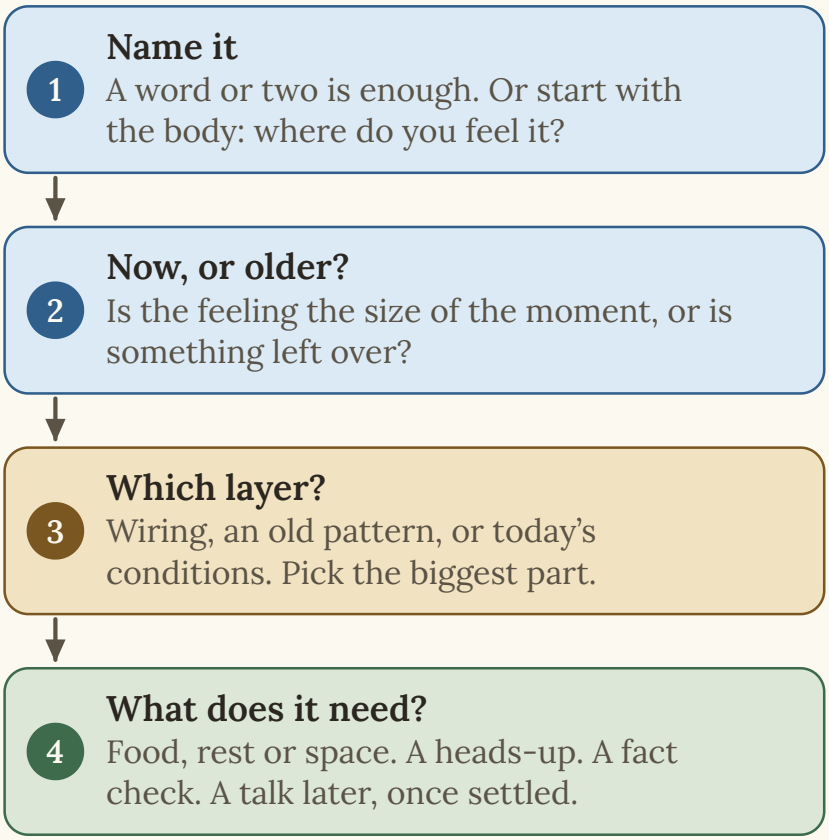
Name the feeling first, even roughly ("tight, annoyed, a bit scared"). Then ask whether it's the size of the moment or feels older, which layer it belongs to, and what it needs right now. Food, space, a heads-up, some reassurance, a proper conversation later: the answer is often more ordinary than you'd expect. It takes a minute and works best once the first wave has passed. A colleague leans over the partition at 4.45 on a Friday and says "Quick question?", your heart starts going, and if you stop to look you might find it's jumpy, with a former boss somewhere in it and a long week on top, and that what it needs is five minutes before you answer.

**When feelings are hard to name.** For some people, "What are you feeling?" is a hard question most days and nearly impossible on bad ones. They notice a racing heart or a heavy stomach and can't tell whether it's worry or hunger, or something else entirely. Psychologists call this *alexithymia*, which means "no words for feelings". It's a trait that runs from a little to a lot, it's common, especially among autistic people, and it isn't an illness. The feelings are there

and the words come slowly. Start with the body (“tight chest, skipped lunch”). Choose between two words rather than finding one from scratch (“more tired or more annoyed?”). Use the sky words if feeling words won’t come, and give it time. “I’ll tell you tomorrow” is a real answer.

## Where is this feeling coming from?

*Four small questions, once the first wave has passed.*




*This book's own four steps. Finding words for feelings is hard for many people; the body is a good place to start.*

FIGURE 6 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected. Do it once the first wave has passed.

05

## Plan what settles you on a calm day.

The middle of being wound up is a terrible time to work out what helps you calm down. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) is a plan you make while you're calm: what tends to set you off, two calming steps, and one sentence for stepping away that says when you'll be back. It's for you. It is never a list of instructions for the other person.

Fourteen-year-old Elsie makes one for the rows she has with her mum about her phone. The next time a row heats up, she says, "I need ten minutes in my room, then I'll come back," goes upstairs, lies on her bed with her headphones in, and twelve minutes later comes back down to the kitchen, where her mum has put the kettle on. On a calm day, write your one stepping-away sentence, with the coming-back time in it.



SUGARFOOT

Make your calm-down plan on a slow, quiet day, with a cup of tea if you like. It's far easier than making one in the middle of a storm.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

06

## Your needs and limits are information, not demands.

What helps you, what matters to you and what you've got left are facts about you, and said kindly they let other people plan around you. "A heads-up helps me." "I can take this one, but not that one." "I'm low today. Can we talk tomorrow?" You don't have to justify a need. A reason is a kindness you can offer when you want to.

Quinn lives with his two partners in a terraced house with one bathroom and a lot of shoes in the hall. He needs an hour alone after work, and once he has said so, calmly, it stops being a mystery and becomes part of the plan, like bin day. Two workpapers from other chapters can help with the words: Who did what, from the Preface (page 62), has ready-made kind ways to say no, and Say it so it lands, from Part Two, Chapter IV (page 120), turns a raw reaction into a plain request. Try writing one need you've never said out loud, and say it to the mirror as a fact, without the apology on the front.

07

## Being wired differently is not being wrong.

Some people take in words, noise, change and feelings differently from the way most social customs were built. That's wiring, which you can understand, plan around and get support for if you choose to. A woman with ADHD keeps forgetting plans with a friend and has been calling herself hopeless for years. Now she tells her friends the one thing that helps, a text the day before, and she turns up (see Neurodivergent relationships, spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).

**A mix-up runs both ways.** When an autistic and a non-autistic person misread each other, the autistic person usually gets the blame. The *double empathy problem*, named by the autistic researcher Damian Milton, is the idea that the gap runs both ways: each person reads the other through their own way of communicating, and each finds the other hard to read. In one study, a story passed along a chain of autistic people kept as much detail as one passed along non-autistic people, while mixed chains lost detail faster. I find that study quietly cheering. Wired Differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) shows how two differently wired people can each misread the other, and "Where did we lose each other?" lets both of you adjust a little.

08

## Explain yourself without over-sharing.

Most moments need one of three short sentences. "This is how I'm wired. It won't change, but here's what helps." "This is an old alarm. I'm working on it, and here's what helps in the moment." "Today's a low-battery day." You never owe anyone your history. Share the part that helps them help you. A man with a long-term illness tells a new friend from the climbing wall, "Some days I have less energy, and if I cancel, it isn't about you," and leaves his medical notes out of it (see When one of you is ill, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

09

## Do your part, and only your part.

Today you control your words, your effort, your rest, your limits and what you ask for. You don't control anyone else's mood or reply or pace, and trying to manage them will drain you faster than almost anything. It also helps to match energy with energy, meeting warmth with warmth, and giving a little less where you keep giving far more than comes back. A protected battery is what keeps you kind.

A grown-up daughter has spent years trying to stop her father worrying about her. She can't. What she can do is send "Home safe x" after long drives on the M6 and then let his worry be his (see For grown-up children, spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children). Write one thing you keep trying to control that isn't yours, and next to it one thing that is. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

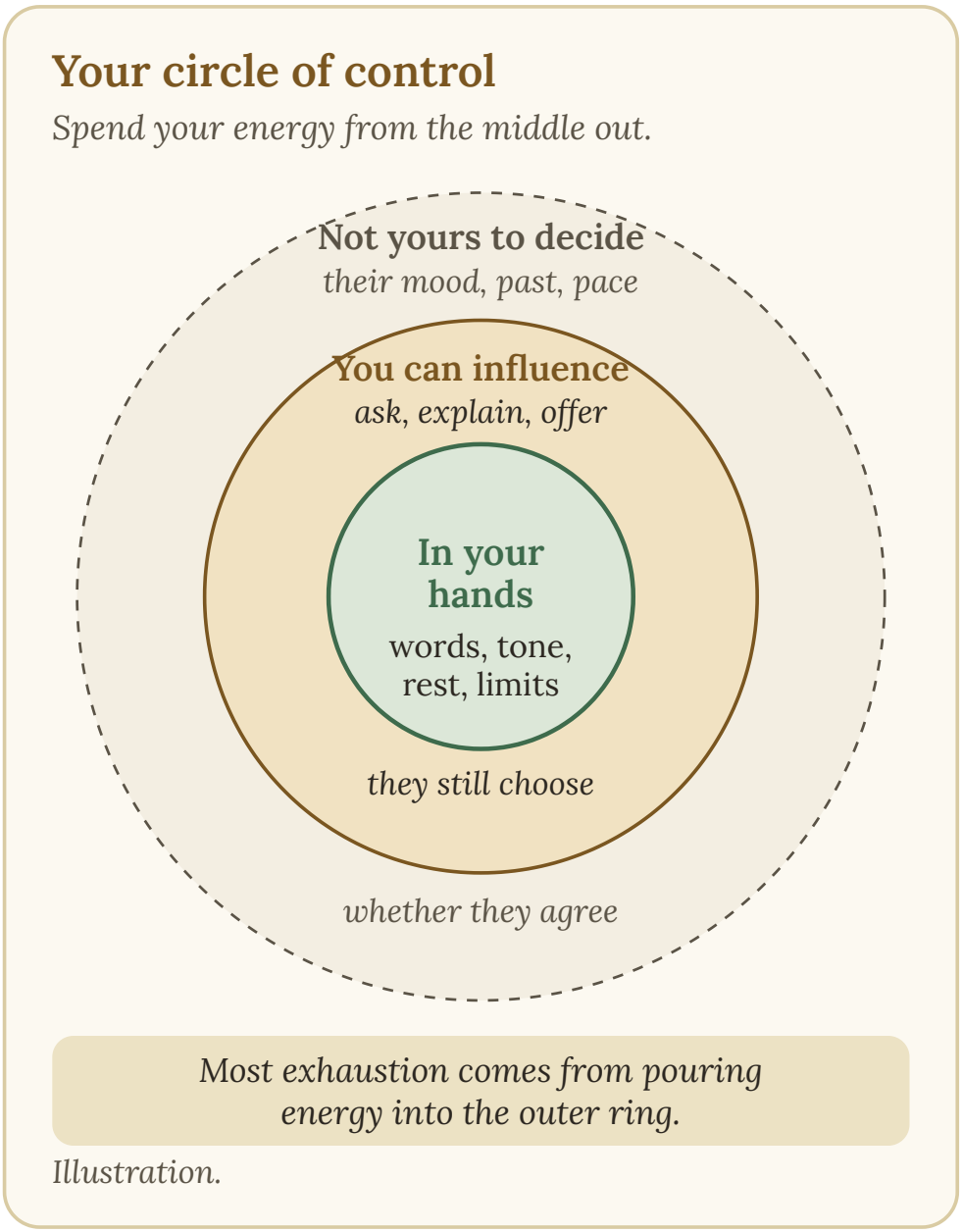



FIGURE 7 Your circle of control. Spend your energy from the middle out; most exhaustion comes from pouring it into the outer ring.

FRIDAY, 6:40PM

*"Surprise! I've booked us dinner with my cousins tonight. Half seven at the Turkish place." They meant it as a gift. You felt your chest tighten and heard yourself say "Great" in a voice so flat it could have been ironed. Later, at the sink, you wonder whether that was just you, something from years ago or the end of a long week. Probably some of each, and you still haven't said anything.*

## You, in all your relationships

Your wiring and your weather come with you everywhere, starting with how you treat yourself on a hard day, when noticing that you're low ought to come before deciding that you're failing. Partners can give each other a heads-up or a quiet hour, and every partner has wiring of their own. With friends and family the question is often how you like to keep in touch and how much you can give this month. At work it may be an agenda the day before, or a minute before you answer. Housemates mostly negotiate noise, and who gets the bathroom first. If you live on your own, you get to build a week that suits how you're built (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## Common mix-ups

A few come up again and again. Knowing yourself is mostly about what helps. A label can come later, or never, and the three layers and a Wave Code are everyday words with no diagnosis in them. "That's just how I am" may well be true, especially about wiring, but it works far better as the start of a conversation ("This is how I'm wired, and here's what helps") than as the end of one. Telling people how you're wired doesn't mean they now have to manage you. It helps their words land, and you still do your part while they still have needs of their own.

And "I'm fine" sometimes means fine. It can also mean you've been tired for so long you stopped noticing. A quick reading once a week shows you the baseline you've got used to, which is sometimes a surprise.

**A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't a diagnosis, a test or treatment, and it can't tell you whether you're autistic, have ADHD or anything else, or what anyone else has. If you'd like to understand yourself more deeply, a qualified professional can help, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you try needs to be shared. If talking about any of this with someone ever feels unsafe, or you feel you can't say no, stop and talk with a trained counselor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counseling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

To put the chapter to use, pick one reaction you had this week and write a line for each layer: the wiring part, the older part, today's part. Take a one-minute reading of your weather. Then write one sentence about what helps you, in your own words, and keep it to yourself for a few days before you try it out on one person on a calm day. Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself), the "How to talk to me" card and How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying) are free on the site.

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WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Today is made of two layers you can work with.
- ✓ Check your weather before you speak.
- ✓ Plan what settles you on a calm day.
- ✓ Being wired differently is not being wrong.
- ✓ Do your part, and only your part.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently**
*Wiring differences: autism, ADHD and the senses* page 261

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*Why your weather changes how you hear things* page 166

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*The stress tank, used between two people* page 105

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*What fair means when you share the work* page 120

PUT IT TO USE

**The self path: get to know your wiring**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

**How much are you carrying? A quick stress check**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

# Next

PART ONE · NEXT

## Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming

*You aren't finished, and some of who you become is up to you. This chapter is about choosing a direction and building small steps that still work on a tired day.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Start with what matters to you
2. Pick one small goal, in plain words
3. Name what gets in the way
4. Make the step tiny, and repeatable
5. Decide ahead with a simple if-then
6. Ask for support, as information
7. Look back kindly once a month
8. Kindness to yourself is part of the plan
9. Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups


WEDNESDAY, 9:10PM

*You meant to start walking after dinner. You meant to last week too. Tonight you're tired, the trainers are still by the door where you left them on Sunday with the laces tucked in, ready, and you tell yourself you'll begin on Monday, which has a nice clean feel to it.*

01

### Start with what matters to you.

A goal built on someone else's idea of success is very hard to keep up. So before you pick anything, ask what you want your days to be like, and write two or three plain words: calm, say, or close to my family, or steady, or creative. They give you a direction to face rather than a score to hit. How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) can help you notice what fills you up and what drains you, if you're not sure.

After their youngest leaves for university, a couple each write two words on the back of an envelope. Hers are “useful, outdoors”. His are “calm, curious”. It suddenly explains why she has been eyeing the volunteers’ hut at the nature reserve while he keeps wandering down the garden to look at the vegetable patch (see Kids grown and gone, spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest). Write your two in pencil, since you’re allowed to change them.

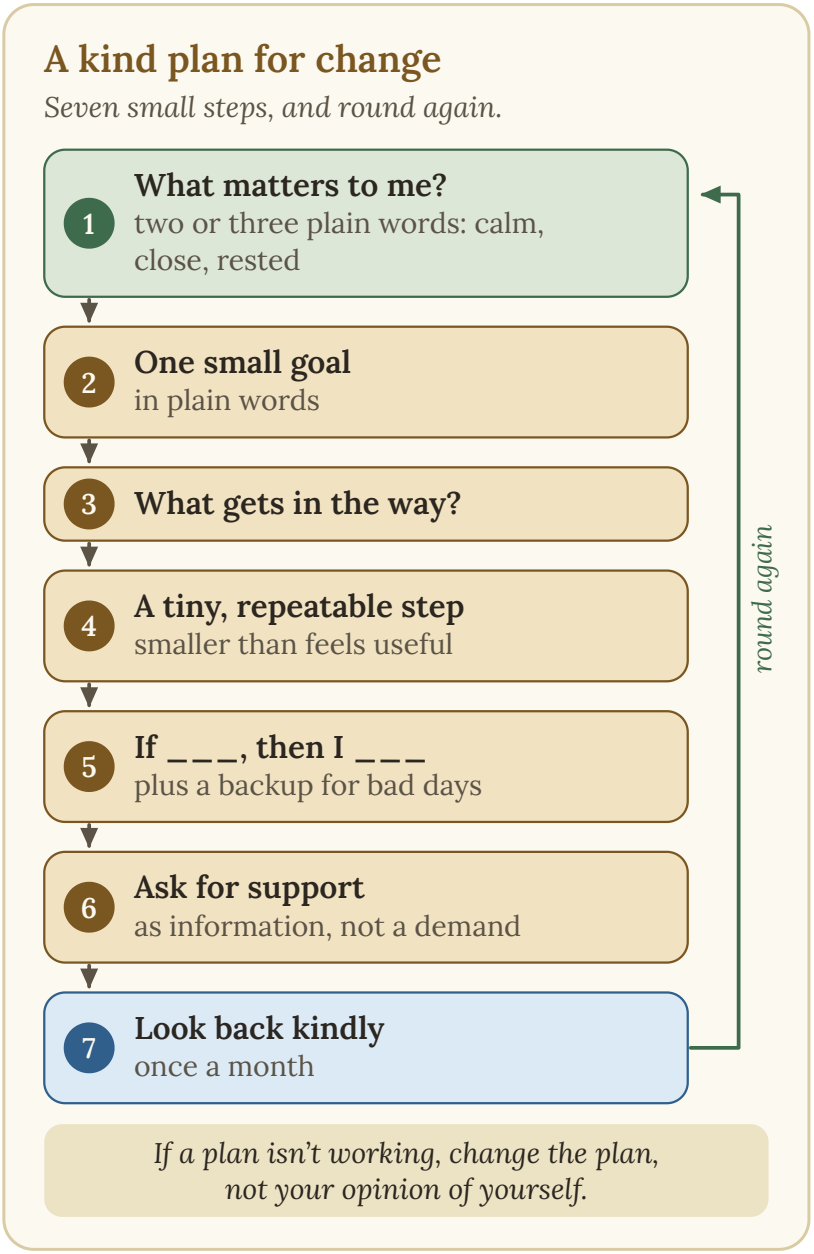



FIGURE 8 A kind plan for change in seven small steps. If the plan isn't working, change the plan, not your opinion of yourself.

02

### Pick one small goal, in plain words.

Just one, said as something you'll do. "Walk for ten minutes after dinner" is a goal you can keep. "Get healthier" is a hope, and hopes are lovely but you can't put them in a diary. Your own actions are up to you; how other people respond, and how things turn out, aren't. A student sharing a room in halls wants to be "less messy", and turned into an action it becomes putting her clothes in the basket before bed (see Sharing a room, spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room). Try rewriting one wish so it starts with "I will…"

03

### Name what gets in the way.

This is where Then (page 22) and Now (page 35) earn their keep. The obstacle might be your wiring, and a plan that ignores how you're built was really made for someone else. It might be an old rule, such as "rest has to be earned". Or it might just be a tired Tuesday. Whichever it is, change the arrangement and leave yourself alone.

A warehouse worker kept missing his evening run and had more or less decided he was lazy. He wasn't. His rota changed every week, so "evenings" meant something different every Monday. Once he tied the run to his first day off, whenever that fell, he stopped missing it (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

04

### Make the step tiny, and repeatable.

Small enough to survive your worst week. "Put my shoes on" counts, and I mean that. Tie it to something you already do, and do it often. The 90-second daily check-in in Part Two, Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1-in-depth) runs on the same idea, that small and frequent outlasts big and rare, and Ten-minute start (spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes) shows how small a whole path can be.

Someone on their own after a breakup wants to "get back out there", which is far too big to start on a Sunday night. The step they choose is one message to one friend every Sunday, usually sent from the sofa during the weather

forecast (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). If your step takes more than two minutes, shrink it again.



TIDBIT

Tiny steps count, wobbly ones included. If you like a game, there's one where each small kind act moves the ball up the field.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

05

## Decide ahead with a simple if-then.

"If it's after dinner, then I put my shoes on." Deciding ahead means one decision fewer on a tired day, which is the same thinking as the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11), made while you're calm. A separated parent who wants calmer handovers decides that when she pulls up outside her ex's house, she'll take three slow breaths with the engine off before she gets out (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting). Pick a cue that happens every day anyway, like the kettle or the front door or brushing your teeth, and if the if-then isn't working, change it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

**The Calm-Down Kit, just for me**

*Nell, on her own*

### The Calm-Down Kit

Your name
*Nell*

Date
*11 October 2026*

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| *A long message from my sister late at night* | *Tight chest, typing fast* |
| *Plans changed with no warning* | *Jaw, hot face* |

### Part A: My two defaults

First default
*Walking it out*

Second, if the first isn't available
*Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)*

### Part A: My pause line

In my words
*I'm at capacity. I'm going to step away for twenty minutes, and I'll answer properly after that.*

### My pause plan (yours to share, if you like)

My pause word or signal
*"Back in a bit"*

The shortest break I take
*20 minutes*

How I set the time to come back
*I text a time, the same day*

The first sentence when I come back
*"Thanks for waiting. I can think straight now."*

### Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

### Part C: Coming back

| Time | What I did | How I feel now |
|---|---|---|
| *9:40 pm* | *Walking it out* | *Still hot* |
| *10:05 pm* | *Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)* | *Settled enough* |

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

**Next**
Settled enough: pick things back up, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
*Reply to my sister's message, one line*

If you put it off: when you'll pick it back up
*Tomorrow after lunch*

☑ I'm going with this

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (Just me) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

06

## Ask for support, as information.

Tell one person what you're trying and what would help. "I'm trying to walk after dinner. Could you ask me how it's going on Sunday?" They can say no, and you don't need anyone's agreement to start.

Since her husband's stroke, Glenys has done almost all his care. She asks her brother whether he could sit with him on Thursday afternoons from two till four so she can go swimming. Because the request is so specific, it's easy for him to say yes, and he does, and he brings biscuits. Some goals are better shared with a qualified professional, and asking for one is a sensible step whenever you want it. (If someone uses your goals to check up on you or control you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

07

## Look back kindly once a month.

This is the monthly look-back from Part Two, Chapter V (page 136), pointed at yourself instead of a household. Once a month, take ten minutes to ask what went well, what kept slipping, and whether the gap was in the plan, in how much you had to give that month or in one strange week. Old misses don't get added up. The only question is what to try next month.

A grandmother raising her two grandchildren sits down with a cup of tea on the first of March and sees that bedtime is working and homework very much isn't. So in March she tries homework at the kitchen table straight after a snack, before the telly goes on. Put ten minutes in your calendar for the first of next month now, while you're thinking of it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your monthly look is the solo version of the monthly look-back for people who share a home. Borrow its two questions if you like: what kept slipping, and what would have made it easier?

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

08

## Kindness to yourself is part of the plan.

There's an old image of the second arrow that I find useful here. The first arrow is the slip itself. The second is the telling-off you give yourself afterwards, which hurts more and helps less, and a plan that needs you to be harsh with yourself is mostly second arrows. Rest belongs inside the plan, and you can shrink a goal or drop it whenever you like.

A sixteen-year-old who planned to revise every night misses three nights running and announces at breakfast that he's useless. His grandmother, buttering toast, asks what he'd tell his best friend if it were him. He thinks about it, rolls his eyes, and shrinks the goal to twenty minutes before tea. Next time you miss a step, say one sentence to yourself that you'd say to a friend.

09

## Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

A goal that depends on someone else changing is really a wish. Shape each one around what you can do, such as asking once, kindly, by Friday. You might wish your grown-up sister rang more often; that's outside your circle. Ringing her on the first Sunday of each month, and telling her you'd love her to ring too, is inside it. Then budget your energy like the limited thing it is. Put more into the people and plans that give something back and less into the ones that only take, so you're still going when you get near the goal.

THE FIRST OF THE MONTH

*You open your notes app. Of the four small things you tried, two have stuck and two quietly stopped somewhere around the second week. You still don't know why the Saturday swim fell away. You liked it. You write a question mark next to it for next month and close the app.*

## You, in all your relationships

A goal for yourself usually touches the people around you, and small steps work everywhere. With a partner, offer one small habit rather than demanding one. With friends, one message a week can be enough to keep a friendship warm. In a family it might be a regular call, a visit you can actually keep up, or a first step after years apart (see Reaching out, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). At work it could be one comment per meeting, and with money, one small saving habit that's yours alone to keep.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

**The self path, step by step**

*Sam, on their own, two weeks in*

### The path, step by step

| Step | Where it's at |
|---|---|
| *Check your battery* | *Done ✓* |
| *Get to know your wiring* | *Done ✓* |
| *See where your lens came from* | *Done ✓* |
| *Plan what settles you* | Not yet |
| *Find words for what you feel* | Not yet |

| Step | Where it's at |
| --- | --- |
| *Practise kind ways to say no* | Not yet |

### Come back gently, once a week

Pick a day and a time, and add a ten-minute reminder to your own calendar. It repeats every week and just says "10 minutes for me".

| Day | Time |
| --- | --- |
| *Sunday* | *7:30 pm* |

**WHAT HAPPENS NEXT**

The next step is Plan what settles you: the Calm-Down Kit. Three steps done is three steps done; the rest will still be here next week.

Fill in your own: The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path)

## Common mix-ups

"A goal has to be big to count" is the commonest, and the least true. Small and repeatable is what survives a bad week, and most big goals turn out to be a lot of small ones in a trench coat. Some people think that once they know themselves they ought to be able to change anything, but wiring stays, so the aim is a goal that fits how you're built. Asking for support doesn't mean you couldn't manage alone. It gives other people the information they need to help. And "I'll start on Monday" isn't always a dodge, since a fresh start can genuinely help, but today's tiny version counts too.

> **A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't therapy, coaching or medical advice, and it can't promise any result. Goals about your health, money, work or a hard stretch in life may deserve a qualified professional, and there's no shame in asking for one. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared. If a goal ever starts to feel like a weight, you can shrink it or put it down.

To start, write two plain words for what matters to you, one small goal as something you'll do, the tiniest first step you can think of and one if-then.

Then put a ten-minute look-back in the calendar for a month from now. Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Ten-minute start are free on the site.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Start with what matters to you.
- ✓ Name what gets in the way.
- ✓ Decide ahead with a simple if-then.
- ✓ Look back kindly once a month.
- ✓ Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life** page 280
*Finding out what matters to you*

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change** page 223
*Why tiny steps and if-then plans work*

**Part Two · Chapter V · The monthly look-back** page 136
*The same monthly look, done together*

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** page 236
*A kinder inner voice when a step slips*


PUT IT TO USE

**The self path, step by step**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

**The Calm-Down Kit: a plan for heated moments**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



PART TWO

# Between us

*One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.*

IN THIS PART


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Preface | The work nobody sees | 62 |
| Chapter I | Why we get out of tune | 75 |
| Chapter II | Is the split working? | 88 |
| Chapter III | Full tanks and different angles | 105 |
| Chapter IV | Two kinds of fair | 120 |
| Chapter V | The monthly look-back | 136 |




TIDBIT

This part comes with workpapers to fill in, together or on your own. If you only try one, make it the one-week log.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

# Preface

PREFACE TO PART TWO

## The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home

*Part Two of the book is about the people you share a life or a home with, and it opens here. Running a life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This preface helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so you can talk about it fairly and kindly.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. On your own: your own unseen work
11. One household, followed for a month
12. Your situation, chapter by chapter
13. Common mix-ups
14. Limits and cautions


IN SHORT

- **Running a home takes unseen work**, the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature, and missing it says little about how much someone cares.
- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- **The list is for seeing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

*Someone notices that the laundry has been sitting in the washer since Saturday morning and will need doing again, that the school trip form is due on Tuesday, and that the birthday card for Auntie Jean is still in its cellophane on the hall table. They also notice that nobody else has noticed. From the hallway the house looks fine. That's exactly the trouble.*

01

## Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing that the milk is low and calming a tense moment never show up on a calendar, so they rarely get a thank-you, and over months they pile up. This book calls the pile *unbilled debt*, because nobody ever sends a bill for it. (It's a ledger word, and I make no apology for it. I spent my career as a government auditor, and work that only got done because one person quietly kept catching it was a finding I saw again and again.) You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. Marcus remembers every school form, dentist visit and bit of lunch money for their two children. His husband, Theo, sees two children who always seem to have what they need, PE kit included, and genuinely doesn't know how. He isn't careless. The work is out of his sight.

Tonight you could write down three things you did today that nobody saw, and leave the list alone for now. If you show it to someone later, something like "I'm not asking you to pay anything back. I just want you to see them" sets the right tone.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The easiest way to see unseen work is to write it down for one ordinary week. Each of you logs only your own jobs, and the thinking counts too.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

02

## A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check that it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy even though nobody can see it. In a shared flat above a launderette, Yasmin

notices that the broadband deal ends in three weeks, compares six plans, picks one, sets it up and checks it went through. Paying took two minutes. The thinking took most of a Thursday evening, and nobody else in the flat knows it happened.

Pick one job at home and split it into its steps, noticing, planning, doing and checking, and then ask who usually does each step.

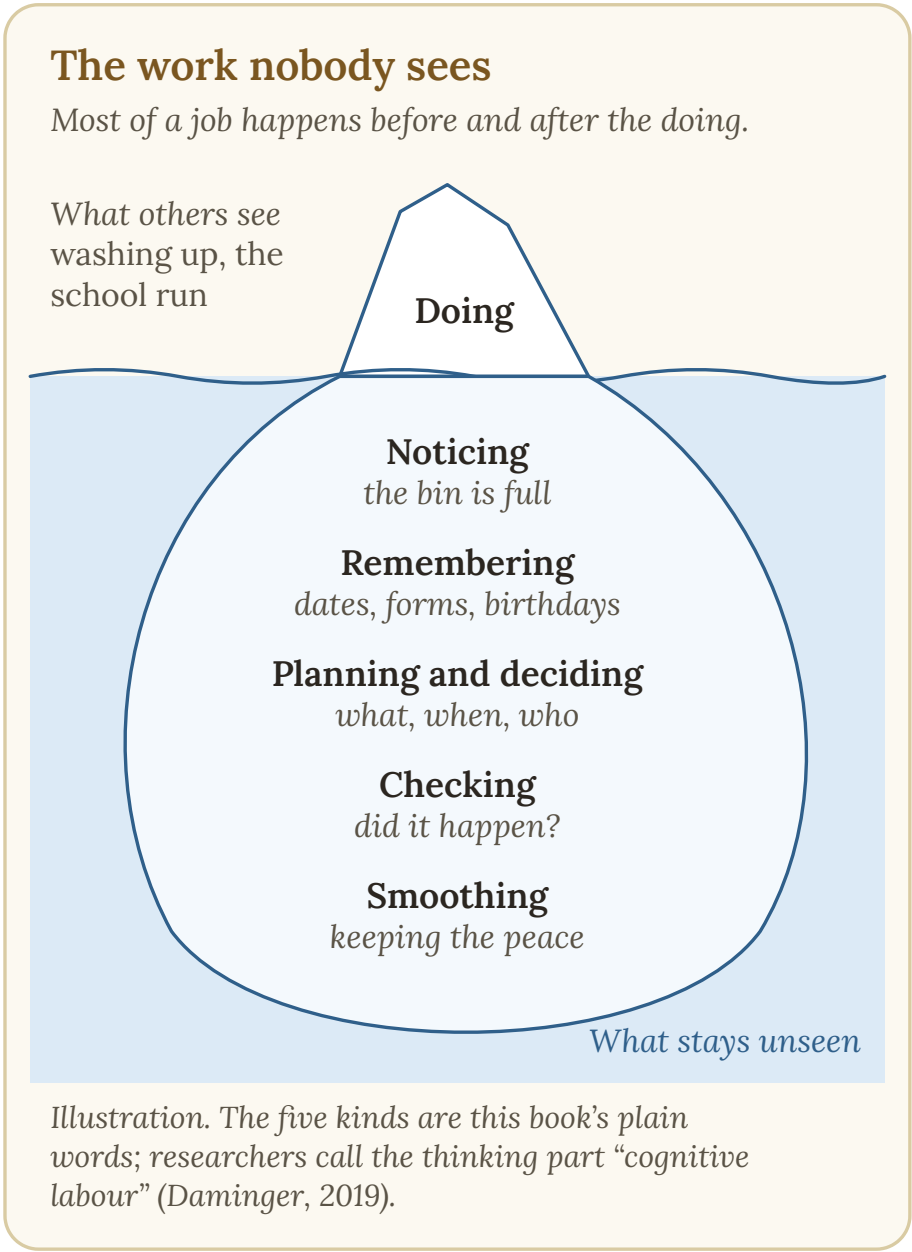



FIGURE 9 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

## The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen, so the other person is rarely ignoring it. From where they stand, things appear to take care of themselves. Edna minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own doctor's appointments to fit, while her daughter believes it all slots in easily. A gentle question often opens it up ("What's something you do that you think I don't see?"), followed by listening without explaining.

Sometimes it only becomes visible when the person who carried it has gone. A widower finds out, slowly, over his first winter alone, how many jobs his wife quietly held: the birthday cards, the boiler service, knowing who to ring when someone was ill. He never saw them until they stopped getting done. If that's where you are, the section for people on their own, further on in this chapter, was written with you in mind.

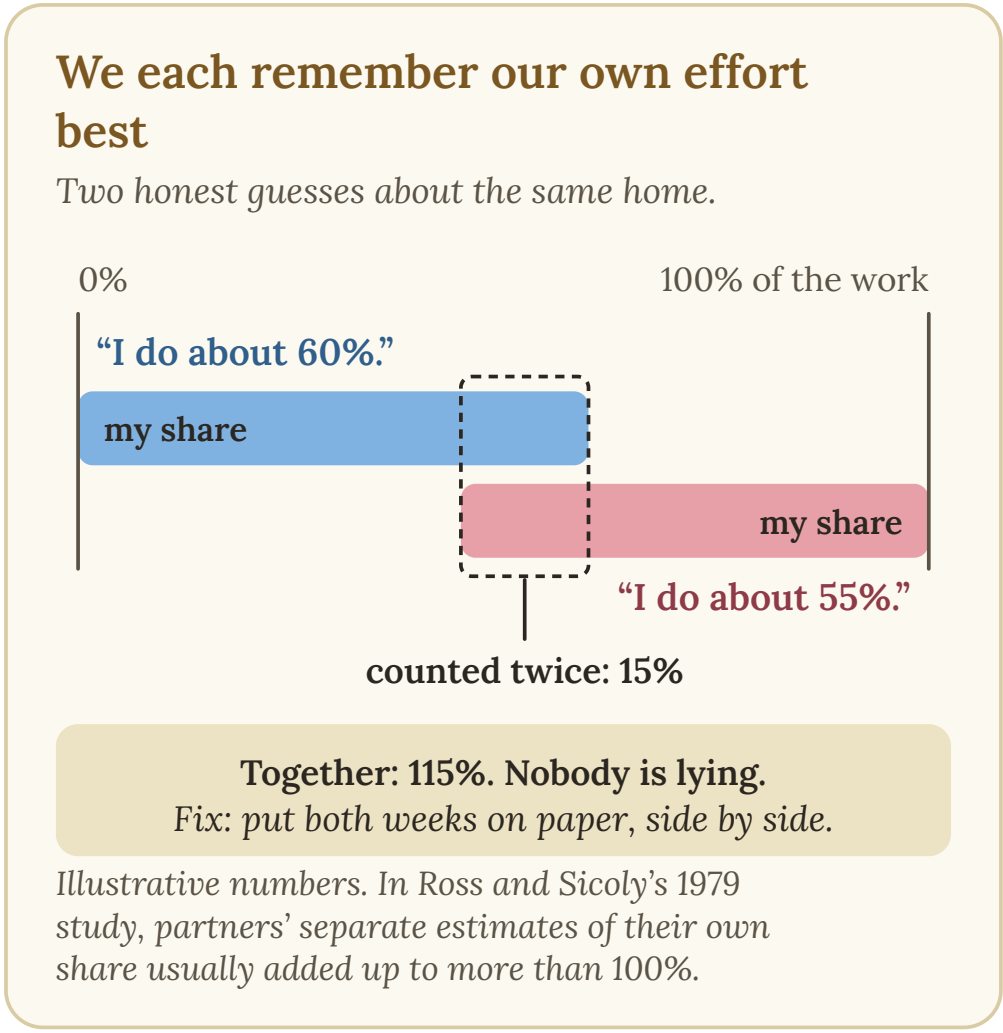



FIGURE 10 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers; in Ross and Sicoly's 1979 study, partners' estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

## Writing it down isn't keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time, so that the talk starts from facts you share. This book calls that shared record a *ledger*, a plain list of who did what, kept for seeing. Two colleagues who job-share each list a week of tasks and find that every difficult client call has landed on the same one of them. They leave last year alone and agree to take turns with the Friday calls. Before you show anyone a

list, ask yourself honestly whether it's to plan next week or to prove a point. If it's the second, keep it in the drawer for now.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

**Who did what**

*Marcus and Theo, a couple*

## Who did what

Person A
*Marcus*

Person B
*Theo*

Week beginning
5 October 2026

### Part A: Who did what, this week

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Mon* | *Plan the week's meals* | *Theo* | 20 | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Mon* | *Cook dinner* | *Marcus* | 45 | *Asked for* |
| *Tue* | *Book the boiler service* | *Theo* | 15 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Tue* | *Dishes* | *Marcus* | 20 | *Asked for* |
| *Wed* | *Laundry, wash to put away* | *Theo* | 60 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Thu* | *Remember Marcus's mum's birthday card* | *Theo* | 10 | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Fri* | *Bins and recycling out* | *Marcus* | 10 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sat* | *Big food shop* | *Both* | 70 | *Asked for* |

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

**Marcus**
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

**Theo**
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

**Workload balance score**
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

**Unasked-for work**
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

**Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no**

Left blank this week.

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

05

## Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did and then read the two lists together, which keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, such as a long week at work or children off school with colds, so that you both understand what you read. Arran, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a rented house, and each writes only their own list. Reading them together at the kitchen table, Sol learns for the first time that Arran has been ringing the landlord about the damp every single month since February.

06

## The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what is happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here. Two brothers share their mum's care, and one of them swaps "You never help" for "There's some unseen work here we haven't looked at." His brother finds it much easier to hear. If words like "ledger" or "debt" feel heavy, use your own. "Our list" and "the stuff nobody sees" do the same job.

07

## One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool, and one week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying that day, and a monthly look-back that needs only a few lines a week. A nurse on nights and a partner on days hardly see each other awake, so they start with one week of notes stuck to the fridge with a magnet from Whitby, and change nothing yet. Your first step can be as small as picking a start day and setting one reminder.



TIDBIT

Counting jobs isn't keeping score. It's looking for the work nobody noticed, and the quick split check is a good place to start.

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`

08

## It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, families, housemates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, and the ideas fit anyone who shares a load. In a foster home, the carer keeps track of family visits and social worker calls, while a teenager in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week, and both kinds of work deserve to be counted.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back towards your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

*"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly. You think: someone did have to. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked as if it took care of itself, the way a house seems to clean itself if you're never in it on a Saturday morning.*

## The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**, meaning the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done and the checking after. It includes knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes, and remembering the form and the party present. It is real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby a gap often opens, and in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to, which researchers call *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in and lets them do it their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, and they say nothing certain about yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women, which is why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper instead of guessing.

Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter II (page 99).

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of, whole jobs, start to finish." Or the other way round, "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

## On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing the unseen. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember (the appointments, the smoothing-over) and write them down for yourself. Count it without charging for it, since the point is to see your real load so that you can plan your energy. Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which simply landed on you, and pick one you could hand back or do less often. Nicola, divorced, has the children every other week, and on paper she sees that she is still buying the birthday presents for both sides of the family, four years after the divorce. She hands his side back in one friendly message, and he replies with a thumbs-up and, to her surprise, "fair enough". More for people living alone or after a breakup is on On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## One household, followed for a month

Three adult siblings share the care of their father, who lives alone in the house they grew up in. On paper the visits are split evenly, two days each. When each of them writes a week of their own side, the picture changes. The eldest, Ffion, also holds the prescriptions, the hospital letters and the calls to the GP, none of which counts as a visit. Their brother is surprised and a little defensive, and the first conversation ends early. A month later they try again,

and he takes over the prescriptions completely, with the reminders on his own phone. Their sister still finds the hospital letters too much to face, so Ffion keeps them for now, and they agree to look again in the spring. The ideas in this chapter fit friendships, teams and shared houses in the same way, and Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) has a page for many kinds of shared life.

## Your situation, chapter by chapter

Some situations get their own section:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws.** Chapter I (page 85)
- **Small children or a new baby.** Chapter II (page 99)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents.** Chapter III (page 117)
- **Money between you, and a couple with a housemate.** Chapter IV (page 133)
- **New together, or grandparents raising a grandchild.** Chapter V (page 147)

## Common mix-ups

"If it mattered, they'd have asked for help" misses how hidden this work is, often from the person doing it, until it's written down. Nobody needs exactly 50/50 either; what you're after is a split you can both see and both agree to. Please don't start by going over the last ten years. Start with one ordinary week, and thank each other for the past without trying to settle it. And the one doing less usually isn't the one who cares less. Usually they just can't see it yet, and once you've both seen it, what happens next is a choice you make together.

To start, each of you can list the things you did this week that nobody saw, then swap lists, read the other one slowly and say one thing on it you hadn't noticed before. Pick one item from their list and say thank you for it in a specific way. If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a cup of coffee with the same questions works too. Fixing comes later, once you have both seen the same picture. Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01) turns this into a gentle week-long log, and How to say

a specific thank-you (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward) has more ideas.

## Limits and cautions

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A list should never be demanded, checked over your shoulder, or used to keep track of where you go or what you spend. If that is happening, it isn't a ledger. It's control, and it's not your fault. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs). If you are a counsellor or group leader using this book with others, see For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors).

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?** page 88
*Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust*

**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other** page 182
*Why each person sees their own work first*

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well** page 305
*Care work and how not to burn out*

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair** page 120
*What fair means to each of you, before you talk*


PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**Who did what**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01

# I

PART TWO · CHAPTER I

# Why we get out of tune: communication at home

*Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. On your own: your side of the tuning
11. One example, followed through
12. Common mix-ups


IN SHORT

- **A clash is often about how things were said.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Say that you are out of tune, pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence** that says what happened, how you feel and what you would like.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

*"I said I'd do it."*

*"I know, I'm just asking when."*

*Four sentences later nobody is talking about the bins any more. Somebody has mentioned last Christmas. Neither of you could point to the moment it turned.*

The radio picture in this chapter is my own. The About page on the website describes how, for years, my closest relationships "filled up with static", with the same misunderstanding arriving again and again, and how what was missing was never care, on either side. It was timing, and a shared way of putting things. This chapter is the shared way.

01

## The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something perfectly reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. Think of two radios slightly out of tune with each other. Together they make a crackle that neither of them was making alone.

One housemate asks, "Is anyone using the oven tonight?" The other says, "Why, did I leave a mess?" A plain question about a lasagne has been heard as a complaint about a baking tray. After your next small clash, ask yourself whether it was the words or the way they came out. It's usually the way.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think the words were fine. Something in how we said them got crossed."

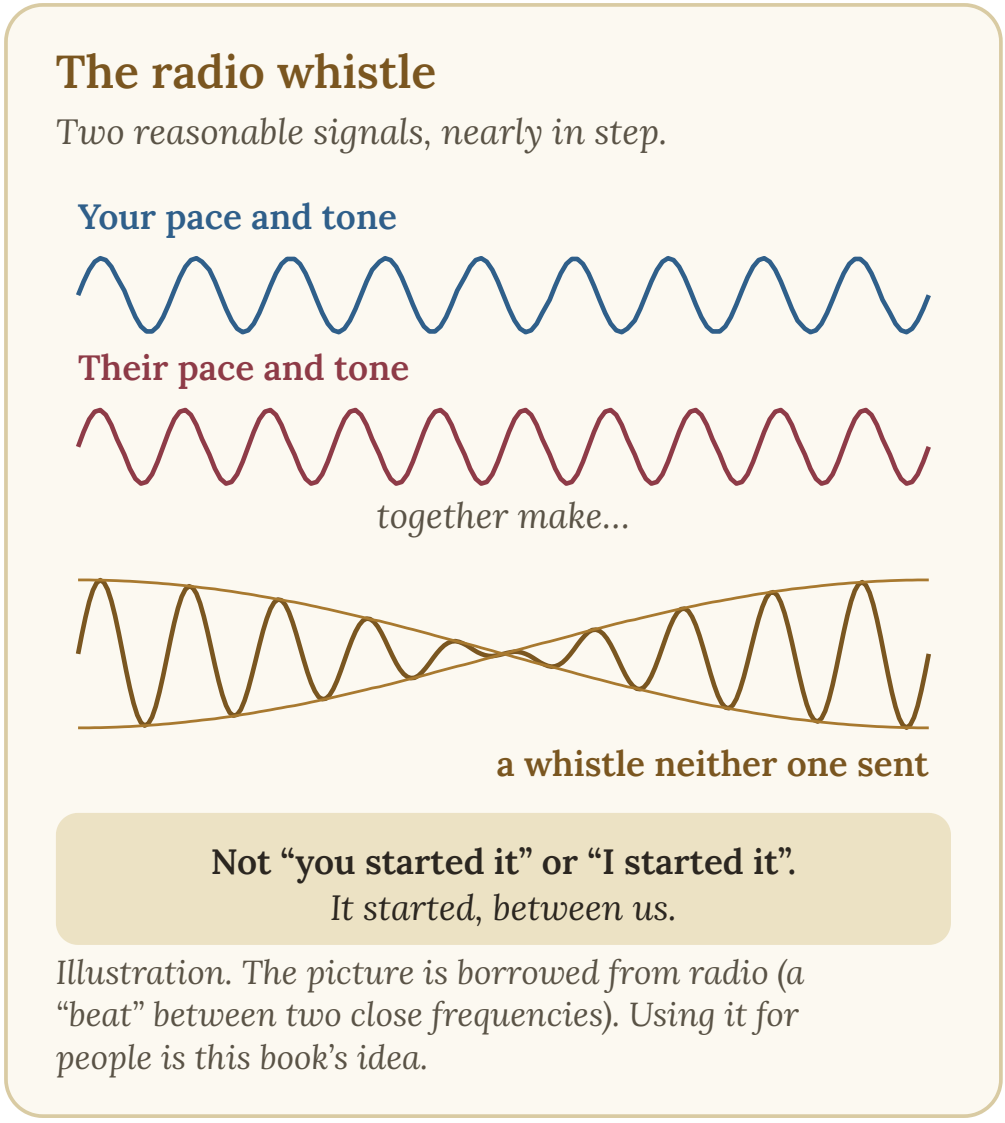



FIGURE 11 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

## Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on very different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they are close but not quite matched, which is why people who know each other well can still clash. Research suggests we check our

meaning less with people we're close to, because we assume they already understand us.

Two sisters who talk on the phone every day argue about holiday plans far more often than either of them does with the cousins they see once a year at a christening or a funeral. The cousins get spelled out; the sisters get shorthand. With someone close to you, check one meaning today: "Just so I've got it right, you mean…?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think I assumed you knew what I meant. Let me say it more clearly."



TIDBIT

Compare your daily rhythms: whose engine runs fast in the morning, and whose at night? Different speeds aren't wrong, they're just different.

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

03

## Three things knock you out of tune.

How fast you're talking is one. Tone is another, as when a simple update is heard as a complaint. The third is how urgent something feels, since "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and some time next week to another. Texts lose most of their tone, which makes urgency especially easy to misread.

One of two business partners texts "Need to talk" between meetings. The other reads it as a crisis and lies awake until two in the morning running through every possible disaster, including the bank. It turns out to be about the printer. Add a time to your next request, so "at some point" becomes "by Friday", and an update can say it's an update.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"By when would be good?" "Is this an update, or a worry?"

04

## Stress changes your station.

When you are tense, you may talk faster and be more likely to hear a pause as a snub. When you are tired and flat, your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, gives you a best guess at which state you are in.

A dad gets home from a night shift at the depot and answers his teenage son in single words. “Fine.” “Yep.” “Later.” His son decides he doesn’t care. He’s simply running on empty, and he’d tell you so if he had the words left.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “I’m running low right now, and it isn’t about you. Can we talk after I’ve slept?”

05

## Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work perfectly will still crackle if they are slightly off, and arguing about whose fault the static is won’t clear it. Retuning will, which just means getting back in step.

A grandmother tells her grown-up son, at the door, that he looks tired. She means it as care. He hears “you’re not coping”. Both of them are right about what they meant and what they heard, which is exactly why arguing about it goes nowhere. In your next clash, try “we” instead of “you”: “We got crossed there.”

> YOU COULD SAY
> “I don’t think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?”

06

## Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say out loud that you think you’re out of sync, and check how tense you feel. Either of you can call a pause, and whoever pauses names a time to come back. Slow down, take shorter turns, and only then go back to the actual topic.

Two roommates in halls agree on a pause word on a calm Sunday, and they pick “static” because it makes them laugh. Three weeks later, in the middle of a row about someone’s music at one in the morning, one of them says it. They stop. They come back at nine the next evening, as agreed, and sort it out in ten minutes. Agree a pause word with someone today, while you’re both calm.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> “I need ten minutes. I’ll come back at half past.”

## Retuning, step by step

*Before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.*

1. **Name the mismatch, without blame**
   "I think we're on different wavelengths."
2. **Check your own state**
   Revved up or running on empty? Pause, and name a time to come back.
3. **Slow the pace on purpose**
   Shorter turns, more pauses, a lower voice.
4. **Then go back to the topic**
   It still matters. Now you can both hear it.

*This book's four steps. Anyone can call a pause, and nobody should be blocked from leaving the room.*

FIGURE 12 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

07

## Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you return to the topic, say what happened, how you feel and what you'd like, in that order and in one go. "The bins go out early on Wednesday morning. I get anxious when they're late. Could you put them out tonight?" Or, from one co-parent to another: "The swim kit wasn't in the bag and I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?" It's worth writing one of these about something small before you need it, so the shape is in your hand when you do.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you go back in, one clear sentence beats a speech. This workpaper helps you shape it before you say it.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

08

## Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), makes tiny corrections before small things drift into a big argument. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

A long-distance couple, one in Leeds and one in Toronto, send each other one 90-second voice note every morning. On the weeks they forget, they notice the difference by Thursday, usually as a slightly odd phone call about nothing much.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was…"

Pick a time and a cue (straight after dinner works for a lot of people) and try it for three days.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

**The 90-second daily check-in**

*Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts*

## The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
*Priya*

Person B
*Dev*

Week beginning
5 October 2026

### Each day

| Day | Person | Stress tank | One thing I appreciated today | One small thing that didn't feel great | One thing that would help tomorrow |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | Priya | High | You left soup in the fridge before my night shift | Woke up to the washing still in the machine | A text when you're leaving work |
| Mon | Dev | Medium | Your note on the kettle | | Bins out before I go at six |
| Tue | Priya | High | You kept the house quiet till noon | | Ten minutes together at the shift change |
| Tue | Dev | Light | You booked the car in | Missed you at dinner again | |
| Wed | Priya | Medium | Breakfast together at 8 | | Early night |
| Wed | Dev | Medium | You remembered my mum's call | | |

STRESS TANK THIS WEEK

**Priya**
2 high, 1 medium, 0 light

**Dev**
0 high, 2 medium, 1 light

### The weekly catch-up

| Sore spot that keeps coming up | Times this week | Move to |
|---|---|---|
| *Washing left in the machine* | 2 | *One owner per job* |
| *Missing each other at dinner* | 2 | *Keep watching* |

*Made-up example. One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.*

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

SATURDAY, 10AM

*One of you says the spare room needs clearing out at some point. She meant this month, and he heard today and has already cancelled his plans in his head. By lunchtime you are both upset about a room nobody has touched, and when you stop to ask what "at some point" meant, you find you are still not sure you agree.*

## Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first, and a shared faith can be one of the strongest tools for staying in tune. Praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can serve as a daily check-in. Some couples each pray on their own before they come back to a hard talk, with the pause still ending at a named time. A pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to, and many can suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

Emeka and Ngozi, married for twenty-six years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch. When a talk gets heated, either of them can say, "Let's pray on it and come back at eight," and they do.

Culture shapes how you talk too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom, and one habit helps a great deal, which is that each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives once you have agreed the message together.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?" "Mum, we love you, and we've thought about it carefully. This year we'll visit in August instead of at Easter."

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

## On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace and your own sense of urgency, so you notice when you are the one running fast or slow. Learn your early signs of drifting. A clipped reply is a common one, and so is a sudden need to win. Learn how you take words in best and say it once, as in "I hear things better in writing." When you drift, step out, settle and come back, which you can do without anyone's permission. Hamid lives alone and has noticed that his texts to friends come

out short when he is tired, so now he waits until morning to answer anything that matters (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## One example, followed through

Cerys, Marisol and Dougie share a house and a car, and two of them talk fast while the third, Dougie, talks slowly. At house meetings Dougie kept getting talked over, and for a while the other two read his silence as agreement. It came out in March, when he said he had never actually agreed to the new car rota. They tried a simple change, a round in which each person speaks once before anyone answers. It felt stilted at first, and Cerys kept wanting to jump in. By the third meeting Dougie was saying more, and the rota he suggested is the one they now use. They still have the occasional evening when the meeting turns into two fast talkers and one quiet one, and someone usually says "round" to reset it. Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) has pages for many other kinds of shared life.

## Common mix-ups

Retuning isn't giving in. You still come back to the topic, at a time when you can hear each other. Being out of sync doesn't mean one of you is wrong, either; two fair points in two different tones will still clash. And a pause never means the topic is dropped. A pause always comes with a time to come back, or it isn't a pause.

To try it, agree on a shared phrase while things are calm, such as "I think we're out of tune", so that it works as a signal when you need it. For one week, each of you can note one moment you felt out of step, and at the end you can compare whether it was mostly pace, tone or urgency. Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder), Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) and the 90-second daily check-in are free on the site.

**A limit to keep in mind:** These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When

someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works**
*How meaning, tone and listening work* page 195

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down* page 166

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*How you like to be spoken to* page 35

**Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently**
*When pace and tone are a wiring difference* page 261


PUT IT TO USE



**Six-week program, week 1**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



**The 90-second daily check-in**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in

# II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

# Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

*One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: is your own load working?
11. One setup, looked at twice
12. Common mix-ups
13. Small children and a new baby
14. If only one of you wants to try this
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Look at the month, not last night**, using what you both wrote down.
- **Three things go in**, which are how the hours split, whether each job has a name, and how full each person's stress tank is.
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- **It judges the setup, never a person**, and it is where a talk starts.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

*One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about: the bin rota, the fish food, the reply to the school, the dentist reminder, the bit of the shopping list that says "bulbs?". When the other says it feels even, they mean it. From inside their own week, it does.*

01

## Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask whether the split is working, the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Ask it again every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

Two housemates had one truly awful week of dishes in May, the kind where you wash a fork to eat with it. The whole month, written down, showed three ordinary weeks and one exam week, which changes the conversation completely. Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.



SUGARFOOT

One bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with something to eat.

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

02

## Three things go in.

The first is how evenly the hours are shared. The second is whether every regular job has a clear owner, from the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). The third is how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on. A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start; rough notes on the back of an envelope work too.

YOU COULD SAY

"Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

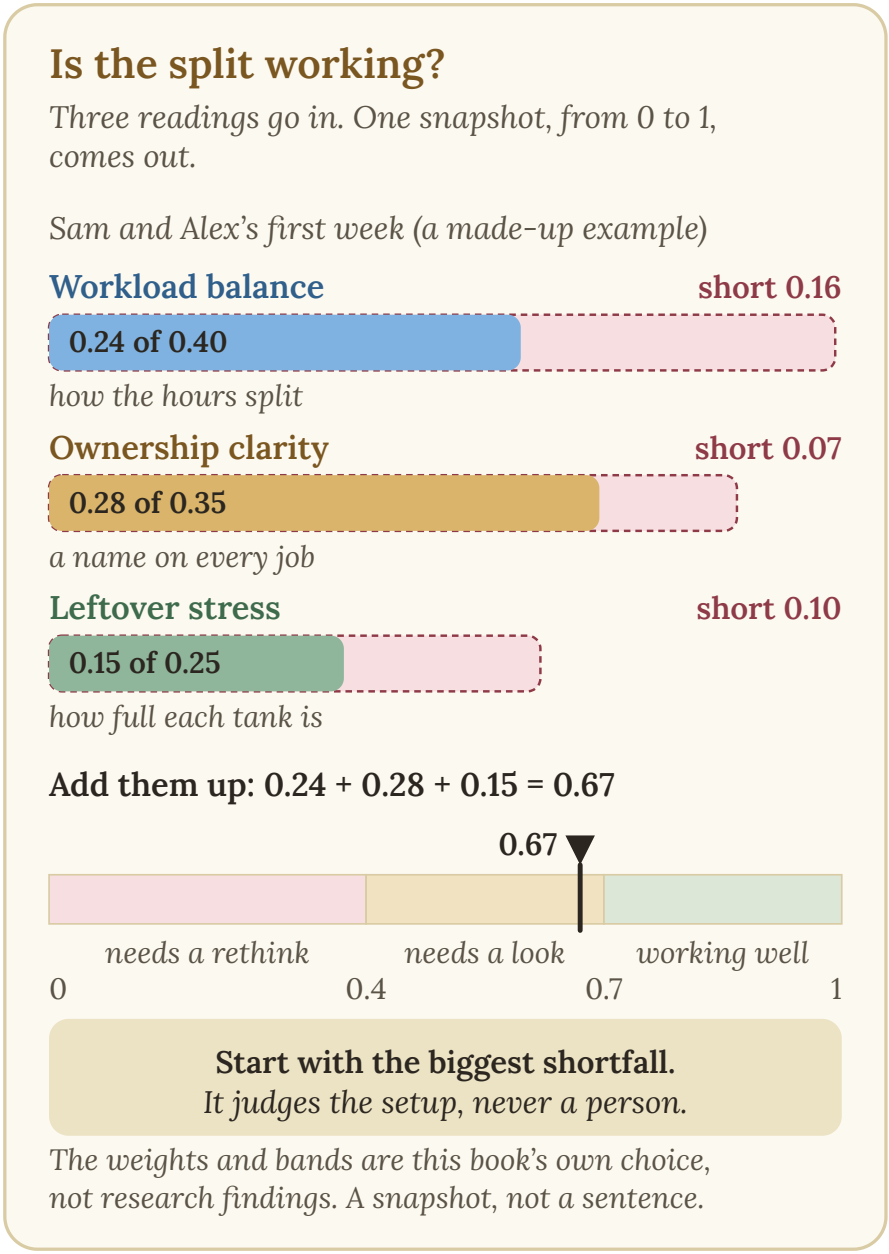



FIGURE 13 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

## Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1 and one person doing everything scores 0, whichever person it is. If you have agreed an uneven split that suits you, perhaps because one of you works longer hours outside the home, compare against that split instead. With three or more of you, compare each person's share with an even share (100 divided by the number of people) or with the split you agreed. Three partners who log 30 hours of home jobs between them, at 15, 9 and 6, would each have 10 as an even share. The "Who does what?" page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic for you.

Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes. Those are the ones that go missing.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

**Who does what? Quick look**

*Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)*

### Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name
*Wren*

Their name
*Josh*

Person 3
*Mei*

| Job | Who mostly does it |
|---|---|
| *Dishes* | *Shared* |
| *Laundry* | *Shared* |
| *Cleaning the bathroom* | *Josh* |
| *Cooking dinner* | *Mei* |
| *Grocery shopping* | *Wren* |

| Job | Who mostly does it |
|---|---|
| *Paying bills* | *Wren* |
| *Noticing what's running low* | *Wren* |
| *Planning the week* | *Mei* |
| *Remembering dates and appointments* | *Wren* |

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

*Made-up example. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.*

Fill in your own: Who does what? Quick look (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

## Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names. The owner does the job from start to finish, and the backstop notices if it slipped and checks in gently, which is very different from supervising. It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner and divide by all the jobs on the list, and leave the jobs nobody owns on the list, because they matter most. A *decision* you make together, such as which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)" and counts as owned, while a *job* that needs doing gets one name.

This one comes almost straight from my old job. In audit work, most of the failures I saw weren't incompetence. They were unclear ownership: work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it quietly lands on whoever

notices first. Two sisters care for their dad, and nobody owned his repeat prescription, so for a fortnight each of them thought the other had ordered it. He ran out on a Sunday.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> “Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn’t fall between us?”



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

A job without a name tends to land on whoever notices first. Write one owner next to each job, and the guessing stops.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

## Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), where a higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your two scores, but if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the overall result looks fine. A setup that only works when you are both well rested can’t last, so more stress lowers the result. A grandmother raising two grandchildren scores 0.70 while her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. Her 0.70 is the headline, whatever the average says. Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other’s.

06

## One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

A result of 0.70 or above reads as *working well*, meaning the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as *needs a look*, because something is drifting, often who owns what, and below 0.40 it reads as *needs a rethink, together*. The result is called the setup score. It is a simple weighted sum, in which the hours count most, then the owners, then stress, and although it looks like a probability it isn’t one. Two friends who run a café together score 0.55, which tells them nothing is broken and something is drifting; it turns out to be the

Monday ordering, which both of them assumed the other did. Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

**Is the setup working for everyone?**
*Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years*

## Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
*Rosemary*

Person 2 (optional)
*Ken*

### 1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the "Who does what?" page: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

### 2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

### 3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

**Working well**
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

*It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.*

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

## Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add, and in the middle band it is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. Separated parents score 0.62 and find that their biggest gap is that nobody owns the school forms, so that is the only thing they change this month.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

08

## It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor

on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

One partner sees 0.35 and says, "So I'm the problem." The other says no, the bathroom has no owner and he works nights, and they start there. Before you begin, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back towards your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

SUNDAY EVENING

*Two week-long logs and two cups of tea on the table. One list has 31 rows. The other has 18. For a moment nobody says anything, and the fridge hums. Then one of you says, "I honestly didn't know about half of these."*

## Words this chapter uses

A **log** is a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took. The **owner** does a job from start to finish, including remembering it, and the **backstop** notices if a job slipped and checks in gently. Your **stress tank** is how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life. The **setup** is the way you share the work right now, which can always be changed, and the **setup score** is the one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing that the soap is running low all belong in your log.

## On your own: is your own load working?

You can ask the same question about your own week, which is whether you are spending more energy than comes back. Add up what you carry, jobs and worries both, and set it beside what refills you. If it runs in the red, change your side by dropping, delaying, asking or saying no kindly. A limit describes your supply, and it says nothing about your worth. After a breakup, Leanne has her children every other week and fills the quiet weeks with favours for friends, including one memorable flat-pack wardrobe. Writing it down shows her she never rests (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

## One setup, looked at twice

Three people share a flat above a bakery, and everyone agrees that cleaning matters while nobody owns the bathroom. Their first check scores 0.67, and the biggest shortfall is ownership: eight of the twelve jobs have a name, and the bathroom, the bins, the recycling and the hallway don't. They give each of those four jobs an owner and a backstop. A month later, with the hours and their stress tanks about the same as before, the score is 0.79. Ownership went from 0.67 to 1.00, and that part counts for 0.35 of the score, so it adds 0.12. The bathroom is better and the recycling is still a sore point, because the one who owns it works late on collection night, and that is the job they talk about next. Shift work, illness and caring can all make hours look even while sleep or energy is not, and an uneven split agreed on purpose can be the fair one (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and When one of you is ill, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

**Our room agreement**

*Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates*

## Our room agreement

Your name
*Kayla*

Their name
*Bea*

Quiet hours
*11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.*

Guests (daytime)
*Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.*

Overnight guests
*Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.*

Cleaning
*Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.*

Borrowing
*Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.*

Lights and alarms
*Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.*

How we bring up problems
*Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.*

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

*They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.*

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

## Common mix-ups

A low number doesn't mean the relationship is failing. It means the current setup needs changing, and setups change all the time. Please don't guess the numbers; a guessed number is a feeling with a decimal point, so use your written logs. One of you can't fill it in for both, either. Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank. And fair doesn't have to mean exactly 50/50. Fair is what you both agree to with your eyes open, and an uneven split you chose together can be the fair one. Two kinds of fair (page 120) looks at this.

## Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs, such as the nursery bag, the jabs, the party invitations, the next size of clothes and the night wakings. That is why the mental load (see the work nobody sees, page 71) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it. Log the children's jobs too, with the thinking time, and count the nights. Hand over whole jobs, such as the clothes and sizes or the GP and the jabs, so that the new owner does the noticing too, in their own way. If a baby is on the way, write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights and agree to look again at six weeks, at three months and before either of you goes back to work. In the first weeks, share by energy more than by hours, so that whoever was up in the night gets the rest.

Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, who is three, and Poppy, who is eight months old, and Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes come out

nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They leave the minutes alone and move one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth.

YOU COULD SAY

"Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

**Who did what, with small children**

*Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts*

## Who did what

Person A
*Hollie*

Person B
*Gareth*

Week beginning
*12 October 2026*

### Part A: Who did what, this week

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Mon* | *Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk* | *Hollie* | 10 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Tue* | *Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP* | *Hollie* | 15 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Tue* | *Bath and bedtime, both children* | *Gareth* | 45 | *Asked for* |
| *Wed* | *Reply to a party invite and buy the present* | *Hollie* | 25 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Wed* | *Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size* | *Hollie* | 40 | *Noticed and handled* |

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Thu* | *Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights* | *Hollie* | *20* | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Thu* | *Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend* | *Gareth* | *75* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Fri* | *Remember the nursery photo money and form* | *Hollie* | *10* | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Fri* | *Night wakings with Poppy* | *Hollie* | *60* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sat* | *Swimming lesson with Alfie* | *Gareth* | *60* | *Asked for* |
| *Sat* | *Big food shop and nappies* | *Both* | *80* | *Asked for* |
| *Sun* | *Washing for both children, to put away* | *Hollie* | *50* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sun* | *Fix the stair gate* | *Gareth* | *20* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sun* | *Update the family calendar and the childcare rota* | *Hollie* | *20* | *Thinking and planning* |

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

**Hollie**
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

**Gareth**
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

**Workload balance score**
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

**Unasked-for work**
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

**Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no**

Left blank this week.

*Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.*

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

## If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week, score your own tank and then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers. A dad noticed he was spending five hours a week driving his sixteen-year-old to training and back, said so without any accusation, and they agreed on a bus pass for two days a week. His son grumbled for a fortnight and then started enjoying the bus. Share one finding at a time and then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at

home?

## More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

To run the check, each of you first logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), because the number only means something if you each wrote your own. Next, fill in the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet, and each score your own stress tank on the same day. Put the three numbers into the calculator (spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working), look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together and check again in a month.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*The unseen work the check counts*
page 62

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*The stress input, explained*
page 105

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*Fixing the setup with small, kind changes*
page 223

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well**
*When one person carries the care*
page 305

PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**One owner per job**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

# III

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

# Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

*Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: reading your own tank
11. Common mix-ups
12. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
13. If only one of you wants to try this
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **A full tank overflows**, so stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute**, and say the band out loud so nobody has to guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles**, and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means later**, so pause, name a time and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

*They ask, perfectly pleasantly, whether you remembered to call the dentist. Your answer comes out about four sizes bigger than the question deserved, with a bit about the car thrown in, and you can hear it happening while it happens.*

01

## A full tank overflows.

If you're already tired or stretched from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction, which is simply human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you have both calmed down. A nurse gets in at eight in the morning after a night shift, and her housemate, eating cornflakes, asks whether she saw his message about the electricity meter. She bites his head off. Twelve hours on her feet did the biting; the meter just came at the end of them.

YOU COULD SAY

"Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I'm running on empty."

02

## Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of you and how much you brought in with you. Being upset about the dishes and being exhausted, with the dishes as the thing you noticed, are different problems. Some of what we bring in is much older, such as an understanding from growing up that whoever notices the mess has to clean it, and if a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) helps you find where it started.

A fourteen-year-old has a horrible day at school, the kind he won't talk about, comes home and explodes because his brother has taken the phone charger. Again. The charger was the last drop in a tank that was already full at lunchtime.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Before a hard talk, check how full your own tank is. Five quick questions, about two minutes, and you'll know whether now is the time.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

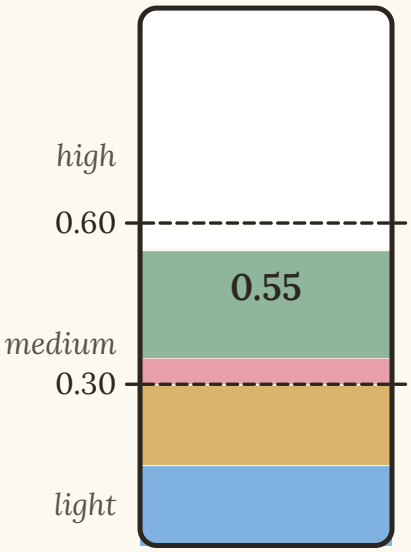
03

## Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is, and a higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4, which are sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels and time pressure today, then add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium and 0.60 or more is high. If it has been high for a long time it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it. A man caring for his wife after her hip operation scores 0.65 three days in a row. That tells him something he hadn't let himself think, which is that he needs help more than he needs to try harder. He rings his son that evening. Score yourself tomorrow morning, before you look at your phone.

## How full is your stress tank?

*Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.*




**Sam today**

| | |
|---|---|
| Time pressure today | 4 |
| Body: hungry, unwell, in pain | 0 |
| Unresolved conflict | 1 |
| Workload elsewhere | 3 |
| Sleep debt | 3 |
| **11 ÷ 20** | **= 0.55** |

**Medium: say it before a hard talk.**
*"Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today."*

*Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.*

FIGURE 14 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. The scores shown are an example; the items and bands are this book's.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

**How much are you carrying?**

*Rosa, who shares her mum's care with her brother*

## How much are you carrying?

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name
*Rosa*

Date
*7 October 2026*

### The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR STRESS TANK

**Your stress tank today**
High (13 out of 20 points)

**What to do**
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

**If it can't wait**
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

**Filled most by**
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

**Stress tank score**
0.65 out of 1.00

### Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
*Mum's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.*

*Made-up example. Higher means a fuller stress tank. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.*

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02)

04

## Three everyday states.

Knowing whether you are calm and connected, revved up or running on empty tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. The labels come from polyvagal theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists, and here they are used

only as everyday words. In one long-distance couple, he takes the video call at midnight his time and is usually running on empty by then, so they move the hard talks to Saturday mornings. It helps to know one body clue for each state; a tight jaw is a common one for revved up.

05

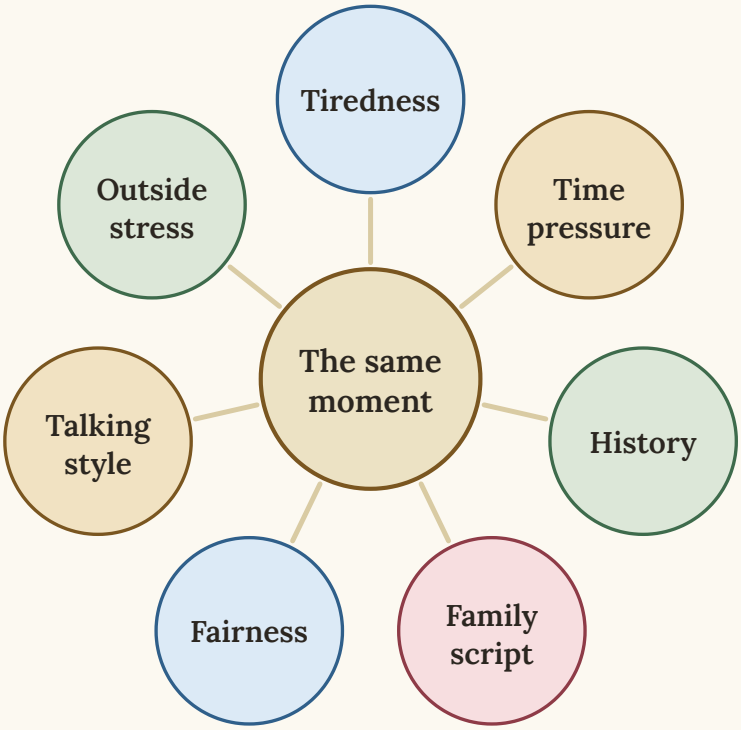
### There are seven angles on the same moment.

The seven angles are tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure that the other sees what they see. The "See their side" step of Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) is built on these seven angles and helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask in place of guesses. Planning Christmas, one parent sees it from family habit (they always go to her mum's, and there's a stocking with each child's name on it) and the other sees it from fairness, since they went there last year too, and the year before.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "Which angle are you seeing this from?"

## Seven angles on the same moment

*Which one are you looking from right now?*




**An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.**
*Name your own. Ask about theirs.*

*Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Rewind the talk's "See their side" uses them.*

FIGURE 15 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

**Rewind the talk: see their side**

*Hana, about her friend Lou*

## See their side

1. What happened?

*I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe".*

2. Who are they to you?

Partner  Family  Roommate  *Friend*  Coworker  Co-parent

My teen or child  Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected  Revved up  *Running on empty*  I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day  *Little sleep*  Rushed or late  Money worries

*Caring for someone*  Not feeling their best  A noisy or crowded place

Other people were there  *It was a text or message*  It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot  They take words literally  *They need time to process*

They think out loud  They're very direct  They hint rather than say

They like a plan  Noise, light or crowds get to them

Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before  They grew up with it done differently

*It's a sore topic for them*  They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload  *a message, call or news you didn't see*

something they had already planned or done  how it looked from where they stood

a promise someone else made them  how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done · *the reason behind your timing*

what you actually meant · how tired or stretched you were · the part already done

a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

*each other's tone, in writing* · what was going on in the other's head

what would happen next · what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether, for you, you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

*These are possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.*

Fill in your own: Rewind the talk: see their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder)

06

## Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing, so the useful question is which angle each of you is seeing it from. Two adult brothers argue about their late mother's house. One sees thirty years of memories, the height marks on the kitchen door

frame, the apple tree. The other sees a roof that needs £9,000 of work. Both of them are looking at the real house.

WORDS TO TRY

"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

07

## Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your stress tank is and which angle you are seeing things from. It works best at the start. Two colleagues begin a tense meeting about a missed deadline with one sentence each about their tank and their angle. It feels a bit odd. The meeting is shorter and calmer than the last one, and nobody cries in the toilets afterwards.

YOU COULD SAY

"Before we start, I'm about half full today, and I'm seeing this from the time angle."



TIDBIT

Say your number out loud, as in "I'm about a seven today." It takes two seconds, and nobody has to guess.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

08

## A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause and never a way out of the talk. Say when you will come back, and let the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round if you still feel hot, and if you are still at 0.60 or more after two rounds, pick a new time and say when. A dad and his fourteen-year-old get heated about phone time. He tells her he's too wound up and will talk at seven. At seven he knocks on her door, which matters more than anything he says once he's inside.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need a break. I'll come back at seven. I promise."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

MONDAY MORNING

*You both look at the same pile of post on the kitchen table, eleven envelopes and a pizza menu. One of you sees a to-do list, and the other sees proof that nobody else ever opens the post. You try saying your angles out loud, and it helps for about a minute before the old argument about the gas bill comes back. The pile is still there at lunchtime, and neither of you has decided whose it is.*

## Words this chapter uses

Your **stress tank** is how much stress you are already carrying before this moment even starts. **Leftover stress** is the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day, while **this-moment stress** is caused by what is in front of you right now. An **angle** is the point of view you are seeing a moment from, such as tiredness or fairness.

## On your own: reading your own tank

On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your tank before you react. Check it for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern, ask yourself before a hard moment how much of it is left over from earlier, and decide on a calm day what settles you so that it is ready when you need it. Living alone after a breakup, Bryony noticed that she snapped at her sister on the phone every Monday. Her morning readings

showed why: Sunday nights were her worst sleep of the week, every week. Now she asks for Tuesday instead (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## Common mix-ups

A big reaction sometimes means it was a big deal. Quite often it means the tank was already full. A high score is never an excuse, either; it's a note to come back later, never a pass to skip the talk. You can't tell how full someone else's tank is, however well you know them, which is why each person scores only themselves. And a pause isn't the silent treatment, because a pause has a time to come back. That's why you always say when.

## Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank, so being quiet, clingy or cross for a few hours after a handover is common and usually says nothing bad about the other home. It helps to give them landing time, with a snack, something familiar and no questions about the other home for the first hour. The child is never the messenger, because adult news goes adult to adult. For money, follow any formal arrangement. Split the extras by a ratio you agree, and settle up once a month from one list. With an ex, share the band and keep the story, as in "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?", and your private life stays yours. If an ex won't cooperate but isn't dangerous, parallel parenting can work, with written messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school and your own list for your own home. When there are new partners, the parent stays the owner of anything involving the other home, and a step-parent starts as a friendly adult rather than the one who tells the children off.

Harriet gives Freya, who is eight, and Arlo, who is five, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's, and she has stopped asking what happened at Dad's at the front door. Sunday evenings are calmer, though Arlo still cries at bedtime on changeover days, and she is waiting to see whether that eases.

WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE)

"Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on 6 November and costs £24. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If you are afraid of your ex, a shared plan isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

## If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this on your own side, by checking your own tank, naming your own angle and pausing and coming back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help, and when one person starts saying it out loud, the other often starts to as well. A daughter visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash over his health. She starts each visit by saying she is a bit tired today, so if she goes quiet it isn't about him. He never scores anything himself, and still the visits get calmer, and one Sunday he says, unprompted, "I'm a bit tired today as well, love."

**A note on safety:** A full tank explains a reaction. It never excuses shouting, threats or hurting anyone. If someone's "stress" often turns into fear for you, that isn't a tank problem. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If sharing how you feel ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

## More for your situation

Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Long distance

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

Before your next hard conversation, score the five things in How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), add them up and divide by 20, then say one sentence out loud about your tank and your angle. If either of you scores 0.60 or more, put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour, and agree on a time to come back.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*The ladder, flooding and rest* page 166

**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other**
*The angles and stories behind a reaction* page 182

**Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger**
*What to do in the hot minutes* page 319

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Checking your own weather first* page 35


PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**How much are you carrying?**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

# IV

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

# Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

*Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. On your own: your own kind of fair
10. Common mix-ups
11. Money between you
12. A couple and a housemate
13. More for your situation
14. A note on safety


IN SHORT

- **There are two kinds of fair**, by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?), so agree which one you are using.
- **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner**, and when you cover for someone, say so out loud.
- **Let a comment land before you react** by noticing it, naming it and then deciding what to say.
- **Keep the two questions apart**, because whether the job was done is a fact and whether the comment hurt is a feeling.

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

*One of you counts hours. The other counts who noticed that the job needed doing in the first place. You're both counting honestly, in two different currencies, and then arguing about the exchange rate, usually on a Sunday evening, usually about the oven.*

01

## There are two kinds of fair.

One kind asks whether everything got done, and the other asks whether each person did what they said they would. Both are reasonable, and friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realising. Nisha and Kezia share a room in halls. Nisha thinks a week was fair if the room is tidy by Friday, whoever tidied it. Kezia thinks it was fair if each of them kept her own half clean. For most of the first term they each think the other is being unreasonable, and neither of them is.

YOU COULD SAY

"When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

## Two kinds of fair

*Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when you use different ones without saying so.*

### Fair by results

*Asks: Did it all get done?*

Guards: Will the home keep running?

Good: flexible. Watch: it can hide who always steps in.

- Bins ✓
- Dentist ✓
- Forms ✓

### Fair by promises

*Asks: Did each of us do what we agreed?*

Guards: Can I rely on you?

Good: clear. Watch: it can feel rigid in a hard week.

- Bins · Sam ✓
- Dentist · Maya ✗
- Forms · Lin ✓

### The agreement: look to the owner

**Bins · owner: Sam**

*second name: Alex, who notices and asks once*

*Once a job has a named owner, judge it by whether the owner did their part (swapping or asking ahead counts), not by whether someone quietly covered. Made-up examples.*

FIGURE 16 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable; trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

02

## Fair by results.

This kind of fair judges by outcomes, by whether the right things got done by whoever had the time or energy. It is flexible and easy-going. Done carefully it counts the cost to whoever covered, and done carelessly it can hide who is always stepping in. A grandmother raising her grandchildren has a grown-up son who helps with whatever is needed when he's home, cheerfully and well. The house runs. And she is always, always the one who notices what is needed. For one week, mark every job you picked up that wasn't planned; the tally is often a surprise.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 14

**Who does what? The Money tab**

*Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes*

### Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
*£ (pounds)*

| Bill | Grace paid (£) | Ruth paid (£) | How it's shared |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Rent* | 1,100 | 700 | *Shared, split* |
| *Power and water* | 160 | 0 | *Shared, split* |
| *Internet and phones* | 0 | 90 | *Shared, split* |
| *Groceries* | 300 | 250 | *Shared, split* |

| | Grace brings in (£) | Ruth brings in (£) | How it's shared |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Pay* | 4,200 | 2,800 | *Money coming in* |

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace £1,560; Ruth £1,040.

Coming in: £7,000 (Grace £4,200, Ruth £2,800). After shared bills: £4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in £260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

*Made-up example. Money is a fair topic only where nobody controls the other's money.*

Fill in your own: Who does what? (Money tab) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

03

## Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It is clear and steady, and it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way. Two business partners run a café. One owns the ordering, the other owns the staff rota. When the rota is late (it's the Thursday before a bank holiday, it's always late then) they ask the rota owner about it, rather than "the team", and nobody takes it personally.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take the bins?"

04

## Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop, who notices if it slipped and checks in gently without supervising, and it can be the same person. If the job is yours, the question is whether you did it, and somebody quietly covering

for you doesn't answer it. That protects the person who keeps filling the gaps. In one stepfamily the thirteen-year-old owns feeding the dog and his stepmum is the second name. When the bowl is empty at seven, she says "Dog's dinner?" once, without doing it for him and without a lecture.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 15

**One owner per job**

*Dee and Mark, foster carers*

### One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A
*Dee*

Person B
*Mark*

Date of this list
*4 October 2026*

The split you agreed (optional)
*Dee works three days; Mark works full time*

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Social worker visits* | *Monthly* | 1.5 | *Dee* | *Mark* | *Mark joins by video when he can* |
| *Reviews and meetings* | *As needed* | 2 | *Dee* | *Mark* | *Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones* |
| *Daily log and placement paperwork* | *Daily* | 0.5 | *Dee* | *Mark* | *Mark writes it on Dee's work days* |
| *Contact visits and calls with their family* | *Weekly* | 1.5 | *Mark* | *Dee* | *Saturday mornings* |
| *School liaison (designated teacher, plans)* | *As needed* | 1 | *Dee* | | |

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Being there after contact* | *As needed* | 1 | *Mark* | *Dee* | *Quiet tea, no questions* |
| *Health and therapy appointments* | *As needed* | 1.5 | *Dee* | | |
| *Training and support group* | *Monthly* | 2 | *Mark* | | *Mark's turn this term* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

**How the jobs are spread**
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time". Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
*Dee and Mark*

*"Being there after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

## Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely, and it helps to mention it, so that the help is seen, as in "I put the bins out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency). Two grown-up sisters take turns driving their dad to his appointments. When one covers for the other, she texts the same day:

"Took Dad on Thursday, you were on lates. All fine, bloods normal." It takes ten seconds and it stops the help from going invisible.



SUGARFOOT

Covering for someone is kind. Say that you did, gently, and ask for what you'd like next time, so it doesn't turn into quiet resentment.

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

06

## Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say "Give me a second." The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically in a fraction of a second, while this pause is a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether the remark needs an answer now or later, or at all. A nurse comes down at two in the afternoon after a night shift and her husband says, "Oh, you're up." She hears "at last". She says she needs a second because she's very tired, and it turns out he meant he was glad to see her and had saved her the last of the soup (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). Agree your own "give me a second" phrase today, while things are calm.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a comment stings, give it a minute to land before you answer. This workpaper is a short check for your reply.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

07

## Notice, name, decide.

First notice that a comment landed hard, then name it kindly, as in "That hit harder than you probably meant," and once you have settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words. A fifteen-year-old tells her dad that he never listens. He feels his chest tighten. He says that stings, and that he wants to hear her properly, and he decides it needs a real talk,

the next evening, after her swimming, in the car, which is where they talk best.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> “I want to answer that, just not this minute. Can we talk at eight?”

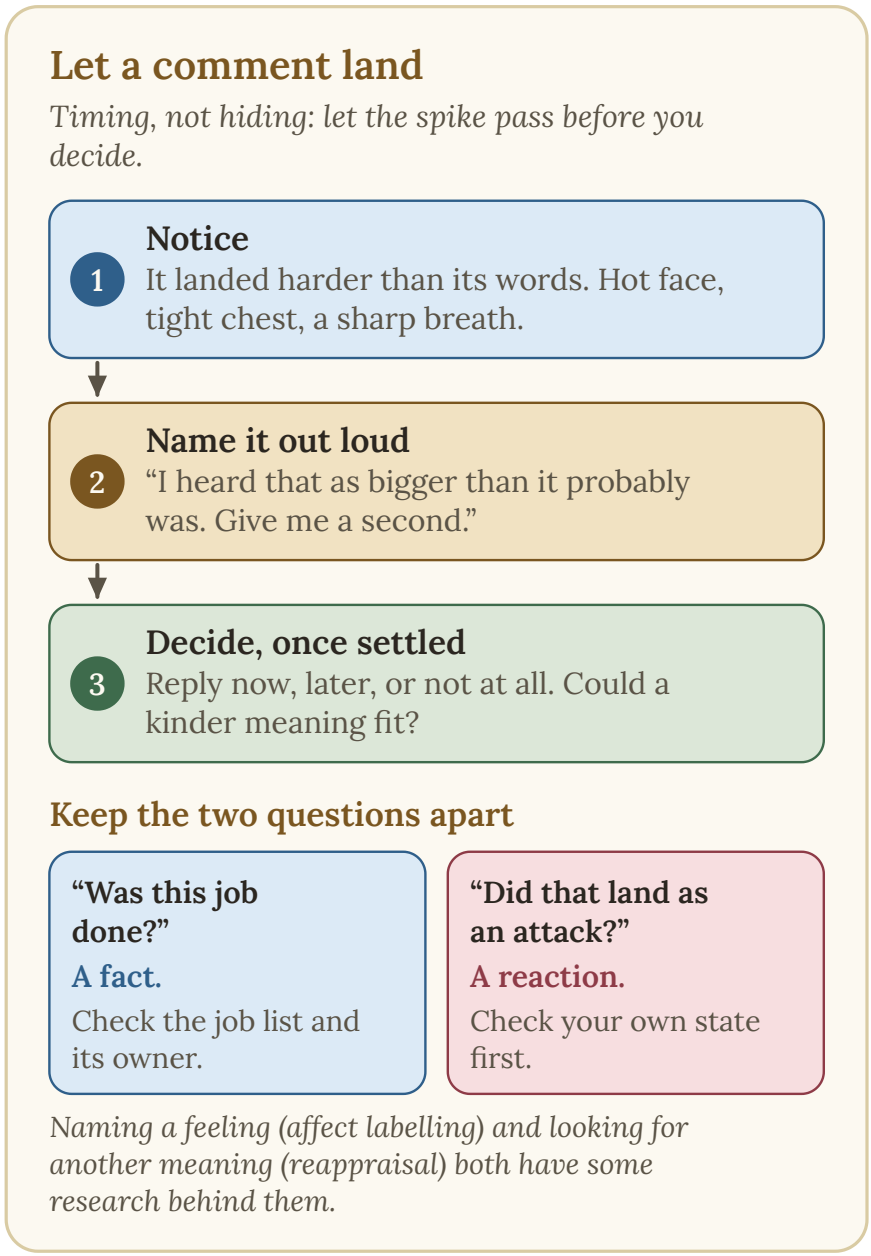



FIGURE 17 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 16

**Say it so it lands**

*Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi*

## Say it so it lands

Your name
*Carla*

Date
*8 October 2026*

### Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction
*Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.*

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)
*The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4.*

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)
*I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.*

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)
*Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?*

### Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(*Yes*) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (*Not sure*)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(*Yes*) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

(*Their words*) A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

**Ways to say it**

Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

**Suggestions**

Your own stress tank is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

*The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.*

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09)

08

## Keep the two questions apart.

Whether the job was done is a question about a fact, and whether the comment hurt is a question about a feeling. Both matter, and each goes better in its own conversation. Separated parents share their children across two homes, and the bag comes back without the school shoes, along with a text about it that felt cold. They sort out the shoes first and talk about the text on Sunday (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting). When a talk tangles, "Fact or feeling?" is a good question to ask out loud, and then you finish one before starting the other.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

*Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the bins but works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken them out three weeks running. At the catch-up Sam mentions it, and Alex admits that Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month, with Sam taking the bins and Alex taking the recycling and the weekly grocery order, and to settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter V (page 136).*

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

*"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, a little flatly. It was meant as a thank-you. It sounded like a criticism. Before you know it you've replied to the criticism, and the person who said thank you is now defending a thank-you.*

## On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what it means to you and which jobs are truly yours. Write down what fair means to you in one sentence, and list the jobs you own alongside the ones you picked up without ever agreeing to. Olu lives alone and has his children every other weekend. His sentence, after some crossing out, is that fair means not doing their jobs for them just because he misses them (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Pick one job you took on without agreeing, and either keep it on purpose or raise it on a calm day.

## Common mix-ups

If it got done, there may still be a problem, because someone may be paying for it in time and energy. Holding the owner to the job isn't being strict; it's keeping the agreement you both made, which is kinder than quiet resentment. Letting a comment land doesn't mean ignoring it. It's about timing, and you still get to answer. And please don't save up months of covering to bring out all at once. A long list lands like a bill. Mention covering as it happens.

## Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Some couples put everything into one pot. Some keep their money separate and pay agreed bills, often half each, which is fair by promises, the same rule for both. Others each pay into a shared pot in line with what they earn and keep the rest, which is fair by results, since each is left with a similar share. Many couples mix them, with a joint account for bills and food and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories, how money worked at home when you were growing up, then move on to the numbers and to a "talk first" amount for big purchases that applies to both of you. A limit you both chose and both keep is care, not control.

Niamh takes home £2,600 a month and Tariq £1,900, and their rent and bills will be £1,500. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay, so she pays £870 and he pays £630.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?"
> "Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

## A couple and a housemate

A couple sharing a home with a housemate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. It helps to keep two lists, **house jobs** for all three of you, such as the bins, the bathroom, the bills and the landlord, and **couple jobs** for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, rather than in bed the night before, hear the housemate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms and never ask them to referee. Ollie and Hamza share a flat with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room, since the couple has the bigger one, and the bills by person, and all three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month, with biscuits, which Bex insists is the only reason she comes.

YOU COULD SAY

"That's a house question. Let's decide it when Bex is here."

## More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · More than two partners (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own

On a calm, easy day, each of you can say which kind of fair comes more naturally, results or promises. Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job), with a second name for someone who notices if it slips. Finally, agree a short phrase for when something lands hard, such as "Give me a second", along with the promise that the person who asked for a second will come back to it.

## A note on safety

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about what's fair ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. Rules one person sets for the other, with checking, punishment or money held back, are control, and that is not your fault. See normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together#control).

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH SOMEONE YOU TRUST

"Things at home don't feel fair, and I'm scared to bring it up. Can I talk it through with you?"

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt** page 292
*Repair and apologies that land*

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works** page 195
*Letting words land before you reply*

**Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life** page 280
*Fairness as a value you choose together*

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture** page 374
*How a group's norms decide what feels fair*


PUT IT TO USE



**Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



**Say it so it lands**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands

# V

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

# The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

*Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. A look-back, three months in
11. Common mix-ups
12. Starting out: before you move in
13. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
14. More for your situation
15. On your own: a monthly look at yourself


THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

*The bins again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth about Tuesday that you had last Tuesday, word for word, or you could notice that this has now happened three Tuesdays running and wonder what it is about Tuesdays.*

01

## Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and patterns are easiest to see when you look at the whole month. The look-back is a careful, friendly glance over that month, closer to a self-check than an inspection.

Four flatmates had an overflowing bathroom bin every week, and every week it seemed like bad luck, until they looked at the month together and saw it had happened every single week since September. In my old job the step that got skipped more than any other was going back afterwards to check that the fix had actually held, and skipping it is exactly how the same problem turns up again three years later. This chapter is that step, made small. Choose a monthly date now, the last Sunday, say, and put it in everyone's calendar.

02

### You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), where a few lines a week is enough, and your job list from One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). Twenty minutes is usually enough. If either of your stress tanks is high that day, at 0.60 or more on How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), move it a day or two. A couple on different shifts keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones and do the look-back on the one evening a month they're both off, with a takeaway, which has become the part they look forward to.

03

### Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job slipped if it was noticed and not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗, because three or four in a month is a real pattern. Two foster carers find the reading log was missed three weeks out of four. They mark the ✗ in pencil, together, before either of them explains anything, which is harder than it sounds and much the best order.

04

## A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

Such a problem gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish, so the fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it. In a home with three partners, “whoever’s free” does the online grocery order, and it was late three times this month. With nobody owning it, everybody assumed someone else had it. One Friday there was no milk at all, and four jars of mustard.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 17

**One owner per job: a list for two homes**

*Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes*

### One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
*Laura*

Person B
*Dan*

Date of this list
*1 October 2026*

The split you agreed (optional)
*Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5*

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Pack the handoff bag* | *Weekly* | *Laura* | *Dan* | *Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it* |
| *Send medicine and chargers with the bag* | *Weekly* | *Laura* | *Dan* | *Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card* |
| *School forms and permission slips* | *As needed* | *Dan* | *Laura* | |
| *Reply to school emails and apps* | *Weekly* | *Dan* | | *Dan reads them Sunday night* |

| Job | How often | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Kids' doctor and dentist visits* | *As needed* | *Dan* | | *Dan books; tells Laura the date* |
| *Homework help (Laura's weeks)* | *Daily* | *Laura* | | |
| *Homework help (Dan's weeks)* | *Daily* | *Dan* | | |
| *Activities and sign-ups* | *As needed* | *Dan* | *Laura* | *Swimming and Cubs* |
| *Buy clothes as they outgrow them* | *As needed* | *Laura* | | *Receipts in the shared folder* |
| *Big decisions (school, health, new activities)* | *As needed* | *Both (decide together)* | | *A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

**How the jobs sit across the homes**
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5". Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

*Made-up example. If one parent is afraid of the other, a shared list isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? on this site.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

### Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

If a job has no clear owner, update the job list. If its owner can't keep up, have a kind, honest talk. If there was a short-term cause, like a bout of flu, note it and move on. Separated parents looking at the missed homework folder ask whether nobody was sure which home signs it, whether one of them is swamped, or whether it was simply the week she had flu (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

## The monthly look-back

*Which gaps kept reopening, however often we closed them?*

### 1 Mark the month

| | Week 1 | Week 2 | Week 3 | Week 4 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Recycling | ✕ | ✕ | ✕ | ✕ |
| Bins | ✕ | ✕ | · | ✕ |
| School forms | · | ✕ | · | · |
| Dog's walk | · | · | · | · |

*The ✗ goes next to a job, never next to a person.*

### 2 Sort each repeat

**Structural gap**
No clear owner, or the wrong name on the list. → **Update the job list.**

**Capacity issue**
An owner who has run out of room. → **Set a time for a kind talk.**

**One-off**
A clear short-term reason: illness, travel. → **Note it and move on.**

### 3 Count, and close the month

Fewer structural gaps over several months is a good sign. Zero isn't the goal.

*Short and kind. A look at the setup, not a review of either person.*

*This book's own method, adapted from team "retrospectives"; it hasn't been tested as a household method.*

FIGURE 18 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 18

**What keeps coming back?**

*Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home*

## What keeps coming back?

| | |
|---|---|
| Person A<br>*Ash* | Person B<br>*Robin* |
| Person C<br>*Jules* | Month<br>*September 2026* |

### Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

| Task | Week 1 | Week 2 | Week 3 | Week 4 | Times flagged |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Cat litter* | ✗ | ✗ | | ✗ | 3 |
| *Recycling out on Thursday* | | ✗ | ✗ | | 2 |
| *Book Jules's car service* | | | ✗ | | 1 |
| *Shared calendar kept up to date* | ✗ | ✗ | ✗ | ✗ | 4 |

### Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

| Task | Named owner on the job list? | Classification | Action |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Cat litter* | No | *Structural gap* | *Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight* |
| *Shared calendar kept up to date* | Yes | *Capacity issue* | *Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list* |
| *Recycling out on Thursday* | Yes | *One-off, no action* | *Two bank holidays moved the day* |

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

**Structural gaps found**

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

**Capacity issues found**

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

**One-offs**

1

**Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?**

| Job | Gets thanked | Only noticed when missed? | One way to notice it |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Keeping the calendar* | *Rarely* | *Yes* | *Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date* |
| *Topping up the cat food* | *Never* | *Yes* | *A note on the fridge* |

*A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.*

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04)

06

## Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working, and a single month can be a normal swing. If it keeps rising, something bigger has changed and it is worth a talk. Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office, next to the fire-drill notice. In March four jobs had no clear owner. By June, one did, and they argue cheerfully about whose fault that one is.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The look-back has its own workpaper: a month of notes, one list, and an ✗ for each week a job slipped. It makes a pattern easy to see.

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

07

## Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news, and it is also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going in quiet months and add one question, "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning*?", which is how a look-back guards against complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency). The children have left home and nothing at all is slipping. At the look-back one of them says, quietly, that they don't really talk at dinner any more. No list would have shown that.

08

## It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet and what you will try next month. After a month in hospital, one partner comes home to a long list of what slipped. They thank each other for what each carried, and set up the month ahead, and that's all.



TIDBIT

A look-back can start with something that went well. Name it first. The weekly card has a nice way to begin.

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

09

## Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well and talk about the job instead of the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins). If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and whoever paused names a time to come back. A mum and two teenagers hold their look-back over pizza on the last Friday. Each says one good thing first (the younger one's is always "the pizza"), one gap gets a new owner, and it's over in fifteen minutes.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 19

**Kitchen-table check-in: this week**

*Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together*

### Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)
*Linda and Jordan*

One thing that went well
*Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.*

One thing that felt heavy
*The bathroom, again. And Mum's back was bad all week.*

One small thing to try next week
*Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.*

Our next check-in
*Sunday after dinner*

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: this week
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

*Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes, twenty minutes. You go down the list together. Most weeks went fine. Two jobs keep coming up, the recycling and the call to the landlord about the window, so you give each of them a name and finish your tea while it's still warm, for once.*

## A look-back, three months in

Sam and Alex's bins slipped three weeks in a row because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After the trial swap they make it official, so Sam owns the bins and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, which keeps the hours even. The second month is clean. In the third, the grocery order slips twice, both times in a week when Alex's mother was in hospital, and they mark it as a one-off and leave the list alone. What changes in month three is that Alex mentions, almost in passing, that he has stopped enjoying their Saturday mornings, which no list had shown, and they agree to talk about it properly on Thursday.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

## Common mix-ups

This isn't where you settle who owes what. Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them; you only fix the setup going forward. A slipped job doesn't mean its owner failed, either, because the gap might be in the list, or in the owner's capacity, or in one strange week. And you can't skip the weekly notes and just do this. The look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.

> **A note on safety:** These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If looking back together ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A look-back is something you both choose. If one person demands logs of the other's every hour, checks their phone without agreement, or uses the ✗ marks to punish, that is control, not a look-back, and it is not your fault. See Not safe at home? and normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).

## Starting out: before you move in

If you are new together and about to share a home, the tools work best now, before habits set, at about one step a week. In the first week, each of you writes down the rulebook from the home you grew up in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) and then you swap, with curiosity. In the second, talk about money, starting with your money stories and moving on to the split (Chapter IV, page 133). In the third, write your first job list, with one owner per job and the thinking jobs included (One owner per job, spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03), and in the fourth, make a pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) on a calm day. In the fifth, each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Part Three, Chapter 10, page 280). After the move, log one ordinary

week once two weeks have passed, and do your first short look-back after four. None of it is a test, and the point is that neither of you has to guess.

Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find that their families meant different things by "tidy", and they agree on the kitchen every night and the rest on Sunday.

## Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it involves things that keep coming back, such as cancelled calls and the hard evenings after contact. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own, and some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't, and for those you can own the plan for the evening after. The child may love both the parent who can't look after them and you, so tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them. Explain an absent parent in short, true words that fit their age, always with the message that it isn't their fault. When the parent is your own adult child and things are hard between you, keep messages about the child short and civil for the child's sake, and leave the door open. Look after yourself too. Ask for respite, and find other kinship carers. In England and Wales, the charity Kinship (kinship.org.uk) can help.

Maureen, who is sixty-three, is raising her grandson Tyler, who is nine. Her look-back shows that his mum's Sunday call fell through three times this month, so she plans those evenings with hot chocolate and his football annual, and asks her brother to take Tyler swimming on Sunday afternoons.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD
> "Mum loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

## More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists pages for each one.

- More than two partners (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Money together · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Kids grown and gone (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

## On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month kindly, more like a weather report than a scorecard. Ask what filled your battery and what drained it, which of your limits held and which slipped, and choose one small thing to keep and one to change. Gillian lives on her own after a divorce, and her look-back shows the same ✗ three weeks running: she skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails. So she moves the emails to Friday morning and keeps the swim (see On my own).

To begin, put a relaxed twenty-minute date in the calendar once a month and keep your weekly notes somewhere you can both find them. At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well, and end by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so that over the next few months you can see whether the number is falling. What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back) is the workpaper for that conversation.

That's the end of Part Two. The book goes on in Part Three: Understanding people (page 152), chapters on how people work, for anyone. To put Parts One and Two into practice first, try the six-week program

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01): six gentle weeks, with one chapter and one small tool each week.

---

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Weekly check-ins miss patterns.
- ✓ Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.
- ✓ Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.
- ✓ Look back even when nothing is slipping.
- ✓ Keep it short and kind.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*The same kind look, on your own* page 50

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*Why problems come back, and how habits stick* page 223

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?**
*The setup score the look-back feeds* page 88

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Repairing what the look-back finds* page 292


PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 6: make it last**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back



PART THREE

# Understanding people

*How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.*

IN THIS PART


Chapter 1 How feelings work 152
Chapter 2 Stress and the nervous system 166
Chapter 3 How we see each other 182
Chapter 4 How communication works 195
Chapter 5 Attachment, trust and belonging 210
Chapter 6 Habits and change 223
Chapter 7 Self-worth, shame and self-compassion 236
Chapter 8 Loss, grief and big life changes 248
Chapter 9 Minds that work differently 261
Chapter 10 Values, meaning and a good life 280
Chapter 11 Healing after hurt 292
Chapter 12 Helping others well 305
Chapter 13 Anger 319
Chapter 14 Personality, temperament and change 334
Chapter 15 Closeness and love 347
Chapter 16 Worry, low mood and trauma 359
Chapter 17 Groups, influence and culture 374




PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If a question pops up while you read, ask me. Nothing you type leaves your device.

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

# 1

PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

# How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

*What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry, whether you're on your own, at home, with friends or at work.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **A feeling is a signal** that something matters to you. It doesn't tell you what to do about it.
- **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often arrives before the word for it.
- **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- **You can let a feeling be there** and still choose what you do next.

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

*A message from your manager: "Have you got a minute tomorrow?" No full stop, no smiley, nothing else. Your stomach drops. By the time you get home you've snapped at the cat, skipped dinner and replayed every mistake of the last month, including one from March that nobody else remembers, although nobody has said anything bad at all.*

Feelings sit underneath almost everything else in this book, from how we talk to how we handle stress. This chapter looks at how they work first, and then at what to do with them. Two tools elsewhere lean on it. My weather today and the daily check-in (Part One, Now, page 35; Part Two, Chapter I, page 75) ask for one word about how you are, because naming a feeling turns its volume down a little and a daily word catches feelings while they're small. And Say it so it lands (Part Two, Chapter IV, page 120) asks you to describe a feeling, because "I felt let down" is a great deal easier to hear than "you never care."

01

## A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear warns that something might be dangerous. Anger says something seems unfair, or in your way. Sadness says you've lost something that mattered. A signal is worth listening to, but it can be wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm goes off for burnt toast with exactly the same urgency it would use for a fire.

Say you feel jealous when a friend makes a new close friend. The jealousy proves nothing about you, and nothing about whether your friend is drifting off. What it shows is how much the friendship matters to you, which is worth knowing, and possibly worth telling her.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

02

## Feelings start in the body.

Often your body reacts before your mind has a word for what's going on: a racing heart, a hot face, a heavy chest, a knot in the stomach. Then the brain tries to make sense of the signal, and it guesses. That's why being hungry or tired or in pain can feel so like being upset.

A teenager comes home furious with his mum over very little, something about a towel. After a cheese sandwich and twenty minutes on the sofa with the dog, most of the fury has gone, and he admits, with some reluctance, that he skipped lunch. A few times today, stop and ask what your body feels like right now. Is there hunger in it, or cold, or a sore back?

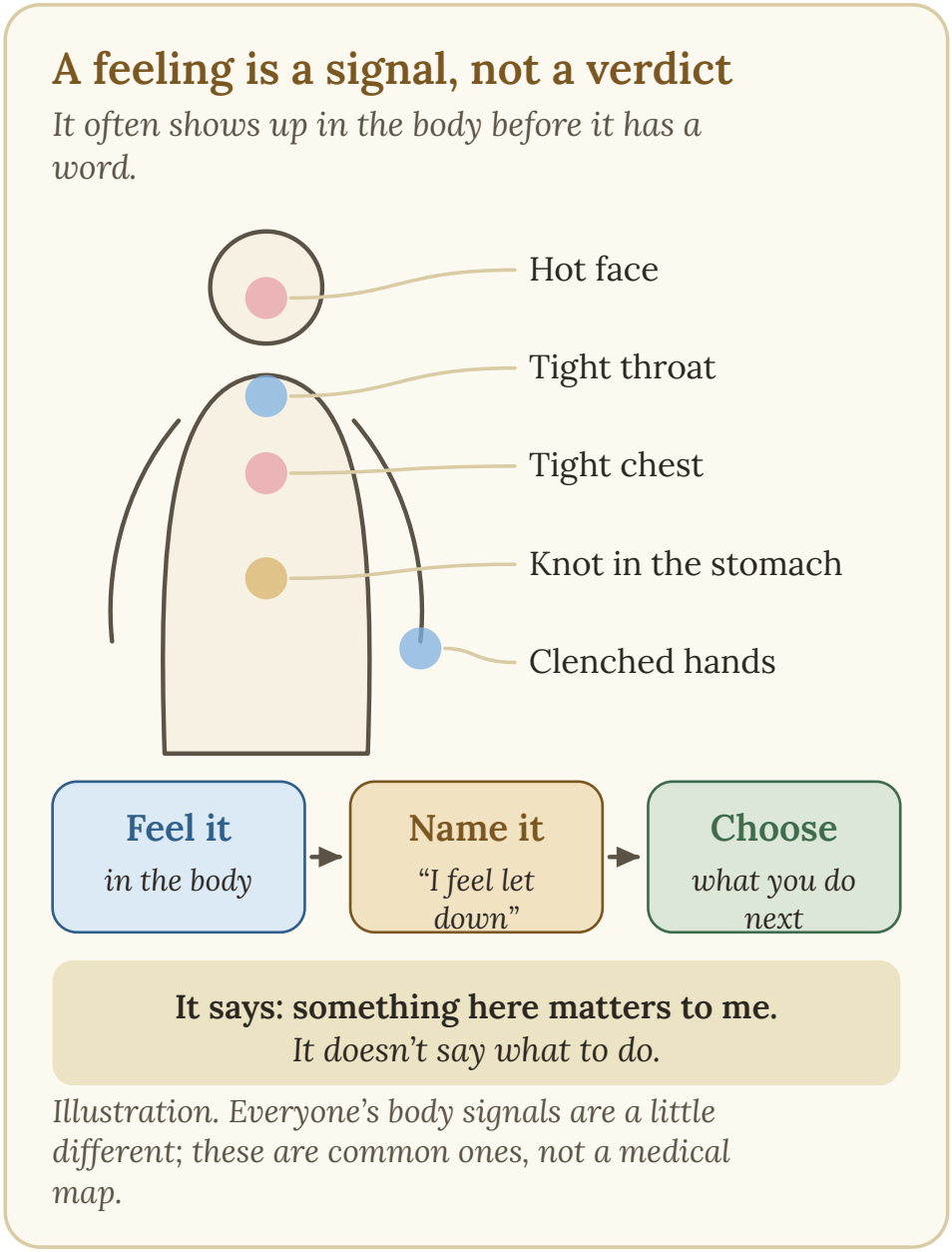



FIGURE 19 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first; naming it helps you choose what to do next.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 20

**My weather today**

*Esme, 29, at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager*

## Check today's weather

### The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

### Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers* · Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

### The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

### Ground conditions

*Haven't eaten in a while* · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

### Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

### People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

### What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

### What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

**Gusty today**
Revved up · Some room today

**Talk window**
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

*Made-up example. Esme ate something, then rang her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.*

Fill in your own: My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

03

## Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so you can see it and talk about it and decide what to do.

Two housemates are tense all evening, passing each other in the hall without a word. Eventually one says, "I think I'm embarrassed about the noise complaint, and I've been acting cross." The other, who had spent two hours wondering what she'd done wrong, puts the kettle on.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think what I'm feeling is…" "I'm not sure what this is yet. Maybe worried?"

Once a day, name one feeling, out loud or on paper. A guess like "something like sad" still counts.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won't come, weather words often will. "Foggy" or "stormy" is a perfectly good place to start.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

## More words, better tools.

"Bad" is a very blunt word. Disappointed is different from left out, and both are different from overwhelmed or ashamed; each points somewhere different and needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don't need fancy words. A number works, and so does a colour.

A dad tells his partner he feels bad about his mum, and they go round in circles for half an hour. Then he says, "Actually, I feel guilty that I haven't been up to see her since Easter, and scared she's getting worse," and within ten minutes they're looking at train times to Carlisle.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"On a scale of one to ten, I'm about a six." "It's less angry and more… let down." "It feels heavy, like a grey day."

05

## Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn't always the one you felt first. Anger is very often a cover for hurt or fear, because anger feels stronger and safer to stand in. We also have feelings about our feelings, like being ashamed of being sad, and that second layer can sting more than the first.

A grandmother is curt with her daughter on the phone after the half-term visit is cancelled for the second time. Under the curtness is hurt. Under the hurt, if she let herself look, is a quieter fear that she isn't needed much any more. She doesn't say any of that. She says "Fine, well, another time," and then sits by the phone for a while. Next time you feel angry, ask yourself whether there's hurt or worry underneath. You don't have to tell anyone what you find.

06

## Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise and peak and settle if you don't keep feeding them. Moods are another matter. A mood is more like weather, a background feeling that lasts hours or days and colours everything, often without you noticing it's there.

A woman who lives alone has a bad morning (the boiler, a bill, a dream about her ex) and by eleven has decided her whole life is going nowhere. By evening, after a walk along the canal and a long call with her sister, the same life looks ordinary and fairly okay, with a dentist's appointment on Tuesday and a library book she wants to finish. Nothing in her life changed between eleven and seven. That's a good reason to leave big decisions until the wave has passed: write the decision down and look at it again tomorrow.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "This is a wave. It will peak and pass." "Is this a feeling about now, or a mood colouring everything?"

07

## Feelings spread between people.

We pick up each other's feelings from a tense voice, a sigh or a door shut a bit too hard, usually without noticing. That's part of how people bond. It also means stress can move round a home or a team like a cold in February.

A team leader comes into the Monday meeting rushed and anxious, and within ten minutes the whole team feels behind on everything. The next week she stops outside the door for two slow breaths before she goes in, and the meeting finishes on time, which in that office counts as a minor miracle. You can care about someone's feeling without catching all of it. Notice who you tend to catch feelings from, and before your next talk with them, give yourself one minute first.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "Is this feeling mine, or did I pick it up?" "I can stay beside their storm without standing in the middle of it."



TIDBIT

Good moods are catching too. If you'd like a small way to share one, there's a tool for it.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

08

## If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Lots of people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private. "Don't make a fuss." "Big boys don't cry." "We don't talk about that." It's especially common among men and older people, and in some cultures keeping your feelings to yourself is a sign of respect and strength.

It isn't a flaw, and it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely put a feeling into words show it every single day by doing things: fixing the tap, driving someone to the hospital at two in the morning, simply turning up. Caring by doing is real caring. Words can be added slowly, a few at a time, if you want them.

A retired builder whose wife has died has never talked about his feelings in his life. On the touchline at his grandson's Saturday match, during a dull bit of the first half, he says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder, and they watch the second half together without saying much else.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

If one of those fits, you could say it once this week, to one person or just out loud in the car. A text counts, and so does writing it down.

09

## Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually comes with an urge attached, to shout or run or hide or check or fix or text. You don't choose the feeling. You have rather more say over the urge. Pushing a feeling down tends to bring it back stronger, and acting on every urge can hurt people, so the workable middle is to let the feeling be there and choose the action.

A father hears glass go and looks out to see his son standing very still in the garden next to a football. He feels a hot rush of anger, says, "I'm too cross to talk right now. Let's sort this out in ten minutes," and goes to fetch the dustpan. If there's one urge you often act on too fast, like the sharp text, make yourself a rule to wait ten minutes before you send it.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm feeling a lot right now. I'm going to take a minute before I answer." "I want to reply when I'm calmer."

FRIDAY, 9:05AM

*The knot is there again, and this time you name it. You're scared you're in trouble. So you go and ask your manager straight away whether today's chat is anything to worry about, and she looks genuinely surprised and says it's about the summer rota. You go back to your desk and eat the breakfast you skipped, a slightly squashed banana.*

## In everyday life

If you live on your own, there's nobody to notice how you are, so a one-word check-in with yourself each day matters more (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, "What are you feeling?" can sound like a test you might fail, while "Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?" is much easier to answer. Children learn feeling words from the adults around them, and hearing you say "I'm frustrated, so I'm taking a breath" teaches them more than any lesson would. At work, a short "I'm a bit flat today, and I'm not upset with anyone" can stop a whole team guessing. And if someone close to you shows care by doing, say by clearing the drive on a bad day, you can thank them for it in words. They may not know what to do with it the first time.

## Common mix-ups

Some feelings are painful and some actions are harmful, but a feeling in itself isn't bad; it's information. Feeling stupid doesn't make you stupid either. Treat a feeling as a signal to check before you obey it. Lots of people expect to be able to name what they feel straight away, and plenty can't, some of them most days, which is why body words and numbers count as answers here. The last one is the most stubborn. We think a face tells us what someone feels, but faces are a poor guide. People show the same feeling in very different ways, and asking is both kinder and more accurate than guessing.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you name it for them. “You’re angry” can land like a label, while “You seem upset. Am I reading that right?” leaves room for them to correct you. Then help the feeling make sense (“Of course you’re upset, that was a lot”), which helps more than advice and doesn’t mean you agree with everything they did. Offer a choice between ideas and just listening; a lot of people only want the second, and are relieved to be asked. Accept other ways of saying it, like a number, a text, a drawing or “I’m at a seven”. And settle yourself first. If their sadness makes you anxious, calm down before you go to them, so they don’t end up looking after your feelings as well as their own.

> YOU COULD SAY
> “That sounds really hard.” “Do you want to talk, or would company help more?” “You don’t have to find the right word. A number is fine.”

## When to get more help

Everyone has hard days and big feelings. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or another trained professional if:

- a low, numb, anxious or angry feeling stays most days for two weeks or more;
- feelings are stopping you from sleeping, eating, working or seeing people;
- you are using alcohol, drugs or other things to stop feeling;
- you feel you can’t cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that’s happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line straight away. You deserve help today.

If you feel afraid of someone you live with or are close to, that fear is an important signal. It is not something to “manage” on your own. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy. It can’t know your situation.

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself): how you tend to feel and react, and why.
- The library: what emotions are (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), naming feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#affect-labeling), emotional granularity (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#emotional-granularity), when feelings are hard to name (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#alexithymia), emotional contagion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#emotional-contagion) and sensing your body (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress).

## More for your situation

- Next in Part Three: Stress and the nervous system (page 166)
- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 35)
- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) and Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens: when feelings get loud (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- For caregivers: resentment and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)

- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Reading your own weather day to day* page 35

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*Feelings when a stress tank is full* page 105

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*What the body does under pressure* page 166

**Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger**
*One feeling up close* page 319


PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

**My weather today**
A short, private daily check of your mood and state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

# 2

PART THREE · CHAPTER 2

# Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

*What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they're flooded, and which kinds of rest actually put something back.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


MONDAY, 7:52AM

*The bus is late. One school shoe is missing, last seen under the sofa on Saturday, and your phone buzzes with a message from work that begins "Quick one". Your partner calls from the hall, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself snap, "I'm not your secretary!"*

*A second later you wonder where that came from, because the keys were never the problem and you were running late before anyone said a word, before the shoe went missing, probably before you were even out of bed.*

Feelings got their own chapter (Chapter 1, page 152). This one goes a layer down, to the nervous system that runs underneath them, and what it does when the pressure is on. Knowing how stress works won't make a busy Monday any quieter. It does make your own reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

It also explains why some of the tools elsewhere work at all. The stress tank in Part Two, Chapter III (page 105) asks you to check how full you are before you judge the moment, because stress piles up from small loads. The Calm-Down Kit in Part One, Now (page 35) settles the body before any words, and it asks you to name a time to come back, so a pause doesn't look like walking out. The setup score in Part Two, Chapter II (page 88) counts stress as well as hours, since a split can look fair on paper and still leave one person running on empty.

01

## Stress is your body getting ready.

Something needs dealing with, and your body gears up before you've decided anything. Heart faster, breath quicker, muscles tight, stress hormones up. That's exactly what you want when a glass is sliding off the table. The trouble comes when the body stays geared up for hours and never gets the signal to stand down.

Morag is a nurse. She handles a cardiac arrest on the ward calmly and well, goes home at nine, eats half a sandwich standing up, and at half past ten finds herself crying at an advert for car insurance, which has never before moved her to anything, while her body carries on running the emergency it thinks she is still in.

So after something stressful, give your body a clear sign that it's over. A walk round the block works, or a hot shower, or one song played loud in the car on the way home; the body takes its cue from what you do far more than from what you tell it.

02

## Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same deadline lands on two colleagues on a Thursday afternoon. One has a quiet evening and a takeaway menu. The other has a seven-year-old at home with a temperature and a partner away in Leeds until Saturday. On paper it's one task. Guess which one is awake at 3am.

Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you've got to meet it with, whether that's time, energy, money, help, skill or sleep. That's why a small thing tips you over on a bad day. It's also why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the job at all.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "It's less the task than how little I've got left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

When something feels huge, I'd write two lists side by side, one for what it asks of you and one for what you've got, and then ignore the first list for a minute and ask what would make the second one a line longer.

03

## The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture of the states your body moves between in a day. Near the bottom you're **calm and connected**, breathing easily and able to hear something hard without bristling. Higher up you're **revved up**, tense, and small things start to feel urgent or personal. Then there's **running on empty**, which feels flat and slow, with the words just out of reach.

Most people go up and down it many times a day. A grandfather minding his toddler granddaughter is calm at two o'clock, revved up by four (she has found the felt-tips) and running on empty by six. Neither of them has changed. Only the hour has, and how much afternoon is left in him.

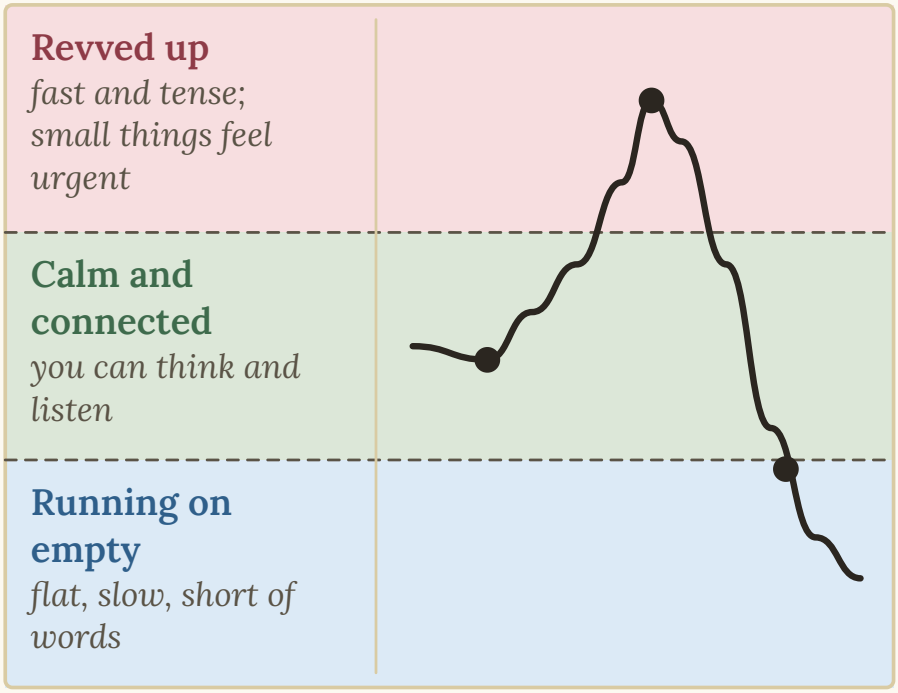
The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is a thirty-second check that gives you a best guess at where you are. If you'd rather not use a screen, set three reminders on your phone for today and, each time one goes off, notice which rung you're on and do nothing else about it.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm revved up right now." "I'm running on empty. Can this wait till the morning?"

## The ladder: three everyday states

*You move up and down it all day.*




*Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.*

**Hard talks go best from the middle band.**

*Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.*

FIGURE 20 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day; hard talks go best from the middle band.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 21

**The ladder (the sky, in My weather today)**

*Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann*

## The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected  Gusty: Revved up  *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner  Family  A co-parent  Roommates  Coworkers  *Someone I care for*  Friends  Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light  Building  *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

*Barely slept*  Short night  About enough  Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work  Money  *Kids or caring*  *Health*  Family  The house  One conversation  Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space  Food or water  *Rest*  To move  To be heard  A plan  Company  Quiet  *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

**Fogged in today**
Running on empty · Very little room today

**Talk window**
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: "I'm at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?"

*Made-up example. A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.*

Fill in your own: My weather today: the sky (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

## When you're flooded, thinking goes offline.

At the top of the stress curve your body is in full alarm, and the things a hard conversation needs most (careful thinking, listening, seeing the other side) get much harder to reach. Lots of people call this being **flooded**. You might say something you don't mean, freeze, or want nothing except to be out of the room.

Two adult siblings start sorting their late father's things one wet Saturday. Within twenty minutes they're shouting about a standard lamp that neither of them even likes. The real subject, that he's gone, sits in the boxes around them and nobody says it.

A flooded person is still a decent person whose body has to come down before the talk can go anywhere. It helps to know your own flood signs in advance. Heat in the face is common. So is a racing heart, or the room

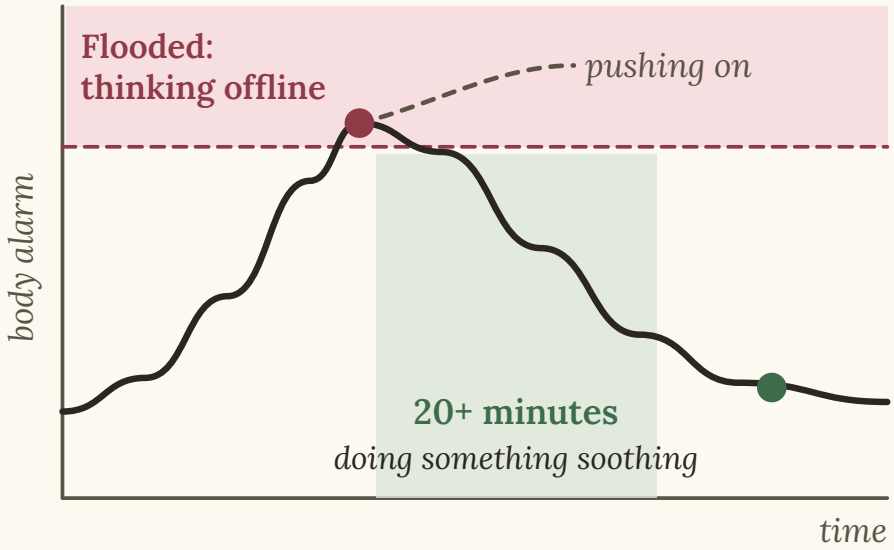
narrowing, or a voice in your head that has gone very loud and very certain. Notice two at once and you have your cue to stop.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

## Flooded means offline

*Pause, settle, then come back.*




- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

*Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.*

FIGURE 21 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.

05

## Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Picture a tank that holds everything you're already carrying today. The traffic goes in. So does the meeting that overran, the noisy shop, the text from your mum that just says "Call me when you can." It's all one tank, and by the evening something tiny makes it overflow and gets the blame for the whole lot.

A fifteen-year-old explodes when he's asked to empty the dishwasher. Later, from a friend's mum at the school gate, his own mum finds out that his closest friendship fell apart at lunchtime, over something said in a group chat, and the dishwasher had simply been the next thing anyone asked of him.

Small daily hassles count as much as big events here, which surprises people. (I can fill mine in one loud restaurant. That's how I'm wired, and the About page on the website says more.) Before you react to a small thing in the evening, ask how full you were before it happened. Part Two, Chapter III (page 105) has a quick way to tell.

YOU COULD SAY

"My tank was full before I got home. That wasn't really about you."
"Rough day? You don't have to explain."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long spell of rain. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

06

## Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm, but you can help the body come down, and the thinking usually follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths works for a lot of people. So does moving, humming something you know by heart, steady pressure like a heavy blanket, or just leaving the noisy room. What works is personal, which is why it's worth finding your own short

list on a calm day rather than in the middle of a row. A manager feels her heart going before she has to give some difficult feedback, so she walks once round the car park, breathing out slowly, and goes in a little steadier than she would have been.

Put your list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) helps you build it, and if you only keep one line from this section, keep "body first, words second".

07

## Rest isn't one thing.

An hour on the sofa scrolling can leave you more tired than when you sat down. That's because recovery comes in different kinds. There's sleep, and there's switching off from work in your head, and real relaxation, and doing something absorbing that you enjoy, and the plain feeling of being in charge of your own time, and none of them stands in for the others.

Two housemates have friends round on a Saturday night for a curry and the quiz on the telly. One wakes up on Sunday refreshed. The other spends the whole of Sunday alone with a library book and the door shut, and comes out at teatime feeling like herself again. Company restores some people and drains others, and neither of them is doing rest wrong.

Ask yourself which kind of tired you are: body-tired, people-tired, brain-tired or feelings-tired. Then pick a rest that matches, rather than the one you always default to.

YOU COULD SAY

"I need quiet rest tonight rather than people rest. It isn't about you."
"What kind of tired are you?"



SUGARFOOT

Rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of quiet music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it somewhere you can reach it.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

08

## Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress land harder. After a short or broken night, small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter and people pull away from each other. This one is well studied. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm centre react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), couples reported more conflict after nights of poor sleep. In experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier.

Saoirse comes off her third night shift at the care home and bursts into tears over a parking ticket. Her sister says, "You've barely slept. Let's sort it out on Thursday." By Thursday it's a parking ticket again, annoying and payable, and she pays it online during her lunch break.

You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story. Before a hard conversation, ask whether you've both slept, and if you haven't, pick another time. At night, try the same few calm steps before bed in the same order, so your body learns the signal. If poor sleep goes on for weeks, talk to a doctor, because sleep problems are common and often treatable.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I slept badly, so if I'm short with you today, that's why." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

09

## Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other down. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder, or just a quiet person in the same room can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud helps too, because "I'm stressed about work" stops your partner wondering whether it's about them.

A father tells his ten-year-old over fish fingers, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. Sorting it is my grown-up job, and you're not in trouble."

Over the next few days the boy stops tiptoeing round him and starts bringing his maths homework to the table again.

Tonight, tell one person your state in one sentence, then ask how they are and listen to the answer.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm stressed, and it isn't about you." "Would a hug help, or some space?"

> MONDAY, 7:58AM
> *Six minutes after the snap, your partner is by the door, still patting their pockets. "Sorry," you say. "My tank was full before you opened your mouth. Your keys are on the bathroom shelf, by the way." They laugh and ask if it's been a rough start. The bus is still late. The shoe is still missing. But the two of you are on the same side of the morning again.*

## In everyday life

Living on your own means nobody's there to notice when you're running on empty, so build rest into the week before you need it. With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, plus the rule that whoever pauses names a time to come back (One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space, spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw, has more on this). A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is something they borrow for years before they can make their own. And at work, a flooded colleague can't take in feedback, so waiting an hour usually beats pushing on.

Some people run on empty for reasons built into their lives, like shift work, a long-term illness or caring for someone. What that calls for is a different setup. More effort won't do it (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and Caregivers, spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers). If you have ADHD, keeping track of everything can quietly fill the tank before breakfast. Get the remembering out of your head and into the world, with labelled alarms and one hook for the keys, and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

People often think all stress is bad. It isn't. Short bursts help you rise to a challenge, and the harm comes from stress that never gets a recovery. Others think that being calm means not being upset, when you can be calm and sad, or calm and very firm. Pausing gets mistaken for avoiding, but a pause with a time to come back is how you finish a talk well, and avoiding is the pause that never comes back. Rest gets called lazy, though bodies and minds that never recover tend to break down. And short replies with a flat face are read as not caring, when far more often they mean someone is worn out.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Nobody in the history of the world has calmed down because they were told to. A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence do far more. So does taking one job off someone's list, which beats any pep talk. Ask what kind of help they'd like (practical help, company, a distraction or some space) instead of guessing. Don't debate with someone who's flooded; offer a break and a time to come back, because the facts will still be there in twenty minutes. And if someone has been running on empty for weeks, say so kindly and help them find support.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

## When to get more help

Stress is normal. Constant stress that never lets up is a warning sign. It may be time to see a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional if:

- you've felt exhausted, dread-filled or numb most days for several weeks, even after rest;
- you can't sleep, or sleep but never feel rested;
- you have physical signs that worry you, such as chest pain, constant headaches or stomach trouble (always get chest pain checked straight

away);

- you're relying on alcohol, drugs or other habits to get through the day;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that is happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line.

If the stress comes from being afraid of someone, such as how they will react, what they will do or whether you are allowed to leave, that is not ordinary stress. Your body may be warning you. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not medical advice or diagnosis.

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks#ladder): a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer), Brain Breakers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) and calm games (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play): gentle ways to come down.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), appraisal (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#appraisal), the window of tolerance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#window-of-tolerance), flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#burnout) and slow breathing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/calm).

## More for your situation

- Back: How feelings work (page 152) · Next: How we see each other (page 182) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles (page 105)
- How to stop fighting: calm steps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner)
- New baby, sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent) and Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- For teens: big feelings and stress (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Sensory overload at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Stress is your body getting ready.
- ✓ The ladder: three everyday states.
- ✓ Stress adds up, like a tank filling.
- ✓ Rest isn't one thing.
- ✓ Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

## THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*The stress tank in a shared home* page 105

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Your weather before you speak* page 35

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune**
*How stress knocks two people out of tune* page 75

**Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma**
*When stress turns into worry or low mood* page 359

## PUT IT TO USE



**The Calm-Down Kit**
Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



**The Nervous System Ladder**
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

# 3

PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

# How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell

*Why two people can watch the same moment and come away with two different stories, and how to see others, and yourself, a little more fairly.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Seeing is a best guess
2. You see what you're looking for
3. We fill the gaps with stories
4. We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions
5. Quick shortcuts can lead us astray
6. Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly
7. "Us" and "them" changes what we see
8. Ask, don't guess
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- **We fill gaps with stories**, and the story often feels like a fact.
- **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions**, and that gap causes a lot of hurt.
- **Asking is kinder and more accurate** than trying to read someone's mind.

WEDNESDAY, 12:15PM

*You wave at a colleague across the canteen, tray in one hand. She looks straight through you and walks off. All afternoon you wonder what you did, running back through Monday's meeting, until at four o'clock she messages to say sorry for not stopping; she'd just had a call about her dad. She never saw you wave.*

How feelings work (page 152) and Stress and the nervous system (page 166) look inward. This chapter looks outward, at how we see other people, why misunderstandings are so common even between kind and clever people, and what helps. Before I built any of this I spent my career as a government auditor, walking into situations where nobody could tell me straight what had happened. Almost everyone, it turned out, was doing their best with the piece of the picture they could actually see. That's more or less this chapter.

Some of the tools elsewhere depend on it. Who did what (the Preface to Part Two, page 62) exists because everyone sees their own effort more clearly than other people's, so two honest guesses of "I do about 60%" can add up to well over 100%, and one shared page settles it. Rewind the talk (Part Two, Chapter III, page 105) slows down the habit of judging ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions. And the Chat analyzer follows this chapter's last idea, that asking beats guessing.

01

## Seeing is a best guess.

Your eyes and ears take in far less than you think, and your brain fills in the rest from what it expects. Most of the time this works well, and fast. It also means that what you see is partly what you expected to see, so two people can watch the same moment and honestly see different things.

Two parents watch their son in an under-12s match on a freezing Sunday morning. One sees him giving up. The other sees him being careful with the ankle he went over on last week. Same boy, same touchline, same flask of tea. Next time you're sure what someone meant by a look, think of two other things it could have meant.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This is what I see, and there may be more to it." "What else could this be?"

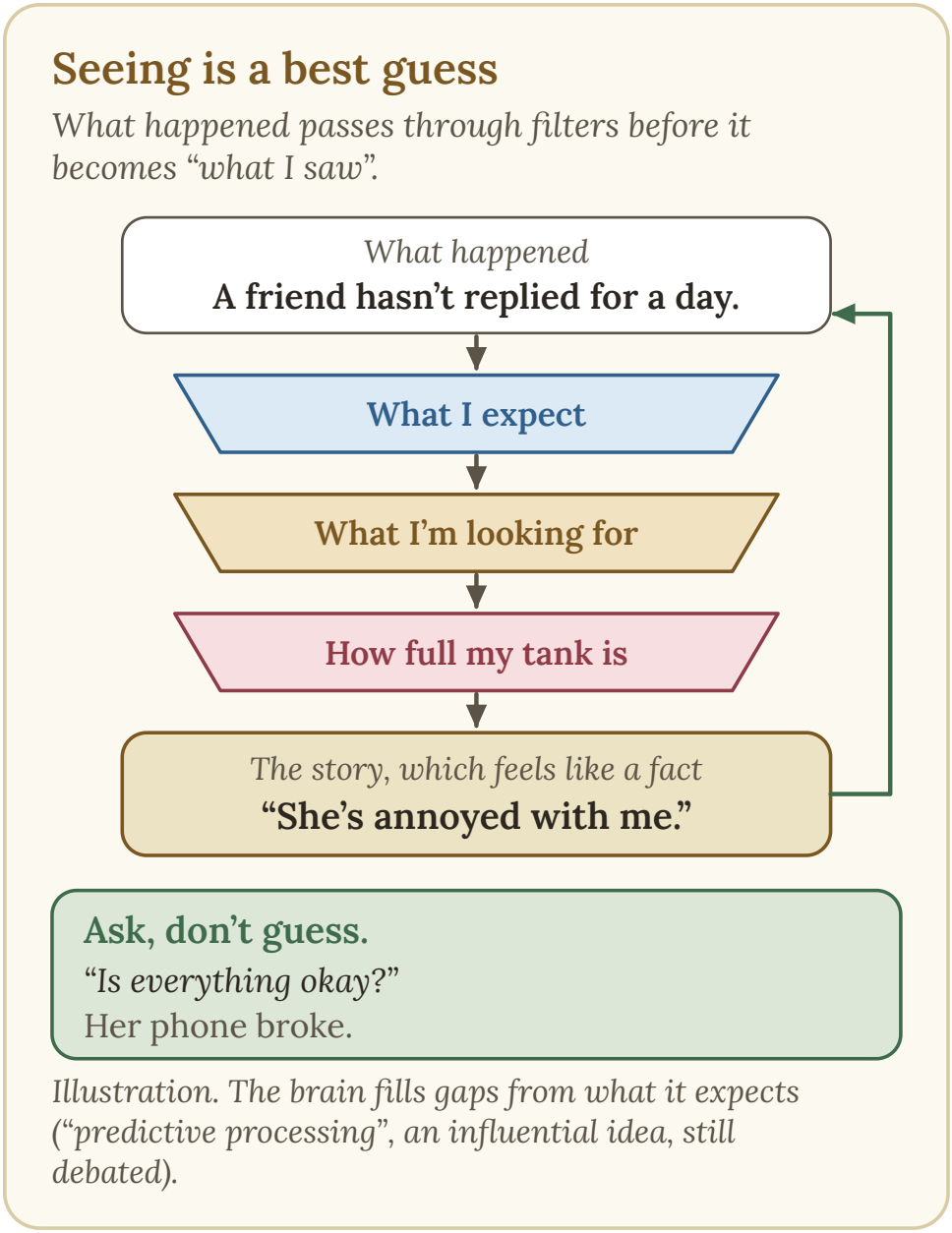



FIGURE 22 Seeing is a best guess. The story that comes out feels like a fact; asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

02

## You see what you're looking for.

Attention is like a torch in a dark room. You see what it lights up and can miss what it doesn't, even when it is right in front of you. If you are looking for proof that someone doesn't care, you will notice every missed call and none of the little kindnesses.

A woman decides in her first week that her new manager doesn't like her. For a month she notices every short email he sends (there are a lot; he writes short emails to everyone). She somehow misses the fact that he gave her the best project on the team. If there's someone you're struggling with, write down one kind thing they do each day for a week. It's an odd exercise, and it tends to change what the torch finds.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "What might I be missing?" "If I were looking for the opposite, what would I see?"

03

## We fill the gaps with stories.

When we don't know why someone did something, the mind makes up a reason fast. A late reply becomes anger and a closed door becomes rejection, and the story arrives feeling like a fact. Memory works this way too, because each time we remember something we rebuild it a little, so two people can honestly remember the same evening differently.

A friend doesn't reply for two days, and by the Sunday evening you've decided she's fed up with you and drafted, then deleted, a message saying so. She was camping in Snowdonia with no signal, and comes back with photos of a sheep.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "The story I'm telling myself is that you're upset with me. Is that right?"

When something someone did hurts, write down the story you're telling yourself, then one other story that would also fit.

04

## We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions.

When you are late, you know why, whether it was the traffic, a phone call or a child who lost a shoe. When someone else is late, you only see the lateness, and it is easy to decide they are careless. We all tend to blame other people's character for things that are really about their situation.

A driver cuts in front of you on the ring road and you call him an idiot, not quite under your breath. The next week, rushing to the hospital because your mum has had a fall, you cut someone up yourself, and you know exactly why, and you'd like them to know it too.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
>
> "What might be going on for them that I can't see?" "If I did this, what would my reason be?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

We know our own reasons and only see other people's actions. Writing out their side, in their words, is a fair way to even that up.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

## Quick shortcuts can lead us astray.

The brain uses shortcuts to save time, and many are useful. Some lead to unfair judgements, such as a first impression that colours everything after it, a bad moment that outweighs ten good ones, or a quick guess about someone from their age, accent, looks or group. Everyone has these shortcuts, and the trouble starts when nobody notices them.

A housemate decides on day one that the new tenant is messy, because of one box left in the hall. Every bit of mess after that counts as proof. Her own mug collection on the landing goes unseen. Pick one person you've made your mind up about and look for one thing that doesn't fit.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Am I looking for proof of what I already think?" "Would I judge this the same if someone I like did it?"

06

## Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly.

Most of us feel that we see things as they really are and that anyone who disagrees must be missing something, or not thinking straight. The other person feels exactly the same about you, and each of you can see the other's lens more easily than your own.

Two adult siblings argue about how their parents raised them, and each insists they are just being realistic, which is true of what each of them lived through.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think we're both seeing this from where we stand. Can you tell me how it looks from yours?"

In your next disagreement, explain the other person's view back to them until they agree you've got it, and only then give yours. You'll find it slows everything down, which is rather the point.

07

## "Us" and "them" changes what we see.

People split into groups quickly, even over tiny things. We tend to see our own group as varied and full of individuals and other groups as all the same, and we give our own side the benefit of the doubt. Spending real time with people from the other group, as equals, is one of the best ways to soften this.

At one depot the night shift calls the day shift lazy and the day shift calls the night shift sloppy, and has done for as long as anyone can remember. After a joint training day with a bad buffet and a fire drill, people start using each other's names. It doesn't fix everything. It does stop the notes on the kettle.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Would I say this about one of 'us'?" "Who in that group do I actually know?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Have one real conversation this month with someone from a group you tend to see as "other", and ask about their day before you ask about their views.

08

## Ask, don't guess.

Imagining yourself in someone's shoes is a kind start, though research suggests it doesn't make us much more accurate about what they think, while asking does. A simple, curious question like "What was that like for you?" works better than the cleverest guess.

A grandmother thinks her teenage grandson hates visiting, because he's always on his phone at her kitchen table. One Sunday she asks. He's been messaging a friend who is having a hard time, and he likes being at her house because it's calm, and because of her apple crumble, though he wouldn't have said so if she hadn't asked.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Can I check what you meant?" "What was going on for you?" "I might have this wrong. How did it look from your side?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 22

**Chat analyzer**

*Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad*

## Chat analyzer

Mode

*I'm about to send this* Someone sent me this

Type your sentence

*You always cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?*

Relationship

*Friends*

Channel

*Text / chat*

THE READ

**How it may land for most listeners**

Some words may hurt. How it may sound: sharp in places.

**What stands out**

The word "always" (words like "always" and "never" leave no room for the times it went fine).

**A clearer way to say it**

Lately it's felt like you cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

**What changed, and why**

always → lately it's felt like. "Always" and "never" erase every exception, so the listener argues the exception.

*Made-up example. The ask stayed; only the word that would start an argument changed.*

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

THURSDAY, 12:20PM

*You see your colleague in the canteen again, and this time you go over and ask how her dad is. She tells you about the hospital, and the waiting, and the car park charges, and you end up sharing a table until the end of the break.*

## In everyday life

We tell stories about ourselves too, and "I always mess things up" is usually built from a few bright memories that leave a great deal out. After years together, partners tend to stop checking and start assuming. And "I know what you meant" can do a lot of quiet damage in a long relationship. Children are often labelled early as the difficult one or the easy one, and the label becomes a lens that only sees what fits. With ADHD, attention is pulled by whatever is new or urgent and can lock on hard, so someone may truly not have seen or heard. It helps to get their attention first and to put requests in writing. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

Nobody just sees things as they are. Everyone sees through a lens, and knowing that is where fairness starts. Memory isn't a recording either; it's rebuilt each time, so two honest people can remember the same evening differently and both be telling the truth. Giving someone the benefit of the doubt doesn't mean ignoring what happened. It means checking the story before you decide, and if something hurtful keeps happening, that matters. And a face or a tone is a clue to what someone meant. Faces and tones vary a lot between people and between cultures, so a face is a weaker clue than it feels.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Start with how they feel. Make sense of the feeling first, and only then ask whether there might be another way to see it. Offer information rather than verdicts: "I know she had a hard week" helps more than "You're being unfair to her." Check your own guesses out loud ("I assumed he was annoyed. I'll ask"), which shows how it's done. Be careful with labels for children and colleagues, because they stick and then shape what everyone sees. And believe people about their own experience. Seeing other angles never means telling someone that what happened to them didn't happen.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "That sounds really hurtful. Do you know what was going on for them?"
> "It might be worth asking. Want to plan what to say?"

## When to get more help

Seeing other people's side is a strength. It should never mean doubting yourself when you know something is wrong. If someone often tells you that what you saw, heard or remember didn't happen, that you're "too sensitive" or "imagining it," and you find yourself unsure of your own mind, take that seriously. It can be part of controlling behaviour. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? can help, privately.

It may also help to talk to a counsellor or other trained professional if you notice you often feel others are against you, find it hard to trust anyone, or keep getting stuck in the same painful stories about yourself. Those patterns are common and understandable, and they often change with support.

This chapter is general education, not diagnosis or therapy.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Rewind the talk: see their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder): a free perspective-taking tool.

- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): how a sentence might land before you say it.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently): how different minds hear the same words.
- Philosophy stories on seeing the other person (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth): the cave, the elephant, the fish and the empty boat.
- The library: the fundamental attribution error (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking), confirmation bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#confirmation-bias), negativity bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#negativity-bias), naive realism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#naive-realism), mind-reading (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#mind-reading) and how memory is rebuilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#memory-reconstruction).

## More for your situation

- Back: Stress and the nervous system (page 166) · Next: How communication works (page 195)
- Part One, Then: where your lens came from (page 22)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles (page 105)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts), Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) and For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- Communication between different minds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Everything on the site (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents) · Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Where your lens came from* page 22

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*Why the other person doesn't see the work* page 62

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*Seven angles on the same moment* page 105

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Us and them, and the stories groups tell* page 374

PUT IT TO USE

**Rewind the talk: see their side**
A free perspective-taking tool
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

**Chat analyzer**
How a sentence might land before you say it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

# 4

PART THREE · CHAPTER 4

# How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages

*Talking feels simple because we do it all day, yet every message has to travel from one mind to another, and a lot can change on the way. This chapter follows that journey and looks at what helps a message arrive the way you meant it.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Meaning is made between two people
2. Every message says two things
3. Listening is something you do
4. Check, don't guess
5. Hard things land better when they start soft
6. Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill
7. Messages lose their tone on the way
8. Different styles aren't wrong styles
9. Small talk has a job, and it can be short
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can differ without either of you being wrong.
- **Every message says two things**, the words themselves and what they seem to say about the two of you.
- **A short question saves a long misunderstanding**, so check before you guess.
- **Mix-ups are normal, and repairing them is the skill.** Small talk is allowed to be short.

THURSDAY, 8:15AM

*Ana texts her brother: "Can you call me when you're free?" She means there's no rush and she has a small question about the weekend. He reads it on the top deck of the 8.10 and spends the whole ride, eleven stops, wondering who is ill.*

Small habits help a message arrive: listening, checking, starting softly, repairing quickly. A few ready-made lines make small talk easier for anyone who dreads it. And three tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. Say it so it lands (Part Two, Chapter IV, page 120) asks for what happened, how you feel and one clear request, because every message carries a second message about the relationship. The 90-second daily check-in (Part Two, Chapter I, page 75) keeps repairs small and frequent. And the Chat analyzer's whole-conversation view shows where a written conversation lost its tone.

01

## Meaning is made between two people.

Words don't carry meaning on their own. The speaker has a meaning in mind, and the listener builds their own from the words, the tone, the timing and everything they already expect. Most of the time the two match well enough. Sometimes they don't, and neither person can see the gap from where they're standing.

A manager writes "Let's chat tomorrow" to a new starter, meaning a friendly catch-up and possibly a biscuit. He spends the evening convinced he's in trouble and rereads his last three emails looking for the mistake.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think what I meant and what you heard might be two different things. Can we check?"

02

## Every message says two things.

There is *what* you say, and there is what it says about the two of you. "You're late" is a fact about time, and it can also mean "I was worried" or "I don't matter to you." People often argue about the fact when the hurt is in the

second layer.

I take one eight-word sentence apart on the website's About page: "don't worry about it, I'll sort it out." Said kindly, in passing, it's reassurance. Said for the third time that month about the same job, it also says a job has no owner and a decision has been put off again. Both layers are in the sentence. Or take a housemate asking whether she used his pan. It's a question about a pan, and underneath it's a question about whether his things are respected here, which no amount of talk about the pan will settle. Next time a small thing stings, ask what it seemed to say about *us*.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I don't really mind about the pan. I think I wanted to know my stuff matters here."

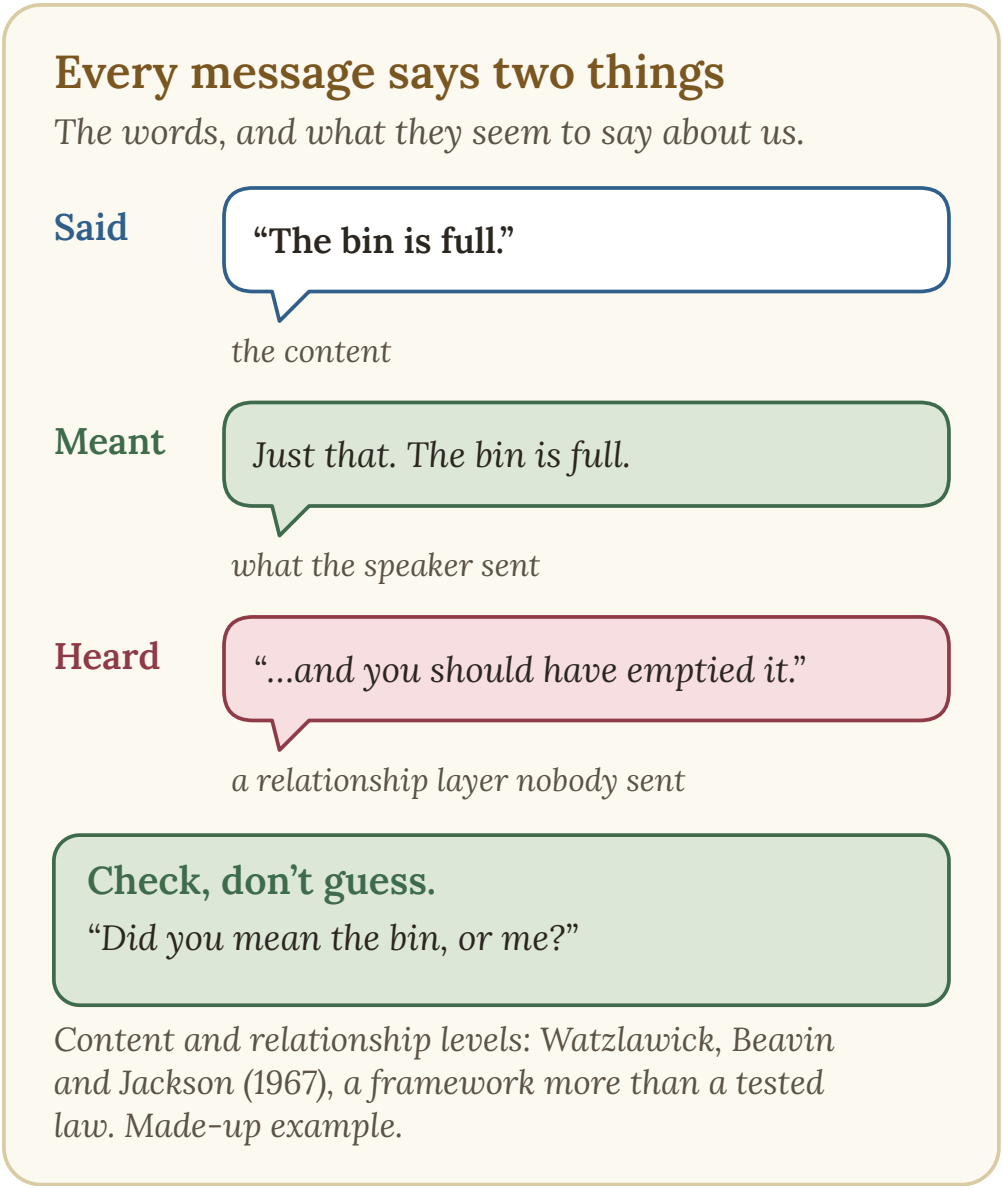



FIGURE 23 Every message says two things: the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you. Check, don't guess.

03

## Listening is something you do.

Hearing happens by itself. Listening is a choice, and most of us do it partly in order to reply, so we can fix or defend or advise or tell our own story. Real listening means following what the other person is trying to say and letting them know you got it before you add anything of your own.

A thirteen-year-old says school is pointless. Her dad starts explaining, at some length, why it isn't, and she stops talking and goes upstairs. The next time she says it, he bites his tongue and asks, "Pointless how? Tell me about today," and she talks for twenty minutes, mostly about a supply teacher and a seating plan.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "So what I'm hearing is... Have I got that right?" "Do you want ideas, or do you want me to just listen?"

In one conversation today, wait until the other person has finished, then say back what you heard before you reply. It's harder than it sounds.

04

## Check, don't guess.

Once we know something, it's hard to imagine not knowing it. So we leave out steps, assume the other person can tell what we mean, and guess what they meant instead of asking. We do it most with the people we know best. A short check costs a sentence. A wrong guess can cost a whole evening.

Two friends agree on "something low-key" for a birthday. One pictures a Chinese takeaway on the sofa in pyjamas. The other books a quiet table at the Italian place and irons a shirt. Both are disappointed, and both thought it was obvious.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Just so I've got it right, you mean...?" "When you say soon, do you mean today or this week?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Checking takes ten seconds and saves an evening. When you're ready to reply, this workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

05

## Hard things land better when they start soft.

How a hard talk begins often shapes how it ends. A complaint about one thing ("The bins weren't taken out") is easier to hear than a criticism of the person ("You never help"). A simple shape works for most hard things, which is to say what happened, how you feel and what you would like.

A woman wants her eighty-one-year-old father to stop driving at night. She has "You're not safe any more" on the tip of her tongue. She leaves it there and says, "You had two near-misses last month and I lie awake worrying. Could I drive us in the evenings?"

YOU COULD SAY

"What happened was... I felt... Could we...?"

## Say it so it lands

*A simple shape for most hard things.*

**What happened**
One specific fact, not a verdict.
*"The bins didn't go out on Tuesday."*

**How I feel**
Your feeling, in a word or two.
*"I felt let down, because I'd asked."*

**What I'd like**
A small, doable ask.
*"Could you set a reminder for next week?"*

✕ **Not: "You never help."**
*That's about the person, so it starts a defence.*

*This book's plain-language shape, a cousin of I-messages and Nonviolent Communication; research on such scripts is mixed, and tone matters most.*

FIGURE 24 Say it so it lands: what happened, how I feel, what I'd like. A complaint about an action can be heard; a criticism of the person starts a defence.

06

## Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.

Even close, kind people misunderstand each other all the time. What keeps a relationship steady is noticing and fixing it, with something like “That came out wrong” or “Can we start again?” Small repairs, made often, build trust far faster than big apologies made rarely.

In the supermarket a stranger snaps “Excuse me!” when your trolley blocks the tins, and you snap back. A second later you add, “Sorry, long day,” and she smiles and says hers has been too, and you end up talking about the price of coffee.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

“Can I try that again?” “I think I took that the wrong way. What did you mean?”



SUGARFOOT

A mix-up isn’t the end of anything. Come back, sit close, and go through it a step at a time.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

07

## Messages lose their tone on the way.

A text or email carries the words without your face or your voice, so the reader fills in the tone with however *they* feel right now, and a tired reader hears a tired, cross message. Short replies, missing greetings and late-night timing all get read as meaning something.

In the group chat for the school summer fair, one parent replies “Fine.” to the plan for the tombola. Two others decide she’s annoyed. She was typing one-handed while stirring a pan of soup.

WAYS TO SAY IT

“Quick reply. I’m not cross!” “This isn’t urgent. Any time this week is fine.”

Before you send your next tricky message, read it out loud in the grumpiest voice you can manage. If it sounds harsh, add a warm word. (This is my

favourite test in the whole book, and it takes four seconds.)

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 23

**Chat analyzer: a whole conversation**

*Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project*

## Chat analyzer: paste a conversation

### 01 Paste the conversation

*Dana: Did the slides go to the client?*
*Raj: Not yet, still waiting on the numbers from finance*
*Dana: I needed them by 10. This always happens.*
*Raj: I can't make finance go faster.*
*Dana: Forget it. I'll do it myself.*

02 Which one is you?

*Dana (3 messages)* Raj (2 messages)

03 THE READ

**What happened**

Ends shut down. 5 messages: 3 from you, 2 from Raj. The words don't make it clear what it's mostly about, so the Reader won't guess. It starts calm. There's no one big turn, but some tension creeps in. By the end someone has pulled back. That isn't the same as calm: it can mean they're overwhelmed, or hurt.

**Your part · always / never**

I said "This always happens", and that isn't fair: it isn't every time. What I meant was: [one recent time, and how it felt].

### 04 Check your reply before you send it

Your reply

*Sorry, that last line wasn't fair. When the numbers weren't in by 10, I felt worried about the client. Could you ask finance for them by 9 next time? I'll chase them with you.*

THE CHECK

✓ Says what you need or how it landed · ✓ Makes one clear ask · ✓ No verdicts, always/never, dismissals, sarcasm, jabs, comparisons or shutting the door · ✓ Stays on one topic

Nothing in the wording is likely to add heat. Read it once more as if you were them, then send it when you're calm.

*Made-up example. The Reader looks at one side's part without blaming anyone.*

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

08

## Different styles aren't wrong styles.

Some people say exactly what they mean. Others hint, and expect you to read between the lines. Some talk fast and overlap; others need a pause to think. Families and cultures and different kinds of minds all shape this, and a clash between two styles is usually a matter of translation rather than of anyone being difficult.

Asked whether the report is ready, an autistic employee says, "No, I need two more days." Her manager hears bluntness until they talk about it, after which he starts to find her clarity a relief.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'm quite direct, so if I sound blunt, it doesn't mean I'm cross." "It helps me if you say exactly what you need."

09

## Small talk has a job, and it can be short.

Small talk ("Cold today, isn't it?" "Busy weekend?") isn't really about the weather. Its job is to say that you see the other person and that the two of you are okay. In 1923 the anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski called this "phatic communion", talk whose main purpose is bonding more than information. Small moments like this matter more than people expect. Sandstrom and Dunn (2014) found that people who had a short, friendly

exchange with a coffee-shop barista felt more belonging and a better mood than people who kept it purely efficient.

Small talk is hard work for many people, though, including many autistic people, shy or anxious people and people speaking a second language. The rules are unwritten, and it uses energy that some people would rather keep. A few ready-made lines, sometimes called social scripts, take the guesswork out, and keeping it short is allowed.

A dad who dreads the school gate keeps three lines ready: "Morning! How's your week going?", then "Oh, nice," and finally "Right, I'd better get going. See you Friday." Some mornings he still sits in the car with the radio on until the bell goes. Most days he gets through it, and one of the other dads now saves him a space by the railings.

YOU COULD SAY

"Morning! How's your week been?" "How do you know Nico?" "Oh, how was that?" "Lovely to see you. I'd better get on." And to opt out kindly, "I'm not great at chit-chat, but it's really nice to see you."

TRY THIS.

Write your own three lines, one to open, one follow-up question and one to close, and use them once this week. If you would rather skip ahead to a real topic, "Can I ask you about something I'm actually curious about?" works too.

THURSDAY, 9:02AM

*Ana's brother rings the moment he's off the bus. "Who's ill?" She laughs and says nobody, she only wanted to know whether he's free on Saturday to help move a wardrobe. He laughs too, a little shakily. The following week her text reads, "No rush and nothing's wrong. Quick question about Saturday, call when you're free."*

## In everyday life

### On your own: how you talk to yourself

You also send yourself messages all day, from "Typical, I always mess this up" to "That was hard, and I handled it." The same ideas apply, so notice the tone, check whether the message is fair and repair it when it is harsh. Catch one harsh sentence you say to yourself today and rewrite it the way you would speak to someone you like.

### With other people

Between partners, "We never go out any more" sounds like a complaint about evenings, and underneath it may mean "I miss you," so answering that layer goes further than defending the calendar. "Stop that!" tells a child what not to do without saying what to do instead, while "Feet on the floor, please" is easier to follow. In meetings, silence is often taken as agreement until a quieter colleague says later that she never agreed, and a round of "Anyone see it differently?" catches this early. "Are you eating properly?" is care in one generation's language and checking up in another's.

- **Feedback at work.** Talk about the work rather than the person, with one recent example of what good looks like. Then ask, "What's been getting in the way?" When you're the one receiving it, "Thanks. Can I think about it and come back tomorrow?" is a fine first answer. The full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth) walks through a whole performance conversation.

## Common mix-ups

"If they loved me, they'd just know" is the big one. Closeness makes us check *less* without making us understand any more, so saying it clearly is a kindness, and no test of love. Listening isn't agreeing, either. You can understand someone completely and still see it differently, and the understanding comes first. A repair doesn't mean you're admitting to being the bad one; it just says it didn't go the way you wanted, and either person can make one. And texts feel safer for hard things because they're easier to

send. They're also much easier to misread, so for anything tender, add warmth, or talk.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Maybe a friend keeps having the same argument with their partner, or your teenager feels nobody listens. You can't communicate for them, but you can help.

- **Listen first.** The most useful thing is often to be the person who really hears them, without fixing.
- **Help them separate the two layers**, by asking what it was about and what it seemed to say about the two of them.
- **Offer the simple shape** of what happened, how they feel and what they would like, and let them find their own words.
- **Stay out of judging the other person's character.** You only hear one side, and they may make up next week.
- **Notice if it's more than a mix-up.** If they seem afraid of the other person, gently share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Do you want me to just listen, or help you think about what to say?"

## When to get more help

Most mix-ups can be eased with the ideas here. Some situations need more.

- **When talking makes things worse every time,** a couples or family counsellor can slow conversations down and help both people be heard.
- **When you're afraid of how someone will react,** that isn't a communication problem. Clearer words are not the fix, and you don't have to keep trying. Not safe at home? lists free, private help, and signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs) may help you name what's happening.

- **When someone is always "misunderstanding" you** in ways that make you doubt your memory or your sense of what happened, talk with someone you trust outside the relationship.
- **When speaking or understanding is hard for you every day,** because of anxiety, a hearing or language difference, or how your mind works, a doctor, speech and language therapist or counsellor may help. Needing support is not a failing.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Try one of these this week with one real conversation. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps you shape a hard sentence, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) walks you back through a talk that went wrong, and the wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) puts how you communicate on one page.

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): calm replies after a fight.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz): a playful look at your own style.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Effective communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication): the site's complete, plain guide, from listening and timing to hard talks, repair and each kind of relationship.
- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins): how to hold a hard conversation kindly.
- Why we get out of tune (page 75) looks at the same ideas at home.

## More for your situation

- At work: messages and meetings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and for parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)
- Neurodivergent relationships: communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune** page 75
*Pace, tone and getting back in tune*

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair** page 120
*Letting a comment land*

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt** page 292
*Repair after it goes wrong*

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words** page 35
*How you like to be spoken to*


PUT IT TO USE



**Chat analyzer**
Calm replies after a fight
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator



**Communication style quiz**
A playful look at your own style
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

# 5

PART THREE · CHAPTER 5

# Attachment, trust and belonging

*Why we need each other, how the bonds we had early on shape what we expect today, and how trust and belonging are built and lost and built again, one small moment at a time.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Belonging is a basic need
2. Early bonds teach us what to expect
3. Patterns, not boxes
4. Trust is built in small moments
5. Feeling safe with someone calms the body
6. Fitting in isn't the same as belonging
7. When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time
8. You can start building connection from wherever you are
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger.
- **Early bonds set expectations that can change.** What we learned about being cared for can soften over time.
- **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- **You can start small**, with one friendly exchange or one kept promise.

SUNDAY, 9:30PM

*Kai sent a long message to a friend at lunchtime, four paragraphs about his new job and a question at the end. It says "Read 12:47". No reply. By teatime he has gone from thinking she's busy to thinking she's annoyed, and by half nine he's wondering whether anybody really likes him at all. The friend, meanwhile, is at her nephew's sixth birthday party at a soft-play centre, with her phone in her coat pocket under a pile of other coats.*

Two tools elsewhere rest on this chapter. One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, page 88) works because trust is built from small promises kept, and a named owner turns "someone will probably do it" into a promise people can rely on. The monthly look-back (Part Two, Chapter V, page 136) looks at the month and keeps both people out of the dock, because feeling safe is what lets anyone say what went wrong.

01

## Belonging is a basic need.

People need to feel connected, the way we need food and sleep. When we feel left out, it can hurt in a way that feels almost physical (Naomi Eisenberger and colleagues, 2003). That hurt works like hunger, telling us to reach for connection.

Rhea moves to Manchester for work. She's busy and doing well, and by the third month she feels flat and teary every Sunday afternoon, when the office is shut and nobody in the city knows her well enough to ring. This week, reach out to one person, even if it's only a short "thinking of you".

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Feeling lonely says I need connection, like anyone does."

02

## Early bonds teach us what to expect.

As children, we learn from the people who cared for us whether others will come when we need them. If help usually came, we tend to expect it. If it came sometimes, or rarely, we may learn to cling harder or to stop asking. These lessons are a starting point that later relationships can change. This is

the idea of attachment, first described by John Bowlby (1969) and studied by Mary Ainsworth and colleagues (1978).

Watch a toddler at the park. He runs off towards the ducks, runs back to check his grandmother is still on the bench, runs off again a bit further, comes back, goes further still. He's braver each time because he knows exactly where she is.

> YOU COULD SAY
> (to a child) "I'm right here. Go and look, and come back whenever you want."

Think of one person who was a safe base for you, at any age, and what they actually did.

03

### Patterns, not boxes.

As adults, some of us worry a lot about being left, and reach out more when we feel unsure. Some of us pull back when things get close, and need more space. Many of us feel mostly secure, and most of us mix all three.

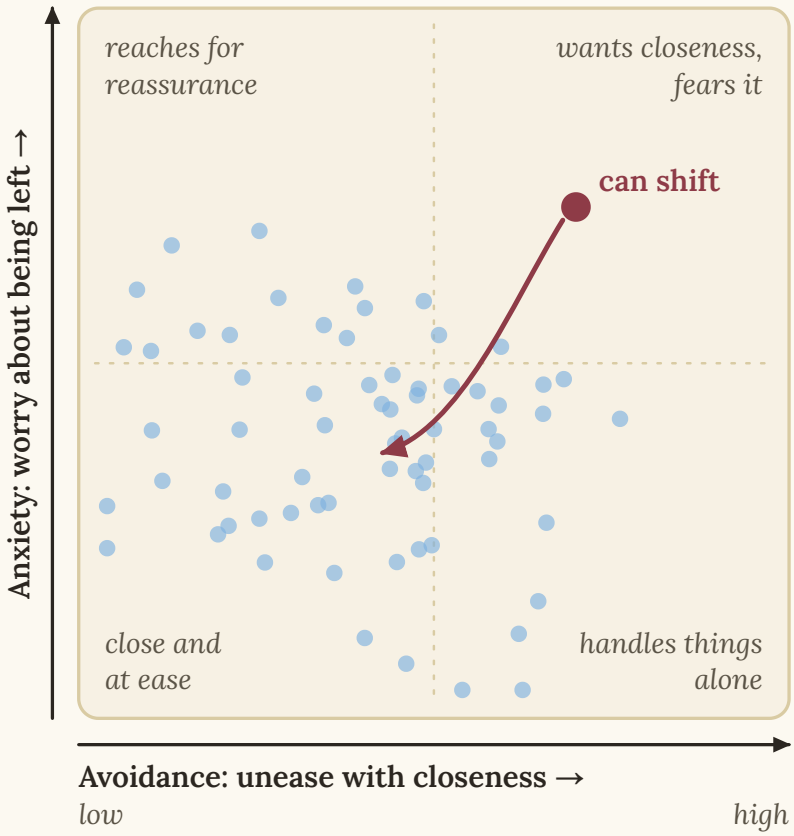
These are patterns that can soften and change, especially in steady, kind relationships. Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) first described them in adults, and later work, such as R. Chris Fraley and colleagues (2015), suggests they work as sliding scales.

When things feel tense, Ronan wants to talk it through straight away. His wife Clara needs to go quiet first, usually in the garden. He reads her quiet as a sign she's leaving; she reads his questions through the back door as pressure. Once they see the pattern, they agree that Clara will say "I need an hour, and I'm coming back," and Ronan will wait, which he finds very hard for about the first month.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm not going anywhere. I just need some quiet. Let's talk at eight."

## Patterns, not boxes

*Two scales. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move.*




*After Brennan, Clark and Shaver (1998) and Fraley and colleagues (2015): adult attachment is best measured as two scales, not types. Dots are illustrative, not data.*

FIGURE 25 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes: worry about being left, and unease with closeness. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move. Dots are illustrative.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 24

**Our pause plan**

*Imani and Kwame, married ten years*

## Our pause plan

Fill this in together on a calm day, or fill it in yourself and send it to your partner to change.

Our pause word or sentence

*"Pause. I'll be back at …", with a hand on the heart*

Shortest break, so our bodies can settle

*30 minutes*

Whoever pauses names a clock time to come back, no later than

*the same evening*

If one of us can't come back on time

*Send one text with a new time. No silence.*

The first sentence when we come back

*"I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"*

YOUR PLAN, READY TO SEND

Our pause plan

Pause word: “Pause. I’ll be back at …”, with a hand on the heart

Shortest break: 30 minutes

Return time: whoever pauses names a clock time, no later than the same evening

If one of us can’t come back on time: Send one text with a new time. No silence.

When we come back, we start with: “I’m back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?”

*Made-up example. For relationships where everyone feels safe.*

Fill in your own: Our pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw)

04

## Trust is built in small moments.

Trust rarely comes from big gestures. It grows from small, ordinary things done again and again, like doing what you said, and being the same person on a hard day as on a good one. Honestly, it’s a bit boring. That’s why it works.

A new team member says she will send the figures by Thursday, and she does. The next week she warns early that something will be late. By the third month her manager trusts her completely, and he would struggle to name a single moment when it happened.

WAYS TO SAY IT

“I said I’d do it by Friday. I’m running late, so here’s where it’s at.”



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Trust grows in small moments that repeat. This workpaper helps you notice the little rituals you already have, and keep them going.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

05

## Feeling safe with someone calms the body.

Being with someone we trust can settle our nervous system. In one study, holding a trusted partner's hand calmed the brain's response to threat (James Coan and colleagues, 2006). A calm voice, a hand to hold, or just someone nearby can make a hard moment easier to bear. It works both ways, so we can be that safe presence for others too, often without saying much.

After a panic attack, Kieran's friend doesn't try to fix anything. He sits next to him on the step outside the flats and says, "Take your time. I'm here," and they stay there until Kieran's breathing slows.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "You don't have to talk. I'll just sit with you." "Would company help right now, or quiet?"

Notice who helps you feel calmer, and tell them. "I always feel better after seeing you" is a lovely thing to hear and almost nobody says it.

06

## Fitting in isn't the same as belonging.

Fitting in means changing yourself to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are. Teams, families, clubs and communities can offer either. Being left out of a group hurts even when the group doesn't matter much to us, and real belonging grows where people feel safe to be themselves and to speak up.

At a new job, Ola laughs at jokes she doesn't find funny and orders a lime and soda "for the drive" so nobody asks why she doesn't drink, and she goes home exhausted every Friday. At her book club, in the back room of the library on alternate Tuesdays, she says what she really thinks of the book, and people ask her to say more.

> YOU COULD SAY
> (in a group) "I see it a bit differently. Is it okay if I say why?" "Has everyone had a chance to say something?"

07

## When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time.

When someone lets us down badly, trust doesn't come back with one apology. It returns slowly, as words are matched by actions over time. The person who broke trust can own what happened and be patient. The person who was hurt can decide, at their own pace, whether and how much to trust again.

Two adult sisters fall out after one tells a private story at a family dinner, for a laugh. The apology is a start, and what slowly rebuilds trust is the months afterwards, when the story never comes up again and the sister checks before sharing anything.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I know sorry isn't enough. I'll show you, and you can take whatever time you need."

08

## You can start building connection from wherever you are.

If you feel alone right now, big friendships can feel a long way off. Belonging can start much smaller than that: a chat with a neighbour, a regular class, an online group about something you love. Even small, light contact with people we barely know can lift our mood (Gillian Sandstrom and Elizabeth Dunn, 2014).

After his divorce, Martin starts saying more than "thanks" to the man at the coffee stall outside the station. A few weeks later they're talking football every morning, mostly about Stoke's defence. It's a small friendship. It makes Mondays easier.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I'm new around here. Is there anything you'd recommend?" "I loved what you said in the group. Would you like to get a coffee sometime?"



TIDBIT

One small hello is a fine start. If you can't think of one, there's a tool that picks one for you.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

MONDAY, 8:10AM

*Kai's phone buzzes with an apology. Her phone was in her coat all day at her nephew's party, she loved the message, and is he free for coffee on Thursday? Kai thinks about how far last night's story ran, and decides that next time a reply is slow he will send a light "No rush, just thinking of you" and leave it there.*

## If you're a teenager

Ezra is sixteen when he sees a photo of his three closest friends at the cinema and finds out there is a group chat he isn't in. It hurts like a punch, because being left out really does register a bit like pain. He drafts something sharp and deletes it, then messages one friend instead, saying he's a bit gutted not to be asked and asking whether he did something. It turns out they thought he would be at football. One of the friendships really is drifting, though, and that is allowed to hurt too.

WORDS TO TRY

"Bit gutted not to be asked. Did something happen?" "I'd like to come next time, even if I can't always make it." "I miss how we used to be. Are we okay?"

## In everyday life

When one partner texts a lot while apart and the other forgets, agreeing on one goodnight message can keep both feeling connected. A child who acts up at pick-up may simply be letting go of a long day with the safest person they know. A friend who always cancels may be overwhelmed, and "Is it easier if we do something short?" keeps the door open. At work, a team where

mistakes can be admitted without blame builds trust faster than one where everyone hides them, and in a shared house, one simple weekly meal can turn people who share a kitchen into people who look out for each other.

### On your own: belonging with yourself

Belonging also includes how you treat yourself. If you are kind to yourself on a bad day, you carry a small safe base wherever you go, and people who learn to comfort themselves often find it easier to let others in, because they are less afraid of being let down. You are allowed to need people, and a lonely day is hard without being a forecast. On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) has more for people living alone.

## Common mix-ups

- **"Needing people means I'm needy."** Everyone needs connection, including the people who hide it well.
- **"My attachment style is fixed for life."** Patterns can change, especially through steady, kind relationships and reflection.
- **"Jealousy and checking up show how much they love me."** Reaching for reassurance is human, and so is asking for something out of care for the relationship. Controlling who someone sees, or checking their phone without agreement, is not love and is not an attachment style. See signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety).
- **"If I forgive, I have to trust again straight away."** Forgiving and trusting are different. Trust can return slowly, or not at all, and that's your call.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Be steady. Turn up when you said you would, which matters more than any big gesture. If someone says they feel alone, listen before you remind them how many friends they have. Invite, and keep inviting; people who feel left out may say no a few times, and a warm invitation with no pressure still counts each time. In groups, notice who is on the edge and ask their view. And leave the labels out. Telling someone they're "so avoidant" or "so clingy"

has never helped anyone, as far as I can tell, while "what would help?" often does.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm here, and I'm not going anywhere." "We're having a few people over on Friday. No pressure, but I'd love you to come."

## When to get more help

- **If loneliness has lasted a long time,** or comes with low mood, hopelessness or thoughts of not wanting to be here, please talk to a doctor or a mental health service. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number or see Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).
- **If fear of being left, or of getting close, keeps hurting your relationships,** a counsellor or therapist can help you understand where it comes from and how to change it.
- **If someone uses your need for them against you,** by cutting you off from friends, checking where you are, or threatening to leave to get their way, that is not about attachment. Not safe at home? lists free, private help.
- **If trust was broken in a way that frightened you,** you don't owe anyone a second chance. Your safety comes first.

## Reading on the website

Pick one small way to turn towards someone this week. Turning towards (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward), When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) and How to apologise so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) have more ideas.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding): what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you.

- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends): when a friendship drifts, and how to reach out.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.

## More for your situation

- On my own after a breakup
- Friends
- Parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Early trust and the rules from home* page 22

**Part Three · Chapter 15 · Closeness and love**
*Being known, at every age* page 347

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Belonging to groups, and their pull* page 374

**Part Three · Chapter 8 · Loss, grief and big life changes**
*When a bond is lost* page 248

PUT IT TO USE

**Bonding: how closeness grows**
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

**Friends**
When a friendship drifts, and how to reach out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

# 6

PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

# Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

*Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- **A small step and a kind setup outlast willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change what is around you.
- **Slips are part of change.** A missed day tells you something about the plan and nothing about your character.
- **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it, though you can't force it.

MONDAY, 7:05AM

*The plan was a walk before work. The trainers are by the door. Somehow the phone is in your hand instead, and at 7:40 you're still scrolling, past a video of a man restoring a rusty axe, next to a cup of coffee that went cold twenty minutes ago. By evening a quiet voice is telling you that you never stick to anything. What you actually ran into this morning was a habit with years of practice behind it, and it won.*

This chapter is the reason several tools in these books are so small. One small step a week (Part One, Next, page 50) starts smaller than feels useful and decides ahead of time. The setup score and One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, page 88) change the setup rather than asking anyone for more willpower. And What keeps coming back? (Part Two, Chapter V, page 136) treats a repeat as information about the plan, because slips are a normal part of changing anything.

01

## Change is hard for good reasons.

Much of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, and it's the whole reason habits exist. The downside is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one, so change asks your brain to do something effortful again and again, for weeks, until the new way becomes the easy one.

Jodie wants to stop snapping at her children in the morning rush, and she means it every night. Every morning the same rush brings the same snap, somewhere between the lost reading book and the cold toast, because the morning has worn a groove deeper than her good intentions.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This is hard because it's a habit." "Old grooves take time to fill in."

Pick one thing you'd like to change and write down when it usually happens, where, and what's going on just before. That's the start of the next idea.

02

## Habits run on cues.

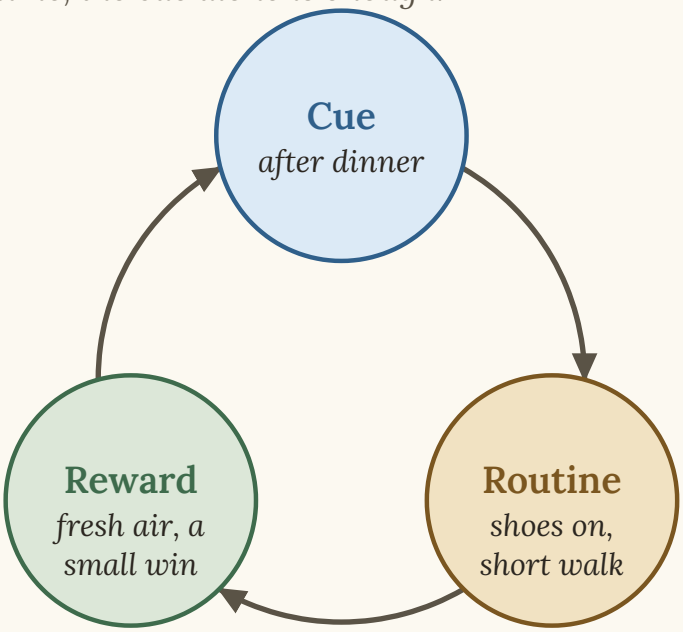
Most habits have a trigger: a time, a place, a feeling, a person, or the thing you've just done. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a little buzz) keeps it going. Once you know the cue, you can plan for it.

A man notices that he reaches for the biscuit tin the moment he opens his laptop after dinner, hungry or not. The laptop is the cue. So he starts making a pot of tea before he opens it, and the biscuits, mostly, stay in the tin. For three days, each time your habit happens, jot down the time, the place, the feeling and what you were doing just before.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "What happened right before I did that?" "What was I getting from it?"

## Habits run on cues

*Over time, the cue alone is enough.*




**Change the setup, not just your willpower:** *move the cue, make the step tiny.*

*The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).*

FIGURE 26 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

## Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring but easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and they work because they are easy enough to do on a bad day. It helps to tie the new step to something you already do, as in “After I put the kettle on, I’ll…”, and to grow it only once it has stuck.

Two housemates want a tidier kitchen. They’ve been promising each other a big Sunday clean since March, and it has happened once. So they agree instead that after dinner each of them wipes one surface. It takes two minutes. By the second week the hob has stopped being a source of tension, and by the fourth somebody has descaled the kettle without being asked.

YOU COULD SAY

“Let’s start with something tiny, and see if it sticks.” “After I ..., I will ...”

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 25

**Your done list**

*Bernie, 71, living on his own*

### Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

*Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe*

Who it was with

*With a friend*

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Rang my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the post office instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

*Made-up example. A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.*

Fill in your own: Your done list (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

## Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when you're tired or hungry. Your surroundings stay the same all day. So make the new habit easier, by putting it in sight or getting things ready the night before, and make the old one a little harder, by moving it out of reach or adding a step. I'd back a small change to the setup over a big push of effort almost every time.

A teenager wants to sleep better and has tried for weeks to stop scrolling in bed. Then he starts charging his phone in the kitchen overnight, next to the bread bin, and within a week he's asleep before midnight most nights. He grumbles about it. He also keeps doing it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

(to yourself or a partner) "What could we change about the setup so this gets easier?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

## Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change and part of you doesn't, and the reluctant part usually has its reasons. The old habit may give comfort, or protect you from something. Pushing harder against that part rarely works, while listening to it often does.

Asif wants to drink less, but he also loves Friday evenings in the pub with his team. When he asks himself what Friday gives him, the answer is friends, laughter and a way to unwind, so he keeps the Friday and switches to alcohol-free after the first pint. Nobody at the table notices, or if they do, nobody says.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
> "What does the old habit give me?" "What would make the change worth it to me?"

Try two lists, one of what you like about how things are and one of what you'd like about changing. Both lists are allowed, and the first one is usually more honest.

06

## Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes, and one slip doesn't undo your progress. What often does the damage is the thought that follows, the "I've blown it, so why bother?" Treating yourself kindly after a slip makes it more likely that you will start again.

After three calm weeks, a dad shouts at his son over homework. That night he sits on the end of the bed and says, "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." The next evening they do the homework at the kitchen table with the radio on, and nobody raises their voice.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "A slip is one moment out of many." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

Decide now, while things are going well, what you'll do after a slip: one kind sentence to yourself, and one small step to start again.



TIDBIT

A slip is a stumble, not a fall. Try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts can make the practising easier.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

## Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change made only to please others, or out of shame, is hard to keep. Change that connects to what you care about, to the kind of person you want to be, has deeper roots, and each small action becomes a vote for that person.

A woman who keeps meaning to be better at keeping in touch starts thinking of herself as someone who shows up for her friends. Sending one voice note on a Sunday evening becomes part of who she is, and some weeks it turns into an hour on the phone.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Who am I becoming with this step?" "This matters to me because..."

08

## You can support change, but not force it.

It is natural to want the people we love to change, perhaps to drink less or look after themselves better. Their change belongs to them, though, and pressure tends to make people dig in. It helps more to say clearly what you need, ask what would help, and notice their small steps out loud.

A colleague keeps missing deadlines. His teammate has the lecture about being organised all ready to go, and skips it. She asks what would make the handover easier, and the two of them set up a shared checklist that he now updates every Friday before lunch.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

*The trainers are still by the door, but the phone charges in the kitchen overnight now, and the plan has shrunk to shoes on and out to the end of the road. Some mornings that is all you manage. Most mornings it turns into a walk past the allotments and back. On the Thursday you miss, the voice starts up again, and you tell it that tomorrow you will get as far as the end of the road.*

## In everyday life

Take one couple who want to spend less time on their phones in the evening. Earlier attempts failed because each of them watched the other, so this time they agree on a basket by the door where both phones go at nine, with one exception for whoever is on call for an elderly parent. The first week is awkward, and on the Wednesday one of them sneaks a look at the football scores. By the third week the basket has become part of the furniture, and the evenings have a shape again, with a film, a crossword or an early night.

Big life changes, a move or a new baby, break old routines, which is disruptive and also a good moment to start new habits. If you have ADHD, make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears and make the reward come straight away. Expect the novelty to wear off, and swap the method when it does instead of blaming yourself. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth).

### On your own: a kind plan for change

If you are working on something alone, the ideas fit into one small plan. Choose one change, the one that would make the most difference or the one that feels most doable. Give it one cue, written as "After I ___, I will ___." Make one tweak to your setup so it is easier to start, decide on the smallest version you could still do on a tired day, and write down one kind sentence to

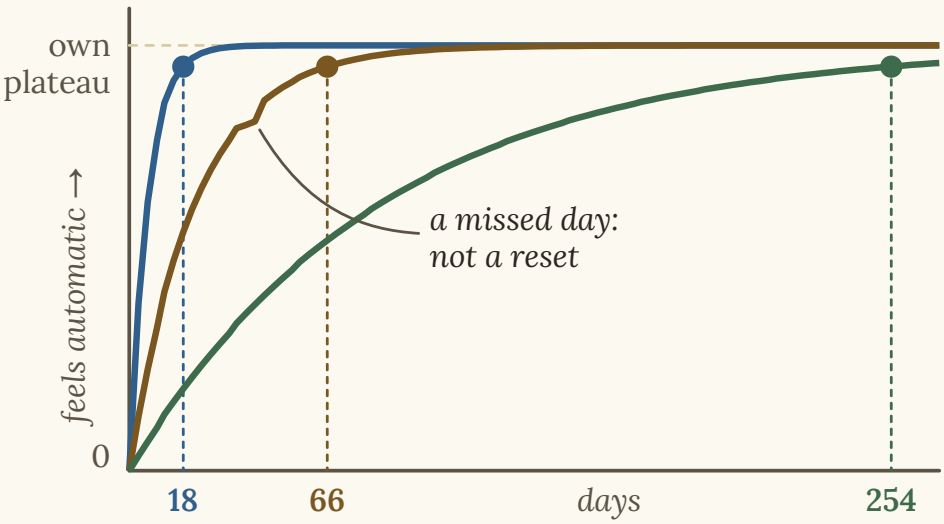
use after a slip. The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Know yourself, next (page 50) walk through this step by step.

## Common mix-ups

"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it" is the cruellest of these, and it's wrong. Wanting is only the start; habits, setup, tiredness and stress all have a vote. Then there's the famous 21 days. There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range. Being hard on yourself doesn't keep you on track either. Harshness tends to make people give up, and kindness makes it easier to try again. And routines don't have to mean being rigid. For a lot of people, autistic people especially, routines are what make life manageable, and change can respect that.

## About two months, give or take a lot

*How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.*




— Fastest in the study: about 18 days
— Middle (median): about 66 days
— Slowest: about 254 days

*Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.*

FIGURE 27 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

### If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you advise, perhaps with "Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?", and help them find their own reasons by asking what

would be different for them if this changed. Practical help with the setup (a lift to the gym, say) often does more than encouragement alone. Notice small steps out loud and be kind about slips. Look after yourself as well, because you can care deeply and still set limits on what you will put up with.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days running. That's not nothing."

## When to get more help

- **If a habit is harming your health or life,** such as drinking, drugs, gambling, eating or self-harm, please talk to a doctor or a specialist service. Needing help with this is common and nothing to be ashamed of.
- **If you can't stop even though you've tried many times,** professional support can make a real difference. It isn't a sign of weakness.
- **If change feels impossible because you're exhausted or low most days,** that may be burnout or depression. A doctor or counsellor can help.
- **If someone is demanding you change in ways that frighten you,** or punishing you when you don't, that isn't support. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Pick one tiny change and try it for a week. The 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), the quick checks (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) and the self path can help you keep track.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Know yourself, next (page 50): values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans.

- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive.

## More for your situation

- On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Gaming, phones and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*One small goal and tiny steps* page 50

**Part Two · Chapter V · The monthly look-back**
*The monthly look-back* page 136

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?**
*Changing the setup, not the person* page 88

**Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change**
*How much people really change* page 334

PUT IT TO USE

**Know yourself, next**
Values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next

**Complacency**
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

7

PART THREE · CHAPTER 7

# Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

*Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame differs from guilt, and why being kind to yourself makes it easier to grow.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


THURSDAY, 11:20PM

*You sent the wrong file to the whole team, last quarter's figures instead of this one's. Priyanka spotted it within four minutes, sent the right one round and said "no worries!" with an exclamation mark. Hours later you're still awake and replaying it, and the voice in your head has moved on from the file altogether. It's telling you that you're useless, and that everyone knows it now.*

This chapter is about how self-worth and shame work, and then about what you can do with them, on your own, at home, with friends or at work. None of it is a diagnosis. Take what helps.

01

## Your worth isn't a score.

A lot of us carry a quiet scoreboard. We're worth something when we're useful, or liked, or slim, or busy, or top of the class, or never any bother. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth", and the trouble with them is that any score can drop. If your worth goes up and down with each day's results, every bad day feels like a verdict on you as a person.

Pam taught Year 4 for forty years. In the September after she retires she feels lost in a way she can't explain to anyone, wandering round the big Tesco at ten on a weekday morning. Nothing is wrong. For four decades being needed was how she knew she mattered, and the bell has stopped ringing. Try finishing the line "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times, and look at what you wrote; those are your scores. Noticing them is plenty for now.

02

## Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points somewhere useful: say sorry, put it right. Shame is about who you are, which feels impossible to fix, and so it makes people hide, freeze, blame someone else or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is the one more likely to lead to repair.

A twelve-year-old knocks his mum's favourite mug off the side, the one with the hare on it from Whitby. Guilt tells him to own up and offer some of his birthday money towards a new one. Shame tells him he ruins everything, and he wraps the pieces in yesterday's newspaper and pushes them to the bottom of the kitchen bin. So next time you feel bad about something, ask which one it is. If it has turned into who you are, try to shrink it back to the one thing you did, and then ask what would make that thing right.

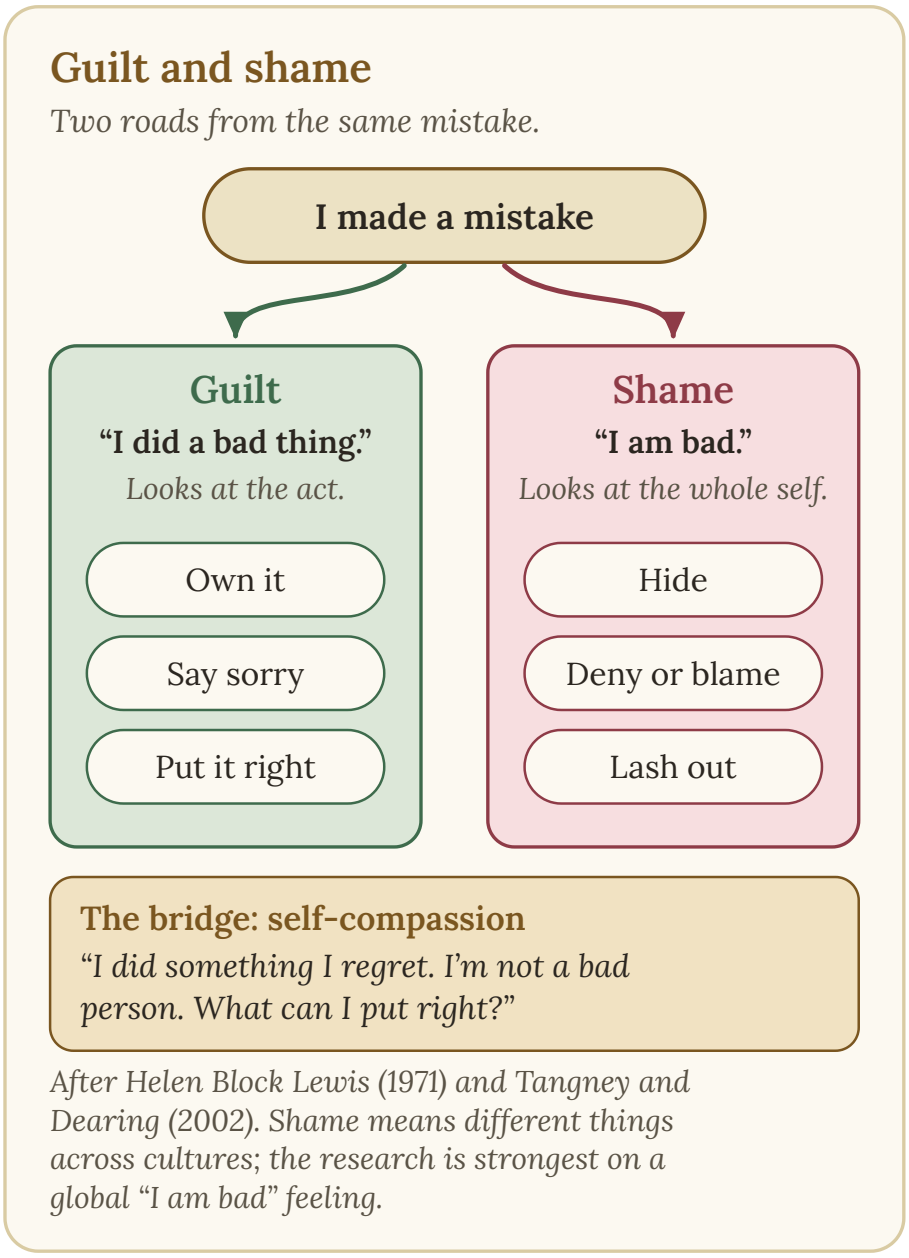



FIGURE 28 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

03

## Shame makes you want to hide.

You feel shame in the body before you think it: a hot face, eyes down, a sinking stomach, the wish for the floor to open. It can also come out sideways as sudden anger or a closed, cold face, which is how a small comment starts a big fight. In a meeting someone asks, mildly enough, "Didn't we already cover this?" and his colleague snaps back at him. That evening she realises the snap had nothing to do with the question; she had felt stupid in front of everyone.

It helps to learn your own shame signs. Next time you suddenly want to disappear, or to bite, you can name it quietly to yourself, and sometimes say it out loud: "I think I felt embarrassed just then, and it came out sharp. Can I try again?"

04

## The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh inner voice usually started as protection. If you criticise yourself first, perhaps nobody else can get in a blow. If you're hard enough on yourself, perhaps you'll never fail again. It meant well. But a voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, and it's exhausting to live with.

A young dad calls himself an idiot every time he forgets something for the baby, the wipes, the rabbit she won't sleep without. It's the word his own father used about him. The voice he hears in the car park at the nursery is an old one, borrowed years ago and never given back. Write down one thing your critic says often and ask whether you'd say it to a friend you love. Some people find it helps to answer the critic directly: "Thanks for trying to protect me. I can take it from here."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 26

**Flip it**

*Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work*

## Flip it

What's on your mind?

*I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.*

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · A worry · *Being hard on myself* · Anger

THE FLIP

**What a good friend might say**

"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

**Kinder words for yourself**

"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll [one thing]."

**One next step**

[one small thing, like a short sorry, a reminder on your phone, or some rest]

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Hamish's own words, after changing the flip

*I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.*

His next step

*Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.*

*Made-up example. The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.*

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

05

## Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you'd treat a good friend who's struggling. One well-known model has three parts: kindness in place of attack, remembering that everyone struggles, and noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest that people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve.

Lindy fails her driving test for the third time, on the reverse round a corner again. In the test centre car park she tells herself that this is hard, that loads of people need more goes, and that she'll practise that one manoeuvre on the industrial estate on Sunday mornings when it's empty. Then she books another lesson. If it feels okay, put a hand on your chest or arm once today and say, slowly, "This is a hard moment. Other people feel this too. What do I need right now?"



SUGARFOOT

Speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first helps.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

## Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

Everyone measures themselves against other people; it's how we work out where we stand. Feeds full of other people's best moments make the measuring wildly unfair, though, and self-esteem that depends on being better than others swings about a great deal.

Two old friends meet for a curry, one with a new house, the other renting a room in a shared flat. The renter spends the whole evening quietly ranking herself and misses what's in front of her, which is that her friend is lonely in the new house and had wanted to talk about it. When you catch yourself comparing today, try swapping it for a question about the other person, like "How are you, really?" You're comparing your inside with their outside, after all.

07

## You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake gets much easier once it doesn't mean you're worthless. A simple shape helps. Say what you did, say what it did to the other person, say what you'll do now, and stop. Beating yourself up afterwards proves nothing about how sorry you are; it just moves the attention back to you.

A housemate forgot to pay her share of the broadband and it was cut off for the whole of a bank holiday weekend. She tells the others, "I forgot to pay, and that left you without internet all weekend. I've paid it and set a reminder for the 28th," and that's the end of it. Think of one small thing you still feel bad about and write your own three-part sentence. Then decide whether to send it or let it rest.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Owning a mistake can be short and plain: what happened, that it was yours, what you'll do. If it went wrong in a talk, Rewind the talk helps you find the words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

08

## Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they're treated, and adults never quite stop learning it. The words matter. "You did a careless thing" leaves room to change, while "you're so careless" shuts the door. Praise for effort and for who someone is, as well as for results, helps people feel they matter on bad days too.

A team lead starts every project review by asking what the team learned rather than who got it wrong. Within six months, people are raising problems in week two instead of week ten, which saves everyone a great deal of Friday evening. Today you could say one thing to someone that has nothing to do with their results, even just "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

*You send one line to the team, sorry for the mix-up with yesterday's file, right one attached. When the old voice starts up you answer it the way you'd answer a friend: you made a mistake and you fixed it, which is what a decent colleague does. Priyanka replies with a thumbs-up. Nobody mentions the file again, and by lunchtime you've mostly stopped thinking about it too.*

## In everyday life

Shame turns up in very ordinary places. Between partners, "You forgot to call" can land as "You're a terrible partner", and so the reply comes out as a defence instead of a sorry. A child who hears "You're so naughty" learns something about who they are, while "That was a naughty thing to do" leaves them a way back. A friend who says yes to everything may be quietly burning out, because saying no feels like risking being dropped. At work, someone may sit on a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proof they don't belong there.

### On your own: a kinder voice to keep

You don't need anyone else to start this. Notice how you talk to yourself and practise one gentler sentence. Catch the critic's favourite words ("always", "useless", "pathetic", "should") and swap one of them for a plain fact, so "I'm hopeless" becomes "I was late twice this week." On hard days keep a short list of what you did well, or simply did, and let getting up count. You're allowed to be disappointed in what you did and still be on your own side.

## Common mix-ups

People worry that self-compassion is self-pity. They feel different from the inside: self-pity says "only me, poor me", while self-compassion says "this is hard, and other people go through it too", which connects you to others rather than shutting you off. Others fear that being kind to themselves will make them lazy. The research leans the other way, because fear of your own attack is what makes people avoid trying and hide mistakes. And self-worth doesn't mean thinking you're great. It means you matter on the days you aren't.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Talk about what happened, never about what kind of person they are. Arguing with someone's shame ("You're not useless!") can feel like being told they're wrong to feel it, so try "It sounds like you feel really low about it. I don't see you that way." Helping them find one small thing they can do gives the feeling somewhere to go. And kindness on ordinary days, when nothing has gone wrong, teaches worth better than anything said in a crisis.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "That sounds like it's weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?" "You don't have to earn being cared about."

## When to get more help

Everyone feels shame and self-doubt sometimes. It's worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if harsh thoughts about yourself are there most days, if they stop you working, eating, sleeping or seeing people, or if you feel you deserve to be hurt. Therapies such as compassion-focused therapy and cognitive behavioural therapy are built to help with exactly this.

**If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here,** please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If someone close to you keeps telling you you're worthless, stupid or lucky to have them, that isn't a self-esteem problem. It can be a way of controlling someone. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? have free, private help.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a feeling that is too big to think through
- Ask Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Shame and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), in the site's library of research notes
- Self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and self-esteem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation)
- Perfectionism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation#perfectionism) and social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life)

- Masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), for anyone who has spent years trying to seem "normal"
- Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up), for where an old inner voice might have started

## More for your situation

- **On your own:** Part One: where you came from (page 22) · Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · On my own after a breakup (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Teens:** For teens: feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Neurodivergent:** Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) · Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **At work:** At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Coming out:** Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Carers and parents:** Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **Related chapters:** Loss, grief and big life changes (page 248) · Minds that work differently (page 261)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Your worth isn't a score.
- ✓ Shame makes you want to hide.
- ✓ Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.
- ✓ Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.
- ✓ Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

## THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Old rules that taught you your worth* page 22

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*Kindness when a goal slips* page 50

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Guilt, apology and forgiveness* page 292

**Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma**
*When the inner critic gets loud* page 359

## PUT IT TO USE

**Upset right now?**
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Ask Professor Puddles**
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

# 8

PART THREE · CHAPTER 8

# Loss, grief and big life changes

*What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves.** A good week followed by a bad day is part of grieving, and it doesn't send you back to the start.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that is healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help than friends can give.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

*Six months on, you're doing fine, or so you tell people. Then in aisle seven you see the cereal your dad always bought, the one with the faded blue box that he said tasted of cardboard and ate every single morning anyway, and you have to leave your trolley where it is and go and sit in the car. Nobody around you knows why.*

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something, whether a person, a pet, a marriage, a friendship, their health, a home, a job, a country or a future they had pictured. It looks at how grief works and then at what can help. There's no right way to grieve. Nothing here is a timetable, and if any of it doesn't fit you, leave it.

01

## Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone, and it isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted away or children leaving home can all bring real grief. Its size usually matches the size of the bond, whatever other people think the loss ought to mean.

When Bramble dies, his owner is shaken by how hard he takes it, and his friends at the pub tell him, kindly enough, that it was only a dog. That dog walked beside him along the same stretch of river every morning for twelve years, through two jobs and a divorce. The lead is still on its hook by the back door, and he can't move it yet.

It can help to say a loss out loud to yourself, especially one you've never called grief. "I'm grieving the friendship." "I'm grieving the life we planned." They're small sentences, and they often bring some relief, because they give the feeling a name and a reason.

02

## Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

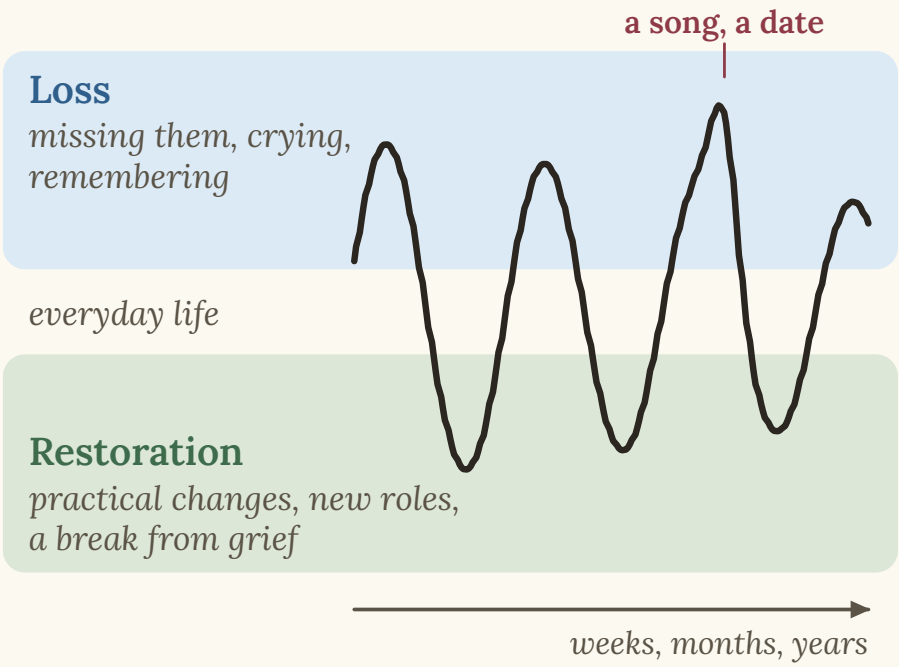
You may have heard of five stages of grief, running from denial through anger, bargaining and depression to acceptance. They came from listening to people who were dying, and they were never meant as steps that everyone

follows in order. Most people swing back and forth, some hours deep in the loss and some hours getting on with life, and researchers who study grief see that swing as healthy. A widow laughs properly over a jacket potato with her sister on a Wednesday, feels guilty about it on the bus home, and cries all evening. The lunch was grief too.

A small break from grief, a walk or a programme you like or a meal with a friend, takes nothing away from the person you lost. And when a wave comes, it does usually pass, even if it knocks you over first.

## Grief comes in waves

*Moving back and forth between loss and life is part of it.*




*Waves, not neat stages. A good week, then a bad day, is normal, not going backwards.*

*After Stroebe and Schut's dual process model (1999), a widely used framework rather than a precise prediction. Illustrative line.*

FIGURE 29 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

03

## Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, poor sleep, no appetite or extra appetite, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there has gone, and that learning takes time and uses energy. A deputy head whose mother has died loses her car keys three times in one week and walks into a governors' meeting on the wrong day, and she starts to worry that something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog. It eases as the months pass, though nobody can tell her exactly when.

While it lasts, protect a few basics: one regular meal, a set bedtime, a short walk outside. It's fine to tell people at work or at home, "I'm grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

04

## Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain to anyone else. Someone may still be alive but changed by dementia or illness, or gone without having died, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Other losses go unrecognised, such as the death of an ex-partner, a pregnancy loss or a friend you only ever knew online. A woman whose father has dementia still visits him at the care home every Sunday at two. He's pleased to see her. He thinks she's his sister. The dad who knew her is fading, and she is grieving someone who hasn't died, which is a very lonely kind of grief because there's no ceremony for it and hardly anyone notices.

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, you can make a small one of your own by lighting a candle, writing a letter, planting something or visiting a place that mattered. You might also tell one person, "I'm grieving something people might not see as a loss. It is one for me."

05

## People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying, and others by doing, whether that means fixing things, organising, working or building something. Neither way is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks another isn't

grieving, when they're grieving differently, and culture, faith, age and how your mind works all shape the way it comes out. After their son's death, one parent wants to talk about him every evening. The other spends every weekend in the garage, restoring the old Raleigh he never got round to fixing. Each feels the other is getting it wrong. Each is grieving the same boy.

A question can bridge the gap. "What has helped you most, even a little?" asked of someone who shares your loss, and listened to without correcting, often shows that the two of you want the same thing by different roads.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 27

**Write it through**

*Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter*

## Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
*Malcolm and Fiona*

Your name (optional)
*Mum*

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)
*How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.*

How I feel about it

*tired* · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)
*Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll ring you if I need you in between?*

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
*I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.*

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

**A GENTLE CHECK**

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

*Made-up example. Fiona rang the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.*

Fill in your own: Write it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

06

## You don't have to let go.

An older idea said that healthy grief meant moving on and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently. People often keep a bond with the person they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head and values they carry forward, so the relationship changes shape without having to end. A teenager wears her grandfather's watch to every exam, a heavy old thing that she has to push up her arm to write. She doesn't believe in luck, and she'd find it hard to explain why the watch matters, except that it feels as if he's in the room.

You might choose one way of keeping a bond, such as cooking their recipe, telling a story about them at a family meal or keeping one of their habits. Some people find it helps to ask, in a hard moment, what the person they lost would have said.

07

## Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retirement, moving country, a child starting school, coming out or getting well after a long illness can all bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts, an ending, a confusing time in between and a new beginning, and the middle part is both the hardest and the easiest to rush. A couple move to Bristol for a job they both wanted. Six months in, one of them feels low, then guilty for feeling low, because this was the plan and they'd toasted it with fizz. What they also lost was a circle of friends, a café where nobody had to ask what they wanted, and a whole way of life.

You can be glad about a change and still miss what came before. For one change you are going through, it may help to write down what ended, what still feels unclear and one small thing that is new and good.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a change is hard to talk about, writing can come first. This is a quiet place to put the words down, at your own pace, and to send them only if you want to.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

08

## Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that, over time, many people find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, even though they never forget. Being with people who let you talk, or let you stay quiet, helps. For some people, though, grief stays at full strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**. It means a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline) and getting in the way of life. It has nothing to do with weakness, and there is specific help for it. A year after his wife died, a man still can't go into their bedroom or face his friends, and his doctor refers him to a grief counsellor. Things begin to move, slowly, starting with one evening a week at his brother's, where they watch the snooker and don't talk much.

On a good day, write down two people you could text on a hard one, and one place you could call if those people aren't enough. If it has been a long time and nothing is easing, it is reasonable to say, "I think I need more help."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

*You sit in the car for ten minutes and let the wave come. Then you go back in. Your trolley is where you left it, next to the porridge, and you put the cereal in. At home you text your sister that you saw Dad's cereal and cried in the car park. She replies straight away that the same thing happened to her with his aftershave in a chemist's, and asks whether you can call tonight.*

## Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage the loss is in everything, from the empty chair to the jobs that were always theirs, the paperwork done alone and the first birthday and anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time, and let one drawer count as a day's work. It is fine to ask someone to sit with you while you fill in the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent while you have lost a partner, and you may grieve on different timetables. If they start checking on you every day, that comes from love and worry. It isn't control. You can still say what helps: "I love that you ring. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll ring you if I need you?"

## In everyday life

After a miscarriage, one partner may want to talk while the other goes quiet, and each can end up worrying that the other doesn't care. A child may laugh and play the day after a funeral and then cry at bedtime, and both belong to grief. A friend who stops calling after your diagnosis is often stuck for words more than cold, and colleagues who avoid the subject when someone returns after a death can leave that person feeling as if the loss has been erased. A whole community can grieve together too, when a town loses its library or its factory.

### On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely even with people around you. When you are carrying it alone, it helps to give the day a small shape, with one meal, one walk and one person you message. Expect harder days around birthdays and anniversaries, and plan something gentle for them. Writing to the person you lost, or about what you lost, can help too, and nobody else ever needs to read it. Some days the only goal is to get to tonight, and that is allowed.

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED. Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief) goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, the page called For a hard evening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#hard-evening) may help.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Show up, and then keep showing up. Support tends to flood in for two weeks and then stop, so a text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal. Offer something specific; "Can I drop off dinner on Thursday?" is far easier to say yes to than "Let me know if you need anything." Say the name. Many grieving people find it a comfort to hear the name of the person they lost, and a memory of them, and if you're unsure, ask. Leave out the explanations, because "Everything happens for a reason" and "At least…" tend to hurt, while "I'm so sorry. I'm here" rarely does. And if you're upset too, lean

on people further from the loss rather than on those closest to it. Comfort goes in towards the centre; venting goes out.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mum today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop. What can I bring you?"

## When to get more help

Grief is not an illness. But it's worth talking to a doctor or a grief counsellor if, after many months, the pain isn't easing at all, you can't manage daily life, you feel life has no meaning without the person, or you are drinking or using other things to get through. Many hospices, faith communities and charities offer free bereavement support, including for children.

**If you are having thoughts of not wanting to be here,** please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If a loss involved violence, or you are grieving a relationship you left because you weren't safe, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help, including after you separate (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#after-separation).

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a wave that feels too big

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- Calm sounds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) for a quiet few minutes

- Grief and later life: loss, family and a new chapter, with a page for a hard evening
- Grief and change (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions) and ambiguous loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), in the site's library of research notes
- Moving and life transitions (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#moving-and-transitions) and writing about hard things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#expressive-writing)
- After a loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), in your self-discovery path

## More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#family) · Family rifts after a loss or a will (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#children) · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Big changes:** Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · New parent (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 236) · Minds that work differently (page 261)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*Why losing a bond hurts so much* page 210

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well**
*Supporting someone who is grieving* page 305

**Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma**
*When grief turns into low mood* page 359

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Losses that shaped your lens* page 22

PUT IT TO USE

**Upset right now?**
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Calm sounds**
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

# 9

PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

# Minds that work differently

*How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why none of them is a character flaw, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognising faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. When to get more help
25. Tools and reading on this site
26. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** A different mind is not a broken one, though differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.
- **Nobody chooses overload.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.

- **Less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests and real rest** help a great deal.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

MONDAY, 8:15AM

*You ask him for the third time to just put his shoes on. Your son is lying on the hall floor with his hands over his ears, because the new socks feel wrong, and you're already late. To him the seam across his toes feels like sandpaper, and the alarm clock from the bedroom, which nobody has switched off, is still ringing inside his head.*

This chapter is for neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and for the people who live and work with them. It explains how these minds work and then what helps. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the words you use for yourself. I should say that some of it is personal: I'm autistic, with ADHD in the mix too, and the About page on the website tells that story. I've tried to write it the way I'd want it written about me.

Two tools elsewhere rest on it. The "How to talk to me" card (Part One, Now, page 35) works because different minds need different input, and saying things plainly helps almost everyone. One owner per job and the written job list (Part Two, Chapter II, page 88) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper, which helps ADHD and autistic minds most and everybody a bit.

01

## Brains vary, like bodies do.

Brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with other people. "Neurodiversity" is the idea that this variety is natural. "Neurodivergent" describes people whose minds work differently from what gets treated as typical. A different mind isn't a broken one. Differences can still be disabling, though, especially in a world built for one kind of mind, and both of those things are true at once.

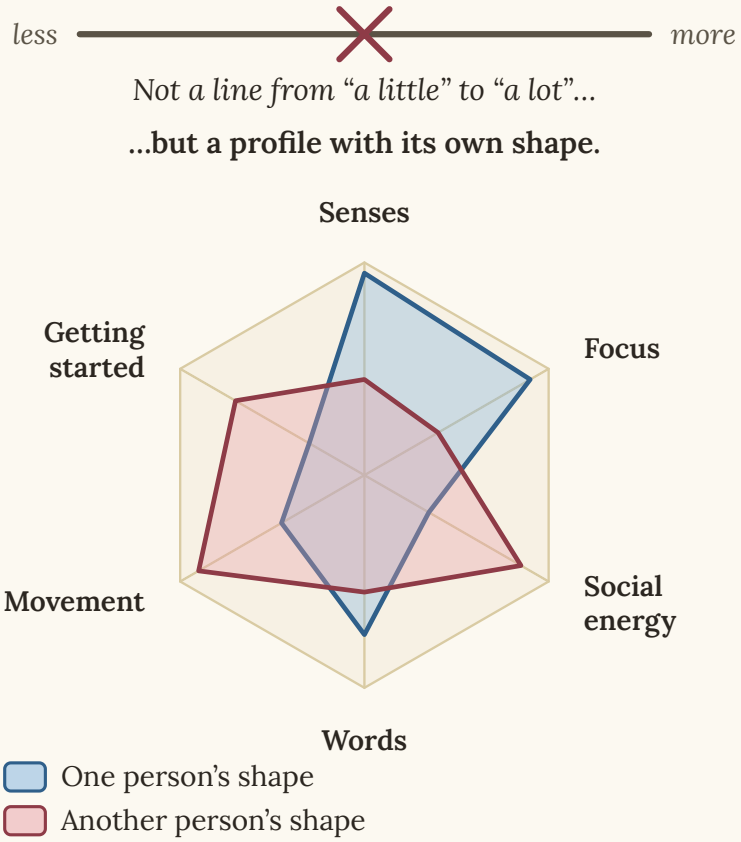
A man who struggled all through school finds out at forty that he's dyslexic. Mostly what he feels is relief, sitting in the car outside the assessment

centre, because for thirty years he had half believed the teachers who called him lazy in red pen.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
> "Maybe this isn't a flaw. Maybe it's a difference that needs a different setup."

## Brains vary, like bodies do

*Different, not broken.*




*Strong in some places, stretched in others.*
*Ask what helps, and say what helps you.*

*Illustration, not a test. "Spiky profile" is a common way to describe uneven strengths and needs.*

FIGURE 30 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot". Different, not broken.

02

## Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally. Many have deep, focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely than others do, and find predictability calming. Autism doesn't run along a single line from "mild" to "severe". Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change from day to day, and misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

An autistic analyst tells a colleague that his slides have three typos, one on slide four and two on the summary. She means it as help; it's what she would want to be told. He hears criticism. They are using different rules for what kindness sounds like, and neither rule is wrong.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I like it when people say exactly what they mean. You can be direct with me." "Do you want my honest view, or just support right now?"

03

## ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD often have plenty of attention. The hard part is pointing it where they choose. Boring tasks can feel impossible while interesting ones swallow whole evenings, time can feel slippery (there's "now" and there's "not now"), and feelings can arrive fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself, and it has nothing to do with effort or care.

A woman with ADHD forgets her best friend's birthday entirely, then spends six hours making her a card with pressed flowers from the garden, glued on with tweezers. The forgetting and the six hours come from the same brain. If something keeps falling out of your head, move it into the world: an alarm with a label, a note on the door, a basket by the exit.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I care about this. My brain drops things. A reminder really helps, and it doesn't annoy me."

04

## Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise or a scratchy label. Others need more input, like movement, strong flavours or firm pressure. Overload is a body at its limit, which is a very different thing from being fussy.

Two housemates fall out over the kitchen radio, because one finds silence eerie and the other finds Radio 2 at breakfast physically painful. They settle on the radio in the mornings until nine and headphones after that, and the arrangement has lasted two years. Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you and one that calms you, and change one small thing today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is useful information, not a complaint. A one-page card lets you share what helps, in your own words.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card`

05

## Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, and none of them measures how clever someone is. Plenty of people have a "spiky" profile, very strong in some areas and struggling in others. The right tools can level the ground a good deal: audiobooks, say, or extra time.

A fourteen-year-old with dyspraxia is called clumsy on the football pitch every Wednesday afternoon, and in the same term he writes and directs the school play. Ask someone you live or work with how they find it easiest to take in information, and then use that.

WORDS TO TRY

"I learn better when I can listen than when I read. Could you send a voice note instead?"

06

## Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences: copying others, forcing eye contact, holding back movements, rehearsing small talk in the car. This is called masking. It can get someone through a day. It also uses a great deal of energy, and over years it can wear a person down into exhaustion and burnout. I masked for a long time, and the cost was invisible to everyone but me, which is rather the point of a mask.

A student seems completely fine all day at college, chatty in the canteen, helpful in class. She gets home, goes straight to her room, and can't speak for an hour while she recovers from a day of performing. Notice one place where you can drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with, and spend a bit more time there.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I need some quiet time after work. It's how I recharge, and I'm not upset with you."

07

## Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and it often lasts months. Rest helps, and so do fewer demands and less masking. Pushing harder usually makes it worse. If you think you might be there, list three demands you could drop or hand to someone else for a month. If it goes on, or you feel hopeless, talk to a doctor.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm in burnout. What I need for a while is fewer demands." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

08

## Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much, and it can look like crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload. What helps is less of everything, so less noise, fewer words, fewer questions, and more space and safety. Talking can wait, sometimes until the next day. On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> (to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk." (for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

09

## Stimming helps, so let it be.

**Stimming** means repeated movements or sounds, like rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing or fiddling with something. Most people stim a little. (Watch any meeting and count the jiggling feet.) For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping. It's worth noticing what your own hands do when you're stressed or focused or happy, because that's yours.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Rocking helps me think. It doesn't mean anything's wrong." "You don't need to stop. It's fine with me."

10

## Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds, often autistic and ADHD ones, go deep into one thing at a time. That focus can be a real gift. It brings real expertise, and a lot of joy. It also makes switching hard. Being interrupted can feel like being pulled out of

water, and a warning before a change helps enormously.

A dad calls his daughter down to dinner three times and gets crosser each time; the fish fingers are going cold. The next evening he gives her a ten-minute warning and then a five, and she comes to the table on time, still talking about the castle she's building and the problem with the drawbridge.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Dinner is in ten minutes. I'll come and get you at five to." "Can you give me a warning before we switch?"

11

## Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing. Ask someone about their favourite subject and let them talk for five minutes without steering. It costs you five minutes, and it's one of the warmest things you can do.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Can I tell you about this for five minutes? It's how I unwind." "Tell me more. What's the best bit?"



TIDBIT

The website can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. The settings are worth a look.

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

12

## Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, explicit words help everyone: say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. And changes made for one person

(a quiet space, a written agenda, flexible hours) usually help a lot of other people too.

A team starts sending meeting agendas a day early for one autistic colleague. Within a month most of the team say the meetings have got shorter, and two people who never spoke in them have started to. Today, swap one "how I work best" fact with someone: tell them one thing that helps you, and ask for one that helps them.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "What would make this easier for you?" "Here's what helps me. What helps you?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 28

**"How to talk to me" card, for work**

*Tom, autistic, for his new manager*

### Your card

Who it's for

A partner · Family · A friend · *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

*Tom*

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

**How I receive things best**
A written list.

**I take words**
Literally.

**Give me time to answer**
Write it down so I can answer later.

**Please avoid**
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

**A request lands best as**
"Could you ___ by ___?"

**Also good to know about me**
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

**Sensory needs**
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

*Made-up example. Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.*

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

13

## Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, and sometimes support and a community too. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person"; others prefer "person with autism." The kindest rule is to ask, use the words the person chooses, and never try to diagnose somebody else, least of all in an argument.

During a row about the washing-up, a man tells his partner, "You're so autistic." It lands as an insult and ends the conversation. The next morning, over toast, he apologises and asks what his partner actually needs from him,

which is the conversation they should have had the night before. If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed and choose one small next step, like talking to someone or asking a doctor.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "How do you like to describe yourself?" "I'm wondering if I might be neurodivergent. I'd like to find out more."

14

## Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they're autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties, fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed the way they understood their own lives. Relief and grief and joy can all turn up together, in the same afternoon. If that's you, look for one autistic-led group or online space, and give yourself time.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I've just found out I'm autistic. I'm still working out what it means." "That explains so much about my life."

15

## Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, and harder on some days than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. The brain's self-management system is working differently. Laziness doesn't come into it.

A woman can write a brilliant forty-page report for her board but cannot, for three weeks, get herself to post one parcel. Once the parcel sits by the front door with a yellow sticky note on it and a phone alarm set for Tuesday at 8.10, it goes on Tuesday. Pick one task that keeps not happening and make

the first step tiny and visible. See routines that help (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) and Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Could you send me that as a list? Spoken steps fall out of my head." "I'm not ignoring it. Starting is the hard bit for me."

16

## When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, changing the subject or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It isn't in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it. A review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Whatever it's called, what helps tends to be the same: less pressure, and requests that feel like invitations. A boy who digs in at "Put your coat on now" puts it on quite happily when his dad says, "It's cold out. Coat or jumper, your choice."

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I wonder if we could…" "No rush. Which would you rather?" (for yourself) "Being told makes it harder. Can I choose when?"

17

## Not recognising faces isn't rudeness.

**Prosopagnosia**, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognise faces, sometimes even close friends seen out of context. It can be something you're born with, and it often runs in families (NHS). Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognise you may be relying on your voice, your hair, your coat or where they usually see you.

A man walks straight past his neighbour in the big Sainsbury's without a word, and she goes home feeling snubbed. When he explains later that he didn't recognise her without her spaniel, she starts saying hello first, with her name, and they get on better than they did before.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

18

## Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication), which can mean typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing: a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest place to start is to presume competence, which means assuming the person understands and has something to say, and giving them the time and the tools to say it.

At a family Sunday lunch, a non-speaking teenager types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her across the table as if she weren't there. Now he waits for her reply and answers her, a bit slower than he'd like, which is fine. Wait longer than feels natural. It will feel very long. It isn't.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Take your time. I'll wait." "Would you rather type or point?" (for yourself) "I can't talk right now. I can type."

19

## Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding. In a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

People don't always respond well, though, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many share a little at a time, starting with what helps and leaving the label for later. On a second date, a woman says, "I'm autistic, so I'm pretty direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in a loud bar." Her date admits he hates loud bars too, and they walk along the canal as far as the lock and back.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

20

## Finding your people.

Lots of autistic people describe meeting other autistic people as a turning point, because at last they don't have to translate or explain or mask. The research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community as well as a diagnosis.

After a late diagnosis, a man joins an online group of autistic adults who love old maps, the Ordnance Survey kind with the hand-drawn hachures. For the first time in years a long conversation leaves him with energy to spare.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "There are people who work like me." "I can belong somewhere without masking."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works and say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Part One: who you are today (page 35)

MONDAY, 8:30AM

*You stop asking and sit down on the hall floor next to him. "Socks feel wrong?" He nods. You go and switch off the alarm clock still beeping in the bedroom, fetch the old seamless pair from the wash basket, and two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late and nobody has shouted. That evening you order three more pairs of seamless socks and let him choose the colours.*

## In everyday life

### On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout before it's on top of you (see Get to know your wiring, spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path). Partners can swap "how I work best" notes about plans, messages, touch and time alone. With children, behaviour often has a sensory or overload reason, so "What's too much right now?" is worth asking before "Why are you doing this?" A friend who cancels at the last minute may just be out of energy, and offering something easier, like a walk, keeps the door open. At work, written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help far more people than the ones they were made for.

**If you have ADHD and share a home,** make the chore tools lighter. Log three days instead of seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labelled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

"Everyone's a bit autistic" is probably the commonest of these. Everyone shares some traits, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life, and the phrase makes real needs sound small. ADHD doesn't just mean not sitting still; many people with it, girls and women especially, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside. "They seem fine to me" overlooks how much

masking can hide, and seeming fine can cost someone their whole evening. Adjustments aren't special treatment. They remove a barrier, the way glasses do. And the idea that autistic people lack empathy is simply out of date: many feel other people's feelings strongly, and the differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Believe them about what's hard and what helps, even when it's different for you. Be clear: say what you mean, give times, write down anything important. Ask what helps, because every neurodivergent person is different and their answer will beat any list, this one included. Protect their energy; quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places matter more than they look. And enjoy their interests. Listening to someone talk about what they love is about the warmest thing you can do for them.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

## When to get more help

If you wonder whether a difference is part of ongoing difficulties at school, work or home, for you or someone you care for, a doctor, school support staff or a psychologist can talk you through an assessment. Waiting lists can be long, so start early and write down what you notice.

Burnout, depression and anxiety are more common among neurodivergent people, often because of the stress of living in a world that doesn't fit. If you're exhausted most days, losing skills you used to have, or feeling hopeless, please talk to a doctor. **If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself,** please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

A difference never excuses harm, and it never makes someone deserve harm. If someone uses your differences to control or belittle you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz) for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): a one-page "how I communicate" card to share
- Wired differently: neurodiversity and communication, including the double empathy problem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently#double-empathy)
- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)
- Research notes: autism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#adhd-basics), monotropism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#monotropism), masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#masking), sensory profiles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#sensory-profiles) and sensory load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress)

## More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships#families)
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · Autistic at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work#autistic-at-work)
- **Teens:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)

- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path#wiring) · Part One: who you are today (page 35)
- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 236) · Loss, grief and big life changes (page 248)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you are autistic, or wondering, several pieces were written with you in mind. Masking and autistic burnout are covered earlier in this chapter, and When feelings are hard to name (page 40) looks at alexithymia. The double empathy problem explains why misunderstandings run both ways, the wiring card gives you a one-page "how I work best" card to share, and Autistic at work has words for asking for what you need.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words** page 35
*Getting to know your own wiring*

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune** page 75
*Pace, tone and meeting in the middle*

**Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change** page 334
*Dials, not boxes*

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works** page 195
*Saying it so it lands for different minds*


PUT IT TO USE



**Communication style quiz**
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz



**The wiring card**
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

# 10

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

# Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

*What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Values are directions you keep walking in
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. If you want to help someone else with this
11. When to get more help
12. Tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Values are directions you keep turning towards.** You never finish being kind, and that is why values still work on days when goals fall apart.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness, and hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.
- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

SUNDAY, 9PM

*The week ahead is full: the MOT on Tuesday, a dentist, two late meetings, your turn for the school run. None of it feels like yours. You aren't sad, exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, rather than because it was next on the list.*

This chapter is about values, the things you care about and the direction you want your life to face, and about what makes a life feel worth living. It borrows from psychology and from philosophy, which has been asking how we should live for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it. I've tried to keep the old names to a minimum and the words plain.

01

## Values are directions you keep walking in.

A goal is something you can tick off, like painting the hall or passing a test. A value is a direction you keep walking in, such as looking after your health, making your home feel cared for or being a fair friend. Nobody ever finishes being kind, and that's exactly why a value still works on a day when a goal falls apart.

Bethan planned to go to the gym three times this week and went once, and on Thursday evening, eating crisps on the sofa in her gym kit, she felt like a failure. When she asked herself what the gym was for, the answer was looking after her body so that she had energy for her children. On Friday she walked for twenty minutes at lunchtime, round the park behind the office, and it counted. If you have a goal that has stalled, try asking "what is this for?" three times in a row, and write down where you end up.

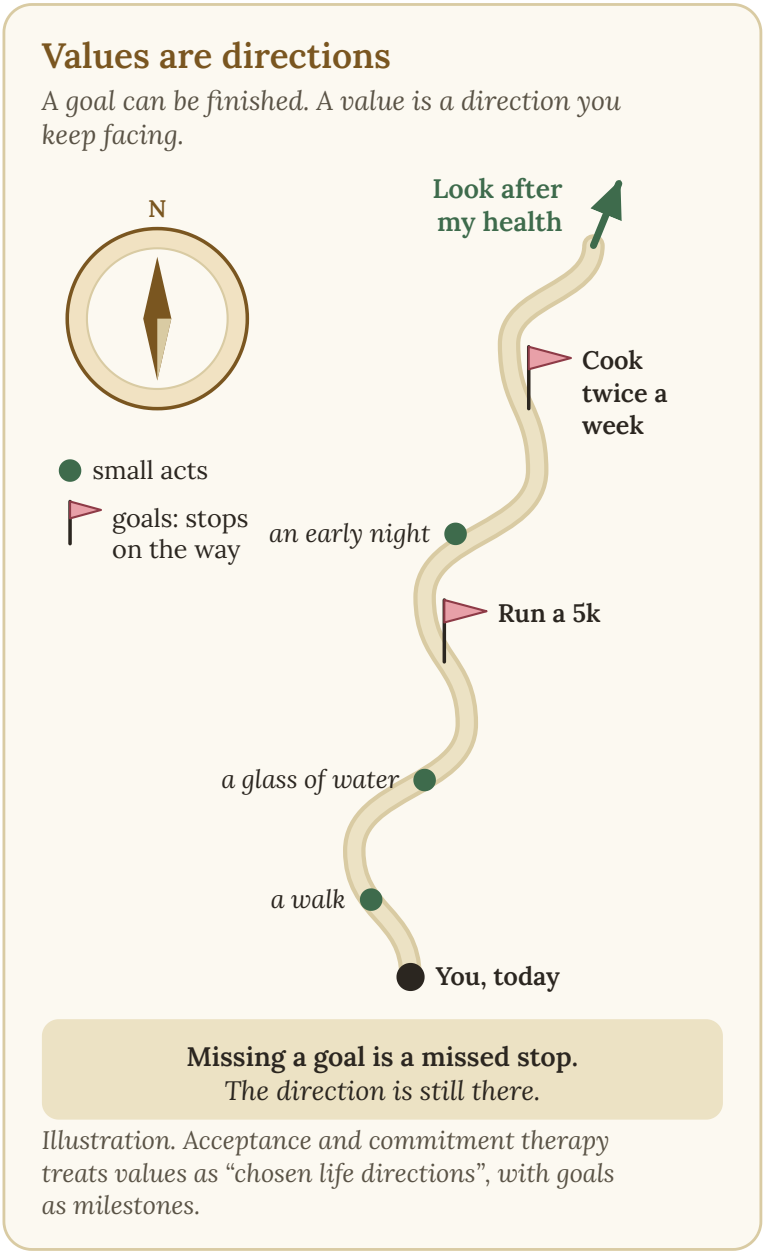



FIGURE 31 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way; missing one doesn't change the direction.

02

## Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from nothing. They show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means something you care about has been stepped on. Envy can point to something you want for yourself. Sadness tends to show what you love. Sacha is furious when a colleague takes credit for the team's work. Under the anger is a value, which is fairness and seeing people's effort, and once he names it he can raise fairness at the next team meeting instead of seething at one person for a week. He might say, "I think I'm upset because fairness really matters to me, more than winning this one."

Think of the last time you felt strongly, in a good way or a bad one, and finish the sentence "That mattered to me because I care about…"

03

## Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices aren't between a good thing and a bad one. They're between two good things, honesty and kindness, say, or family and rest. Feeling torn usually just means you care about more than one thing, and even when you choose well it's normal to feel a little sad about the side you didn't pick. A mum cares about being honest and about protecting her eight-year-old. When the family dog is very ill, she finds a way to honour both and tells the truth gently, in words a child can hold. "Biscuit is very poorly. The vet is helping, and we'll look after him together."

If you feel stuck on a choice, write down the good thing on each side. It often helps to ask whether you can honour some of both, even if you can't have all of either.

04

## Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren't. It's one of the oldest ideas in this book and still one of the most useful. (I spent my career as a government auditor, and sorting what could actually be fixed from what couldn't was a large part of the work.) Your own choices and how you treat people are up to you. Other people's choices, and the weather, and

the past, are not. Worry tends to collect in the second pile, and values do their work in the first. Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas with her family, and she can't make him enjoy it. She can plan a shorter visit, put a long muddy walk on Boxing Day into it, which he'll like, and be warm herself. That's her part, and it turns out to be quite a lot.

One way to try this is to write a worry in two columns, the parts that are up to you and the parts that aren't, then pick one small thing from the first column and do it.

05

## A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. Many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists today, also describe a second kind of wellbeing, which comes from growing, using your strengths, being a good friend and doing things that matter even when they are hard. Aristotle called it flourishing, and he thought we build it the way we build any skill, by practice, a little at a time. Jade spent a month of evenings helping a friend move out of a damp, unhappy flat, scrubbing black mould off a bathroom ceiling and carrying boxes down three flights. It was tiring and not much fun. When she looks back on her year, she counts it among the best months of it.

Tonight you might write down one thing that felt good today and one that felt worthwhile, and notice whether they turn out to be the same thing.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If you enjoy big questions, put philosophy next to psychology and see what they share. It's one of my favourite rainy-day pastimes.

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

06

## Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts to it. Your life makes some sense to you, you are heading somewhere, and your life matters to someone. Most meaning comes from people, from work done with care and from small roles that others count on, far more than from big moments.

Walter has lived alone since his wife died, and for a long time his days went quiet. Now he reads to children at the library one morning a week, which gives him a reason to iron a shirt on Tuesday nights and a small group of people who notice when he isn't there.

Try listing the roles you play, big or small (neighbour, sister, the one who waters the office plants), and next to each one write who it matters to.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 29

**Keep your little rituals alive**

*Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together*

## Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
*Lachlan*

Person B
*Sunita*

Date
*2 October 2026*

### Part A: Our rituals, big and small

| Ritual or habit | How often | How it's doing | What it gives us, or what got in the way |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Monday coffee call, cameras optional* | *Weekly* | *Fading* | *Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30* |
| *Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat* | *Weekly* | *Alive* | *Five minutes; people notice each other's work* |
| *A card and lunch when someone leaves* | *Now and then* | *Alive* | *People leave feeling thanked* |
| *Office day with lunch together* | *Monthly* | *Stopped* | *Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests* |
| *Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day* | *Daily* | *New idea* | *So nobody wonders who's around* |

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

**Your rituals**
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

**Fading or stopped**
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

**New ideas**
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

### Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
*Monday coffee call*

The smallest version that still counts
*Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional*

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
*Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite*

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
*A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.*

### Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual
*Office day with lunch together*

What it gave us
*A day all together, back when we all lived near the office*

*Made-up example. The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.*

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15)

07

## Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order, with one putting safety first and another adventure. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life and that they can't all be ranked on one scale, which leaves room to disagree without either person being bad. Jasper values a calm, tidy home, and his housemate Darnell values an open door and friends dropping by. For months each privately thought of the other as messy or uptight. Once they named what each of them cared about, they could make a plan, and Friday nights became open house while Sundays stayed quiet.

In your next disagreement, it may help to ask, "What matters to you about this?", and to listen for the value underneath the position.

08

## Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again, such as how you greet people, whether you keep small promises and how you talk about someone who isn't in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become, and later thinkers who wrote about care said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you. At the supermarket an older man is struggling with the card machine, and the queue behind him is growing; someone near the back tuts. You wait without sighing and tell him there's no rush. It costs you about forty seconds.

Pick one value, choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it each day this week. You'll drift. Everyone does. Turning back is the practice.



SUGARFOOT

A value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A "What feels like care" card helps you learn what that is for each of you.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

**YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART.** You can choose your direction. When you notice you've drifted, you can turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

*You write three words on the back of an envelope, people, health and making things, and under each one a small thing for this week. Ring Gran. Walk on Wednesday. Finish the shelf in the spare room, the one that has been "nearly done" since Easter. The week is still full. You prop the envelope against the kettle, where you'll see it in the morning before you see anything else.*

## In everyday life

Partners may rank the same values differently, such as security and adventure, and it helps to say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan. Two generations of a family can both value family and mean quite different things by it, from living close by to being free to go, so it is worth asking what the word means to each of you. When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain often shows up as tiredness or cynicism, and naming the clash is a first step. A club, a faith group or volunteering can give you a place to act on a value alongside other people.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Asking "What matters most to you about this?" helps more than telling someone what they ought to care about. People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words, so it can help to notice them out loud, as in "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" With children, naming the value when you see it teaches more than a lecture. Try not to use values as a weapon, because "I thought you valued

family" lands as a guilt trip. You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

## When to get more help

Feeling a bit lost or flat for a while is part of being human. But some signs mean it's worth talking to someone trained:

- Life has felt empty or pointless for more than two weeks, and things you used to enjoy don't reach you. That can be depression, which is common and treatable. A doctor or counsellor is a good first step.
- You have thoughts of not wanting to be alive. Please talk to someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.
- Someone in your life is pushing you to give up what matters to you, cutting you off from friends, or making you afraid to disagree. That's about control. It has nothing to do with values. The page When it's more than a rough patch (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) can help you think it through.

Some therapies, such as acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), work directly with values. A counsellor can help you find yours when everything feels foggy.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), step by step, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Part One, Next: start with what matters (page 50), a short values step from the self-discovery part of the book.
- Library: values, what matters most (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation) and self-determination theory (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation#self-determination-theory).
- Library: why new things stop feeling new (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life) and comparing yourself to others (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#social-comparison).
- Stories from philosophy: What is up to us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth), Three kinds of friendship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth#friendship) and The circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth#circles).

**A limit to keep in mind**: This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

## More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · A new chapter after loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- **Couples with different priorities:** Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Friends and work:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · Growing up (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*Turning values into one small goal* page 50

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*Two kinds of fair* page 120

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Whose values a group rewards* page 374

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion**
*Worth that is not a score* page 236

PUT IT TO USE



**Your self-discovery path**
Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



**Part One, Next: start with what matters**
A short values step from the self-discovery part of the book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next

# 11

PART THREE · CHAPTER 11

# Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help

*How hurt heals, why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, what forgiveness is and isn't, and when it's time to get more help.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice. Safety comes first
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying a hurt says more about how much it mattered than about any weakness in you.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks, and a real apology names what happened, owns it and offers to mend it.
- **Forgiving and going back are separate choices.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

THURSDAY, 2AM

*It was one sentence, three weeks ago, said over someone's shoulder in a kitchen at a party, and they've probably forgotten it. You haven't. It plays again word for word, along with every clever thing you could have said back, and you're tired of carrying it around without knowing how to put it down.*

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter looks at how hurt works and how relationships mend, and at how you can heal with or without the other person, for small hurts and bigger ones. If someone is hurting you on purpose, or you feel afraid, start with safety first: Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

01

## Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered, whether the person, your trust or your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them, and to keep you safe from the next one. Healing rarely runs in a straight line. The feeling can come back on an anniversary, or when something reminds you, and that doesn't mean you've failed.

Months after a friend said something cruel at a party, Kwesi feels a jolt when the song that was playing comes on the radio. He tells himself it's an old bruise being pressed. He turns the volume down and goes back to chopping onions. When a hurt replays for you, notice it, name it ("there's that memory again"), and bring your attention to something in the room you can see or touch.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

02

## Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

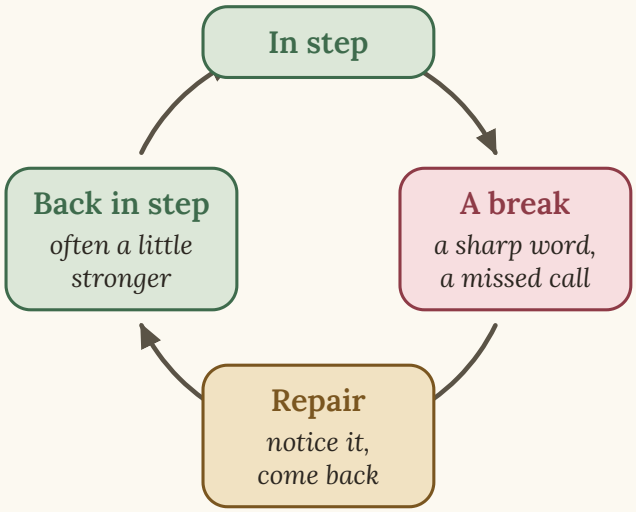
No relationship is smooth all the time. People snap and forget and misread each other, and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way: breaks are normal, and what matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, made soon, often leaves a relationship feeling safer than it did before the break.

A dad snaps at his son for knocking a full glass of orange juice across the breakfast table. Twenty minutes later he sits down next to him on the sofa and says, "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair. Spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?" They go and do it together, and the boy pours, very carefully, with his tongue out. Think of a small break from this week, with anyone, and go back and mend it with one sentence.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "Can I have a do-over? That came out badly." "I didn't like how I spoke to you earlier. I'm sorry."

## Every close relationship has breaks

*What counts is coming back.*




### A real apology

| Name it | Own it | Mend it |
|---|---|---|
| *say what you did* | *no "but"* | *now and next time* |

*Trust comes back in small, kept promises.*

*Everyday breaks and repairs show up in parent and baby play (Tronick), in couples (Gottman's "repair attempts") and in therapy (Eubanks and colleagues, 2018).*

FIGURE 32 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

03

## Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance, and it works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, leaving out what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, well away from the middle of an argument.

Amara says to her friend, on a walk rather than over the phone, "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." She had a stronger word ready. She leaves it out and sticks to what happened and what she needs, and her friend, who had honestly thought she was helping, goes red and apologises.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "When… happened, I felt… What I'd like is…" "I'm telling you because I want us to be okay."

Before you say it, it helps to write it in three short lines: what happened, how you felt, what you'd like.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 30

**Write it through**

*Carys, writing to her brother Owen*

### Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
*Owen*

Your name (optional)
*Carys*

What kind of message?

*Raise something* · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)
*At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.*

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

*Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?*

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

*I'm not angry with you as a person.*

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

**A GENTLE CHECK**

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

*Made-up example. Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.*

Fill in your own: Write it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

04

## A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand how it affected the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

Leila presented a shared idea at the Tuesday meeting as if it were hers, and saw her colleague's face. The next day she tells him, "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll email the team today and say it was joint work."

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I did… That was my doing. I can see it left you feeling… Here's what I'll do."

Next time you say sorry, check it has all four parts in it. Apology languages (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) has more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. Rewind the talk can help you find those words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

## Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even, and it happens inside you. Forgiving someone doesn't mean saying that what happened was okay, or forgetting it, or trusting the person again, or keeping them in your life. It's a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on anyone else's timetable.

Danielle forgave her father for missing much of her childhood. She still keeps his visits short, and she still won't leave her children alone with him when he has been drinking, and for her the forgiving and the protecting sit together without strain.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

If you're weighing it up, write down what forgiving someone would mean to you, and what it wouldn't. Seeing the difference can make it feel possible. It can also show you that you aren't ready, which is fine.

06

## You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck, because the person may be gone, or unwilling to understand. Your healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe and decide what it means for you now.

After a hard breakup, Martha writes a letter she never sends, four pages in biro: what hurt, what she'd hoped for, what she's taking with her. She folds it into the back of a notebook, and over the following weeks she reaches for it less and less, and then one day realises she hasn't for a month.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I don't need them to understand for my healing to count."

Writing works for a lot of people. Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes on three or four days in a row, the facts and the feelings both. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop and talk to someone instead.

07

## Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in many small moments where someone does what they said they would do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture, and if you were let down, it is fair to watch what someone does as well as what they say.

Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner for most of a year. After it came out, he started leaving his bank statement on the kitchen table on the first of each month, without being asked. Nobody made a speech about it. After a year of small, steady openness, his partner says, one evening, that she can breathe again.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I know my words aren't enough. I want to show you, over time." "I need to see it for a while before I can feel it."

08

## Going back is a choice. Safety comes first.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship or change its shape. You can also step away. All three can be healthy. If someone keeps hurting you after you've told them, if you feel afraid of them, or if they control, threaten or put you down, the work is to protect yourself, not to repair. Counselling together isn't advised when someone is afraid of their partner.

Ellie's housemate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie let the first time go. The second time, forty pounds for a train ticket, she said, "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get on in the house," and they still share the Sunday roast most weeks.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm not angry any more, and I'm not going back to how it was." "I need some distance while I work out what I want."

Three questions can guide what comes next: is it safe, has the hurt stopped, and do you want this relationship in your life? If you feel unsafe, see signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

09

## Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind, as poor sleep or a jumpy feeling that won't settle. Healing goes better with basic care, which means rest, food, movement, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you would talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful, and some don't. Neither is a test you can fail.

A man shouted at Idris on the top deck of the bus and called him names, and nobody else said a word. For days afterwards he felt shaky. He told a friend, went for long walks after work, and kept reminding himself that it was about the man on the bus and that he was safe now. Over a couple of weeks the shakiness faded, though he sat downstairs for a while.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "This was hard. Anyone would be shaken. What do I need right now?"

Pick one small act of care for today, an early night or a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologise for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologise or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

*You've written it all down, every word of it. Then a much smaller version. "When you said that, I felt small. I'd like you to know." You still haven't decided whether to send it. It sits in your drafts, between a half-written email to the council and a shopping list. The two o'clock replays have gone a little quieter since it went onto paper.*

## In everyday life

Between partners, small breaks happen most days, and a quick "That came out wrong. Can I try again?" mends most of them (see How to apologise so it counts). Old family hurts often need a different kind of talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. A friend may not know they hurt you, and "Can I tell you something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift" keeps the door open. You can even heal a hurt with someone who has died, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust.

- **After an affair.** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months, and a couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth).
- **If you decide to separate.** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and

consider family mediation where it's safe. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth#separating).

## If you want to help someone else with this

- **Listen before you advise.** "That sounds really painful" helps more than "You should just let it go."
- **Don't rush forgiveness.** Pushing someone to forgive can feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter.
- **Don't push them to cut someone off, either.** It's their relationship and their choice, unless they're in danger.
- **If you caused the hurt,** give a real apology and then give them time. Don't ask them to make you feel better about it.
- **If they mention fear, threats or control,** take it seriously and share Not safe at home?

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

## When to get more help

Some hurts are too heavy to carry alone, and getting help takes some strength. Think about talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if:

- More than a month after something frightening, you still have flashbacks, nightmares, feel constantly on edge, or avoid places and people that remind you of it. These can be signs of trauma, and there are well-tested treatments for it, such as trauma-focused talking therapies.
- The hurt is taking over: you can't sleep, work or enjoy anything, or you're drinking or using more to cope.
- The hurt came from abuse or violence, now or in the past. The page Free, private people to talk to (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#talk) includes specialist lines.

- You're having thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else. Please reach out today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If anyone is in danger now, call your local emergency number.

If you and someone else both want to mend things, a couples or family counsellor can help, as long as nobody is afraid of the other.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) for checking your state.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Apology languages: how to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages#forgive).
- Library: forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict), what research says about apologies (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict#apology-research) and repair attempts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships).
- Library: rumination (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), expressive writing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#expressive-writing) and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- Stories from philosophy: the Second Arrow (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

## More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)

- **After a breakup:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy, and it isn't a reason to stay somewhere unsafe. If you're afraid of someone, the most healing step is getting safe. Not safe at home?

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair** page 120
*Covering kindly and saying it out loud*

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works** page 195
*Repair in everyday talk*

**Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger** page 319
*When anger did the damage*

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** page 236
*Guilt without shame*


PUT IT TO USE

**Upset right now?**
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Apology languages**
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

# 12

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

# Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out

*How to help someone without taking over, by asking what they need, listening first, caring without drowning and keeping kind limits, with what to do in a crisis and how to keep going without burning out.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Ask what kind of help they want
2. Listening is a kind of help
3. Fixing it for them can take away their power
4. Care without drowning in their feelings
5. Your limits make your help last
6. Notice when you're running on empty
7. In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help
8. Don't wait for someone else to step in
9. Let other people help you too
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- **Listening is help.** Fixing a problem for someone can take away their power.
- **Your limits make your help last**, and caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.

- **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

*Your friend is telling you about her awful week, and you have five good ideas before she's finished her first sentence. You share all of them, in order, with reasons. She goes quiet and says, "Yeah, maybe." You both hang up feeling a little worse, and neither of you could quite say why.*

Most of us want to help the people around us, and helping well is a skill, because good intentions don't always land. This chapter looks at how support works, why fixing can backfire and how to care for others in a way you can keep up. Two tools elsewhere grew out of it: One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, page 88), because carers burn out when everything counts as "just helping" and nobody else owns a job, and How much are you carrying? (Part Two, Chapter III, page 105), which helps you notice you're running on empty before you snap or stop.

01

## Ask what kind of help they want.

Help comes in different kinds. Some people want ideas, some want someone to listen, some want a practical hand such as a meal or a lift, and some just want company. Giving the wrong kind, however kindly, can leave someone feeling unheard, and the simplest fix is to ask.

In the phone call above, a better start might have been, "That sounds like a rotten week. Do you want ideas, or do you just want to vent?" It feels slightly formal the first few times. People tend to love being asked.

YOU COULD SAY

"Would ideas help, or would you rather I just listened?" "What would help most right now?"

## Ask what kind of help they want

*The wrong kind of help can feel like not being heard.*

**"Ideas, or just someone to listen?"**

**Listening**
*comfort, company*

**Practical**
*a lift, a meal*

**Ideas**
*advice, if asked*

**Making sense**
*thinking it through*

- Fixing it for them can take away their power.
- Care from a steady place. Your limits make your help last.
- In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

*Kinds of support after House (1981). Support helps most when it fits what the person needs (Cutrona and Russell, 1990), though the evidence for exact matching is mixed.*

FIGURE 33 Ask what kind of help they want. Fixing it for them can take away their power, and your limits make your help last.

02

## Listening is a kind of help.

Being truly heard helps people calm down and think, and quite often they find their own answer. Good listening means paying attention, letting them finish, checking you understood and showing that their feelings make sense, even if you would feel differently.

Ravi comes home upset about his boss. His partner resists saying "Just quit" and says, "So he criticised you in front of everyone, after you stayed late all week. No wonder you're furious." Ravi's shoulders drop. Ten minutes later he's sketching out his own plan on the back of a takeaway menu, and it's a better plan than "just quit".

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "So what happened was… Have I got that right?" "That makes sense. Anyone would feel that way."

In one conversation today, listen for two whole minutes without giving advice, then sum up what you heard. Two minutes is longer than you think.



SUGARFOOT

Sometimes the best help is sitting close and listening, with no fixing. Listening takes energy too, so check your own tank now and then.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

03

## Fixing it for them can take away their power.

When we love someone, we want to make the problem go away. Doing things for people that they could do themselves can leave them feeling less capable, though, so helping well often means helping someone do it themselves, which respects that it is their life and their choice.

Rosalind's twenty-four-year-old son is struggling with a job application for the council, and she is itching to rewrite it; she can see three things wrong with the first paragraph alone. She asks instead whether he'd like her to read it and say what stands out. He makes the changes himself, and when he gets

the interview he's quietly, enormously proud, and so is she, though she keeps that to herself.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "Is this mine to fix, or theirs to solve with my support?" "What do they want to do here?"

04

## Care without drowning in their feelings.

Feeling someone's pain as if it were your own can wear you out fast. Researchers separate this "empathic distress" from compassion, which is warm concern from a steadier place, still caring deeply without sinking alongside the other person. A steady helper is more use than a second person drowning.

When Abi's housemate went through a breakup, Abi cried with her every night and stopped sleeping, and after a week she was wrecked. After that she stayed kind and present and also took breaks, a run in the mornings, an evening with her own friends, and kept reminding herself that this was her housemate's pain to feel and hers to keep company with.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I can be with them in this without making it mine." "I care, and I'm steady."

05

## Your limits make your help last.

Saying yes to everything leads in the long run to resentment, exhaustion and eventually to not being able to help at all. Limits tell people what you can give, so your yes means something, and a kind no that comes with an offer of what you can do is still help.

Kojo's sister keeps asking to borrow money, fifty here, eighty there, and none of it comes back. He loves her and he is running out. So he tells her, "I can't lend money any more. I can help you go through your bills on Sunday, if you'd like."

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't do that, but I can do this." "I want to help, and I need to stop at nine tonight."

If there's something you're giving that you can't keep giving, plan a smaller version you could offer instead.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your limits keep your help going for longer. When you need to say "not this time", Say no kindly helps you find the words, with something to offer instead.

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

06

## Notice when you're running on empty.

People who help a lot, such as carers, parents, nurses, teachers and the friend everyone calls, can burn out. The signs include feeling exhausted most of the time, or numb and cynical about the people you help, or dreading the next call. They mean that you need help too.

Helen has looked after her husband since his stroke two years ago. She snaps at him over the remote control and then feels terrible for the rest of the day, and when she mentions it to her doctor, almost in passing, the doctor says it sounds like carer strain. A local carers' group on Tuesday mornings and a few hours of respite each week give her back a little of herself.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"Looking after myself is part of looking after them."

THIS WEEK.

Rate your energy from 1 to 10 each evening for a week. If it's often 3 or lower, ask someone for one specific kind of help. See Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).

07

## In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

If someone tells you they're thinking of ending their life, or you're worried they might be, it's okay to ask them directly. Research, such as a review led by Dazzi and colleagues (2014), suggests asking about suicide doesn't put the idea in someone's head; it can bring relief. You don't have to be their therapist. Your job is to listen, stay with them, and help them reach trained support.

*For example (a coworker)*: A colleague says, "Sometimes I think everyone would be better off without me." Kirsty says gently: "I'm really glad you told me. Are you thinking about ending your life?" She says she's had thoughts. Kirsty stays with her and they call a crisis line together.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Are you thinking about suicide?" "I'm glad you told me. You don't have to go through this alone. Let's call someone together."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Save a crisis number in your phone now, so you have it if you ever need it. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If someone is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

08

## Don't wait for someone else to step in.

When lots of people see something go wrong, each person can assume someone else will act. Psychologists call this the bystander effect, and knowing about it helps you break it. Small, safe actions count, such as asking "Are you okay?" or fetching a member of staff.

On a train, a man is making a young woman uncomfortable, leaning in, asking where she's getting off. Yvonne doesn't confront him. She sits down next to the woman and asks brightly, "Hi! Is this the train to Leeds?" The woman joins

in the chat with obvious relief, and at the next stop the man moves down the carriage.

YOU COULD SAY

"Are you okay? Do you need anything?" To someone else nearby: "Can you get the driver? I'll stay here."

It helps to decide in advance what your safe move would be (distracting, getting help, checking in afterwards), because people with a plan act and people without one tend to freeze.

09

## Let other people help you too.

Helping goes both ways, and people who are good at giving help are often bad at receiving it. Letting others help is a gift to them too, because most people like being useful to someone they care about, and relationships where only one person ever helps tend to feel uneven over time.

Nkechi said "We're fine, thanks" to every offer after the baby came, including several when she very much wasn't. When she finally said yes to a neighbour's offer of a lasagne, the neighbour was delighted. These days they walk their buggies round the park together on Thursday mornings. Say yes to the next small offer of help you get, even if you could manage without it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Yes, thank you. That would really help." "Could you do one thing for me this week?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 31

**One owner per job: sharing the care**

*Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue*

### One owner per job: sharing the care

| Person A | Person B |
| --- | --- |
| *Margaret* | *Alan* |

Person C
*Sue*

Date of this list
*6 October 2026*

## Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Medicines and the pill box (as the care team directs)* | *Weekly* | 0.5 | *Margaret* | *Sue* | *Sue checks it on Sundays* |
| *Book and go along to medical appointments* | *As needed* | 3 | *Sue* | *Margaret* | *Sue drives; Mum comes too* |
| *Insurance and paperwork* | *Monthly* | 1 | *Alan* | *Sue* | *Dad can do this from his chair* |
| *Night care and night-time calls* | *Daily* | 1 | *Margaret* | | *Ask the nurse about a night sitter* |
| *Sunday call with the family* | *Weekly* | 0.5 | *Alan* | | |
| *Book respite: a break for the main carer* | *Monthly* | 0.5 | *Sue* | | *Mum's Thursday afternoon off* |
| *Groceries and meals* | *Weekly* | 2 | *Sue* | *Margaret* | *Online shop, Sue orders* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
7 of 7. Every job has an owner.

**Who's carrying more right now**
Margaret 63% · Alan 9% · Sue 28%. Does this match what you agreed? If it doesn't match, ask which job could move first. It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

### Changes to the list

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| *6 Oct 2026* | *Sue takes Tuesday nights from next week, so Margaret gets one full night's sleep.* | *Margaret, Alan and Sue* |

*Made-up example. This is about who owns each job, not medical advice.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (sharing the care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can offer help and listen well, and be honest about your limits. You can't make someone accept help or get better on your timetable. Their life and their choices are theirs. If someone is in danger, your part is to bring in help, not to carry it alone.

THE NEXT WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

*Your friend calls again, and this time you ask whether she wants ideas or just to talk it out. She laughs and says just talk, so you listen, through her manager and her landlord and the cat's vet bill (£212, for a sock). At the end she says she thinks she knows what she's going to do, and you realise you haven't offered a single idea, and that it was a much better phone call.*

## In everyday life

Helping yourself counts too, and you can ask yourself the same question, whether you need ideas right now or just some rest. Caring for a parent or a child with extra needs is long-haul help, so share the load early (see Caring for someone you love). The friend everyone calls needs someone to call too. Covering for a struggling coworker is kind for a week, and after that it needs a real conversation with the team. In an emergency, point to one person, as in "You in the blue coat, please call for help," because a crowd often waits for someone else. If you have ADHD, helping can feel interesting and urgent, so a fast yes comes easily, and "I'd like to help. Let me check my week and come

back to you tonight" gives you time. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

- **"Helping means solving the problem."** Often, helping means listening, being there or helping someone find their own answer.
- **"Good helpers never say no."** Good helpers last because they know their limits.
- **"Asking about suicide might give them the idea."** Research suggests it doesn't, and asking can help someone open up.
- **"I'll make it worse if I step in."** There are small, safe ways to help. Doing nothing often feels worse for the person in trouble.

## If you want to help someone else with this

The helpers around you need looking after too.

- **Notice the helpers**, such as the carer, the friend everyone calls and the coworker who always covers, and ask them how they are as if you mean it.
- **Offer specific help.** "Can I take the kids on Saturday morning?" is easier to accept than "Let me know if you need anything."
- **Give them permission to rest.** "You're allowed a night off. I've got this."
- **If a helper seems burned out,** share Caring for someone you love or suggest they talk to a doctor.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "You look after everyone. Who looks after you?" "I'd love to do something for you this week. What would help?"

## When to get more help

- **If someone is in danger now,** call your local emergency number.

- **If someone talks about suicide,** stay with them and contact a crisis line together. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.
- **If someone tells you they're being hurt or controlled at home,** believe them, don't confront the other person yourself, and share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- **If you're burned out as a helper or carer,** talk to your doctor, a carers' organisation or a counsellor. Respite and support are not luxuries.
- **If helping someone is becoming unsafe for you,** step back and bring in professionals. You can still care from a safer distance.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins), for tender conversations, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask) if you want help finding words.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Library: active listening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication), advice or support? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#advice-vs-support) and validation (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#validation-in-conversation).
- Library: empathic distress and compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and social support (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection#social-support).
- Library: burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress) and caregiver strain (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#caregiver-strain).
- Library: saying no (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#saying-no) and boundaries (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#boundaries).

- Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

## More for your situation

- **Carers:** Caring for someone you love · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill)
- **Friends:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Parents and grandparents:** For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **At work:** At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors, coaches and group leaders (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter is about everyday helping. It isn't training in crisis care or therapy. When someone's safety is at risk, the most helpful thing you can do is bring in people trained to help.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*The care work nobody sees* page 62

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?**
*Sharing the load so it lasts* page 88

**Part Three · Chapter 8 · Loss, grief and big life changes**
*Helping someone through grief* page 248

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*Noticing your own stress first* page 166

PUT IT TO USE

**Check-ins**
For tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

**Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth

# 13

PART THREE · CHAPTER 13

# Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

*What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterwards, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed, and what you do with it is the part you choose.
- **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it, while calming the body, putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments help more.

- **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

*Your brother texts: "Can't do Thursday after all, sorry!! Work thing." Thursday is Mum's hospital appointment, the one with the consultant, and this is the third time this month. Your jaw sets. Your face goes hot. Your thumbs are already typing "TYPICAL. You never…" and the message is one tap from sent.*

Plenty of us were taught that anger was rude or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. Anger itself is a normal human feeling, though, and it very often points at something real. This chapter looks at how it works and then at what to do with it. It also sits under two tools elsewhere: the Calm-Down Kit (Part One, Now, page 35), which works because anger rises in the body first and slowing the body is what makes words possible, and letting a comment land before you react (Part Two, Chapter IV, page 120), which is the step back described further on.

01

## Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says that something is unfair, that someone is in your way, or that a line has been crossed. It pushes you *towards* a problem so you'll change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or come out far bigger than the problem in front of it.

Somebody keeps eating Shabnam's lunch from the office fridge. Week one, she assumes a mistake. Week two, she writes her name on the box in marker pen. By week three her anger has told her clearly that a line has been crossed, and it's the anger, frankly, that gets her to raise it at the Monday meeting. (It was the new starter. He thought the fridge was communal. He bought her a meal deal.) Next time you're angry, finish this sentence privately: "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

02

## Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than what sits under it, whether that's hurt or fear or shame or plain tiredness. Chapter 1 (page 152) calls this layers. The layer underneath usually tells you what you actually need.

A father snaps at his sixteen-year-old for coming in an hour late. Under the anger is an hour spent at the front window, phone in hand, imagining the worst. When he tells her about that hour instead of the curfew, she hears it, and says sorry, and means it.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across cross, but I think I'm actually hurt."

03

## Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart, a voice getting louder: that's the body getting ready for a fight, and it can happen in seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking gets much harder, and so does listening. Chapter 2 (page 166) calls this being flooded, when you're so stirred up that the thinking part of you goes quiet for a while.

Halfway through an argument about whose turn it was to put the bins out, a woman notices her hands are shaking and realises she hasn't heard a word her housemate has said for at least a minute. That's her sign to stop. Learn your own early signs, two or three of them, like a tight jaw or talking faster, and treat them as your cue to slow down.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

04

## In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Stop talking, or typing. Breathe out slowly, so the out-breath is longer than the in-breath. Unclench your hands, and if you can, move away for a while. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

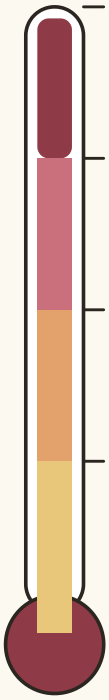
A dad feels his temper going while he helps with fractions homework at the kitchen table. He says, "I'm getting frustrated, and that's not your fault. I'm going to get a glass of water and come back in five minutes." He comes back in five, and they finish the sheet together, and both of them get number six wrong.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm too angry to talk well right now. I'll come back at eight." "I need ten minutes. I'm coming back to this conversation."

Make the plan on a calm day: your early sign, the words you'll say, and where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has steps for the hottest moments.

## Anger rises fast

*What helps depends on how hot it is.*



**Hot minutes**
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

**Angry**
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

**Annoyed**
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

**Irritated**
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

**Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.**
Then repair any sharp moments.

*In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help. If anger frightens or controls someone, safety comes first.*

FIGURE 34 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first; letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 32

**The Calm-Down Kit**

*Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13*

## The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
*Pat (Nan)*

Date
*4 October 2026*

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| *Door slammed after a call with his mum* | *Shoulders up by my ears* |
| *Being shouted at in front of the neighbours* | *Hot face, can't find words* |

### Part A: My two defaults

First default
*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*

Second, if the first isn't available
*Low, steady sound*

### Part A: My pause line

In my words
*I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm putting the kettle on for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you at half past.*

### Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
*"Kettle time"*

The shortest break we take
*20 minutes*

How we set the time to come back
*Whoever pauses says a time before they go*

The first sentence when we come back
*"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."*

### Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

### Part C: Coming back

| Time | What I did | How I feel now |
|---|---|---|
| *5:10 pm* | *Gating (lower the lights, step out)* | *Settled enough* |

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

**Next**
Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
*Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule*

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up
*After tea, at 6*

☑ I'm going with this

*Made-up example. Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating", one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.*

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

05

## Letting rip doesn't empty it.

A lot of people believe anger works like steam, so that shouting or slamming a door or hitting a pillow lets it out and leaves you calmer. It's a lovely tidy idea, and the research doesn't support it. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier than before.

Going over what happened again and again in your head has a similar effect. In studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even towards someone who only mildly annoyed them. Anger fades faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

After a row with a colleague, a man spends his lunch break telling three different people how awful she is, and by the afternoon he's angrier than he was at noon. The next time it happens he walks to the river and back instead, and by two o'clock he can think about the actual problem. If you catch yourself replaying an argument, set a timer for twenty minutes, do something absorbing, then come back to it.

06

### Step back and look from the outside.

Once your body has settled a bit, try looking at the moment as if you were watching from across the room. What happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall", instead of reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

Furious that a friend has cancelled again, a woman imagines telling the whole story to a kind stranger on a train. Telling it that way, she remembers that her friend is caring for her dad, who has been in and out of hospital since June, and the anger turns slowly into worry. One way in is to write two lines about the moment with your own name instead of "I": "Wes got angry because…" It feels odd. It also works.

07

### Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. Once you're calmer you can still say you were angry, and why, without attacking anyone. A simple shape helps: what happened, how you felt, what you're asking for.

So instead of "You always let me down," a woman says to her sister, "When you cancelled Mum's appointment again, I felt really angry and alone with it. Can we make a plan for who takes her over the next three months?" It's longer. It's also the only version that ends with a plan. Write your angry message, then rewrite it in that shape before you send anything. Chapter 4 (page 195) has more on saying hard things.

YOU COULD SAY

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?"
"When ___ happened, I felt ___, and what I'm asking for is ___."



SUGARFOOT

Say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it far easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

08

## After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp now and then. What happens next matters a great deal. A short, real repair rebuilds trust, and it means naming what you did without a "but", then saying what you'll do differently.

A grandmother shouts at her grandson when the blue vase from the hall table ends up in pieces, and he cries. An hour later she sits beside him on the stairs and says, "I shouted, and that was scary. You matter far more to me than the vase. I'm sorry." He leans against her shoulder for a bit and then asks whether they can glue it. They try. It now has a visible crack and lives on the landing. Is there a recent moment when your anger landed on someone, and a short repair you could still make? Chapter 11 (page 292) has more on apologies that land.

YOU COULD SAY

"I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry." "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

09

## When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, shouting so someone is scared,

or using anger to control what another person does, wears, spends or who they see. People walking on eggshells around you is a sign too. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

For example, a man realises his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they are afraid of him. He talks to his doctor and joins an anger course.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it." (If it's happening to you) "I'm frightened of how they get when they're angry."

TRY THIS.

If this sounds like you, see Find a counsellor or therapist (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help) and the Cool-down corner. If you're afraid of someone else's anger, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down, and you don't have to accept being shouted at, threatened or controlled. If someone else's anger frightens you, getting safe matters more than working it out. Not safe at home?

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

*You put the phone face down on the arm of the sofa and walk round the block, breathing out long. Somewhere near the postbox on the corner you notice what's under the anger. You're tired, and you're frightened about Mum. Back home you delete the capitals and write, "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel alone with Mum's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"*

*He reads it at 6:52. By ten o'clock there's still no reply, and you go to bed not knowing who'll drive her on Thursday. You sent the message you can stand behind. That part is done, even if the rest of it isn't.*

## If you're a teenager

Maisie is sixteen, and at ten o'clock her dad takes her phone, right in the middle of a group chat about Saturday. She shouts and slams her bedroom door hard enough to rattle the picture on the landing. The next morning, calmer, she tells him it felt as if he didn't trust her, says sorry for the door, and asks for ten minutes' warning next time. He agrees, and adds that he'd much rather hear this over breakfast than through a door.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and arguments often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care is not control, even when it feels unfair, and a calm request the next day works more often than a slammed door.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "I don't mind the rule so much as how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

## In everyday life

Anger at yourself counts too. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward, and it helps to talk to yourself the way you would to a friend who'd made the same

mistake (Chapter 7, page 236, goes further). With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, and a time you'll always come back. Children copy what we do with anger far more than anything we say about it. At work anger is common and rarely spoken, and "I'm frustrated about the deadline change. Can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful.

If you have ADHD, anger can arrive fast and big and then go just as quickly, so plan for the speed: a three-word pause line like "Back in ten", and a rule to wait before you send anything. If you're managing a clash between two other people, hear each of them alone first and then together, always about what happened and never about each other. The fight is often about the setup, two people who both believe they own the same job. The full chapter has a worked example (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

Anger itself isn't a bad feeling. It's normal and it carries information; it's some of the things done in anger that cause harm. Letting it out isn't the healthy option it sounds like, because shouting or hitting things tends to keep anger going. "They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted" mixes up two things: someone can do something unfair, and what you do next is still yours. And holding it in isn't as safe as it looks. Anger swallowed for years tends to come out sideways, as coldness or sarcasm or a sudden explosion over a teaspoon, so saying it calmly and early is the safer route.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Keep yourself safe first. If someone's anger scares you, step away; you don't have to stay and calm them down. Otherwise speak lower and slower, and leave the argument until they've come down. Then listen for the message under it. There's often something fair in there, and you can take that part seriously while still saying that the way it was said wasn't okay.

YOU COULD SAY

"I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" "I can tell this really matters to you."

## When to get more help

Everyone gets angry. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or an anger management course if:

- your anger feels out of control, or you often regret what you do or say when angry;
- people close to you seem nervous or walk on eggshells around you;
- you have hit, pushed, thrown things, broken things or threatened anyone;
- anger is hurting your work, your friendships or your health;
- you are using alcohol or drugs to cope with angry feelings.

Help for anger works for many people: a review of anger treatments by Del Vecchio and O'Leary (2004) found medium to large benefits. It is good for your health too: a review by Chida and Steptoe (2009) linked anger and hostility with a higher risk of heart disease. Asking for help is a responsible thing to do. Find a counsellor or therapist (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help#counsellor) lists places to start, some of them free, and the Cool-down corner helps in the hot minutes.

If you are afraid of someone else's anger, that fear is an important signal. Not safe at home? lists free, private help. If you or anyone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- When we keep having the same fight (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner) and When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- How to apologise so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages).
- The library: anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#rumination), rethinking versus holding it in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#reappraisal-suppression), time-outs (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict) and managing flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict#managing-flooding).

## More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · Repair after you've scared a child (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents#repair-scared)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Not safe at home?
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*Leftover stress behind a reaction* page 105

**Part Three · Chapter 1 · How feelings work**
*Feelings as signals* page 152

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Repair after the hot minutes* page 292

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day* page 50

PUT IT TO USE



**The Calm-Down Kit**
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



**Upset right now?**
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

# 14

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

# Personality, temperament and change across life

*What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Traits work like dials
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are usually about fit
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Traits work like dials.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are, and what happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average people grow steadier and more organised as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.
- **Most clashes between personalities are about fit**, and nobody has to be at fault.

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

*It's your aunt's seventieth in the function room above the cricket club, and you're standing quietly by the cake when she announces, loud enough for the whole room, that you were always the shy one. Everyone laughs. You smile along while something stings. You're forty-two. You stand in front of thirty children every weekday morning at twenty to nine. So are you still the shy one? Were you ever?*

We describe each other by personality all the time (laid-back, a worrier, the organised one) and descriptions like those have a way of hardening into boxes. This chapter is about how personality actually works, and what stays put and what moves. Two tools elsewhere build on it: the "How to talk to me" card and the style quiz (Part One, Now, page 35) describe how you lean on a few dials, which is more use than knowing which box someone put you in, and One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, page 88) arranges the jobs around people's differences so nobody has to become someone else to share a home.

01

## Traits work like dials.

Personality is the usual pattern in how you think and feel and act. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five": **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organised and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness** (warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them well. Each one runs from low to high, and most people sit somewhere near the middle of most of them. That's the bit the online quizzes tend to leave out. Two friends do one on a train and get told, with great confidence, that one is an introvert and the other an extravert; when they look at the actual scores, they're four points apart and both near the middle. If you're curious, mark where you think you sit on each dial from one to ten, then ask where a close friend would put you. The gap is often the interesting part.

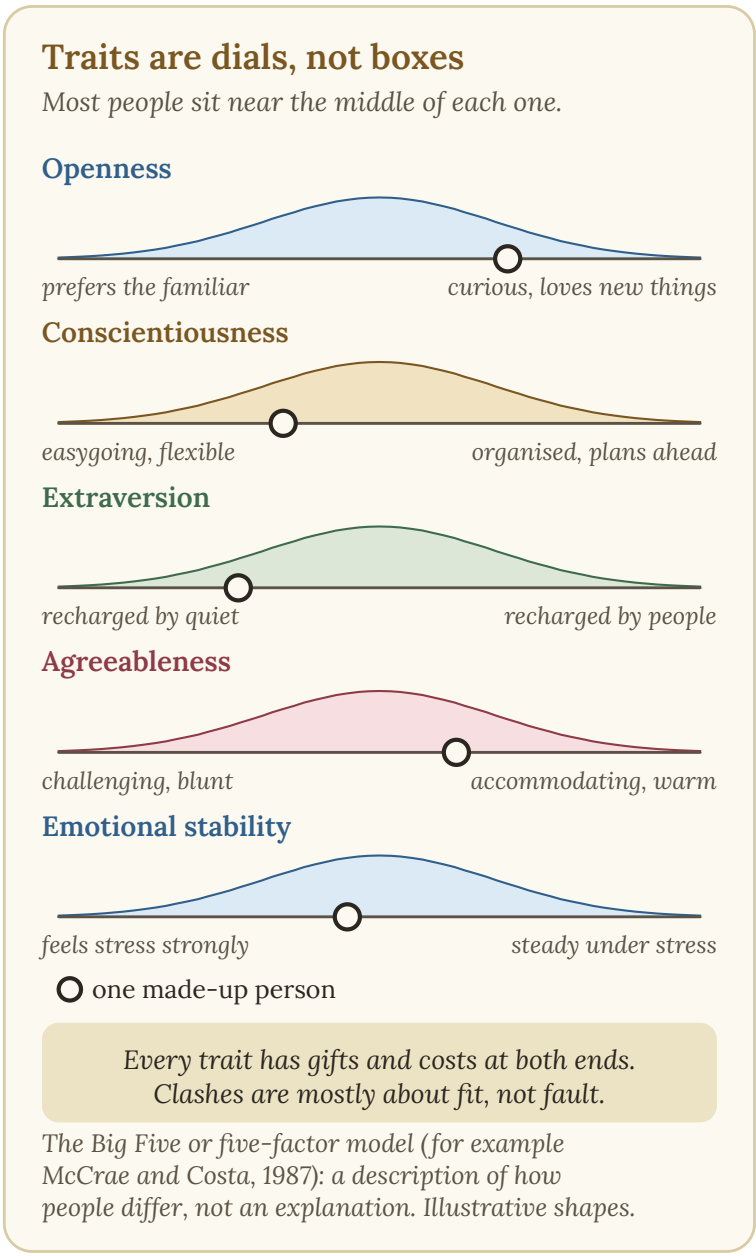



FIGURE 35 Traits work like dials, and most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

02

## Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality you can see from very early on. Some babies are very active and some are calm. Some settle easily into new routines and some take their time. Some react strongly to noise or change. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences and the idea of "goodness of fit", meaning how well a child's temperament fits what the people and places around them expect of it.

A toddler who is slow to warm up cries at every new playgroup. Her mum stops trying to coax her into the circle and lets her watch from her lap for ten minutes instead, a bit awkwardly, in a church hall that smells of squash. By the third week the little girl climbs down on her own and goes to the sand table.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready." (to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made."

03

## Situations matter too.

Personality describes a pattern, and patterns have exceptions. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, or endlessly patient with toddlers and very short with call centres. A trait tells you what someone tends to do across lots of situations. It tells you much less about this one.

A manager decides that a new colleague is cold. Then at the team's charity football match she watches the same colleague in a borrowed bib, chatty, shouting encouragement at the goalkeeper, and on Monday she sits looking at the open-plan office wondering how much of what she'd seen was the room. Before you decide what someone is "like", try to see them somewhere else, or at least ask them about somewhere else.

04

## Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often like people very much. What they find is that busy, noisy social time uses up energy, and they need quiet afterwards to get it back. People who are more extraverted tend to be topped up by company and busy places. Most of us are a mix, sometimes called an ambivert, and every point on the dial just needs different things to feel at its best.

At about eleven at a wedding in a barn near Hexham, one partner wants to go on to the after-party in the village pub and the other wants bed and silence. So one goes for an hour and the other walks back to the hotel, and they meet at breakfast, one of them a bit hoarse, both of them happy.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I loved tonight, and I'm out of social energy." "Shall we go together, and I'll head home at ten?"



TIDBIT

Some people recharge in a busy park and some under a quiet blanket. Both are fine. A short quiz can show you your own style.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

05

## People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable. It also moves. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organised, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness went on growing right across the lifespan. Big life events play a part, and so do the roles people take on and who they love.

A man who was a nervous, disorganised student, the one who lost his keys every fortnight, is a calm, steady nurse in his forties, and his old school friends barely recognise him at the reunion. When they ask, he says that life

kept asking him to cope and he slowly learned how. Write down one way you've changed in the last ten years, and what helped it happen.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
> "Who I was at fifteen isn't who I have to be now." "People I knew years ago may have changed too."

06

## You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

If you want to change a trait, you can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways again and again. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended to move in the direction they wanted over sixteen weeks. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially towards more emotional steadiness.

A woman who wants to be less shy at work makes one small plan: say one thing in each team meeting, even if it's only agreeing with someone. For the first fortnight her heart pounds every time. After two months speaking up has become ordinary, and she has started to forget it was ever a plan. Pick one small action that fits who you'd like to be more of, like replying to messages the same day or saying hello first, and do it three times this week. Chapter 6 (page 223) has more on habits.

07

## Every trait has gifts and costs.

There's no good personality. Each trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are kind and easy to be with, and may find no almost impossible to say. Very conscientious people are the ones you'd trust with your keys, and they may struggle to rest. People high in openness love new things and can be bored rigid by routine.

A very organised woman spends most of a year irritated by her relaxed housemate, his trainers in the hall and his "it'll be fine". Then the boiler packs in on the coldest night in January, and he's the one who stays calm, finds an emergency plumber at ten o'clock and makes everyone hot water bottles

from the kettle. Pick one trait of yours that people sometimes complain about, and write down a time it helped.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"What is the gift in this trait, and what is the cost?" "What they do that annoys me might be the flip side of something I value."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Every trait has gifts and costs. Writing down what helps you on a one-page card turns a "flaw" into useful information.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

## Differences are usually about fit.

When two people with different personalities share a home or a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one can both be right in their own way, and so can a planner and someone spontaneous, or a talker and someone who needs quiet. What helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it, without either of you being the problem. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions; if something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 9 (page 261) may help.

A couple argue about every single holiday, because one wants every hour planned and the other wants to wander about and see what happens. This year they plan the mornings and leave the afternoons free. They still argue about the mornings. I'd count that as progress.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I think we're just made differently here. What would work for both of us?" "I'm a planner and you're not. Can we plan half and leave half?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 33

**How you connect: the style quiz**

*Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum*

## The style quiz: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)

*Mo*

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk — *Need a moment, or a day, to think first*

A sudden change of plans feels…

*Fine, maybe even fun* — Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

*The why and the big vision* — The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it — *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine — *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

MO'S FOUR LEANINGS (HIS WAVE CODE: S F N A)

**What each letter means**

Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

**The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow**

Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

**Watch for**

agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's style-quiz statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

*Made-up example. A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.*

Fill in your own: How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practise one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

*As people start to drift off with foil-wrapped slices of cake, you think about sitting down next to your aunt and telling her about the thirty children. In the end you help clear the plates and say nothing. On the drive home you're still turning it over, half annoyed with her and half with yourself. You wonder whether she'll say it again at Christmas, and what you would like to say back if she does.*

## In everyday life

### On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you build a life that suits you, with about the right amount of company and quiet. “I’m just not a people person” might be true, or it might be an old label worth testing at least once. With a partner, a shared plan (one of you does the bills, the other the holidays) usually works better than trying to change each other. A quiet friend who hardly texts may still care a great deal, so ask what kind of contact suits them. A child’s temperament says nothing about good or bad parenting, and adjusting to fit them is a skill you learn. And family roles like “the clever one” or “the difficult one” can stick long after they stop fitting. You’re allowed to grow out of them, even if your aunt hasn’t noticed.

## Common mix-ups

You aren’t simply an introvert or an extravert. Most people are somewhere in the middle, and where you sit can shift with the setting and your mood. Personality isn’t set in stone by adulthood either; it keeps moving slowly across the whole of life. Online type quizzes are good for fun and conversation, and that includes the website’s own Wave Code, which shows four leanings on four dials, but they sort people into a handful of types when real people are spread along each dial. “They’re just difficult” often means “they’re different from me”, and it can hide stress or illness or a need nobody has asked about. And practising something new isn’t being fake. It feels unnatural at first, the way new shoes do, and becomes part of you over time.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Drop the old labels. Notice if you still describe someone the way they were years ago, and look for who they are now. Ask instead of guessing: “What helps you recharge?” or “How do you like to plan things?” will tell you more than any theory about their personality. Notice growth out loud, because “You handled that so calmly” can show someone a change they hadn’t spotted in themselves. And describe the action rather than the person. “You’re so

uptight" or "You're just lazy" closes doors that a plain description of what happened would leave open.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I used to think of you as the shy one. I don't think that fits any more."
> "What do you need to be at your best this week?"

## When to get more help

Personality differences are normal and don't need fixing. It may be worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or psychologist if:

- a pattern in how you feel, think or relate to people keeps causing you or others real distress, across many parts of life;
- you feel very unsure who you are, or your moods swing so much it's hard to cope;
- worry, low mood or fear of people is stopping you from living the life you want.

Please don't diagnose yourself or anyone else with a "personality disorder" from what you read online. Those are clinical terms that only a qualified professional can use, after a proper assessment.

A personality trait never excuses controlling, frightening or hurtful behaviour. If you're afraid of someone close to you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength): four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz).

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Know your own wiring: how you tend to feel, react and recharge.
- The library: the Big Five (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), introversion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#introversion), morning and evening people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#chronotypes) and highly sensitive people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#sensory-processing-sensitivity).

## More for your situation

- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 35)
- Part Three, Chapter 6: Habits and change (page 223)
- Part Three, Chapter 9: Minds that work differently (page 261)
- For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Your wiring today* page 35

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Temperament and how you grew up* page 22

**Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently**
*Minds that work differently* page 261

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*How change really happens* page 223

PUT IT TO USE

**How you connect**
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

**Communication style quiz**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

# 15

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

# Closeness and love: being known, at every age

*How closeness grows, what it means to feel truly known, how love changes over the years, and how it looks in every kind of relationship, at every age, including for people on their own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Love comes in many forms
2. Closeness grows from being known
3. Closeness is built a step at a time
4. Feeling understood matters most
5. Old maps show up in love
6. Love changes over time
7. Love at every age
8. Love is something you do
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation


FRIDAY, 10:30PM

*You and Charlie have shared a home for eleven years. Tonight you're both on the sofa and both on your phones, a cooking programme on in the background that neither of you is watching, and you realise you can't remember the last time the two of you talked about anything except bills, the boiler and whose turn it is to cook. You love Charlie. You feel oddly alone in the same room.*

This chapter is about closeness in all its forms, far beyond romance. It looks at what helps people feel near to each other, and why closeness fades and how it grows back, and it builds on Chapter 5 (page 210), on attachment and trust.

01

## Love comes in many forms.

The ancient Greeks had several words for love, for friends, for family, for romantic partners and for strangers. People love in many ways today too. There are lifelong friendships, partners of any gender, people with more than one partner, chosen family, people who are asexual or aromantic and build deep closeness without romance or sex, and people on their own who pour love into friends, family, pets, work and community. A life can be full of love without a partner in it.

A woman in her fifties who has never wanted a partner describes her best friend of thirty years as her great love story. They have been through two house moves, one cancer scare, a disastrous caravan holiday in Tenby and more Sunday phone calls than either of them could count. Try writing down three or more people you love, of any kind, and next to each one the way you show it. The list is usually longer than people expect.

02

## Closeness grows from being known.

Intimacy is about much more than touch or romance, and at its heart is being known. The psychologists Reis and Shaver described it as a back-and-forth, in which one person shares something real about themselves and the other responds in a way that leaves them feeling understood and cared for. In a diary study by Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998), feeling that the other person really responded was a big part of what made everyday conversations feel intimate.

Two brothers who mostly talk about football are driving to their dad's care home when one admits that he finds the visits really hard. The other says he does too, and that he always feels guilty on the way home. It's the longest conversation they've had in years, and it lasts all the way to the car park, where they sit with the engine off for another ten minutes. Sharing one small, true thing with someone you care about (a worry, a hope, something that made you happy this week) and noticing how they respond is the same thing on a smaller scale.

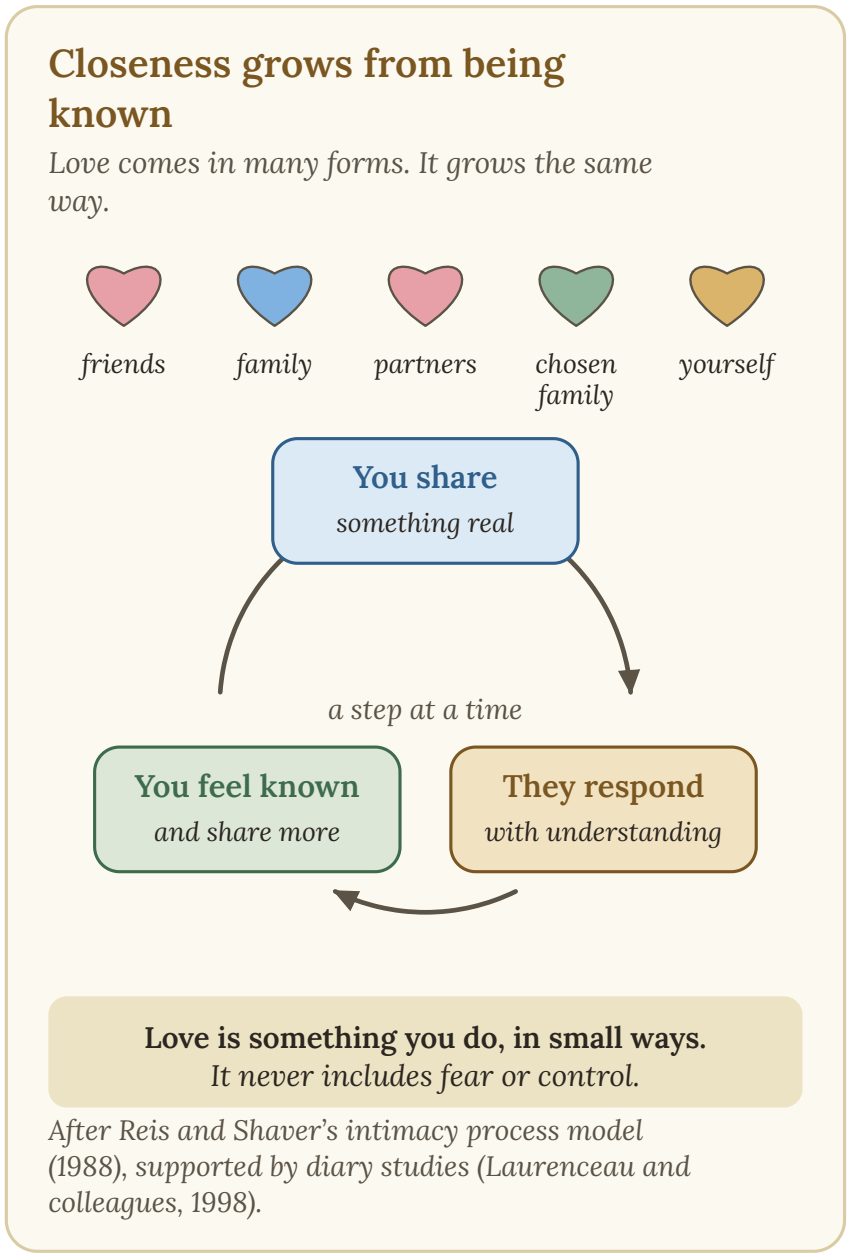



FIGURE 36 Closeness grows from being known: you share something real, the other person responds with understanding, and you share a little more.

03

## Closeness is built a step at a time.

People usually get close by sharing a little more, and then a little more, when it feels safe. In a well-known study by Aron and colleagues (1997), pairs of strangers who took turns asking gradually more personal questions, now known as the "36 questions", felt closer after forty-five minutes than pairs who made small talk. The same idea works in friendships and long relationships, where closeness grows when both people take small, matched steps. Two new neighbours start with the weather and the parking, which in their street is a serious subject. A few months later one asks how the other's mum is getting on. Some time after that, over the fence, one of them says, "Can I tell you what's really been going on?"

Next time you talk to someone you would like to know better, ask one question a little deeper than usual, such as what has been on their mind lately, and if they answer, share something of your own back.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Closeness grows when you know what feels like care to the other person, not just to you. A "What feels like care" card is a gentle way to find out.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

04

## Feeling understood matters most.

What makes someone feel loved is often less about grand gestures and more about feeling understood. Researchers call this *responsiveness*, meaning noticing, understanding and caring about what matters to the other person, and it shows in small moments such as how you react to good news. Gable and colleagues (2004) found that people whose partners usually met their good news with real interest and warmth felt closer and more satisfied together. When a teenager announces that she's been picked for the school band, her grandad puts the paper down, smiles, and asks which instrument and when the first concert is. She talks for twenty minutes, mostly about the trombone section. The next time someone shares good news with you, put your phone face down and ask two follow-up questions. That's the whole method.

05

## Old maps show up in love.

The patterns from Chapter 5 (page 210) often come out most strongly with the people we love most. Hazan and Shaver (1987) suggested that adult love uses the same attachment system as childhood bonds. When closeness feels shaky, some people reach harder for reassurance and others pull back to feel safe, and both are ways of protecting something precious. When his partner goes quiet, Leo texts five times in an hour, while his partner, who goes quiet in order to calm down, feels crowded. They agree that his partner will say, "I need an hour, and I'll message you at eight," and Leo finds, somewhat to his surprise, that he can wait for a known time. What he couldn't bear was the not knowing. It's worth noticing what you do when closeness feels shaky, and telling someone you trust what helps you feel safe again.

06

## Love changes over time.

Early love is often intense, with racing thoughts and a lot of longing, and over the years it usually settles into something calmer and deeper. A review by Acevedo and Aron (2009) found that some people in long relationships still report strong romantic love, without the anxious, obsessive edge of early love, and that this was linked to being happier together.

In experiments by Aron and colleagues (2000), couples who tried a new, mildly challenging activity together felt better about their relationship afterwards than couples given a dull task. After twenty-five years, one couple sign up for a pottery class at the community centre. They're both terrible at it. They laugh all evening and bring home a bowl that won't stand up, and on the way home one of them says it felt like a date. I'd take new over big: a new walk, a new recipe, a new café in the next town.



SUGARFOOT

Little rituals, like a Sunday walk or a goodnight text, keep love warm through the years. Look after the ones you already have.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

07

## Love at every age.

Love looks different across a life. Teenagers' first loves can be huge and real, and adults juggle love with work and children and, often, ageing parents. Many older people choose to spend their time with fewer, closer people, which Carstensen and colleagues (1999) linked to feeling that time is more limited, so that the most meaningful relationships matter more. People find new love at seventy and eighty, and people lose great loves and carry them always. A widower of seventy-eight meets a woman at his walking group, and when his children are surprised he tells them, "I loved your mother for fifty years. I still do. And I'm allowed to be happy now."

If it feels right, ask someone from another generation about love in their life. Older relatives usually have stories nobody has asked for.

08

## Love is something you do.

Feelings of love come and go, while the actions of love can be steady. They include turning towards someone when they speak, keeping small promises, saying thank you and sorry, and making room for who they are. Physical closeness, like a hug or holding hands, matters a lot to some people and less to others, and sex is part of closeness in some relationships and not in others. What matters is that both people feel comfortable and free to say yes or no. Love never includes fear, threats or control.

A woman notices that her friend has gone quiet since his divorce. She has never once said she loves him. Every Thursday she texts the single word "Walk?" and turns up at his door at six, in her old wax jacket, whatever the weather. Ask someone you love what small thing makes them feel cared for, and do it this week.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 34

**Our time-together deal**

*Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings*

## Our time-together deal

Your name
*Jamal*

Their name
*Tess*

Game nights (or long phone time)
*Tuesday and Friday evenings, plus Sunday afternoon*

Heads-up rule
*Say before a session over an hour, and roughly when it ends.*

When one of us asks for time
*Finish this match, then I'm yours. No new one.*

Our protected evening
*Wednesday, from 7: we cook together*

Phone-free times
*Dinner, and the first 20 minutes in bed*

Chores before the session
*Dishes and our own jobs for the day are done first.*

YOUR DEAL, READY TO SEND

Our time-together deal (Jamal and Tess), with each line above. A link holds the deal as it is right now: if either of you changes something, send a new link.

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: Our time-together deal (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can share a little of yourself, listen well, turn towards the people you love and keep small promises. You can't make someone love you, or love you in the way you want. If closeness keeps hurting you, or you feel afraid, that is not a failure of love on your part. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

THE NEXT FRIDAY, 10:30PM

*This time you leave both phones on the kitchen counter, make two cups of tea and ask Charlie what they've been thinking about lately that they haven't told you. Charlie is quiet for a moment and then talks about their dad getting older, and how they dread the phone ringing late at night. You listen, and then you talk about the restructure at work. The tea goes cold, and it is midnight before either of you looks at the clock.*

## If you're a teenager

First love can be huge and real, and so can a first breakup. Ines is sixteen when she is dumped by message on a Tuesday night, and she cries until two in the morning. Being told by adults that she will get over it doesn't help. Telling her cousin, who simply listens, does, along with muting the chat instead of rereading it and a rule of no checking his profile after ten. A few weeks later she notices that a whole day has gone by without her thinking about him.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't need advice, I just need to tell someone." "Can we reply when we can, rather than all day?" And if you are the one ending it, "I don't want to go out any more. I'm sorry. It isn't about something you did wrong."

## In everyday life

### On your own

Being single, widowed, divorced or happily alone doesn't mean a life without love, because friendships, family, community and the way you treat yourself are all places where love lives. If you want a partner and don't have one, that longing is real and worth being gentle with (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Most partners drift into talking only about jobs and bills, and one real question a week can bring them back. Friendship needs tending like any other love, and families often love each other deeply and say it rarely, so a short "I'm glad you're my sister" can mean a great deal.

- **Different levels of desire.** This is very common in long relationships and is nobody's fault. Talk at a calm time, keep some affection that doesn't have to lead anywhere, and remember that a kind "no" is a no to the moment and never a rejection of the person. A qualified sex therapist or couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

The spark fading doesn't mean love is over; early intensity usually settles, and many long relationships stay warm and close and lively for decades. Nobody reads minds, either, however much they love you, so saying what helps is a gift and not a failure of romance.

- **"Jealousy proves love."** Feeling jealous is human, and asking for something out of care for the relationship is not control. Checking up without agreement, cutting someone off or punishing them is not love. See signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

## If you want to help someone else with this

Respect their kind of love, without assuming that everyone wants a partner or children. Be a safe person to tell things to, which means listening without

judging and keeping what they share private. After a loss or a breakup, keep showing up, because many people get plenty of support for two weeks and very little after that.

- **If you're worried about someone's relationship,** stay close and kind rather than criticising their partner. If they seem afraid, gently share Not safe at home?

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm always glad to hear from you." "You don't have to explain your relationship to me. I just want you to be happy and safe."

## When to get more help

- If you feel very lonely or low most days for two weeks or more, talk to a doctor or counsellor.
- If closeness feels frightening, or you keep ending up in relationships that hurt you, a counsellor or therapist can help you understand why.
- Couples or family counselling can help when you feel stuck, or keep having the same fight.
- If someone you love controls you, frightens you, checks your phone, cuts you off from friends or pressures you into anything you don't want, that isn't love. Not safe at home? lists free, private help.
- If you're in danger now, call your local emergency number. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) can help you take the first step.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

## Reading on the website

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding), what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you.

- Turning towards (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward), on small daily moments of connection.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection), on the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency), on why good things fade and how to keep them alive.
- The library: responsiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), love maps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#love-maps), self-expansion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#self-expansion), adult attachment (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#adult-attachment) and sharing good news (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

## More for your situation

- Attachment, trust and belonging (page 210)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- On my own · Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Love comes in many forms.
- ✓ Closeness is built a step at a time.
- ✓ Old maps show up in love.
- ✓ Love changes over time.
- ✓ Love is something you do.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*Attachment and trust* page 210

**Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune**
*Staying in tune day to day* page 75

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*Noticing the work love does* page 62

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*Growing as a person inside a relationship* page 50

PUT IT TO USE



**Bonding: how closeness grows**
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding



**Turning towards**
On small daily moments of connection
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

# 16

PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

# Worry, low mood and trauma

*How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, how to support someone, and when and where to get more help. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2 (page 166). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.
- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.

- **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

*The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice and the back door once. Tomorrow is the hospital appointment, ten o'clock, and the same three thoughts keep going round: what if it's bad, what if you can't cope, what if there's nobody to tell. Your chest is tight and your mind won't stop. And if you're honest, you haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks now. Even answering messages has started to feel like too much.*

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people the feelings settle by themselves. For others they stick, and grow, until they shape every day. This chapter explains how they work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you aren't alone, and things can get better.

Some tools elsewhere in the books lean on this chapter. The daily check-in's "low, medium or high" (Part Two, Chapter I, page 75) lets the people around you adjust when worry or low mood has shrunk the room you have. "A full tank means later, not never" (Part Two, Chapter III, page 105) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going. And picking one small goal (Part One, Next, page 50) suits low mood, since doing very often comes before feeling better.

01

## Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that is here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen, and worry is the thinking part, the "What if…?" on repeat. All three run through the stress system described in Chapter 2 (page 166): a racing heart, a tight chest, shallow breathing, a churning stomach, poor sleep. The alarm is trying to protect

you. The trouble is that it can be set too sensitive, and it can't tell a real tiger from a worrying email.

A fifteen-year-old's heart pounds before every presentation in class. Nothing bad has ever happened in one. Her alarm still treats a room of her own classmates, half of whom she's known since primary school, as a dangerous place. When worry rises, breathe out slowly five times, each out-breath longer than the in-breath, then name three things you can see. It tells the body that the danger isn't here right now.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "This is my alarm talking, and alarms can be wrong." "My body is getting ready to protect me. I can thank it and carry on."

02

## Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief, and the relief teaches the brain that escaping was a good idea. So next time the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is going back towards the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to learn that you can cope. Therapists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

After a panic attack on the number 42, a man starts walking everywhere, even in the rain, even the three miles to work. With his sister beside him he rides one stop, then two. Some weeks later he does the whole journey into town, and his brain has slowly learned that buses are survivable. Pick one small thing you've been avoiding, break it into three steps from easiest to hardest, and do the easiest one this week.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "What do I think will happen? Let's see what actually happens." "Uncomfortable isn't the same as dangerous."

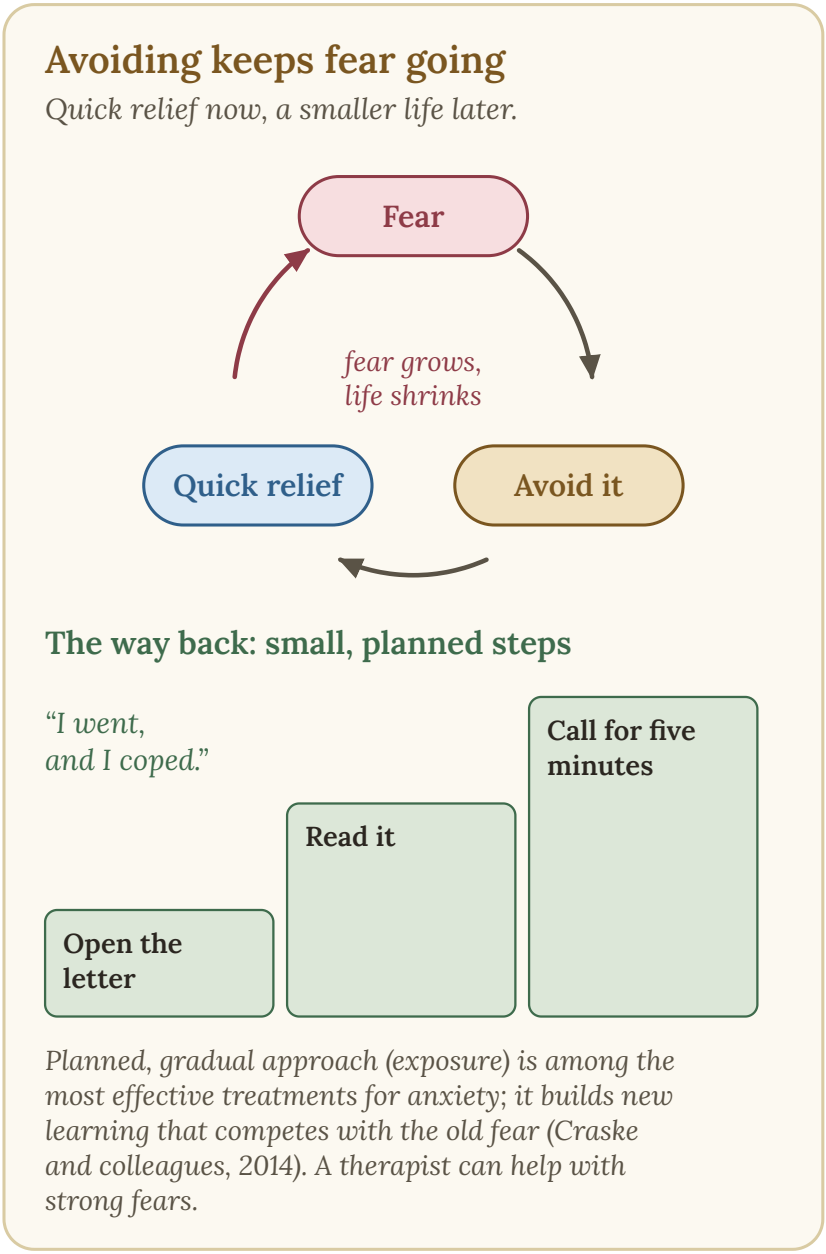



FIGURE 37 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most, and a therapist can help with strong fears.

03

## Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps a lot of people is postponing it: you notice a worry, write it down, and save it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practised this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, ask of each worry whether there's something you can do about it. If there is, plan one step. If there isn't, practise letting it go.

A man caring for his own father keeps a worry notebook by the kettle, a small red one. At six in the evening he gives it fifteen minutes with a cup of tea, and by then many of the morning's worries already look smaller, and a couple have sorted themselves out. Choose a fifteen-minute worry time well before bed.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"Noted. I'll think about that at six." "Can I do anything about this today? If not, it can wait."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 35

**Flip it**

*Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam*

### Flip it

What's on your mind?

*What if I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?*

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone | (A *worry*) | Being hard on myself | Anger

THE FLIP

**The best outcome would be**
[what you hope for]

**The main thing in the way**
I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

**If that happens, I'll**
[one small thing you could do]

**One step today**
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version
*Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.*

When the worry comes back at 1am
*It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.*

*Made-up example. If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust, or your doctor.*

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

## Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a disappointment is normal. Depression is different. It means low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, for most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, changes in appetite, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard to think. It can look like sadness. It can also look like irritability, or simply running on empty. It is a health problem, and nobody gets it by being weak.

A retired teacher notices he has stopped going to his Thursday walking group, isn't reading, and wakes at four every morning. He tells himself he's just getting old, until his daughter, on a visit, gently suggests it might be depression and that depression can be treated. If you've felt low or lost interest most days for two weeks or more, book a talk with a doctor this week, and write down what you've noticed to take with you.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness."
> "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

05

## Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood tells you to wait until you feel like it. Withdrawing makes life emptier, though, and that deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioural activation turns this round: you plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure or a sense of having done something, and you do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

A woman living alone after her divorce plans three small things a day: a ten-minute walk to the postbox and back, one call or message, and one job she can finish, like wiping the hob. Some days they feel pointless. She does them anyway. Over a few weeks the days begin to feel less flat, though she couldn't tell you which day it changed. Tomorrow, try three tiny things of your own, one for pleasure, one for connection and one you can finish.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I don't have to feel like it to do it." "Small counts."

06

## Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter. The evidence for them is solid. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too. A review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. Belonging to groups protects as well. Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse. A new dad who is exhausted and flat agrees with his partner on one protected long sleep each at the weekend, a pram walk every morning, and his old Wednesday five-a-side. Pick whichever of the three is most off for you right now and make one small change to it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

## Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common. In surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

Months after a car crash on a wet roundabout, a woman still jumps at screeching brakes and won't drive after dark. Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger and hasn't yet unlearned it, which is a long way from overreacting. If something frightening happened more than a month ago and

it still shapes your days, talk to a doctor. Trauma-focused talking therapies help many people.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "My reactions make sense after what happened." "It's in the past, even if my body doesn't feel that yet."

08

## After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. A review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first, and the same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

After a break-in, a grandmother doesn't want to talk about it. Her grandson doesn't push. He fixes the back-door lock, stays the night on her sofa, and says, "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here." A week later, over the phone, she does.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "You don't have to tell me anything. What would help right now?" "You're safe now. I'm staying."

09

## Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It's one of the most studied talking therapies, and a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioural activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Questions about medicine, including starting, changing or

stopping it, are for a doctor or prescriber. Please don't stop a medicine suddenly without advice.

A young man is too embarrassed to ask for help with panic attacks, until one stops him getting on the 7.40 for the second week running. His GP refers him to a short course of CBT, and after eight sessions he's taking the train to work again, with a book and a bottle of water for the bad days. Before an appointment, it helps to write three lines: what you've noticed, how long it has lasted, and what it's stopping you doing.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while." "What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

**YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART.** You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back towards life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work. If you feel unsafe, reaching out today matters more than anything in this book.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

*Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope from the gas board and told them they could wait until today, and you slept a little. This morning you breathe out long at the kitchen window, then text your neighbour: "Hospital at ten. A bit scared. Fancy a cuppa after?"*

*She replies with three hearts and says of course. The appointment is still the appointment. You won't be facing it on your own, though. Looking at the envelope again, you notice how many weeks it's been since you felt like yourself, and you add one more line at the bottom, to ask the doctor about your mood as well.*

## If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all pile up at once, usually at about one in the morning. Tolu is seventeen and can't sleep the night before a chemistry exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step (ask Mr Okafor about question types) and puts her phone on the landing. The next day she tells her mum, and it helps more than she expected it to.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust or your doctor. Under 19 in the UK, you can call Childline free on 0800 1111.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

## In everyday life

Living alone can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss, so one small contact a day is worth protecting, even a two-minute call (see On your own: when it's lonely, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, low mood can look like not caring and anxiety can look like nagging, so name it plainly: "I'm low today, and I'm not cross with you." Children and teenagers get anxious and low too, and calm, routine and listening help them more than reassurance on repeat. A friend who keeps cancelling may be struggling. Keep inviting them, with no pressure to say yes.

Grief and depression overlap without being the same thing, and Chapter 8 (page 248) looks at grief on its own terms. At work, a short, honest line to a manager often opens up more support than people expect. If you have ADHD, avoidance often looks like putting things off, so make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

Anxiety doesn't mean something is wrong with you. It's a normal alarm, and it only becomes a problem when it rings too loud or too often, or starts shrinking your life. Depression isn't just sadness, and nobody snaps out of it; it affects sleep, energy, thinking and the body as well as mood, and many people recover with the right help. Not everything bad that happens is trauma in the clinical sense, which usually means a threat to life or safety, but other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair. Talking about trauma straight away doesn't help everyone. Some people want to and some don't, forcing it can make things worse, and safety and choice come first.

And asking someone about suicide does not put the idea in their head. A review by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found no evidence that asking increases suicidal thoughts, and it may help.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Notice, and ask. "You've seemed low lately. How are you doing, really?" opens the door, and after that it helps to listen more than you talk. Leave the feeling alone rather than arguing with it; "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away, while "That sounds really hard" keeps them close. Offer something specific, like a walk, a meal, a lift to the doctor or an evening on the sofa together, because a small practical offer is much easier to accept than a big vague one.

**Ask directly about safety if you're worried.** "Are you having thoughts of ending your life?" If yes, stay with them, and get help together today. And look after yourself too, because supporting someone who is struggling is tiring (see Chapter 12, page 305).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here." "Would it help if I came with you to the doctor?"

## When to get more help

Talk to a doctor, a counsellor or a mental health service if:

- you've felt low, empty or hopeless, or lost interest in things, most days for two weeks or more;
- worry or panic is stopping you doing things, or you're avoiding more and more;
- something frightening happened over a month ago and still shapes your days and nights;
- you're using alcohol, drugs, food or anything else to cope;
- you're not sleeping, eating or looking after yourself;
- you have thoughts of harming yourself.

**If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or you are in danger, get help now.** Call your local emergency number (911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 in most of Europe). In the US, call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, or text HOME to 741741. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123, or text SHOUT to 85258.

In Canada, call or text 988. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Under 19 in the UK? Childline is free on 0800 1111. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines in your country. More are on Someone to talk to, free (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help).

In England you can usually refer yourself to NHS Talking Therapies without seeing a GP first. Find a counsellor or therapist (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help#counsellor) has more places to start. If someone at home is hurting or frightening you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education. It isn't a diagnosis or a substitute for care from a professional.

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

**Reading** **pages to read on the website**

- The calm visualizer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer) for slow breathing.
- Help beyond this book: counsellors, helplines and support groups.
- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), the window of tolerance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#window-of-tolerance), sleep and mood (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#sleep-and-mood), going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), catastrophising (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and loneliness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

## More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Not safe at home?

- **More in Part Three:** Stress (page 166) · Self-worth and self-compassion (page 236) · Healing (page 292)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

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THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system** page 166
*The stress ladder and rest*

**Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** page 236
*A kinder inner voice*

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well** page 305
*Supporting someone who is struggling*

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words** page 35
*Checking your weather each day*

PUT IT TO USE



**The Calm-Down Kit**
A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



**Upset right now?**
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

# 17

PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

# Fitting in: groups, influence and culture

*Why fitting in pulls so hard, how groups shape what we say and do, how culture and family set the unwritten rules, and how to stay yourself, and disagree kindly, without losing your place, whether the group is a family, a friendship, a team, a faith, a neighbourhood or a group chat.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. The pull to fit in is old and strong
2. We go along more than we think
3. Authority can lead people a long way
4. "Us and them" forms fast
5. Norms are the rules nobody wrote down
6. Cultures differ, and so do people inside them
7. Every family is a small culture
8. Online groups pull harder and faster
9. You can belong and still be yourself
10. Disagree kindly, and early
11. If you're a teenager
12. In everyday life
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Reading on this site
16. More for your situation


THURSDAY, 9:20PM

*The family group chat is buzzing. Someone has posted a joke about your cousin's new partner, and the laughing faces are piling up underneath it. You don't find it funny, and you also don't want to be the one who can't take a joke. Everyone else seems fine with it, and your thumb is already hovering over the laughing face.*

We all belong to groups, and we need them. Chapter 5 (page 210) looks at belonging, at why we need each other and how trust grows. This chapter

looks at the other side, at how groups pull on us, why we go along and how to stay true to yourself while staying connected.

01

## The pull to fit in is old and strong.

For most of human history, being part of a group meant survival, and being left out still feels alarming. In studies by Williams and colleagues (2000), people who were simply left out of an online ball-throwing game, by strangers they would never meet, felt worse and less as if they belonged. So we bend to stay in, by laughing at jokes, keeping quiet and going along. A new starter at a warehouse gets called "Prof" because he wears glasses and once used the word "ostensibly". He hates it. He laughs anyway, every time, because more than anything that first month he wants to be one of the team.

This week, notice one moment when you went along with something to fit in. Wanting to fit in is normal. You still get to choose what you go along with.

02

## We go along more than we think.

In Solomon Asch's famous experiments (Asch, 1956), people judged which of three lines matched another line. When the actors around them all gave the same wrong answer, people went along with the group on about a third of the answers, even though the right answer was obvious.

Many people never went along at all. Later research, such as a review by Bond and Smith (1996), found the effect is real but varies, smaller in more recent studies and larger in cultures that put the group first. In a meeting where everyone praises a new rota, one woman sees a big problem with the Friday cover and stays quiet. Afterwards, by the lifts, two colleagues tell her they had doubts too. Writing down your own view before a group decision, and only then listening to the group, makes it easier to say what you actually think.

## We go along more than we think

*And one other voice changes a lot.*




### Alone against the group




*went along on about 1 in 3 answers*

### With one ally




*going along fell sharply*

*One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.*

*Asch (1956). About a quarter of people never went along. Across 133 later studies the effect held but varied by time and culture (Bond and Smith, 1996).*

FIGURE 38 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot. In Asch's studies, going along fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.

03

## Authority can lead people a long way.

In Stanley Milgram's experiments (Milgram, 1963), many ordinary people kept giving what they believed were painful electric shocks to a stranger because a man in a lab coat told them to, although no shocks were real. Burger (2009) repeated part of the study safely and found similar results. The studies are also debated. Later researchers, such as Haslam and Reicher (2012), argue that people went along when they believed in the cause, and many people refused.

A nurse is told by a senior doctor to give a dose that looks wrong to her. She checks, speaks up and turns out to be right, and checking was the loyal thing to do. Think of one person whose word you tend to follow without question, and whether there is anything you would want to check next time, perhaps with "Before I do this, can I check one thing?"

04

## "Us and them" forms fast.

Part of how we see ourselves comes from our groups, whether that is a family, a town, a team, a faith or a job. Tajfel and Turner (1979) called this social identity. It brings pride and loyalty, and it also makes us quick to favour "us" and to see "them" as all the same, even when the groups are formed on almost nothing. Two branches of one family always sit apart at weddings, and nobody can quite remember why. One year a cousin quietly swaps the seating plan, and the two sides discover a shared weakness for terrible music.

Think of a "them" in your life and name one person from that group as an individual, with something they like and something they worry about.

05

## Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.

Every group has norms about what you wear, how you speak, what you laugh at and what you never mention, and we often guess them wrong. In studies at one university, Prentice and Miller (1993) found that most students were privately less comfortable with heavy drinking than they thought everyone else was. Each person thought they were the odd one out, so everyone kept going along. In one office everyone answers emails at midnight because they

think it's expected, until a manager says, quite casually, that she doesn't expect replies after six, and the relief is almost audible. In my years as a government auditor I heard "we have always done it this way" constantly, and it usually meant a norm nobody had checked in years.

Pick one unwritten rule in a group you belong to and ask one person, privately, what they really think of it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 36

**House rules for us**

*Shona and her son Dexter, 15*

## House rules for us

Person A
*Shona*

Person B
*Dexter*

Date of this list
3 October 2026

### Our rules, and who keeps each one

| Rule | Who keeps it | Why it matters to Shona | Why it matters to Dexter |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Phones charge in the kitchen from 10 on school nights* | *Both (decide together)* | *I sleep better knowing you're not up at 2* | *Fine if it's both our phones, not just mine* |
| *Homework before games, Monday to Thursday* | *Dexter* | *Less nagging from me* | *Weekends are mine, then* |
| *Say where you're going and when you'll be back* | *Both (decide together)* | *So I don't worry* | *Mum does it too, so it's fair* |
| *Friday tea together, no phones at the table* | *Both (decide together)* | *It's my favourite hour of the week* | *Only if I can pick the food sometimes* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Rules with someone who keeps them**
4 of 4. Every rule has someone who keeps it.

### Changes to the list

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| 3 Oct 2026 | *Dexter asked for weekends without phone rules. Agreed for a month, then we look again.* | *Shona and Dexter* |

*Made-up example. The norms nobody wrote down, written down, with room for both of them to change them.*

Fill in your own: House rules for us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

06

## Cultures differ, and so do people inside them.

Cultures differ in how much they put the individual or the group first, which researchers call individualism and collectivism (Hofstede, 1980). In some, standing out is admired, and in others fitting in and keeping harmony are signs of maturity. Labels need care, though. A large review by Oyserman and colleagues (2002) found the differences were smaller and less tidy than often claimed, and individuals vary hugely within every culture. A woman raised in a close-knit family moves in with a partner who grew up being told to do his own thing. He sees her daily calls home as clingy and she sees his rare calls as cold, while each is following the rules they learned.

Name one thing you think of as simply how people should behave, then ask where you learned it and whether someone else might have learned the opposite.

07

## Every family is a small culture.

Families have their own norms about how loud people are and how feelings are shown. Some things get talked about and some never do, and there are rules about how you say sorry, if you do. We often only notice our family's

rules when we live with someone from a different family, and Where your lens came from (page 22) looks at the rules you grew up with. Two housemates clash over the kitchen because in one's family you wash up straight after eating and in the other's you leave it to soak and do it in the morning. Neither of them is lazy or fussy. Each is following a rule from a kitchen two hundred miles away.

Write down three rules from the family you grew up in. Keep one you value, and question one you don't, perhaps by asking, "What did yours do? Shall we make our own rule?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 37

**Kitchen-table check-in: family plan**

*Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents*

### Our family plan

A plan for the family, not a list of chores.

Who's in this plan (optional)
*Amaka, Chris, Nana Joy and Grandad Pete*

Visits
*Sunday lunch every other week, 12 to 3. Text the day before.*

Advice
*Ask first: "Do you want ideas, or just to talk?"*

The baby's or children's routines
*Nap at 1. Back to sleep on her back, always. Ask us before any new food.*

A regular job for a grandparent or relative
*Grandad Pete does the Tuesday morning walk with the pram.*

We'll look at this again on
*The first Sunday of December*

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side.

*Two family cultures, one plan written on purpose.*

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: family plan
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

08

## Online groups pull harder and faster.

Group chats, forums and social media make group pressure quicker and more public, because likes and replies show the norm instantly. In a study of over half a million posts, Brady and colleagues (2017) found that messages with more moral and emotional words spread further, mostly among people who already agreed. Outrage travels fast while quiet doubts stay put. A parents' group chat turns against a teacher after one angry post about a detention, forty messages in an hour. A dad who knows the teacher a little sends a calm message saying he'd want to hear her side before anyone decides anything. Two other parents agree with him. The thread goes quiet, and stays quiet.

Before you react to a heated post, wait ten minutes, then decide whether to reply in public, in private, or not at all.



TIDBIT

Group chats move fast. Before you send a reply, a helper on the website can read the room with you.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

09

## You can belong and still be yourself.

Belonging means being accepted as you are, while fitting in means changing in order to be accepted (Chapter 5, page 210, says more). Good groups have room for difference. It helps to know your own values, to have more than one group and to have at least one ally, and in Asch's experiments, when just one other person gave the right answer, going along with the group dropped

sharply. A teenager who loves chess gets teased about it by his mates. He doesn't drop chess and he doesn't drop his mates. He joins the club that meets in the library on Wednesdays as well, and with two groups, neither one gets to decide who he is.

Write down three things you value, and the next time a group pulls on you, check whether the pull is in line with them.

10

## Disagree kindly, and early.

You don't have to choose between going along and starting a war. A kind disagreement is short and calm, it is about the issue rather than the people, and it leaves room for others. Speaking early is easier than speaking late, and a private word often works better than speaking in front of everyone. Some people keep a sentence ready, such as "I see it a bit differently. Can I say why?", "I'm not comfortable with that joke" or "Can we hear from people who haven't spoken yet?"

Choose the sentence that sounds most like you and say it out loud a few times, so it is ready when you need it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Disagreeing early and kindly is easier with the words ready. This workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can notice the pull to fit in, check what you actually think, choose your groups, and say "I see it differently" kindly.

You can't control what a group does, and you don't have to stay in a group that keeps asking you to hide who you are or go against what's right. If a group, a family or a partner uses pressure, fear or threats to control you, that's not belonging. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

THURSDAY, 9:40PM

*You delete the laughing face and message your aunt privately instead. "I know it was meant to be funny, but it might hurt if they see it. Could we leave it?" A few minutes later the joke disappears, followed by a message to you saying it was only a bit of fun and people are too sensitive these days. Later your cousin messages you to say thank you, because she saw it before it went. Your aunt is noticeably short with you at Sunday lunch, and you still don't know whether that will pass.*

## If you're a teenager

Group chats are where a lot of friendship happens, and a lot of hurt. Rhys is fifteen when he finds a photo of himself from PE being joked about in his class chat. He doesn't answer back.

He screenshots it and mutes the chat. Then he tells his sister, and together they tell his form tutor. Then a girl in his class messages him privately to say it wasn't funny and that she is sorry she didn't say anything. Most people in a group chat don't like what is happening, and each of them thinks everyone else does.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm not okay with this. Please delete it." To a friend, "That wasn't okay. Are you alright?" To an adult, "Something's happening online and I need help with it."

## In everyday life

Having no group can be as hard as having a pushy one, and groups built around something you enjoy bring belonging along with the activity. Partners bring two families and two sets of rules, which are worth talking about openly before you make your own. Children and teenagers feel peer pressure strongly, and practising a "no" that saves face helps them. Old family roles, the peacekeeper or the black sheep, can be hard to step out of. At work, when everyone agrees too fast, it helps if whoever leads shares their view last

and asks each person to name one risk before deciding (more in the full chapter, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth). And online, you are allowed to mute, leave or take a break from groups that leave you feeling worse.

## If you want to help someone else with this

If someone speaks up, back them up, even quietly with "I think that's a fair point," because one ally makes a big difference. In any group you lead, invite quieter people and different views by asking what nobody has thought of yet. If someone seems to be going along against their wishes, ask gently, away from the group, and keep an eye on who gets left out of the chats and the plans, so you can bring them in.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I noticed you went quiet when they said that. Are you okay?" "I'd like to hear what you think, even if it's different."

## When to get more help

Group pressure is part of life. It may be time for more help if:

- a group, family or partner controls who you see, what you wear, what you spend or what you believe, or punishes you for disagreeing;
- you feel you can't leave a group without being threatened, shamed or cut off from everyone you know;
- you're being bullied, at school, at work or online;
- being left out or pressured is leaving you very low, anxious or hopeless.

Talk to someone you trust, a counsellor or a doctor. Not safe at home? lists free, private help if someone at home controls or frightens you. For low mood or worry, see Chapter 16 (page 371). If you are thinking about ending your life, please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or

text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

## Reading on the website

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card), to share how you work best so a group can make room for you.
- Leading a group (spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups), a six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference.
- The library on teams (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/teams), including psychological safety.
- The library: family scripts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#social-comparison), the false consensus effect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and confirmation bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#confirmation-bias).
- How communication works (page 195), on saying hard things so they land.

## More for your situation

- For teens: friends and pressure (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · In-laws (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#in-laws)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- For teachers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-teachers)
- **Related chapters:** Belonging and trust (page 210) · How we see each other (page 182) · Values (page 280)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ The pull to fit in is old and strong.
- ✓ Authority can lead people a long way.
- ✓ Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.
- ✓ Online groups pull harder and faster.
- ✓ Disagree kindly, and early.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other**
*Bias and the stories we tell* page 182

**Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*Why belonging matters so much* page 210

**Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life**
*Holding on to your own values* page 280

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*Agreeing what fair means in your group* page 120


PUT IT TO USE



**The wiring card**
To share how you work best so a group can make room for you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



**Leading a group**
A six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference
spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups

# Afterword

AFTERWORD

## What the book adds up to

*A short look back at the whole book: what each part was for, the few ideas that run through all of it, and where to go next. For anyone who has read some or all of it, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Three parts, one idea
2. Six threads that run through the book
3. Notice before you judge
4. Settle before you speak
5. Say it plainly and kindly
6. Small steps beat big pushes
7. Repair is normal
8. Your part, and only your part. Safety first
9. Where to go from here


IN SHORT

- **Part One was about you:** where your lens came from, how you work now, and where you want to go.
- **Part Two was about sharing a life:** seeing the work, sharing it fairly, and talking about it kindly.
- **Part Three was about people:** how feelings, stress, trust, change, loss, minds and groups work.
- **The thread through all of it:** notice before you judge, settle before you speak, say it plainly and kindly, take small steps, repair, and keep everyone safe.

You don't need to have read every page to get something from this one. If you skipped around, that's how most people read. The book was written so you could start anywhere, stop anywhere and pick it up again.

## Three parts, one idea

**Part One: Yourself** (page 22) looked at the lens you see through: what life taught you, how your mind and body work now, and what matters to you next. It came first because everything else depends on it. You can't share a life well if you don't know how you work.

**Part Two: Between us** (page 62) looked at the quiet work of running a shared life, a home, a family, a team, and how to see it, share it fairly and talk about it without blame. Each chapter came with a worksheet, because ideas only help when they turn into something you do.

**Part Three: Understanding people** (page 152) looked at how people work: feelings, stress, how we see each other, how we talk, why we need each other, how we change, our worth, loss, different minds, values, healing, helping, anger, personality, love, worry and low mood, and the pull of groups.

Underneath all three is one idea: **most of what goes wrong between people is understandable, and much of it can be put right.** Mostly by seeing a little more clearly and acting a little more kindly, which is easier than trying to be perfect.

## Six threads that run through the book

The book rests on five big ideas, set out at the front: *see the whole load*; *fix the setup, not the person*; *read your state first*; *tune how you send and receive*; and *notice the quiet incentives*. The six threads below are the same ideas said as everyday habits, plus one rule that sits around all of them: safety first. The table after the list shows how they match.

01

### Notice before you judge.

A sharp word, a forgotten job or a quiet evening usually has a reason: tiredness, a full stress tank, a different family rule, a different kind of mind. Asking "What might be going on?" before "What's wrong with them?" changes most conversations. See Chapter 3 (page 182).

02

### Settle before you speak.

When the body is flooded, nobody listens well. Slow the breath, step away with a time to come back, then talk. See Chapter 2 (page 166) and Chapter 13 (page 319).

03

### Say it plainly and kindly.

What happened, how it felt, what you're asking for. Clear is kind, for everyone. See Chapter 4 (page 195).

04

### Small steps beat big pushes.

One job with one owner. One walk. One message. One step on the ladder. Change that lasts is usually small and repeated. See Chapter 6 (page 223).



TIDBIT

That's the end. Pick one small thing from the book and try it this week, and leave the rest for later.

TOOL **Ten-minute start** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

05

### Repair is normal.

Everyone gets it wrong. What keeps relationships going is coming back: a short, real apology and a plan for next time. See Chapter 11 (page 292).

06

### Your part, and only your part. Safety first.

You can change what you do. You can't make anyone else change, and you never have to accept being frightened, controlled or hurt. If that's happening, getting safe comes before working it out. See Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

### How the six threads match the five big ideas

| THREAD | BIG IDEA |
|---|---|
| Notice before you judge | See the whole load; fix the setup, not the person |
| Settle before you speak | Read your state first |
| Say it plainly and kindly | Tune how you send and receive |
| Small steps beat big pushes | Fix the setup, not the person; notice the quiet incentives |
| Repair is normal | Tune how you send and receive |
| Your part, and only your part. Safety first. | Not one of the five: the frame around all of them |

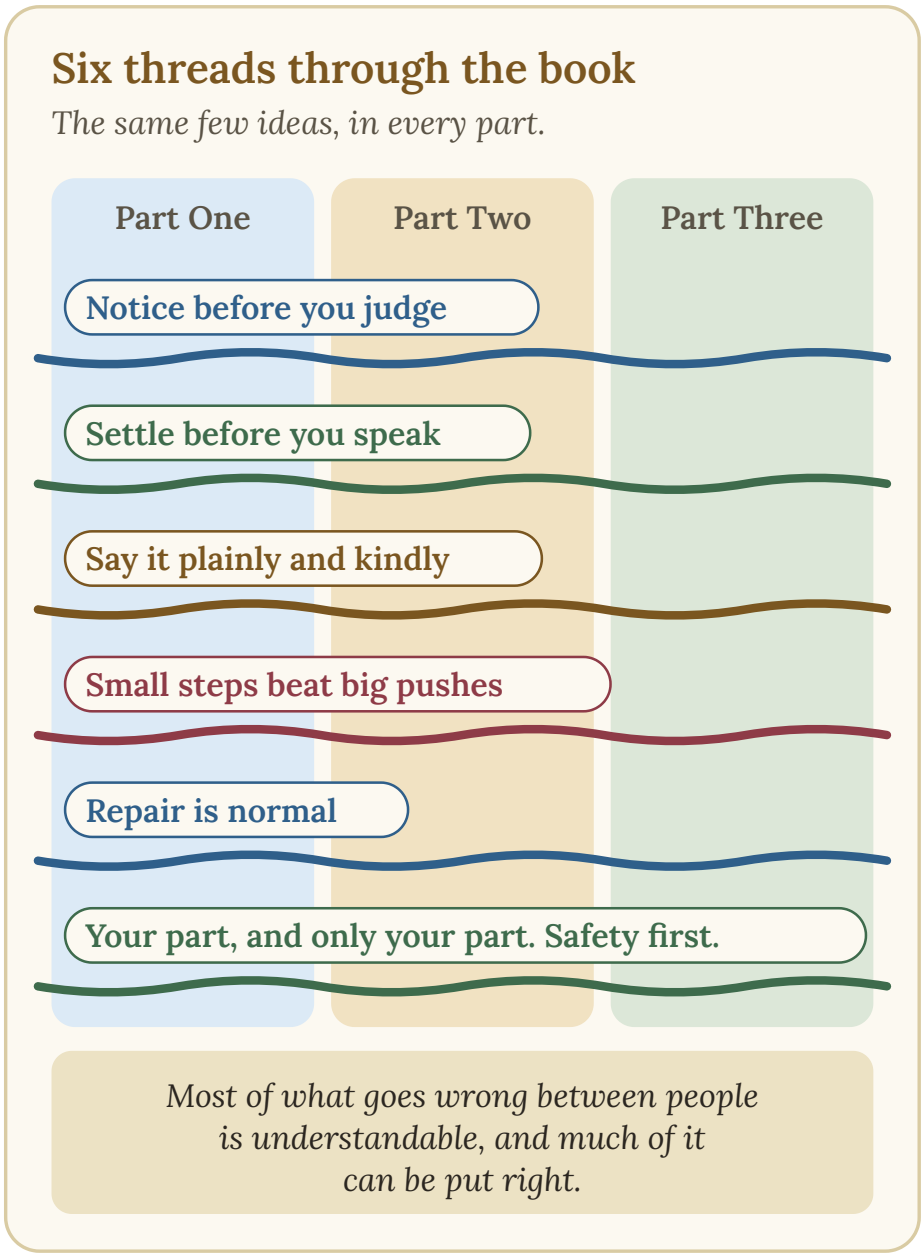



FIGURE 39 Six threads that run through the whole book, from Part One to Part Three.

## Where to go from here

- **On your own:** The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) turns Part One into a few steps you can take at your own pace.
- **With someone:** The six-week program (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) turns Part Two into one small step a week, for a home, a family or a team. Miss a week? Pick up anywhere.
- **With a question:** Ask Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's private helper, about anything in the book.
- **Want the evidence?** The research behind this book lists every study the book draws on, in plain words, with how strong the evidence is.
- **Read it again, differently:** every chapter has a fuller version, and the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/) lists them all.
- **When it's more than a book can help with:** Help beyond this book (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help) lists counsellors, helplines and support groups.

> ANY DAY, ANY TIME
>
> *You close the book. Nothing at home has changed yet. But maybe next time a sharp word lands, you'll wonder what's under it. Maybe you'll breathe out before you answer. Maybe you'll say the thing plainly, or say sorry sooner. That's all this book was ever asking for: a little more understanding, a little more often. Thank you for reading.*

This book is general education, not therapy. If you are struggling, please reach out: someone to talk to, free (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help#talk).



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you're ready, every workpaper in the book is in one place, to fill in on screen or to print. Start with whichever one fits this week.

WORKPAPERS **All the workpapers, to fill in on screen or print** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Then · Where your lens came from**
*Start again at the beginning, on your own*
page 22

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*Start the shared part, with someone*
page 62

**Part Three · Chapter 1 · How feelings work**
*Start the background chapters*
page 152

PUT IT TO USE

**The self path**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

**The six-week program**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

# Workpapers and tools in this book

*Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.*

## Workpapers mentioned in this book

*Pages to fill in, on your own or together.*

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01
In: The work nobody sees (page **62**), Is the split working? (page **88**), The monthly look-back (page **136**)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Your wiring, weather and words (page **35**), Is the split working? (page **88**), Full tanks and different angles (page **105**), The monthly look-back (page **136**), Stress and the nervous system (page **166**), Helping others well (page **305**)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Is the split working? (page **88**), Two kinds of fair (page **120**), The monthly look-back (page **136**), Habits and change (page **223**), Helping others well (page **305**), Groups, influence and culture (page **374**)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04
In: Who you are becoming (page **50**), The monthly look-back (page **136**)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Why we get out of tune (page **75**), Two kinds of fair (page **120**), How communication works (page **195**), Groups, influence and culture (page **374**)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Your wiring, weather and words (page **35**), Who you are becoming (page **50**), Full tanks and different angles (page **105**), How feelings work (page **152**), Stress and the nervous system (page **166**), Anger (page **319**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **359**)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Why we get out of tune (page **75**), Habits and change (page **223**)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **210**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **280**), Closeness and love (page **347**)

WORKPAPERS **All the workpapers, to fill in on screen or print** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill

In: What the book adds up to (page 387)

## Tools mentioned in this book

*Interactive helpers to use on the site.*

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

In: How we see each other (page 182), How communication works (page 195), Groups, influence and culture (page 374)

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Why we get out of tune (page 75), Full tanks and different angles (page 105), How we see each other (page 182), How communication works (page 195), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 236), Healing after hurt (page 292)

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

In: Helping others well (page 305)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 166), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 210), Anger (page 319)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

In: The monthly look-back (page 136), How communication works (page 195), Helping others well (page 305), Groups, influence and culture (page 374)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Two kinds of fair (page 120), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 236), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 359)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: How feelings work (page 152), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 210), Closeness and love (page 347)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 280), Closeness and love (page 347)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

In: Where your lens came from (page 22), Your wiring, weather and words (page 35), Who you are becoming (page 50), Personality, temperament and change (page 334)

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 35), How communication works (page 195), Minds that work differently (page 261), Personality, temperament and change (page 334), Groups, influence and culture (page 374)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Where your lens came from (page 22), Full tanks and different angles (page 105), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 236), Values, meaning and a good life (page 280)

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

In: Why we get out of tune (page 75)

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

In: The work nobody sees (page 62)

TOOL **Who does what? Count the hours and bills** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

In: Is the split working? (page 88), Two kinds of fair (page 120)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How feelings work (page 152), Stress and the nervous system (page 166), How communication works (page 195), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 210), Habits and change (page 223), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 236), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 248), Healing after hurt (page 292), Anger (page 319), Closeness and love (page 347), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 359)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

In: Anger (page 319)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 166), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 248), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 359)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 35), Full tanks and different angles (page 105), How feelings work (page 152)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Why we get out of tune (page **75**), Full tanks and different angles (page **105**), Stress and the nervous system (page **166**), Healing after hurt (page **292**)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **236**), Loss, grief and big life changes (page **248**), Healing after hurt (page **292**)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **236**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **280**), Helping others well (page **305**), What the book adds up to (page **387**)

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page **261**)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Who you are becoming (page **50**), Habits and change (page **223**)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Who you are becoming (page **50**), Is the split working? (page **88**), Full tanks and different angles (page **105**), Two kinds of fair (page **120**), The monthly look-back (page **136**), How we see each other (page **182**), How communication works (page **195**), Healing after hurt (page **292**)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

In: Who you are becoming (page **50**), Full tanks and different angles (page **105**), Two kinds of fair (page **120**), The monthly look-back (page **136**), How communication works (page **195**), Minds that work differently (page **261**), Personality, temperament and change (page **334**)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

In: Is the split working? (page **88**), Attachment, trust and belonging (page **210**), Habits and change (page **223**), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **236**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **280**), Helping others well (page **305**), Anger (page **319**), Personality, temperament and change (page **334**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **359**), Groups, influence and culture (page **374**)

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page **280**)

TOOL **Ten-minute start** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

In: Who you are becoming (page **50**), What the book adds up to (page **387**)

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working`
In: Is the split working? (page **88**)

# How the numbers work

*Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.*

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

## The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III, page **105**, scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.

`3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

**Two or more of you:** each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

**Coming back after a pause** (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named

time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

## My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

| WHAT YOU PICKED | ADDS |
|---|---|
| The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in | 0, 26, 34 |
| The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6) | 0, 10, 20 |
| Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6) | 0, 2, 10, 18 |
| People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4) | 0, 3, 9, 14 |
| Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on) | 4 each, up to 14 |
| What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on) | 3 each, up to 10 |

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now, page 35, picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).
>
> `26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

## Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

**Two people.** Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷ 100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the stress

tank sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Part Two, Chapter II, page **88**). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

**Three or more people, or an agreed split.** The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split you
agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter II, page **88**): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167; most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667; balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

## Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

**Who carries more of the list.** A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷ 0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of all
the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

**Who's carrying more right now.** Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the example in the Preface, page **62**, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

## The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average tank score) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the tank score. The tank is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − tank. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the "Who does what?" page says "holding"); 0.40 up to 0.70 as

needs a look ("drifting"); below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter II, page **88**): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own tank scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.
>
> `0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.
>
> **The shortfall** is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067; ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088; tank 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the tank, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a tank score lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

**The overall score** adds a fourth part, retuning: of the moments that landed badly this week, how many you retuned before answering.

```
overall = balance × 0.35 + ownership × 0.30 + (1 − tank) × 0.20 +
retuning × 0.15
(no rough moments this week: leave retuning out, and divide the first
three parts by 0.85)
```

In Chapter II's first worked example (balance 0.60, ownership 0.80, an average tank score of 0.40, and 3 of 5 rough moments retuned): `0.21 + 0.24 + 0.12 + 0.09 = 0.66`.

## The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the stress tank, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership, tank),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller didn't
shift
```

**One next step:** a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's tank at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

**Hours to change hands over the month:** for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks: hours 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12; jobs with an owner 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12; Rosemary's tank 0.45, 0.50, 0.40, 0.35 and Ken's 0.30 every week; rescues 3, 2, 1, 1.

| PART | START (WEEKS 1–2) | END (WEEKS 3–4) | CHANGE | READS AS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Balance | (0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79 | (0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96 | +0.17 | Better |
| Ownership | 0.75 | 0.92 | +0.17 | Better |
| Average tank score | 0.39 | 0.34 | −0.05 | About the same |
| Rosemary's own tank | 0.48 | 0.38 | −0.10 | Lighter |
| Rescues a week | 2.5 | 1 | −1.5 | Fewer |

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

### On your own: is your week sustainable?

The “Who does what?” page’s “just me” view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book’s own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn’t be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a “How is this worked out?” note.

# Blank worksheets

*Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them in by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.*

# Who did what

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01.html

Write down what actually happened this week, before anyone starts remembering it as a story. Write down only what you did or saw yourself; never fill in someone else's side for them.

Person A _____ Person B _____

Week beginning _____

### Part A: Who did what, this week

One row for each task noticed or done, including the invisible ones: remembering, planning, booking, forms. Time spent only thinking, noticing or planning counts too: log it as "Thinking and planning".

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |
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### This week's totals

Person A: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Person B: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Workload balance score: 1 − (A% − B%, ignoring any minus sign) ÷ 100 = _____

Part B (optional), Kind ways to say no: say why the request is fair, say honestly what you have left, and offer something instead.

Describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it. How the score works: "How the numbers work", at the back.

# How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

### The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That fills the tank; it isn't a mood.

| | Not at all | | | | Very true |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sleep debt (less rested than usual) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Recent unresolved conflict (any source) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Time pressure today specifically | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |

### How full is your stress tank?

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Tank: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a fuller tank (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

### Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

**Anything you want to name before talking**

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

# One owner per job

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03.html

Every regular job gets one owner: the person who does it and sees it through. If you like, add a helper or backup who pitches in, notices if it slips, or covers it on a bad week. List the invisible jobs too: forms, gifts, renewals, planning, appointments.

Date of this list

The split you agreed (optional)

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Owner | Helper or backup (optional) | Size (optional) | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
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| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, As needed, Ongoing. Size: Small, Medium, Big.

### Does every job have an owner?

Jobs with an owner: _____ of _____ = _____ out of 1.00

### Changes to the list (optional)

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |

### Where we've landed

Agreeing means everyone has read this version and knows who owns what. It doesn't mean every job feels perfectly fair, only that ownership is clear.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

# What keeps coming back?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04.html

A monthly look-back, done together, across four weeks of Who did what and One owner per job. It looks for the tasks that keep slipping. The goal is to find where the setup needs a fix, not to tally what anyone owes.

Month

### Part A: Gather the month's notes

List every task that was noticed but not done, or done only after being raised more than once. Mark an ✗ for each week it came up.

| Task | Week 1 | Week 2 | Week 3 | Week 4 | Times flagged |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

### Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more. A **structural gap** has no clear owner (fix One owner per job now). A **capacity issue** has an owner who can't keep up (set a time for an honest conversation). A **one-off** has a temporary cause (note it and move on).

| Task | Named owner on the job list? (Yes / No) | Classification | Action |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

### Part C: Wrap up the audit

Structural gaps found

Capacity issues found

One-offs

### Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

| Job | Gets thanked (Often / Sometimes / Rarely / Never) | Only noticed when missed? (Yes / No) | One way to notice it |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

Not a bill for the past, and not a performance review. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

# Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

### Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

**Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)**

**What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The bins went out late on Tuesday."**

**What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.**

**What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.**

### Before you react: four quick checks

| Check | Circle one |
|---|---|
| Is this about a specific, nameable task or event? | Yes · No |
| Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot? | Yes · No · Not sure |
| Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said? | Yes · No |
| Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation? | Their words · A past pattern |

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keeps it honest.

# The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| | |
| | |
| | |

### Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed flat into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

### Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at quarter past."

_____

### Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

**Part B, in the moment:** say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

### Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your stress tank score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50 go back; 0.50 to 0.59 another round; 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

| Time | What I did | How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough) | Stress tank before (0–1) | Stress tank after (0–1) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

### Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

# The 90-second daily check-in

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13.html

Each person answers each prompt in one sentence, about their own day, and fills in only their own rows. No debating, no solving, no arguing back. Anything that needs a real discussion waits for the weekly catch-up.

Week beginning

## Each day

| Day | Person | Stress tank (Light / Medium / High) | One thing I appreciated today | One small thing that didn't feel great | One thing that would help tomorrow |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | | |
| Mon | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |

## The weekly catch-up (optional)

Skim the week for anything that came up more than twice, and move it to the right worksheet.

| Sore spot that keeps coming up | Times this week | Move to (One owner per job / Say it so it lands / Keep watching) |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |

## Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

# Same moment, different speeds

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-12.html

For a few moments that come round often, each person marks how fast they want to move, how much they want to talk, and how urgent it feels. Each person fills in only their own rows, ideally before looking at the other's. There are no right answers.

Date

### Part A: Each person's speed

Speed: right away · within the hour · later the same day · after a night's sleep. Talk: quiet time first · a few words, then act · talk it all through. Urgency: low · medium · high.

| Moment | Person | Speed | Talk | Urgency | What helps me (optional) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A plan changes at the last minute | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| A bill, letter or form needs dealing with | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| Something breaks or goes wrong at home | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| One of us is upset about something | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| Deciding what to do with free time | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

### Part B: Where your speeds differ

For each moment, count how many steps apart your answers are on each list. Start with the biggest gap: a difference in pace, not in how much anyone cares.

### Part C: One small agreement

| Moment | What we'll try | Try it until |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |

### Where we've landed

Agreeing means you have both seen the gaps and will try the agreement. It doesn't mean either of you has to change speed for good.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Not a compatibility test and not a diagnosis. Run it again every few months, or after a big change.

# Is it us, or is it everything else?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-14.html

A one-week log that keeps two things apart: pressure from outside (money, work, health, sleep, family) and friction that really starts between you. A line or two each evening, each person about their own day. Write what happened, not who was wrong.

Week beginning

**Part A: Each evening**

| Day | Person | Outside pressure today (None / A little / A lot) | Where it came from | A tense moment between us (if any) | Looking back, it was mostly (Outside pressure / Between us / Some of both / Not sure yet) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | | |
| Mon | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |

**Part B: The week at a glance**

Tense moments on heavy days: _____ of _____

**Part C: What got blamed on the wrong thing?**

| The moment | What it seemed to be about | What was really going on | What would help next time |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |

**Part D: One plan for the pressure**

The pressure we're facing right now

How we'll flag a heavy day

What we'll go easy on until it passes

One bit of outside help we could ask for (optional)

Outside pressure explains a hard day. It doesn't excuse unkindness, and it doesn't make what anyone felt less real.

# Keep your little rituals alive

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15.html

Every three months or so, a short look at the small shared habits that keep you close: the morning coffee, the Sunday walk, the birthday breakfast. Nobody is to blame for one that lapsed.

Date

### Part A: Our rituals, big and small

How it's doing: Alive (still happening, still means something) · Fading (on autopilot or less often) · Stopped · New idea. How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Yearly, Now and then.

| Ritual or habit | How often | How it's doing | What it gives us, or what got in the way |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
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| | | | |

### Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual

The smallest version that still counts

The first time: when, and who will suggest it

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)

### Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual

What it gave us

### Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

A ritual is something you would both miss, not a test of love. Look at this sheet again in about three months.

# Words used in this book

*The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.*

### Alexithymia

Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

### Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

### Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

*For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your stress tank is nearly full and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.*

### A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

*For example: They show you a photo of a dog. Looking and smiling back is turning towards it.*

### Calm-down plan

Your calm-down plan (once called the Calm-Down Kit) is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

*For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.*

### Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

*For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.*

### Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

*For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"*

### Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

*For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.*

### Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

### Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

*For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.*

### Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

*For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"*

### Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

*For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.*

### Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

### If-then plan

A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

### A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

*For example: "I can't take that on this week. I could help on Saturday."*

### Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

### The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

### Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book works the same way: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

### The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

*For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.*

### Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

*For example: Forcing eye contact and rehearsing small talk all day, then needing the evening to recover.*

### Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

### Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

### My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

*For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.*

### Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

*For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.*

### Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

### Person A and Person B

Person A and Person B are simply the two people on a two-person worksheet or tool. They are labels, not a ranking.

*For example: In the Chat analyzer, Person A sends the message and Person B receives it.*

### Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

*For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.*

### Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

### Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

### Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

*For example: "I said that badly. What I meant was…"*

### Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

*For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."*

### The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

*For example: "Whoever notices the mess cleans it" was the rule at home, so a messy kitchen feels like "It's always me."*

### Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

### Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

### Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

### Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

*For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.*

### Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

### Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

*For example: Your window says "wait," so you ask to talk after dinner instead of right now.*

### Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

*For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.*

### Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

### Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

### Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

*For example: A hint like "the bins are full" may be heard as a plain fact, not a request.*

### Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

*For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.*

### Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

*For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.*

### Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

*For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.*

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# Research notes

*The 445 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.*

## Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study", "linked with", "didn't replicate". Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

**Correlational ("linked with")**
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

**Experiment**
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

**Meta-analysis**
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

**Replication**
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

**Effect size**
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

**Who was studied**
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

**Self-report**
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

**How the book labels things:** a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PART ONE · THEN

## Where your lens came from


**Ainsworth, M. D. S., Blehar, M. C., Waters, E., & Wall, S. (1978).** *Patterns of Attachment: A Psychological Study of the Strange Situation.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Reported the Strange Situation studies of infants and mothers and described secure and insecure attachment patterns.
search.worldcat.org/title/4194069

**Bowlby, J. (1969).** *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

**Clark, M. S., & Mills, J. (1979).** *Interpersonal attraction in exchange and communal relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(1), 12–24. Distinguished communal relationships (benefits given in response to needs) from exchange relationships (benefits given in return for benefits). When people wanted a communal relationship, being repaid in kind reduced attraction.
clarkrelationshiplab.yale.edu

**Erikson, E. H. (1950).** *Childhood and Society.* New York: W. W. Norton (book). Set out eight stages of life from infancy to old age, each with its own question or tension (for example trust against mistrust in infancy, identity against confusion in adolescence).
librarything.com/work/37187

**Felitti, V. J., Anda, R. F., Nordenberg, D., et al. (1998).** *Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults: The Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACE) Study.* American Journal of Preventive Medicine, 14(4), 245–258. Of 13,494 adults at a large health plan sent a questionnaire, 9,508 responded; the more categories of childhood adversity people reported, the higher their risk of many adult health problems, in a graded relationship.
doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797(98)00017-8

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987).** *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

**Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971).** *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

**Kerr, M. E., & Bowen, M. (1988).** *Family Evaluation: An Approach Based on Bowen Theory.* W. W. Norton. Explains Bowen family systems theory (differentiation, triangles, roles passed across generations) and how to evaluate a family as an emotional unit.
find.library.upenn.edu/catalog/999557963503681

**Malle, B. F. (2006).** *The actor-observer asymmetry in attribution: A (surprising) meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 895–919. A meta-analysis of 173 studies found average actor-observer effects near zero; the asymmetry appeared only in some conditions (for example when actor and observer were intimates, or for negative events), with a reverse pattern for positive events.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.895

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Ross, L. (1977).** *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behaviour.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

**Walster, E. [Hatfield, E.], Walster, G. W., & Berscheid, E. (1978).** *Equity: Theory and Research.* Allyn and Bacon (Boston). Extended equity theory to close relationships: feeling under-benefited goes with anger and resentment, feeling over-benefited with guilt, and both with less satisfaction than feeling things are roughly fair.
elainehatfield.com/publications.html

PART ONE · NOW

## Your wiring, weather and words

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006).** *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Kinnaird, E., Stewart, C., & Tchanturia, K. (2019).** *Investigating alexithymia in autism: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Psychiatry, 55, 80–89. Across 15 studies, about half of autistic participants (around 50%) had high alexithymia compared with about 5% of comparison participants; alexithymia is common in autism but not universal.
doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2018.09.004

**Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Sifneos, P. E. (1973).** *The prevalence of "alexithymic" characteristics in psychosomatic patients.* Psychotherapy and Psychosomatics, 22(2–6), 255–262. Introduced the term "alexithymia" for difficulty finding words for feelings, along with a limited fantasy life, and found these traits more often in psychosomatic patients than in controls.
karger.com

**Walster, E. [Hatfield, E.], Walster, G. W., & Berscheid, E. (1978).** *Equity: Theory and Research.* Allyn and Bacon (Boston). Extended equity theory to close relationships: feeling under-benefited goes with anger and resentment, feeling over-benefited with guilt, and both with less satisfaction than feeling things are roughly fair.
elainehatfield.com/publications.html

PART ONE · NEXT

## Who you are becoming

**Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012).** *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006).** *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

**Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010).** *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

**Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984).** *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991).** *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

PREFACE TO PART TWO

## The work nobody sees

**Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999).** *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 61(1), 199–212. Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labour.
doi.org/10.2307/353894

**Clark, M. S., & Mills, J. (1979).** *Interpersonal attraction in exchange and communal relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(1), 12–24. Distinguished communal relationships (benefits given in response to needs) from exchange relationships (benefits given in return for benefits). When people wanted a communal relationship, being repaid in kind reduced attraction.
clarkrelationshiplab.yale.edu

**Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992).** *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

**Daminger, A. (2019).** *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**di Leonardo, M. (1987).** *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

**Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009).** *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

**Gordon, A. M., Impett, E. A., Kogan, A., Oveis, C., & Keltner, D. (2012).** *To have and to hold: Gratitude promotes relationship maintenance in intimate bonds.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 103(2), 257–274. People who felt more appreciated by their romantic partners were more appreciative of their partners in return, and appreciation was linked with relationship maintenance and commitment.
doi.org/10.1037/a0028723

**Hochschild, A. R. (1983).** *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling.* Berkeley: University of California Press (reissued 2003, 2012). Coined "emotional labour" from a study of flight attendants (and bill collectors) trained to display feelings at work; distinguished surface acting from deep acting.
search.worldcat.org/title/9280843

**Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989).** *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com

**Kurdek, L. A. (2007).** *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Journal of Family Issues, 28(1), 132–148. Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

**Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979).** *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

**Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., Brown, G. L., Cannon, E. A., Mangelsdorf, S. C., & Sokolowski, M. S. (2008).** *Maternal gatekeeping, coparenting quality, and fathering behavior in families with infants.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(3), 389–398. In 97 couples with infants, fathers were more involved in day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them (gate-opening); when mothers were highly critical (gate-closing), fathers' own beliefs about involvement mattered less.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

**Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015).** *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 77(3), 662–679. Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

PART TWO · CHAPTER I

## Why we get out of tune

**Bryant, C. M., Conger, R. D., & Meehan, J. M. (2001).** *The influence of in-laws on change in marital success.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 63(3), 614–626. Following couples for several years, found that conflict and poorer relationships with in-laws predicted later declines in marital success (stability, satisfaction and commitment).
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2001.00614.x

**Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999).** *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

**Gilovich, T., Savitsky, K., & Medvec, V. H. (1998).** *The illusion of transparency: Biased assessments of others' ability to read one's emotional states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(2), 332–346. In several sets of studies, people overestimated how well others could read their internal states (for example, liars overestimated how detectable their lies were, and people thought their disgust showed more than it did).
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.2.332

**Gordon, T. (1970).** *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularised "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behaviour rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005).** *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

**Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010).** *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

**Lambert, N. M., Fincham, F. D., Stillman, T. F., Graham, S. M., & Beach, S. R. H. (2010).** *Motivating change in relationships: Can prayer increase forgiveness?* Psychological Science, 21(1), 126–132. In two small experiments with students, people asked to pray for a romantic partner (study 1) or for a friend daily for four weeks (study 2) reported more willingness to forgive that person than people in comparison conditions; in study 2 this went with a rise in selfless concern.
doi.org/10.1177/0956797609355634

**Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

**Mahoney, A. (2010).** *Religion in families, 1999–2009: A relational spirituality framework.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 72(4), 805–827. Reviewed a decade of peer-reviewed studies on religion in marriage and parent–child relationships, "for better and worse", organising them by how faith may help form, maintain and change family relationships; faith can strengthen family life and can also be a source of strain.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2010.00732.x

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Ross, L. (1977).** *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behaviour.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

**Savitsky, K., Keysar, B., Epley, N., Carter, T., & Swanson, A. (2011).** *The closeness-communication bias: Increased egocentrism among friends versus strangers.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 47(1), 269–273. In three experiments, people overestimated how well they communicated with friends and spouses, more than with strangers, and made more egocentric errors following a friend's directions; closeness seemed to relax the checking people do with strangers.
sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022103110002118

**Yoo, S.-S., Gujar, N., Hu, P., Jolesz, F. A., & Walker, M. P. (2007).** *The human emotional brain without sleep—a prefrontal amygdala disconnect.* Current Biology, 17(20), R877–R878. After a night without sleep, the amygdala reacted more strongly to negative pictures and was less connected to the prefrontal cortex.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2007.08.007

## Is the split working?

**Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983).** A *global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

**Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992).** *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

**Daminger, A. (2019).** *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**di Leonardo, M. (1987).** *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

**Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009).** *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

**Feinberg, M. E., & Kan, M. L. (2008).** *Establishing Family Foundations: Intervention effects on coparenting, parent/infant well-being, and parent-child relations.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(2), 253–263. A randomised trial with 169 expectant first-time couples found that the Family Foundations classes, delivered before and after birth, improved coparenting and some aspects of parent and infant wellbeing at follow-up.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.2.253

**Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975).** *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* Paper presented at the Conference in Monetary Economics, Sydney, July 1975; published in Papers in Monetary Economics, Vol. I (Reserve Bank of Australia, 1976); reprinted in Goodhart, Monetary Theory and Practice (Macmillan, 1984). The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

**Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989).** *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com

**Kurdek, L. A. (2007).** *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Journal of Family Issues, 28(1), 132–148. Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

**Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979).** *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

**Strathern, M. (1997).** *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* European Review, 5(3), 305–321. Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org

**U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (annual, since 2003).** *American Time Use Survey* (ATUS). Federal survey (conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau). The federal survey of how, where and with whom Americans spend their time, including unpaid housework and childcare; it has run every year since 2003.
bls.gov/tus

**Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015).** *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 77(3), 662–679. Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

## Full tanks and different angles

**Amato, P. R. (2001).** *Children of divorce in the 1990s: An update of the Amato and Keith (1991) meta-analysis.* Journal of Family Psychology, 15(3), 355–370. Updated a meta-analysis comparing children of divorced and continuously married parents; differences in wellbeing were small on average and persisted in studies from the 1990s.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.15.3.355

**Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983).** *A global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

**Emery, R. E. (1982).** *Interparental conflict and the children of discord and divorce.* Psychological Bulletin, 92(2), 310–330. Reviewed evidence that conflict between parents, in married and divorced families, is linked to children's problems, and that the amount and type of conflict matter.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.92.2.310

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Hetherington, E. M., & Kelly, J. (2002).** *For Better or For Worse: Divorce Reconsidered.* W. W. Norton. Drawing on long-term studies of about 1,400 families, argues that most children of divorce and remarriage turn out reasonably well, with outcomes varying widely.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393324136-for-better-or-for-worse

**Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971).** *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

**Maccoby, E. E., & Mnookin, R. H. (1992).** *Dividing the Child: Social and Legal Dilemmas of Custody.* Harvard University Press. Following more than a thousand separating families for three years, described three patterns of co-parenting among families where children spent time in both homes: cooperative, conflicted and disengaged; most parents avoided legal battles but many found it hard to cooperate.
hls.harvard.edu

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Neff, L. A., & Karney, B. R. (2009).** *Stress and reactivity to daily relationship experiences: How stress hinders adaptive processes in marriage.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 97(3), 435–450. Spouses under more stress outside the relationship reacted more strongly to everyday negative experiences within it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015663

**Papernow, P. L. (2013).** *Surviving and Thriving in Stepfamily Relationships: What Works and What Doesn't.* Routledge. Describes "stepfamily architecture" and five common challenges it creates, drawing on research and clinical experience; closeness between stepfamily members typically builds slowly.
routledge.com

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

## Two kinds of fair

**Adams, J. S. (1965).** *Inequity in social exchange.* In L. Berkowitz (Ed.), Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, Vol. 2, pp. 267–299. Academic Press. Founding statement of equity theory: people compare the ratio of what they put in to what they get out with someone else's, and feel tension when the ratios differ.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60108-2

**Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999).** *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 61(1), 199–212. Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labour.
doi.org/10.2307/353894

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**Deming, W. E. (1986).** *Out of the Crisis.* MIT Press (Center for Advanced Engineering Study), Cambridge, MA. Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

**Deutsch, M. (1975).** *Equity, equality, and need: What determines which value will be used as the basis of distributive justice?* Journal of Social Issues, 31(3), 137–149. Argued that equity is only one of several justice principles, alongside equality and need, and proposed when groups favour each: equality in cooperative relationships, equity in economic ones, need in caring ones.
data.gesis.org/gesiskg/resource/zis-Deutsch1975Equity

**Dew, J., Britt, S., & Huston, S. (2012).** *Examining the relationship between financial issues and divorce.* Family Relations, 61(4), 615–628. In US national survey data on about 4,500 couples, financial disagreements were the strongest of the disagreement types in predicting later divorce, for both wives and husbands.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2012.00715.x

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Klontz, B., Britt, S. L., Mentzer, J., & Klontz, T. (2011).** *Money beliefs and financial behaviors: Development of the Klontz Money Script Inventory.* Journal of Financial Therapy, 2(1), 1–22. In 422 respondents, beliefs about money clustered into four "money scripts" (money avoidance, money worship, money status and money vigilance), several of which were linked with income and net worth.
doi.org/10.4148/jft.v2i1.451

**Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005).** *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

**Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

**Papp, L. M., Cummings, E. M., & Goeke-Morey, M. C. (2009).** *For richer, for poorer: Money as a topic of marital conflict in the home.* Family Relations, 58(1), 91–103. In home diary records of marital conflict, money was not the most frequent topic, but money conflicts were more pervasive, problematic and recurrent than other conflicts and more likely to stay unresolved.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2008.00537.x

**Rick, S. I., Small, D. A., & Finkel, E. J. (2011).** *Fatal (fiscal) attraction: Spendthrifts and tightwads in marriage.* Journal of Marketing Research, 48(2), 228–237. Tightwads and spendthrifts tend to marry each other; the bigger the difference within a couple, the more conflict over money, which in turn predicts lower marital wellbeing.
doi.org/10.1509/jmkr.48.2.228

**Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979).** *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

**Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., Brown, G. L., Cannon, E. A., Mangelsdorf, S. C., & Sokolowski, M. S. (2008).** *Maternal gatekeeping, coparenting quality, and fathering behavior in families with infants.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(3), 389–398. In 97 couples with infants, fathers were more involved in day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them (gate-opening); when mothers were highly critical (gate-closing), fathers' own beliefs about involvement mattered less.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

**Stone, D., Patton, B., & Heen, S. (1999).** *Difficult Conversations: How to Discuss What Matters Most.* Viking (New York); 10th-anniversary edition, Penguin 2010. A practitioner book from the Harvard Negotiation Project describing three conversations inside every hard conversation (what happened, feelings, identity) and the gap between intent and impact.
penguinrandomhouse.com

**Taylor, M. J., McNicholas, C., Nicolay, C., Darzi, A., Bell, D., & Reed, J. E. (2014).** *Systematic review of the application of the plan–do–study–act method to improve quality in healthcare.* BMJ Quality & Safety, 23(4), 290–298. Of 73 healthcare articles reporting the use of plan–do–study–act cycles, most did not report key features of the method, such as iterative cycles, small tests of change and real-time data.
doi.org/10.1136/bmjqs-2013-001862

**Thibaut, J., & Walker, L. (1975).** *Procedural Justice: A Psychological Analysis.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Founded procedural-justice research: people's judgments of whether a decision process is fair (especially having a voice) shape how satisfied they are with the outcome.
law.virginia.edu/node/127096

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

## The monthly look-back

**Boss, P. (1999).** *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Harvard University Press. Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**Dekker, S. (2007).** *Just Culture: Balancing Safety and Accountability.* Ashgate (2nd ed. 2012). Argues for a "just culture" that separates honest mistakes from reckless behaviour, and that who draws the line matters as much as where it is drawn.
relbib.de/Record/1613173431

**Deming, W. E. (1986).** *Out of the Crisis.* MIT Press (Center for Advanced Engineering Study), Cambridge, MA. Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

**Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975).** *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* Paper presented at the Conference in Monetary Economics, Sydney, July 1975; published in Papers in Monetary Economics, Vol. I (Reserve Bank of Australia, 1976); reprinted in Goodhart, Monetary Theory and Practice (Macmillan, 1984). The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

**Hayslip, B., Jr., & Kaminski, P. L. (2005).** *Grandparents raising their grandchildren: A review of the literature and suggestions for practice.* The Gerontologist, 45(2), 262–269. Reviewed research on custodial grandparents: the costs and benefits of raising a grandchild, how varied these families are, their need for social support, parenting, and help at several levels.
doi.org/10.1093/geront/45.2.262

**Pillemer, K. (2020).** *Fault Lines: Fractured Families and How to Mend Them.* Avery (Penguin Random House). Draws on the Cornell Reconciliation Project, including a national survey on estrangement and interviews, to show family estrangement is more common than people assume and that some people reconcile.
search.worldcat.org/oclc/1145305518

**Reason, J. (1990).** *Human Error.* Cambridge University Press. A theory of human error that sorts slips, lapses and mistakes, and introduced the layered-defences thinking behind the "Swiss cheese" model of accidents.
doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781139062367

**Reason, J. (1997).** *Managing the Risks of Organizational Accidents.* Ashgate (now Routledge). Describes how organisational accidents arise from latent conditions combining with front-line errors, and sets out ideas for a safety and "just" culture.
routledge.com

**Strathern, M. (1997).** *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* European Review, 5(3), 305–321. Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org

**Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1973).** *Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability.* Cognitive Psychology, 5(2), 207–232. People judge how common something is by how easily examples come to mind. That usually works, but vivid or recent examples make some things seem more common than they are.
apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA045770.pdf

PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

## How feelings work

**Barrett, L. F. (2017).** *The theory of constructed emotion: an active inference account of interoception and categorization.* Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience, 12(1), 1–23. Sets out the theory that the brain constantly predicts the body's needs and constructs emotions by making sense of body sensations using learned concepts.
doi.org/10.1093/scan/nsw154

**Barrett, L. F., Adolphs, R., Marsella, S., Martinez, A. M., & Pollak, S. D. (2019).** *Emotional expressions reconsidered: Challenges to inferring emotion from human facial movements.* Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 20(1), 1–68. Concluded that facial movements are not reliable enough to infer a person's specific emotion across situations and cultures.
doi.org/10.1177/1529100619832930

**Bird, G., & Cook, R. (2013).** *Mixed emotions: The contribution of alexithymia to the emotional symptoms of autism.* Translational Psychiatry, 3(7), e285. Argued that emotional difficulties seen in some autistic people are better explained by co-occurring alexithymia than by autism itself.
doi.org/10.1038/tp.2013.61

**Bushman, B. J. (2002).** *Does venting anger feed or extinguish the flame? Catharsis, rumination, distraction, anger, and aggressive responding.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(6), 724–731. Angered people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who provoked them felt angrier afterwards than people who were distracted or did nothing.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202289002

**Cacioppo, J. T., & Patrick, W. (2008).** *Loneliness: Human Nature and the Need for Social Connection.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book arguing that loneliness is a biological signal, like hunger, that we need connection, and that chronic loneliness can trap people in isolation and harm health.
wellcomecollection.org/works/wp45vzsp

**Craig, A. D. (2002).** *How do you feel? Interoception: the sense of the physiological condition of the body.* Nature Reviews Neuroscience, 3(8), 655–666. Described a pathway that carries signals about the body's internal state to the brain (including the insula), and proposed it underlies subjective feelings, emotion and self-awareness.
doi.org/10.1038/nrn894

**Dutton, D. G., & Aron, A. P. (1974).** *Some evidence for heightened sexual attraction under conditions of high anxiety.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 30(4), 510–517. In a field study, men approached by an attractive female interviewer on a high, swaying suspension bridge were more likely to call her afterwards than men approached on a low, sturdy bridge; the authors read this as arousal from fear being mislabelled as attraction.
doi.org/10.1037/h0037031

**Ekman, P., & Friesen, W. V. (1971).** *Constants across cultures in the face and emotion.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 17(2), 124–129. In the Fore people of Papua New Guinea, who had seen little Western media, adults and children mostly matched short emotion stories to the same facial expressions that Western people chose. This was taken as evidence that a few facial expressions of emotion are shared across cultures.
doi.org/10.1037/h0030377

**Gross, J. J., & John, O. P. (2003).** *Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: Implications for affect, relationships, and well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 85(2), 348–362. Across five studies, people who habitually reappraised had better emotional experience, relationships and well-being; habitual suppression was linked to worse outcomes.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

**Hatfield, E., Cacioppo, J. T., & Rapson, R. L. (1994).** *Emotional contagion.* Cambridge University Press (Studies in Emotion and Social Interaction). Describes emotional contagion: people tend to mimic each other's faces, voices and postures, and that mimicry can shift their own feelings.
catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb37435416b

**James, W. (1884).** *What is an emotion?* Mind, os-IX(34), 188–205. James argued that bodily changes follow directly from perceiving something exciting, and that our feeling of those bodily changes is the emotion.
doi.org/10.1093/mind/os-IX.34.188

**Kashdan, T. B., Barrett, L. F., & McKnight, P. E. (2015).** *Unpacking emotion differentiation: Transforming unpleasant experience by perceiving distinctions in negativity.* Current Directions in Psychological Science, 24(1), 10–16. Reviewed research on emotion differentiation (emotional granularity): people who describe negative feelings in fine-grained ways tend to rely less on unhelpful coping such as binge drinking or aggression.
doi.org/10.1177/0963721414550708

**Kircanski, K., Lieberman, M. D., & Craske, M. G. (2012).** *Feelings into words: Contributions of language to exposure therapy.* Psychological Science, 23(10), 1086–1091. Spider-fearful people who described their feelings in words while near a live spider showed lower skin-conductance arousal a week later than people who reappraised, distracted themselves or had exposure alone; self-reported fear did not differ between groups.
doi.org/10.1177/0956797612443830

**Levant, R. F., Hall, R. J., Williams, C. M., & Hasan, N. T. (2009).** *Gender differences in alexithymia.* Psychology of Men & Masculinity, 10(3), 190–203. A meta-analysis of 41 samples found that men scored slightly higher than women on alexithymia (difficulty identifying and describing feelings), but the difference was small.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015652

**Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

**Marlatt, G. A., & Gordon, J. R. (Eds.) (1985).** *Relapse prevention: Maintenance strategies in the treatment of addictive behaviors.* Guilford Press. An edited volume setting out the cognitive-behavioural relapse prevention model, including the "abstinence violation effect": after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure can make a full relapse more likely.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/27251005X

**Matsumoto, D., Yoo, S. H., & Nakagawa, S. (2008).** *Culture, emotion regulation, and adjustment.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 94(6), 925–937. Across 23 countries, cultures that placed more value on social order and hierarchy tended to report more suppression of emotions; cultures valuing individual autonomy and egalitarianism reported less.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.94.6.925

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Schachter, S., & Singer, J. (1962).** *Cognitive, social, and physiological determinants of emotional state.* Psychological Review, 69(5), 379–399. Proposed the two-factor theory: an emotion is physical arousal plus a label we give it from the situation.
doi.org/10.1037/h0046234

**Schwarz, N., & Clore, G. L. (1983).** *Mood, misattribution, and judgments of well-being: Informative and directive functions of affective states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 45(3), 513–523. People in a good mood (including people phoned on sunny days) rated their happiness and life satisfaction higher. A bad mood stopped lowering their ratings once their attention was drawn to an outside cause, such as the weather.
worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl

**Singer, T., & Klimecki, O. M. (2014).** *Empathy and compassion.* Current Biology, 24(18), R875–R878. Distinguished empathic distress (sharing someone's pain, which can overwhelm) from compassion (warm concern), which engage different brain networks; brief compassion training increased positive feelings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2014.06.054

**Torre, J. B., & Lieberman, M. D. (2018).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling as implicit emotion regulation.* Emotion Review, 10(2), 116–124. Reviewed evidence that naming a feeling can reduce its intensity even though it does not feel like regulating it at the time.
doi.org/10.1177/1754073917742706

**Verduyn, P., & Lavrijsen, S. (2015).** *Which emotions last longest and why: The role of event importance and rumination.* Motivation and Emotion, 39(1), 119–127. Of 27 emotions studied, sadness lasted longest, while shame, surprise, fear and disgust were among the shortest; long-lasting emotions tended to follow important events and involve rumination.
ppw.kuleuven.be/okp/_pdf/Verduyn2015WELLA.pdf

**Wegner, D. M., Schneider, D. J., Carter, S. R., & White, T. L. (1987).** *Paradoxical effects of thought suppression.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 53(1), 5–13. People asked not to think of a white bear kept thinking of it, suggesting that trying to suppress a thought can backfire.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.53.1.5

## Stress and the nervous system

**Arnsten, A. F. T. (2009).** *Stress signalling pathways that impair prefrontal cortex structure and function.* Nature Reviews Neuroscience, 10(6), 410–422. Reviewed evidence that stress chemicals rapidly weaken the prefrontal cortex, which supports planning and flexible thinking, while strengthening more habitual responses.
doi.org/10.1038/nrn2648

**Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2007).** *The job demands-resources model: State of the art.* Journal of Managerial Psychology, 22(3), 309–328. A review of the job demands-resources model: high job demands drive strain and burnout, while job resources such as support, control and feedback drive motivation and help buffer demands.
doi.org/10.1108/02683940710733115

**Balban, M. Y., Neri, E., Kogon, M. M., Weed, L., Nouriani, B., Jo, B., Holl, G., Zeitzer, J. M., Spiegel, D., & Huberman, A. D. (2023).** *Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal.* Cell Reports Medicine, 4(1), 100895. In a month-long randomised trial of five minutes a day, breathing exercises improved mood more than mindfulness meditation, with cyclic sighing (long out-breaths) showing the largest benefits.
doi.org/10.1016/j.xcrm.2022.100895

**Ben Simon, E., & Walker, M. P. (2018).** *Sleep loss causes social withdrawal and loneliness.* Nature Communications. After a night without sleep, young adults kept an approaching person at a greater distance and felt lonelier, with brain changes linked to social avoidance; rested people who briefly watched them felt lonelier too.
doi.org/10.1038/s41467-018-05377-0

**Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000).** *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

**Coan, J. A., Schaefer, H. S., & Davidson, R. J. (2006).** *Lending a hand: Social regulation of the neural response to threat.* Psychological Science, 17(12), 1032–1039. In an fMRI study, married women facing the threat of a mild shock showed less threat-related brain activity while holding their husband's hand than when alone.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2006.01832.x

**Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014).** *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(2), 168–175. In a 14-day daily study, people reported more conflict with their partner after poor nights of sleep, and conflicts were resolved best when both partners were well rested.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613488952

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Jamieson, J. P., Nock, M. K., & Mendes, W. B. (2012).** *Mind over matter: Reappraising arousal improves cardiovascular and cognitive responses to stress.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 141(3), 417–422. People told to see their stress arousal as helpful showed healthier cardiovascular responses and less attention to negative information than control groups.
doi.org/10.1037/a0025719

**Kanner, A. D., Coyne, J. C., Schaefer, C., & Lazarus, R. S. (1981).** *Comparison of two modes of stress measurement: Daily hassles and uplifts versus major life events.* Journal of Behavioral Medicine, 4(1), 1–39. Everyday hassles predicted psychological symptoms better than major life events did, and still did after life events were taken into account.
doi.org/10.1007/BF00844845

**Kaplan, S. (1995).** *The restorative benefits of nature: Toward an integrative framework.* Journal of Environmental Psychology, 15(3), 169–182. Set out attention restoration theory: effortful, directed attention gets fatigued, and environments such as nature, which hold attention effortlessly, help it recover; the paper links this with stress recovery.
doi.org/10.1016/0272-4944(95)90001-2

**Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984).** *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

**Leikas, S., & Ilmarinen, V.-J. (2017).** *Happy now, tired later? Extraverted and conscientious behavior are related to immediate mood gains, but to later fatigue.* Journal of Personality, 85(5), 603–615. In a 12-day experience-sampling study, acting extraverted went with better mood at the time but more fatigue about three hours later, for introverts and extraverts alike.
doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12264

**McEwen, B. S., & Stellar, E. (1993).** *Stress and the individual: Mechanisms leading to disease.* Archives of Internal Medicine, 153(18), 2093–2101. Introduced "allostatic load": the cumulative wear and tear on the body from repeated or chronic stress responses.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/8379800

**Miserandino, C. (2003).** *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Repetti, R. L. (1989).** *Effects of daily workload on subsequent behavior during marital interaction: The roles of social withdrawal and spouse support.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(4), 651–659. In a daily study of air traffic controllers, after high-workload days they were more socially withdrawn and less emotionally expressive with their spouses that evening.
psych.ucla.edu/wp-content/uploads/Repetti-JPSP-1989.pdf

**Shaw, P., Stringaris, A., Nigg, J., & Leibenluft, E. (2014).** *Emotion dysregulation in attention deficit hyperactivity disorder.* American Journal of Psychiatry, 171(3), 276–293. A literature review found that trouble regulating emotions (quick, strong feelings that are hard to bring back down) is common in ADHD across the lifespan, with clinic studies of young people putting it at roughly a quarter to a half, and that it adds a lot to the day-to-day difficulty ADHD brings.
doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2013.13070966

**Siegel, D. J. (1999).** *The developing mind: Toward a neurobiology of interpersonal experience.* Guilford Press. A book linking attachment, memory and brain development; it introduced the "window of tolerance", the range of arousal in which a person can feel strong emotion and still think and respond flexibly.
catalog.library.nashville.org/Record/CARL0000114962

**Sonnentag, S., & Fritz, C. (2007).** *The Recovery Experience Questionnaire: Development and validation of a measure for assessing recuperation and unwinding from work.* Journal of Occupational Health Psychology, 12(3), 204–221. Identified four separate recovery experiences outside work: psychological detachment, relaxation, mastery and control.
doi.org/10.1037/1076-8998.12.3.204

**Taylor, S. E., Klein, L. C., Lewis, B. P., Gruenewald, T. L., Gurung, R. A. R., & Updegraff, J. A. (2000).** *Biobehavioral responses to stress in females: Tend-and-befriend, not fight-or-flight.* Psychological Review, 107(3), 411–429. Proposed that under stress people, perhaps especially women, often respond by protecting others and seeking social connection ("tend and befriend"), not only fight or flight.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.107.3.411

**Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978).** *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

**Yerkes, R. M., & Dodson, J. D. (1908).** *The relation of strength of stimulus to rapidity of habit-formation.* Journal of Comparative Neurology and Psychology, 18(5), 459–482. Studied how the strength of an electric shock affected how quickly dancing mice learned to avoid a black passage; later writers turned it into a general "inverted U" for arousal and performance.
doi.org/10.1002/cne.920180503

**Yoo, S.-S., Gujar, N., Hu, P., Jolesz, F. A., & Walker, M. P. (2007).** *The human emotional brain without sleep—a prefrontal amygdala disconnect.* Current Biology, 17(20), R877–R878. After a night without sleep, the amygdala reacted more strongly to negative pictures and was less connected to the prefrontal cortex.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2007.08.007

**Zaccaro, A., Piarulli, A., Laurino, M., Garbella, E., Menicucci, D., Neri, B., & Gemignani, A. (2018).** *How breath-control can change your life: A systematic review on psycho-physiological correlates of slow breathing.* Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 12, 353. Slow breathing was linked with changes in heart-rate variability and with more comfort, relaxation and alertness and less arousal and anxiety.
doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2018.00353

PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

## How we see each other

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Epley, N. (2014).** *Mindwise: How We Understand What Others Think, Believe, Feel, and Want.* Alfred A. Knopf (New York). A book reviewing research on how people infer others' thoughts and feelings, and why this 'sixth sense' is more error-prone than we believe.
wellcomecollection.org/works/zh83qear

**Eyal, T., Steffel, M., & Epley, N. (2018).** *Perspective mistaking: Accurately understanding the mind of another requires getting perspective, not taking perspective.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 114(4), 547–571. As the title states, a series of experiments found that imagining another person's perspective did not make people more accurate about what that person thought or felt, whereas getting their perspective directly (by asking) did.
doi.org/10.1037/pspa0000115

**Hastorf, A. H., & Cantril, H. (1954).** *They saw a game: A case study.* Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology, 49(1), 129–134. Students from Princeton and Dartmouth watched the same rough football game and saw it very differently, for example in how many infractions each team committed.
doi.org/10.1037/h0057880

**Jones, E. E., & Harris, V. A. (1967).** *The attribution of attitudes.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 3(1), 1–24. In three experiments, people judged a speaker's true attitude from a speech; they tended to attribute the stated position to the speaker even when told the speaker had been assigned it.
doi.org/10.1016/0022-1031(67)90034-0

**Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971).** *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

**Malle, B. F. (2006).** *The actor-observer asymmetry in attribution: A (surprising) meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 895–919. A meta-analysis of 173 studies found average actor-observer effects near zero; the asymmetry appeared only in some conditions (for example when actor and observer were intimates, or for negative events), with a reverse pattern for positive events.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.895

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Pronin, E., Lin, D. Y., & Ross, L. (2002).** *The bias blind spot: Perceptions of bias in self versus others.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(3), 369–381. People, from students to airport travelers, readily saw common biases in others but rated themselves as less biased than their peers (the bias blind spot).
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202286008

**Ross, L. (1977).** *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behaviour.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

**Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017).** *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* Scientific Reports, 7, 40700. Across three studies, non-autistic observers formed less favourable first impressions of autistic children and adults from a few seconds of video, and were less willing to interact with them; the bias disappeared when they judged only transcripts of what was said.
doi.org/10.1038/srep40700

**Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1973).** *Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability.* Cognitive Psychology, 5(2), 207–232. People judge how common something is by how easily examples come to mind. That usually works, but vivid or recent examples make some things seem more common than they are.
apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA045770.pdf

## How communication works

**Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999).** *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Daft, R. L., & Lengel, R. H. (1986).** *Organizational information requirements, media richness and structural design.* Management Science, 32(5), 554–571. Proposed media richness theory: richer channels (face to face, then phone, then written) are better suited to ambiguous, equivocal messages.
doi.org/10.1287/mnsc.32.5.554

**Epley, N., & Schroeder, J. (2014).** *Mistakenly seeking solitude.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(5), 1980–1999. Commuters asked to talk with a stranger on their train or bus reported a more positive journey than those told to sit in solitude, even though people predicted the opposite; misjudging how pleasant such talk would be keeps people apart.
doi.org/10.1037/a0037323

**Gilovich, T., Savitsky, K., & Medvec, V. H. (1998).** *The illusion of transparency: Biased assessments of others' ability to read one's emotional states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(2), 332–346. In several sets of studies, people overestimated how well others could read their internal states (for example, liars overestimated how detectable their lies were, and people thought their disgust showed more than it did).
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.2.332

**Gordon, T. (1970).** *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularised "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behaviour rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Gottman, J. M., Coan, J., Carrère, S., & Swanson, C. (1998).** *Predicting marital happiness and stability from newlywed interactions.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 60(1), 5–22. In a six-year study of newlyweds, husbands who accepted influence from their wives were more likely to have stable, happy marriages, while active-listening style paraphrasing during conflict was rare and did not predict outcomes.
jstor.org/stable/353438

**Gunraj, D. N., Drumm-Hewitt, A. M., Dashow, E. M., Upadhyay, S. S. N., & Klin, C. M. (2016).** *Texting insincerely: The role of the period in text messaging.* Computers in Human Behavior, 55, 1067–1075. Short text-message replies ending in a period were rated as less sincere than the same replies without one; the effect did not appear for handwritten notes.
doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2015.11.003

**Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005).** *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

**Malinowski, B. (1923).** *The problem of meaning in primitive languages.* Supplement I (pp. 451–510 in later printings) in C. K. Ogden & I. A. Richards, The Meaning of Meaning. London: Kegan Paul; New York: Harcourt, Brace. Named "phatic communion": small talk whose job is not to pass on information but to create and keep up a bond ("ties of union are created by mere exchange of words").
archive.org/details/meaningofmeaning00ogde

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014).** *Is efficiency overrated? Minimal social interactions lead to belonging and positive affect.* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(4), 437–442. People who had a brief, friendly social exchange with a coffee-shop barista reported more belonging and positive mood than those who kept the exchange purely efficient.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613502990

**Savitsky, K., Keysar, B., Epley, N., Carter, T., & Swanson, A. (2011).** *The closeness-communication bias: Increased egocentrism among friends versus strangers.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 47(1), 269–273. In three experiments, people overestimated how well they communicated with friends and spouses, more than with strangers, and made more egocentric errors following a friend's directions; closeness seemed to relax the checking people do with strangers.
sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022103110002118

**Schegloff, E. A., Jefferson, G., & Sacks, H. (1977).** *The preference for self-correction in the organization of repair in conversation.* Language, 53(2), 361–382. Analyses of everyday conversation showed that 'repair' of trouble in speaking, hearing and understanding is a built-in, organised part of talk, and that people strongly prefer to correct themselves rather than be corrected.
doi.org/10.1353/lan.1977.0041

**Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978).** *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

**Watzlawick, P., Beavin [Bavelas], J. H., & Jackson, D. D. (1967).** *Pragmatics of Human Communication: A Study of Interactional Patterns, Pathologies, and Paradoxes.* New York: W. W. Norton (book). Set out a few "axioms" of communication, including that every message has a content level (what is said) and a relationship level (what it says about us), and that the relationship level often decides how the content is heard.
ci.nii.ac.jp/ncid/BA01493188

**Weger, H., Jr., Castle Bell, G., Minei, E. M., & Robinson, M. C. (2014).** *The relative effectiveness of active listening in initial interactions.* International Journal of Listening, 28(1), 13–31. People who talked with a listener using active-listening responses felt more understood than those who received advice or simple acknowledgements; differences in satisfaction and liking were small.
doi.org/10.1080/10904018.2013.813234

## Attachment, trust and belonging

**Ainsworth, M. D. S., Blehar, M. C., Waters, E., & Wall, S. (1978).** *Patterns of Attachment: A Psychological Study of the Strange Situation.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Reported the Strange Situation studies of infants and mothers and described secure and insecure attachment patterns.
search.worldcat.org/title/4194069

**Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995).** *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

**Bowlby, J. (1969).** *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

**Brennan, K. A., Clark, C. L., & Shaver, P. R. (1998).** *Self-report measurement of adult attachment: An integrative overview.* In J. A. Simpson & W. S. Rholes (Eds.), Attachment Theory and Close Relationships (pp. 46–76). Guilford. A large factor-analytic study of all known self-report adult attachment measures found that they reduce to two broad dimensions: attachment anxiety and avoidance.
labs.psychology.illinois.edu/~rcfraley/measures/brennan.html

**Cacioppo, J. T., & Patrick, W. (2008).** *Loneliness: Human Nature and the Need for Social Connection.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book arguing that loneliness is a biological signal, like hunger, that we need connection, and that chronic loneliness can trap people in isolation and harm health.
wellcomecollection.org/works/wp45vzsp

**Coan, J. A., & Sbarra, D. A. (2015).** *Social baseline theory: The social regulation of risk and effort.* Current Opinion in Psychology, 1, 87–91. Proposes that the brain expects to have supportive people around, which lowers perceived risk and effort; without them, coping takes more effort.
doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2014.12.021

**Coan, J. A., Schaefer, H. S., & Davidson, R. J. (2006).** *Lending a hand: Social regulation of the neural response to threat.* Psychological Science, 17(12), 1032–1039. In an fMRI study, married women facing the threat of a mild shock showed less threat-related brain activity while holding their husband's hand than when alone.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2006.01832.x

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Edmondson, A. (1999).** *Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams.* Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383. In 51 teams at a manufacturing company, a shared belief that it was safe to take interpersonal risks (psychological safety) was linked with more team learning behaviour, which in turn was linked with performance.
doi.org/10.2307/2666999

**Eisenberger, N. I., Lieberman, M. D., & Williams, K. D. (2003).** *Does rejection hurt? An fMRI study of social exclusion.* Science, 302(5643), 290–292. Being left out of a virtual ball-tossing game increased activity in the anterior cingulate cortex, a region also involved in physical pain distress, in proportion to how upset people felt.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1089134

**Epley, N., & Schroeder, J. (2014).** *Mistakenly seeking solitude.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(5), 1980–1999. Commuters asked to talk with a stranger on their train or bus reported a more positive journey than those told to sit in solitude, even though people predicted the opposite; misjudging how pleasant such talk would be keeps people apart.
doi.org/10.1037/a0037323

**Fraley, R. C., Hudson, N. W., Heffernan, M. E., & Segal, N. (2015).** *Are adult attachment styles categorical or dimensional? A taxometric analysis of general and relationship-specific attachment orientations.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(2), 354–368. Taxometric analyses suggested that adult attachment differences are dimensional (degrees of anxiety and avoidance) rather than distinct types.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000027

**Hall, J. A. (2019).** *How many hours does it take to make a friend?* Journal of Social and Personal Relationships, 36(4), 1278–1296 (online first 2018). Studies of adults who had recently moved and of students found that more hours spent together, especially in leisure, went with moving from acquaintance to closer friendship.
doi.org/10.1177/0265407518761225

**Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987).** *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

**Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010).** *Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review.* PLoS Medicine, 7(7), e1000316. A meta-analysis of 148 studies (308,849 participants) found people with stronger social relationships had about 50% greater odds of survival over the study periods, consistently across age, sex and health status.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1000316

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B., Jr. (2016).** *An exploration of the structure of effective apologies.* Negotiation and Conflict Management Research, 9(2), 177–196. Testing six apology components with 755 participants, acknowledging responsibility was rated most important, then an offer of repair; a request for forgiveness mattered least. Apologies with more components were rated better.
doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073

**Main, M., & Solomon, J. (1990).** *Procedures for identifying infants as disorganized/disoriented during the Ainsworth Strange Situation.* In M. T. Greenberg, D. Cicchetti & E. M. Cummings (Eds.), Attachment in the Preschool Years (pp. 121–160). University of Chicago Press. Added a fourth attachment pattern, disorganized/disoriented, for infants who seemed frightened or confused by the caregiver in the Strange Situation, with indices for coding it.
chicagoreference.com/ucp/books/book/chicago/A/bo3774473.html

**Rempel, J. K., Holmes, J. G., & Zanna, M. P. (1985).** *Trust in close relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 49(1), 95–112. Described trust in close relationships as having three components, predictability, dependability and faith, and developed a self-report Trust Scale to measure them.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.49.1.95

**Rutgers, A. H., Bakermans-Kranenburg, M. J., van IJzendoorn, M. H., & van Berckelaer-Onnes, I. A. (2004).** *Autism and attachment: A meta-analytic review.* Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry, 45(6), 1123–1134. Across 16 studies, about half of autistic children in Strange Situation studies were securely attached; autistic children were less often secure on average, but the difference disappeared in samples of children with higher mental development.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1469-7610.2004.t01-1-00305.x

**Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014).** *Is efficiency overrated? Minimal social interactions lead to belonging and positive affect.* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(4), 437–442. People who had a brief, friendly social exchange with a coffee-shop barista reported more belonging and positive mood than those who kept the exchange purely efficient.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613502990

**Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979).** *An integrative theory of intergroup conflict.* In W. G. Austin & S. Worchel (Eds.), The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations (pp. 33–47). Brooks/Cole. Sets out social identity theory: part of our self-image comes from the groups we belong to, and we are motivated to see our groups positively, often by favouring them over others, even when groups are formed on trivial grounds.
alnap.org

**Williams, K. D., Cheung, C. K. T., & Choi, W. (2000).** *Cyberostracism: Effects of being ignored over the Internet.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(5), 748–762. In an online ball-tossing game (1,486 people from 62 countries in the first study), being left out by computer-controlled "players" made people feel worse and lowered their sense of belonging.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.748

PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

## Habits and change

**Baumeister, R. F., Bratslavsky, E., Muraven, M., & Tice, D. M. (1998).** *Ego depletion: Is the active self a limited resource?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1252–1265. In four experiments, an earlier act of self-control (such as resisting chocolate and eating radishes) was followed by giving up sooner on a later task, which the authors took as evidence that self-control draws on a limited resource.
researchconnect.suny.edu

**Bem, D. J. (1972).** *Self-perception theory.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 6, 1–62. Proposed that people come to know their own attitudes and feelings partly by observing their own behaviour, much as an outside observer would.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60024-6

**Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000).** *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

**Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012).** *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

**Bryan, C. J., Walton, G. M., Rogers, T., & Dweck, C. S. (2011).** *Motivating voter turnout by invoking the self.* PNAS, 108(31), 12653–12656. Asking people about "being a voter" rather than "voting" increased interest in registering and, in two US statewide elections, increased turnout measured in official records.
doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1103343108

**Christensen, A., & Heavey, C. L. (1990).** *Gender and social structure in the demand/withdraw pattern of marital conflict.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(1), 73–81. Wife-demand/husband-withdraw was more common overall, but who demanded depended partly on whose issue was being discussed; the authors linked the pattern to social structure (who wants change) as well as gender.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.1.73

**Christensen, A., Atkins, D. C., Berns, S., Wheeler, J., Baucom, D. H., & Simpson, L. E. (2004).** *Traditional versus integrative behavioral couple therapy for significantly and chronically distressed married couples.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 72(2), 176–191. In a randomised trial with 134 seriously distressed couples, both integrative (acceptance-based) and traditional behavioural couple therapy produced similar rates of clinically significant improvement, with different patterns of change during treatment.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-006X.72.2.176

**Drigotas, S. M., Rusbult, C. E., Wieselquist, J., & Whitton, S. W. (1999).** *Close partner as sculptor of the ideal self: Behavioral affirmation and the Michelangelo phenomenon.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 77(2), 293–323. Across four studies, people whose partners saw and treated them in line with their ideal self moved closer to that ideal over time, and this affirmation was linked with better couple functioning and more stable relationships.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.77.2.293

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006).** *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

**Hagger, M. S., Chatzisarantis, N. L. D., Alberts, H., et al. (2016).** *A multilab preregistered replication of the ego-depletion effect.* Perspectives on Psychological Science, 11(4), 546–573. A preregistered replication across 23 labs (2,141 participants) found an ego-depletion effect close to zero (d = 0.04, confidence interval including zero).
doi.org/10.1177/1745691616652873

**Hofmann, W., Baumeister, R. F., Förster, G., & Vohs, K. D. (2012).** *Everyday temptations: An experience sampling study of desire, conflict, and self-control.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 102(6), 1318–1335. Tracking people's desires through the day by smartphone, the researchers found that people high in trait self-control reported fewer temptations and conflicts, rather than resisting more often.
doi.org/10.1037/a0026545

**Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979).** *Prospect theory: An analysis of decision under risk.* Econometrica, 47(2), 263–291. People weigh choices as gains and losses from where they stand now, and a loss feels bigger than a gain of the same size ("loss aversion"), which helps explain why change can feel risky even when it would help.
jstor.org/stable/1914185

**Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010).** *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

**Marlatt, G. A., & Gordon, J. R. (Eds.) (1985).** *Relapse prevention: Maintenance strategies in the treatment of addictive behaviors.* Guilford Press. An edited volume setting out the cognitive-behavioural relapse prevention model, including the "abstinence violation effect": after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure can make a full relapse more likely.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/27251005X

**Miller, W. R., & Rollnick, S. (1991).** *Motivational interviewing: Preparing people to change addictive behavior.* Guilford Press. The first full presentation of motivational interviewing: a way of talking about change that treats mixed feelings as normal and draws out the person's own reasons for change.
motivationalinterviewing.org

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Neal, D. T., Wood, W., Wu, M., & Kurlander, D. (2011).** *The pull of the past: When do habits persist despite conflict with motives?* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 37(11), 1428–1437. In field experiments on habitual eating, people with a strong cinema-popcorn habit ate stale popcorn about as much as fresh popcorn in a cinema, but not in a different setting: context cues drove the habit more than taste or intentions.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167211419863

**Prochaska, J. O., & DiClemente, C. C. (1983).** *Stages and processes of self-change of smoking: Toward an integrative model of change.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 51(3), 390–395. Applied an integrative "stages of change" model to 872 people quitting smoking on their own, describing movement through stages such as contemplation, action and maintenance.
digitalcommons.uri.edu/psy_facpubs/572

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

**Samuelson, W., & Zeckhauser, R. (1988).** *Status quo bias in decision making.* Journal of Risk and Uncertainty, 1, 7–59. In decision experiments and in real choices of health plans and retirement programmes, people disproportionately stuck with the current option (status quo bias).
jstor.org/stable/41760530

**Thaler, R. H., & Sunstein, C. R. (2008).** *Nudge: Improving decisions about health, wealth, and happiness.* Yale University Press. Argues that small changes in how choices are presented (defaults, order, ease) can steer people towards better decisions without removing their freedom to choose.
identity.wellcomecollection.org/works/usu4u2um

**Wood, W., Quinn, J. M., & Kashy, D. A. (2002).** *Habits in everyday life: Thought, emotion, and action.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 83(6), 1281–1297. In two diary studies with hourly reports, a large share of everyday behaviour was habitual (repeated in the same place, often while thinking about something else), and habits came with less stress than non-habitual actions.
dornsife.usc.edu

## Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

**Baumeister, R. F., Campbell, J. D., Krueger, J. I., & Vohs, K. D. (2003).** *Does high self-esteem cause better performance, interpersonal success, happiness, or healthier lifestyles?* Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 4(1), 1–44. A major review concluded that high self-esteem does not reliably cause better performance or relationships; for example, good school performance partly produces high self-esteem rather than the reverse.
doi.org/10.1111/1529-1006.01431

**Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012).** *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

**Curran, T., & Hill, A. P. (2019).** *Perfectionism is increasing over time: A meta-analysis of birth cohort differences from 1989 to 2016.* Psychological Bulletin, 145(4), 410–429. A meta-analysis of college students' perfectionism scores found perfectionism rose between 1989 and 2016, with the largest rise in the sense that others expect perfection.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000138

**Festinger, L. (1954).** *A theory of social comparison processes.* Human Relations, 7(2), 117–140. Proposed that people judge their own opinions and abilities by comparing themselves with others, especially when there is no objective standard.
doi.org/10.1177/001872675400700202

**Hewitt, P. L., & Flett, G. L. (1991).** *Perfectionism in the self and social contexts: Conceptualization, assessment, and association with psychopathology.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 60(3), 456–470. Introduced a multidimensional model of perfectionism, distinguishing self-oriented, other-oriented and socially prescribed perfectionism, and linked these to psychological difficulties.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.60.3.456

**Lewis, H. B. (1971).** *Shame and guilt in neurosis.* International Universities Press, New York. Drawing on therapy sessions, Lewis distinguished shame, which centres on the whole self, from guilt, which centres on a specific act.
find.library.upenn.edu/catalog/99549673503681

**Mueller, C. M., & Dweck, C. S. (1998).** *Praise for intelligence can undermine children's motivation and performance.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(1), 33–52. In six studies, children praised for intelligence cared more about looking good than learning, and after failure persisted less and performed worse than children praised for effort.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.1.33

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991).** *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

**Tangney, J. P., & Dearing, R. L. (2002).** *Shame and guilt.* Guilford Press. Summarizes years of research distinguishing shame (about the self) from guilt (about the act): guilt-proneness goes with empathy and repair, shame-proneness with hiding, blame and anger.
guilford.com/books/Shame-and-Guilt/Tangney-Dearing/9781572309876

## Loss, grief and big life changes

**Bonanno, G. A. (2004).** *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

**Bonanno, G. A. (2009).** *The other side of sadness: What the new science of bereavement tells us about life after loss.* Basic Books. A book summarising bereavement research: most people are resilient after a loss, grief tends to come and go rather than follow fixed stages, and only a minority develop long-lasting, severe grief.
hachettebookgroup.com

**Boss, P. (1999).** *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Harvard University Press. Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

**Bowlby, J. (1969).** *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

**Bridges, W. (1980).** *Transitions: Making sense of life's changes.* Addison-Wesley. Distinguished outer change from inner transition and described three phases: endings, a "neutral zone", and new beginnings.
narrativestudies.lib.unb.ca/bibcite/reference/16554

**Doka, K. J. (Ed.) (1989).** *Disenfranchised grief: Recognizing hidden sorrow.* Lexington Books. Coined "disenfranchised grief": grief that is not openly acknowledged, publicly mourned or socially supported.
openlibrary.org/books/OL354418M

**Holmes, T. H., & Rahe, R. H. (1967).** *The Social Readjustment Rating Scale.* Journal of Psychosomatic Research, 11(2), 213–218. Created the Social Readjustment Rating Scale, a list of 43 life events (such as divorce, job loss, moving and bereavement) rated by how much readjustment they demand.
doi.org/10.1016/0022-3999(67)90010-4

**Klass, D., Silverman, P. R., & Nickman, S. L. (Eds.) (1996).** *Continuing bonds: New understandings of grief.* Taylor & Francis. Challenged the idea that healthy mourning means cutting ties with the dead, showing across many groups that ongoing inner bonds with the deceased are common and often healthy.
routledge.com

**Kübler-Ross, E. (1969).** *On death and dying.* Macmillan. Described five stages (denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance) from work with dying patients.
search.worldcat.org/title/4238

**Martin, T. L., & Doka, K. J. (2000).** *Men don't cry... women do: Transcending gender stereotypes of grief.* Brunner/Mazel. Described intuitive (feeling-focused) and instrumental (thinking- and doing-focused) grieving patterns, plus blended ones, arguing that they are related to gender but not determined by it.
opac.tangaza.ac.ke/bib/168348

**O'Connor, M.-F. (2022).** *The grieving brain: The surprising science of how we learn from love and loss.* HarperOne. A neuroscientist's account of grief as partly a learning problem: the brain must slowly update a map of the world in which the lost person is always there.
newbooksnetwork.com/the-grieving-brain

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Stroebe, M., & Schut, H. (1999).** *The dual process model of coping with bereavement: Rationale and description.* Death Studies, 23(3), 197–224. Proposed the dual process model: healthy grieving moves back and forth (oscillates) between loss-oriented and restoration-oriented coping, including taking breaks from grief.
research-portal.uu.nl

PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

## Minds that work differently

**American Speech-Language-Hearing Association (ASHA) (2018).** *Facilitated communication [Position statement].* ASHA policy PS2018-00352. States that facilitated communication, where a helper supports the person's hand or arm while they type or point, is discredited: research has found the messages come from the facilitator, and it should not be used.
asha.org/policy/ps2018-00352

**Aron, E. N., & Aron, A. (1997).** *Sensory-processing sensitivity and its relation to introversion and emotionality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 73(2), 345–368. Across seven studies, the authors identified a single core trait of sensory-processing sensitivity, partly independent of introversion and emotionality, and developed the 27-item Highly Sensitive Person Scale.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.73.2.345

**Au-Yeung, S. K., Freeth, M., & Thompson, A. R. (2025).** *'Am I gonna regret this?': The experiences of diagnostic disclosure in autistic adults.* Autism, 29(8), 2181–2192. In interviews with 12 adults diagnosed as autistic in adulthood, telling others helped some reach support, be more themselves and help others, but many had not been believed, which made them more cautious about telling.
doi.org/10.1177/13623613251337504

**Barkley, R. A. (1997).** *Behavioral inhibition, sustained attention, and executive functions: Constructing a unifying theory of ADHD.* Psychological Bulletin, 121(1), 65–94. A theoretical review proposing that ADHD centres on a difficulty with behavioural inhibition, which in turn affects executive functions such as working memory, self-regulation of emotion and motivation, and the sense of time.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.121.1.65

**Bird, G., & Cook, R. (2013).** *Mixed emotions: The contribution of alexithymia to the emotional symptoms of autism.* Translational Psychiatry, 3(7), e285. Argued that emotional difficulties seen in some autistic people are better explained by co-occurring alexithymia than by autism itself.
doi.org/10.1038/tp.2013.61

**Blackwell, A. G. (2017).** *The curb-cut effect.* Stanford Social Innovation Review, 15(1), Winter 2017. An essay arguing that laws and programmes designed for disadvantaged groups, like kerb cuts made for wheelchair users, often end up benefiting everyone.
ssir.org/issue/winter-2017

**Botha, M., & Frost, D. M. (2020).** *Extending the minority stress model to understand mental health problems experienced by the autistic population.* Society and Mental Health, 10(1), 20–34. In 111 autistic adults, everyday discrimination, internalised stigma and concealing being autistic predicted poorer mental health even after accounting for general stress, suggesting minority stress plays a part.
doi.org/10.1177/2156869318804297

**Cooper, K., Smith, L. G. E., & Russell, A. (2017).** *Social identity, self-esteem, and mental health in autism.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 47(7), 844–854. In 272 autistic and 267 non-autistic participants, autistic people who identified more strongly with other autistic people had higher self-esteem, which was in turn linked to lower anxiety and depression.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2297

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Demetriou, E. A., Lampit, A., Quintana, D. S., et al. (2018).** *Autism spectrum disorders: A meta-analysis of executive function.* Molecular Psychiatry, 23, 1198–1204. Pooling 235 studies with over 14,000 participants, found that autistic people on average scored lower than non-autistic people across executive function tasks, with wide variation and mixed findings across ages.
doi.org/10.1038/mp.2017.75

**Donnellan, A. M. (1984).** *The criterion of the least dangerous assumption.* Behavioral Disorders, 9(2), 141–150. Proposed that when we lack evidence about what someone can understand or do, we should act on the assumption that would do the least harm if wrong, which usually means presuming competence.
scholar.google.com

**Dunn, W. (1997).** *The impact of sensory processing abilities on the daily lives of young children and their families: A conceptual model.* Infants & Young Children, 9(4), 23–35. Proposed a model of sensory processing in which people differ in their neurological thresholds (high or low) and in how they respond (going along with them or acting against them), giving four patterns that affect daily life.
doi.org/10.1097/00001163-199704000-00005

**Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018).** *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* Autism Research, 11(5), 766–775. In a survey of autistic adults in the Netherlands Autism Register, about two-thirds reported a special interest; greater motivation for the interest was linked to higher wellbeing, while very high intensity of engagement was linked to lower wellbeing.
research.vu.nl

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Kapp, S. K., Steward, R., Crane, L., Elliott, D., Elphick, C., Pellicano, E., & Russell, G. (2019).** *"People should be allowed to do what they like": Autistic adults' views and experiences of stimming.* Autism, 23(7), 1782–1792. Interviews with 32 autistic adults described stimming as a way to regulate overwhelming emotions and sensations, and as something that becomes accepted through understanding; participants objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319829628

**Kenny, L., Hattersley, C., Molins, B., Buckley, C., Povey, C., & Pellicano, E. (2016).** *Which terms should be used to describe autism? Perspectives from the UK autism community.* Autism, 20(4), 442–462. A survey of 3,470 people in the UK autism community found no single preferred term: "autism" and "on the autism spectrum" were widely endorsed, and "autistic" was favoured by many autistic adults and families but much less by professionals.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361315588200

**Kildahl, A. N., Helverschou, S. B., Rysstad, A. L., Wigaard, E., Hellerud, J. M., Ludvigsen, L. B., & Howlin, P. (2021).** *Pathological demand avoidance in children and adolescents: A systematic review.* Autism, 25(8), 2162–2176. Reviewing 13 studies, found they nearly all relied on Newson's original descriptions and mostly on parent reports, seldom considered other explanations such as anxiety, and none asked people with the profile about their own experience.
doi.org/10.1177/13623613211034382

**Leedham, A., Thompson, A. R., Smith, R., & Freeth, M. (2020).** *'I was exhausted trying to figure it out': The experiences of females receiving an autism diagnosis in middle to late adulthood.* Autism, 24(1), 135–146. Interviews with eleven autistic women diagnosed at 40 or older explored how they made sense of a lifetime of feeling different and how the diagnosis changed their understanding of themselves.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319853442

**Millar, D. C., Light, J. C., & Schlosser, R. W. (2006).** *The impact of augmentative and alternative communication intervention on the speech production of individuals with developmental disabilities: A research review.* Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research, 49(2), 248–264. Across 23 studies (67 people aged 2 to 60), AAC did not hold back speech, and in many cases speech increased, though most studies lacked strong experimental control.
doi.org/10.1044/1092-4388(2006/021)

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Miserandino, C. (2003).** *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Newson, E., Le Maréchal, K., & David, C. (2003).** *Pathological demand avoidance syndrome: A necessary distinction within the pervasive developmental disorders.* Archives of Disease in Childhood, 88(7), 595–600. Proposed recognising "pathological demand avoidance" as a separate profile within the autism spectrum, based on 150 cases with an equal sex ratio, describing strong avoidance of everyday demands.
doi.org/10.1136/adc.88.7.595

**NHS (n.d.).** *Prosopagnosia (face blindness).* NHS website (nhs.uk), health A to Z. Describes face blindness as difficulty recognising faces, often present from childhood and sometimes running in families; there is no treatment, but strategies such as recognising voices, hair or clothes, and telling people, can help.
nhs.uk/conditions/face-blindness

**Phung, J., Penner, M., Pirlot, C., & Welch, C. (2021).** *What I wish you knew: Insights on burnout, inertia, meltdown, and shutdown from autistic youth.* Frontiers in Psychology, 12, 741421. Interviews with eight autistic children and young people explored burnout, inertia, meltdown and shutdown as separate experiences, what they feel like, and what others do that helps or makes them worse.
doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.741421

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Sasson, N. J., & Morrison, K. E. (2019).** *First impressions of adults with autism improve with diagnostic disclosure and increased autism knowledge of peers.* Autism, 23(1), 50–59. 215 observers formed more favourable first impressions of autistic adults when told they were autistic, and observers who knew more about autism rated them more favourably.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361317729526

**Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017).** *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* Scientific Reports, 7, 40700. Across three studies, non-autistic observers formed less favourable first impressions of autistic children and adults from a few seconds of video, and were less willing to interact with them; the bias disappeared when they judged only transcripts of what was said.
doi.org/10.1038/srep40700

**Weigelt, S., Koldewyn, K., & Kanwisher, N. (2012).** *Face identity recognition in autism spectrum disorders: A review of behavioral studies.* Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews, 36(3), 1060–1084. Found that autistic people were, on average, less accurate at recognising and remembering face identity, especially when memory was involved, while processing faces in broadly the same way; whether the difficulty is specific to faces was unclear.
doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2011.12.008

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

## Values, meaning and a good life

**Baumeister, R. F., Vohs, K. D., Aaker, J. L., & Garbinsky, E. N. (2013).** *Some key differences between a happy life and a meaningful life.* Journal of Positive Psychology, 8(6), 505–516. In surveys of about 400 adults, happiness and meaningfulness overlapped but differed: good health and an easy life went with happiness but not meaning, while thinking more about the past and future went with more meaning but less happiness.
doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2013.830764

**Curry, O. S., Rowland, L. A., Van Lissa, C. J., Zlotowitz, S., McAlaney, J., & Whitehouse, H. (2018).** *Happy to help? A systematic review and meta-analysis of the effects of performing acts of kindness on the well-being of the actor.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 76, 320–329. A meta-analysis of 27 experiments found that performing acts of kindness had a small-to-medium positive effect on the giver's well-being ($\delta = 0.28$).
doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2018.02.014

**Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999).** *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

**Hayes, S. C., Strosahl, K. D., & Wilson, K. G. (1999).** *Acceptance and commitment therapy: An experiential approach to behavior change.* Guilford Press. The first main book on acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), which puts chosen values at the centre and teaches making room for difficult feelings while acting on what matters.
contextualscience.org/publications/hayes_strosahl_wilson_1999

**Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010).** *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

**Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984).** *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

**Markus, H. R., & Kitayama, S. (1991).** *Culture and the self: Implications for cognition, emotion, and motivation.* Psychological Review, 98(2), 224–253. Argued that cultures differ in how they construe the self, as independent or interdependent with others, and that this shapes cognition, emotion and motivation.
sites.duke.edu

**Martela, F., & Steger, M. F. (2016).** *The three meanings of meaning in life: Distinguishing coherence, purpose, and significance.* Journal of Positive Psychology, 11(5), 531–545. Proposed that meaning in life has three parts: coherence (life makes sense), purpose (having core goals and direction) and significance (feeling that one's life has value).
research.aalto.fi

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005).** *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

**Rotter, J. B. (1966).** *Generalized expectancies for internal versus external control of reinforcement.* Psychological Monographs: General and Applied, 80(1), 1–28. Described individual differences in "locus of control", how far people believe outcomes depend on their own actions rather than outside forces, and introduced a scale to measure it.
doi.org/10.1037/h0092976

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2001).** *On happiness and human potentials: A review of research on hedonic and eudaimonic well-being.* Annual Review of Psychology, 52, 141–166. Reviewed two traditions of well-being research: hedonic (pleasure and the absence of pain) and eudaimonic (meaning, self-realisation and full functioning), and how they diverge and complement each other.
doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.141

**Ryff, C. D. (1989).** *Happiness is everything, or is it? Explorations on the meaning of psychological well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(6), 1069–1081. Proposed six dimensions of psychological well-being (self-acceptance, positive relations, autonomy, environmental mastery, purpose in life and personal growth) and tested them with 321 adults, finding that several were not captured by earlier happiness measures.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.57.6.1069

**Schwartz, S. H. (1992).** *Universals in the content and structure of values: Theoretical advances and empirical tests in 20 countries.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 25, 1–65. Using data from 20 countries, found that the meaning of a set of basic value types was broadly similar across most groups, and that values are organised by two dimensions into a circle of compatible and conflicting motivations.
cris.huji.ac.il

**Steger, M. F., Frazier, P., Oishi, S., & Kaler, M. (2006).** *The Meaning in Life Questionnaire: Assessing the presence of and search for meaning in life.* Journal of Counseling Psychology, 53(1), 80–93. Developed the 10-item Meaning in Life Questionnaire, which separately measures the presence of meaning and the search for meaning, and tested its reliability and validity across three studies.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-0167.53.1.80

## Healing after hurt

**Baumeister, R. F., Stillwell, A., & Wotman, S. R. (1990).** *Victim and perpetrator accounts of interpersonal conflict: Autobiographical narratives about anger.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(5), 994–1005. People wrote stories about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them; perpetrators and victims described the same kinds of event very differently, for example in how serious, understandable and finished the harm was.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.5.994

**Bonanno, G. A. (2004).** *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

**Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999).** *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

**Cohen, S., & Wills, T. A. (1985).** *Stress, social support, and the buffering hypothesis.* Psychological Bulletin, 98(2), 310–357. A review arguing that social support protects (buffers) people from the harmful effects of stress, especially perceived availability of support, alongside general main effects of being socially integrated.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.98.2.310

**Eisenberger, N. I., Lieberman, M. D., & Williams, K. D. (2003).** *Does rejection hurt? An fMRI study of social exclusion.* Science, 302(5643), 290–292. Being left out of a virtual ball-tossing game increased activity in the anterior cingulate cortex, a region also involved in physical pain distress, in proportion to how upset people felt.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1089134

**Eubanks, C. F., Muran, J. C., & Safran, J. D. (2018).** *Alliance rupture repair: A meta-analysis.* Psychotherapy, 55(4), 508–519. Across 11 studies (1,314 patients), repairing ruptures in the therapist-client relationship was moderately associated with better outcomes; training therapists in rupture repair did not show a significant effect on outcomes in 6 studies.
doi.org/10.1037/pst0000185

**Frattaroli, J. (2006).** *Experimental disclosure and its moderators: A meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 823–865. Pooling 146 randomised studies, experimental disclosure (such as expressive writing) had a small but significant positive average effect.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.823

**Frazier, P., Tennen, H., Gavian, M., Park, C., Tomich, P., & Tashiro, T. (2009).** *Does self-reported posttraumatic growth reflect genuine positive change?* Psychological Science, 20(7), 912–919. Measuring 122 students before and after a trauma, the researchers found that self-reported growth was largely unrelated to actual measured change, and perceived growth went with more distress while actual growth went with less.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2009.02381.x

**Gordon, K. C., Baucom, D. H., & Snyder, D. K. (2004).** *An integrative intervention for promoting recovery from extramarital affairs.* Journal of Marital and Family Therapy, 30(2), 213-231. In a small study of six couples who had a structured couples therapy after an affair, most were less distressed by the end, and the hurt partners reported more forgiveness. The therapy moved in stages: dealing with the shock, understanding how the affair came about, and then deciding how to move on.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/15114949

**Gottman, J. M. (2011).** *The Science of Trust: Emotional Attunement for Couples.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book drawing on Gottman's lab research and game theory to argue that trust is built through emotional attunement in everyday moments, and describing how couples can repair it.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393705959-the-science-of-trust

**Kim, P. H., Ferrin, D. L., Cooper, C. D., & Dirks, K. T. (2004).** *Removing the shadow of suspicion: The effects of apology versus denial for repairing competence- versus integrity-based trust violations.* Journal of Applied Psychology, 89(1), 104–118. Trust was repaired more successfully when people apologised for competence-based violations but denied culpability for integrity-based violations, depending also on later evidence of guilt or innocence.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.89.1.104

**Leary, M. R., Springer, C., Negel, L., Ansell, E., & Evans, K. (1998).** *The causes, phenomenology, and consequences of hurt feelings.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1225–1237. Hurt feelings were triggered by events that signalled relational devaluation (feeling less valued by someone), usually by people the person knew well.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1225

**Leary, M. R., Tate, E. B., Adams, C. E., Allen, A. B., & Hancock, J. (2007).** *Self-compassion and reactions to unpleasant self-relevant events: The implications of treating oneself kindly.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 92(5), 887–904. In five studies, self-compassion softened people's reactions to unpleasant events in ways distinct from, and sometimes more helpful than, self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.92.5.887

**Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B., Jr. (2016).** *An exploration of the structure of effective apologies.* Negotiation and Conflict Management Research, 9(2), 177–196. Testing six apology components with 755 participants, acknowledging responsibility was rated most important, then an offer of repair; a request for forgiveness mattered least. Apologies with more components were rated better.
doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073

**McNulty, J. K. (2008).** *Forgiveness in marriage: Putting the benefits into context.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(1), 171–175. Looked at newly married couples and argued, as the title says, that the benefits of forgiving depend on the context, such as how often a partner behaves badly.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.1.171

**McNulty, J. K. (2011).** *The dark side of forgiveness: The tendency to forgive predicts continued psychological and physical aggression in marriage.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 37(6), 770–783. In newlywed couples over four years, partners' aggression stayed stable towards more forgiving spouses but declined towards less forgiving ones, suggesting forgiveness can remove consequences that would discourage repeat offending.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167211407077

**Milton, D. E. M. (2012).** *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991).** *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

**Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986).** *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

**Pillemer, K. (2020).** *Fault Lines: Fractured Families and How to Mend Them.* Avery (Penguin Random House). Draws on the Cornell Reconciliation Project, including a national survey on estrangement and interviews, to show family estrangement is more common than people assume and that some people reconcile.
search.worldcat.org/oclc/1145305518

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Rempel, J. K., Holmes, J. G., & Zanna, M. P. (1985).** *Trust in close relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 49(1), 95–112. Described trust in close relationships as having three components, predictability, dependability and faith, and developed a self-report Trust Scale to measure them.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.49.1.95

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Tedeschi, R. G., & Calhoun, L. G. (1996).** *The Posttraumatic Growth Inventory: Measuring the positive legacy of trauma.* Journal of Traumatic Stress, 9(3), 455–471. Developed the 21-item Posttraumatic Growth Inventory with five areas of reported growth: new possibilities, relating to others, personal strength, spiritual change and appreciation of life.
doi.org/10.1007/BF02103658

**Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978).** *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

**Wade, N. G., Hoyt, W. T., Kidwell, J. E. M., & Worthington, E. L., Jr. (2014).** *Efficacy of psychotherapeutic interventions to promote forgiveness: A meta-analysis.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 82(1), 154–170. Across 54 reports, people in explicit forgiveness interventions reported more forgiveness than untreated controls and than those in other treatments, along with larger improvements in depression, anxiety and hope than no treatment.
doi.org/10.1037/a0035268

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

## Helping others well

**Bloom, P. (2016).** *Against empathy: The case for rational compassion.* Ecco. A book arguing that empathy, feeling what others feel, is biased towards people like us and can cloud judgment, and that reasoned compassion is a better guide to helping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/c5q8eupq

**Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000).** *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

**Brown, S. L., Nesse, R. M., Vinokur, A. D., & Smith, D. M. (2003).** *Providing social support may be more beneficial than receiving it: Results from a prospective study of mortality.* Psychological Science, 14(4), 320–327. In a five-year study of older married adults, those who reported giving practical help to others or emotional support to their spouse had lower mortality, while receiving support was not linked to mortality once giving was accounted for.
researchconnect.stonybrook.edu

**Cutrona, C. E., & Russell, D. W. (1990).** *Type of social support and specific stress: Toward a theory of optimal matching.* In B. R. Sarason, I. G. Sarason & G. R. Pierce (Eds.), Social Support: An Interactional View (pp. 319–366). New York: Wiley. Proposed the "optimal matching" idea: support helps most when its type fits the problem, for example practical help for things you can change and comfort for things you can't.
search.worldcat.org

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**Dazzi, T., Gribble, R., Wessely, S., & Fear, N. T. (2014).** *Does asking about suicide and related behaviours induce suicidal ideation? What is the evidence?* Psychological Medicine, 44(16), 3361–3363. A review of published studies in adults and adolescents, in the general population and in groups at higher risk. None found a significant rise in suicidal thoughts after people were asked about suicide; talking about it may even lower them.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24998511

**Dunn, E. W., Aknin, L. B., & Norton, M. I. (2008).** *Spending money on others promotes happiness.* Science, 319(5870), 1687–1688. Spending more of one's income on others predicted greater happiness in a nationally representative survey and in a field study of windfall spending, and people randomly assigned to spend money on others were happier than those assigned to spend it on themselves.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1150952

**Figley, C. R. (Ed.) (1995).** *Compassion fatigue: Coping with secondary traumatic stress disorder in those who treat the traumatized.* Brunner/Mazel, New York. An edited volume introducing "compassion fatigue" as a cost of helping traumatized people, distinguished from burnout and PTSD, with ideas for prevention.
routledge.com

**Fischer, P., Krueger, J. I., Greitemeyer, T., Vogrincic, C., Kastenmüller, A., Frey, D., Heene, M., Wicher, M., & Kainbacher, M. (2011).** *The bystander-effect: A meta-analytic review on bystander intervention in dangerous and non-dangerous emergencies.* Psychological Bulletin, 137(4), 517–537. Across 105 effect sizes and over 7,700 participants, the bystander effect was reliable but weaker when situations were clearly dangerous.
doi.org/10.1037/a0023304

**Flynn, F. J., & Lake, V. K. B. (Bohns) (2008).** *"If you need help, just ask": Underestimating compliance with direct requests for help.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 95(1), 128–143. In five studies, people asking for help underestimated how many others would agree to a direct request, by as much as 50%, partly because they overlooked how awkward it feels to say no.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.95.1.128

**Helgeson, V. S., & Fritz, H. L. (1998).** *A theory of unmitigated communion.* Personality and Social Psychology Review, 2(3), 173–183. Proposed "unmitigated communion", focusing on others to the exclusion of oneself, and distinguished it from healthy caring; unmitigated communion, not communion, was linked to psychological distress.
doi.org/10.1207/s15327957pspr0203_2

**Hobfoll, S. E. (1989).** *Conservation of resources: A new attempt at conceptualizing stress.* American Psychologist, 44(3), 513–524. Proposed conservation of resources theory: stress arises when people's valued resources are threatened or lost, or when investing resources does not pay off, and people strive to protect what they have.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.44.3.513

**House, J. S. (1981).** *Work Stress and Social Support.* Addison-Wesley (Reading, MA). A book on social support at work that distinguished emotional, instrumental, informational and appraisal support.
libcat.library.tamu.edu/Record/in00000649568

**Maslach, C., & Jackson, S. E. (1981).** *The measurement of experienced burnout.* Journal of Occupational Behaviour (now Journal of Organizational Behavior), 2(2), 99–113. Developed the Maslach Burnout Inventory, with three subscales: emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and reduced personal accomplishment.
scienceopen.com/document/vid/19d4ed76-9f31-47eb-93e2-81f08d26f4d4

**Miller, W. R., & Rollnick, S. (1991).** *Motivational interviewing: Preparing people to change addictive behavior.* Guilford Press. The first full presentation of motivational interviewing: a way of talking about change that treats mixed feelings as normal and draws out the person's own reasons for change.
motivationalinterviewing.org

**Miserandino, C. (2003).** *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

**Philpot, R., Liebst, L. S., Levine, M., Bernasco, W., & Lindegaard, M. R. (2020).** *Would I be helped? Cross-national CCTV footage shows that intervention is the norm in public conflicts.* American Psychologist, 75(1), 66–75. Analysing CCTV footage of real public conflicts in three countries, the researchers found that at least one bystander intervened in most incidents, at similar rates across countries, and that more bystanders made intervention more likely.
doi.org/10.1037/amp0000469

**Pinquart, M., & Sörensen, S. (2003).** *Differences between caregivers and noncaregivers in psychological health and physical health: A meta-analysis.* Psychology and Aging, 18(2), 250–267. Across 84 studies, caregivers reported more stress and depression and lower wellbeing and self-efficacy than non-caregivers, with smaller differences in physical health; gaps were larger for dementia caregivers.
doi.org/10.1037/0882-7974.18.2.250

**Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020).** *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

**Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000).** *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

**Singer, T., & Klimecki, O. M. (2014).** *Empathy and compassion.* Current Biology, 24(18), R875–R878. Distinguished empathic distress (sharing someone's pain, which can overwhelm) from compassion (warm concern), which engage different brain networks; brief compassion training increased positive feelings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2014.06.054

**World Health Organization (2019).** *Burn-out an "occupational phenomenon": International Classification of Diseases.* WHO news item, 28 May 2019. ICD-11 includes burn-out as an occupational phenomenon, not a medical condition: a syndrome from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed, with exhaustion, mental distance or cynicism about one's job, and reduced professional efficacy. WHO says the term should not be used for other areas of life.
who.int

## Anger

**Baumeister, R. F., Stillwell, A., & Wotman, S. R. (1990).** *Victim and perpetrator accounts of interpersonal conflict: Autobiographical narratives about anger.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(5), 994–1005. People wrote stories about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them; perpetrators and victims described the same kinds of event very differently, for example in how serious, understandable and finished the harm was.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.5.994

**Bushman, B. J. (2002).** *Does venting anger feed or extinguish the flame? Catharsis, rumination, distraction, anger, and aggressive responding.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(6), 724–731. Angered people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who provoked them felt angrier afterwards than people who were distracted or did nothing.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202289002

**Bushman, B. J., Bonacci, A. M., Pedersen, W. C., Vasquez, E. A., & Miller, N. (2005).** *Chewing on it can chew you up: Effects of rumination on triggered displaced aggression.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 88(6), 969–983. In three experiments, people who ruminated about a provocation, even for eight hours, were later more aggressive towards someone who only mildly annoyed them than people who were distracted.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.88.6.969

**Carver, C. S., & Harmon-Jones, E. (2009).** *Anger is an approach-related affect: Evidence and implications.* Psychological Bulletin, 135, 183–204. A review of evidence that anger is usually an "approach" emotion: like eagerness, it moves people towards a goal or obstacle rather than away from it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013965

**Chida, Y., & Steptoe, A. (2009).** *The association of anger and hostility with future coronary heart disease: A meta-analytic review of prospective evidence.* Journal of the American College of Cardiology, 53(11), 936–946. Anger and hostility were linked with a modestly higher risk of later coronary heart disease events, in both initially healthy people and people with heart disease; the link was no longer significant in studies that controlled for behaviours such as smoking.
doi.org/10.1016/j.jacc.2008.11.044

**Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020).** *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

**Del Vecchio, T., & O'Leary, K. D. (2004).** *Effectiveness of anger treatments for specific anger problems: A meta-analytic review.* Clinical Psychology Review, 24(1), 15–34. Across 23 controlled studies of adults with anger problems, anger treatments produced medium to large effects; cognitive approaches did well for long-standing (trait) anger, anger suppression and driving anger, and relaxation for in-the-moment anger.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cpr.2003.09.006

**Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014).** *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(2), 168–175. In a 14-day daily study, people reported more conflict with their partner after poor nights of sleep, and conflicts were resolved best when both partners were well rested.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613488952

**Gordon, T. (1970).** *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularised "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behaviour rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

**Gross, J. J. (1998).** *The emerging field of emotion regulation: An integrative review.* Review of General Psychology, 2(3), 271–299. Set out the process model of emotion regulation, with five points where emotion can be shaped: situation selection, situation modification, attention, cognitive change (reappraisal) and response modulation.
doi.org/10.1037/1089-2680.2.3.271

**Gross, J. J., & John, O. P. (2003).** *Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: Implications for affect, relationships, and well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 85(2), 348–362. Across five studies, people who habitually reappraised had better emotional experience, relationships and well-being; habitual suppression was linked to worse outcomes.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

**James, W. (1884).** *What is an emotion?* Mind, os-IX(34), 188–205. James argued that bodily changes follow directly from perceiving something exciting, and that our feeling of those bodily changes is the emotion.
doi.org/10.1093/mind/os-IX.34.188

**Kapp, S. K., Steward, R., Crane, L., Elliott, D., Elphick, C., Pellicano, E., & Russell, G. (2019).** *"People should be allowed to do what they like": Autistic adults' views and experiences of stimming.* Autism, 23(7), 1782–1792. Interviews and focus groups with 32 autistic adults described stimming as a way to regulate overwhelming emotions and sensations, and as something that becomes accepted through understanding; participants objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319829628

**Kinnaird, E., Stewart, C., & Tchanturia, K. (2019).** *Investigating alexithymia in autism: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Psychiatry, 55, 80–89. Across 15 studies, about half of autistic participants (around 50%) had high alexithymia compared with about 5% of comparison participants; alexithymia is common in autism but not universal.
doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2018.09.004

**Kjærvik, S. L., & Bushman, B. J. (2024).** *A meta-analytic review of anger management activities that increase or decrease arousal: What fuels or douses rage?* Clinical Psychology Review (April 2024). Across 154 studies, activities that calm the body (such as slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness) reduced anger and aggression, while arousal-increasing activities showed little or no benefit.
news.osu.edu

**Kross, E., Ayduk, O., & Mischel, W. (2005).** *When asking "why" does not hurt: Distinguishing rumination from reflective processing of negative emotions.* Psychological Science, 16(9), 709–715. After recalling an anger-provoking experience, people who asked why they felt as they did from a self-distanced perspective showed less emotional reactivity than those who relived it through their own eyes.
rascl.studentorg.berkeley.edu/assets/files/kross_etal_2005_ps.pdf

**Mischkowski, D., Kross, E., & Bushman, B. J. (2012).** *Flies on the wall are less aggressive: Self-distancing "in the heat of the moment" reduces aggressive thoughts, angry feelings and aggressive behavior.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology. After being provoked, people who reflected on the moment from a distanced, "fly on the wall" view felt less angry and behaved less aggressively than people who relived it from their own point of view.
doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2012.03.012

**Mostofsky, E., Penner, E. A., & Mittleman, M. A. (2014).** *Outbursts of anger as a trigger of acute cardiovascular events: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Heart Journal, 35(21), 1404–1410. Across nine case-crossover studies, the rate of heart attacks, strokes and arrhythmias was higher in the two hours after an outburst of anger than at other times, especially for people already at high risk.
doi.org/10.1093/eurheartj/ehu033

**Rosenberg, M. B. (1999).** *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

**Saini, M. (2009).** *A meta-analysis of the psychological treatment of anger: Developing guidelines for evidence-based practice.* Journal of the American Academy of Psychiatry and the Law, 37(4), 473–488. Across 96 studies and 139 treatment effects, psychological treatments for anger (such as CBT, skills training and relaxation) were generally effective, with considerable variation between treatments and studies.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/20018996

**Shaw, P., Stringaris, A., Nigg, J., & Leibenluft, E. (2014).** *Emotion dysregulation in attention deficit hyperactivity disorder.* American Journal of Psychiatry, 171(3), 276–293. A literature review found that trouble regulating emotions (quick, strong feelings that are hard to bring back down) is common in ADHD across the lifespan, with clinic studies of young people putting it at roughly a quarter to a half, and that it adds a lot to the day-to-day difficulty ADHD brings.
doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2013.13070966

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

## Personality, temperament and change

**Bleidorn, W., Schwaba, T., Zheng, A., Hopwood, C. J., Sosa, S. S., Roberts, B. W., & Briley, D. A. (2022).** *Personality stability and change: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies.* Psychological Bulletin, 148(7–8), 588–619. Who is more or less of a trait compared with others becomes steadier through childhood and levels off by about 25, while average levels keep shifting gently across life, with emotional stability rising most.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000365

**Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018).** *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* Autism Research, 11(5), 766–775. In a survey of autistic adults in the Netherlands Autism Register, about two-thirds reported a special interest; greater motivation for the interest was linked to higher wellbeing, while very high intensity of engagement was linked to lower wellbeing.
research.vu.nl

**Hudson, N. W., & Fraley, R. C. (2015).** *Volitional personality trait change: Can people choose to change their personality traits?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(3), 490–507. In two 16-week studies, people who wanted to change a trait tended to shift a little in that direction, especially when they set concrete plans to act differently.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000021

**Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017).** *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

**Leedham, A., Thompson, A. R., Smith, R., & Freeth, M. (2020).** *'I was exhausted trying to figure it out': The experiences of females receiving an autism diagnosis in middle to late adulthood.* Autism, 24(1), 135–146. Interviews with eleven autistic women diagnosed at 40 or older explored how they made sense of a lifetime of feeling different and how the diagnosis changed their understanding of themselves.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319853442

**McCrae, R. R., & Costa, P. T., Jr. (1987).** *Validation of the five-factor model of personality across instruments and observers.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(1), 81–90. Ratings of 275 adults by their peers showed the same five broad trait factors found in self-reports, and peers and the people themselves agreed moderately well. This helped establish the "Big Five" as a common map of personality.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.1.81

**Roberts, B. W., Luo, J., Briley, D. A., Chow, P. I., Su, R., & Hill, P. L. (2017).** *A systematic review of personality trait change through intervention.* Psychological Bulletin, 143(2), 117–141. Across 207 studies, personality trait scores changed noticeably during therapy and other interventions over about six months, mostly towards more emotional stability, and the changes lasted in follow-ups.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000088

**Roberts, B. W., Walton, K. E., & Viechtbauer, W. (2006).** *Patterns of mean-level change in personality traits across the life course: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(1), 1–25. Pooling 92 long-term studies, people on average became more confident in social settings, more conscientious and more emotionally stable, especially between about 20 and 40, and traits kept changing in middle and old age.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.1.1

**Thomas, A., & Chess, S. (1977).** *Temperament and Development.* New York: Brunner/Mazel. From the New York Longitudinal Study, which followed children from infancy, the authors described inborn differences in temperament, such as activity, regularity, adaptability and mood, and argued that how well a child's temperament fits their surroundings matters ("goodness of fit").
wellcomecollection.org/works/epddh966

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

## Closeness and love

**Acevedo, B. P., & Aron, A. (2009).** *Does a long-term relationship kill romantic love?* Review of General Psychology, 13(1), 59–65. Reviewing studies of short- and long-term relationships, the authors concluded that romantic love without obsession can last in long-term relationships and is linked with greater satisfaction and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/a0014226

**Algoe, S. B., Gable, S. L., & Maisel, N. C. (2010).** *It's the little things: Everyday gratitude as a booster shot for romantic relationships.* Personal Relationships, 17(2), 217–233. In a daily-diary study of cohabiting couples, feeling gratitude after a partner's thoughtful act predicted greater relationship connection and satisfaction the next day, for both partners.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1475-6811.2010.01273.x

**Aron, A., & Aron, E. N. (1986).** *Love and the Expansion of Self: Understanding Attraction and Satisfaction.* Hemisphere Publishing (Washington, DC). Introduced the self-expansion model: people are motivated to grow by including a partner's perspectives, resources and identity in their sense of self.
libcat.library.tamu.edu/Record/in00000408876

**Aron, A., Melinat, E., Aron, E. N., Vallone, R. D., & Bator, R. J. (1997).** *The experimental generation of interpersonal closeness: A procedure and some preliminary findings.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 23(4), 363–377. Pairs of strangers who spent about 45 minutes on gradually deepening self-disclosure tasks (the "36 questions") felt closer afterwards than pairs given small-talk tasks; matching on attitudes or expecting to like each other made no significant difference.
ggia.berkeley.edu/practice/36_questions_for_increasing_closeness

**Aron, A., Norman, C. C., Aron, E. N., McKenna, C., & Heyman, R. E. (2000).** *Couples' shared participation in novel and arousing activities and experienced relationship quality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 78(2), 273–284. Couples who took part together in a novel, mildly challenging activity reported higher relationship quality afterwards than couples who did a mundane task.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.78.2.273

**Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995).** *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

**Carstensen, L. L., Isaacowitz, D. M., & Charles, S. T. (1999).** *Taking time seriously: A theory of socioemotional selectivity.* American Psychologist, 54(3), 165–181. Proposes that perceived time left shapes social goals: when time feels open-ended people seek new information and contacts; when it feels limited they focus on fewer, emotionally meaningful relationships.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.3.165

**Driver, J. L., & Gottman, J. M. (2004).** *Daily marital interactions and positive affect during marital conflict among newlywed couples.* Family Process, 43(3), 301–314. Observing 49 newlywed couples over dinner and in a conflict discussion, the authors linked turning towards each other's everyday bids with more positive emotion (such as humour and affection) during later conflict.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.2004.00024.x

**Fraley, R. C., Hudson, N. W., Heffernan, M. E., & Segal, N. (2015).** *Are adult attachment styles categorical or dimensional? A taxometric analysis of general and relationship-specific attachment orientations.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(2), 354–368. Taxometric analyses suggested that adult attachment differences are dimensional (degrees of anxiety and avoidance) rather than distinct types.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000027

**Gable, S. L., Reis, H. T., Impett, E. A., & Asher, E. R. (2004).** *What do you do when things go right? The intrapersonal and interpersonal benefits of sharing positive events.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 87(2), 228–245. Across four studies, telling others about good news was linked with higher daily positive mood and well-being beyond the event itself, especially when the listener responded actively and constructively; couples whose partners usually responded enthusiastically reported more intimacy and satisfaction.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.87.2.228

**Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987).** *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

**Laurenceau, J.-P., Barrett, L. F., & Pietromonaco, P. R. (1998).** *Intimacy as an interpersonal process: The importance of self-disclosure, partner disclosure, and perceived partner responsiveness in interpersonal exchanges.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1238–1251. Diary studies of everyday social interactions supported Reis and Shaver's model: disclosing feelings, and feeling that the other person responded with understanding, both contributed to how intimate an interaction felt.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1238

**Reis, H. T., & Shaver, P. (1988).** *Intimacy as an interpersonal process.* In S. Duck (Ed.), Handbook of Personal Relationships (pp. 367–389). Chichester: Wiley. Described intimacy as a back-and-forth process: one person shares something, the other responds with understanding, validation and care, and the first feels known.
search.worldcat.org

## Worry, low mood and trauma

**Bonanno, G. A. (2004).** *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

**Borkovec, T. D., Wilkinson, L., Folensbee, R., & Lerman, C. (1983).** *Stimulus control applications to the treatment of worry.* Behaviour Research and Therapy, 21(3), 247–251. People who described themselves as worriers and were taught to postpone worry to a set time and place each day reported less daily worry after four weeks than people given no treatment.
doi.org/10.1016/0005-7967(83)90206-1

**Carleton, R. N. (2016).** *Fear of the unknown: One fear to rule them all?* Journal of Anxiety Disorders, 41, 5–21. A review arguing that fear of the unknown, closely related to intolerance of uncertainty, may be a fundamental fear underlying anxiety and neuroticism.
doi.org/10.1016/j.janxdis.2016.03.011

**Craske, M. G., Treanor, M., Conway, C. C., Zbozinek, T., & Vervliet, B. (2014).** *Maximizing exposure therapy: An inhibitory learning approach.* Behaviour Research and Therapy, 58, 10–23. Describes exposure therapy for anxiety as building new learning that competes with old fear, and sets out ways to strengthen it, such as testing specific expectations, dropping safety behaviours and practising in varied settings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.brat.2014.04.006

**Cruwys, T., Dingle, G. A., Haslam, C., Haslam, S. A., Jetten, J., & Morton, T. A. (2013).** *Social group memberships protect against future depression, alleviate depression symptoms and prevent depression relapse.* Social Science & Medicine, 98, 179–186. In population data on adults aged 50 and over followed for two to four years, belonging to fewer groups predicted more depression later; among people already depressed, joining one group was linked to a 24% lower risk of relapse and joining three to a 63% lower risk.
doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2013.09.013

**Dazzi, T., Gribble, R., Wessely, S., & Fear, N. T. (2014).** *Does asking about suicide and related behaviours induce suicidal ideation? What is the evidence?* Psychological Medicine, 44(16), 3361–3363. A review of published studies in adults and adolescents, in the general population and in groups at higher risk. None found a significant rise in suicidal thoughts after people were asked about suicide; talking about it may even lower them.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24998511

**Ekers, D., Webster, L., Van Straten, A., Cuijpers, P., Richards, D., & Gilbody, S. (2014).** *Behavioural activation for depression; an update of meta-analysis of effectiveness and sub group analysis.* PLoS ONE, 9(6), e100100. Across 26 randomised trials (1,524 people), behavioural activation, planning and doing small valued activities, reduced depression more than control conditions, and at least as much as medication in the four trials that compared them.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0100100

**Felitti, V. J., Anda, R. F., Nordenberg, D., et al. (1998).** *Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults: The Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACE) Study.* American Journal of Preventive Medicine, 14(4), 245–258. Of 13,494 adults at a large health plan sent a questionnaire, 9,508 responded; the more categories of childhood adversity people reported, the higher their risk of many adult health problems, in a graded relationship.
doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797(98)00017-8

**Freeman, D., Sheaves, B., et al. (2017).** *The effects of improving sleep on mental health (OASIS): A randomised controlled trial with mediation analysis.* The Lancet Psychiatry, 4(10), 749–758. In 3,755 university students with insomnia, an online CBT course for sleep greatly reduced insomnia and also reduced paranoid thoughts and hallucinatory experiences compared with usual care, with better sleep explaining much of the change.
doi.org/10.1016/S2215-0366(17)30328-0

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ncsacw.acf.hhs.gov/userfiles/files/SAMHSA_Trauma.pdf

## Groups, influence and culture

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doi.org/10.1037/h0093718

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doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

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doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.1.111

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csmapnyu.org

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doi.org/10.2307/2666999

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doi.org/10.1371/journal.pbio.1001426

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alnap.org

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doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.748

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*Key ideas and the pages where the book talks about them. Chapter names are in the contents.*


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